A NOVEL

The Gleaning Ground

Loop Chronicles Book 4 · A novel that begins at Ruth 1:16

Jaehyuk Choi

TABLE OF CONTENTS

The Gleaning Ground, Part One · Going In After Her

Chapter 1. Outside

Chapter 2. Three

Chapter 3. I'm Going Back

Chapter 4. Three Times

Chapter 5. Your People

Chapter 6. Pikra

Chapter 7. On the Road

Chapter 8. The Gate

Chapter 9. No Standing

Chapter 10. Nobody Drove Us Out

Chapter 11. Article Nine

Chapter 12. The First Day

The Gleaning Ground, Part Two · The Field Where Nothing Falls

Chapter 13. The Loss Rate

Chapter 14. The Second Day

Chapter 15. Lytron

Chapter 16. I Haven't Done Anything Wrong

Chapter 17. Trampled Stalks

Chapter 18. The Hired Hands

Chapter 19. The One Who Gleans Beside Me

Chapter 20. The Administrator

Chapter 21. The Arithmetic

Chapter 22. Transfer

Chapter 23. Why Don't You Leave

Chapter 24. The Day It Rained

The Gleaning Ground, Part Three · Mena's Record

Chapter 25. Someone Passing Through

Chapter 26. The One Who Writes It Down

Chapter 27. The Reputation Field

Chapter 28. That Isn't What I Wrote

Chapter 29. The Same Pattern

Chapter 30. Then Why Not Fix It

Chapter 31. Learning

Chapter 32. Where There Is Always a Little More

Chapter 33. Lytron and Mena

Chapter 34. I Have Never Lost Anything

Chapter 35. Setting It Back

Chapter 36. Found Out

The Gleaning Ground, Part Four · The Price

Chapter 37. The Nearer Kinsman

Chapter 38. The Refusal

Chapter 39. The Price

Chapter 40. Going Down

Chapter 41. Entered

Chapter 42. Pikra's Answer

Chapter 43. The Corner

Chapter 44. What the Names Mean

Chapter 45. The Standard

Chapter 46. I Hadn't Done Anything Wrong

Chapter 47. The One Who Gleaned Beside Me

Chapter 48. The Writing Down

The Gleaning Ground, Part One

Going In After Her

Chapter 1. Outside

Outside, there's no such word as standing.

I didn't know the word until I was sixteen. I'd heard it — people from the city used it sometimes. But I didn't know it was a word you attached to a person. I thought it was a word you attached to things. This wheat has standing, that wheat doesn't. Something like that.

By the time I learned it was a word for people, I was already standing at the city gate.

. . .

Our settlement had no name.

It was never a problem. A name is only useful when someone far away comes looking for you, and no one ever came looking for us from far away.

There were twenty-two houses. I could count all twenty-two, and I knew the name of everyone who lived in them. I knew whose door got knocked on at night, and I had a rough idea of who wouldn't make it through winter.

I can still count those twenty-two houses in order, even now. For a while after I came into the city, whenever I couldn't sleep, I counted them. It was the only list I had.

We planted a little wheat, kept a few goats, drew water from the channel. When the harvest failed, we went hungry. Hunger was a bad thing, but it wasn't a strange thing.

The strange thing was the city.

They said no one in the city ever went hungry. I didn't believe it for a long time. How could no one go hungry in a year the wheat failed? Wheat was something heaven gave, or didn't.

Later I learned it was true. In the city, truly, no one goes hungry. And I learned why that's a frightening thing to say.

People from the city didn't look at us with pity. That surprised me. I'd expected them to feel sorry for us, but they didn't. They looked at us the way you'd look at **something that needed explaining**.

Once, one of them stood looking at our field for a long time, then said:

"…Why do you spill so much here?"

I didn't know what he meant.

"…You drop it while you're reaping. There, and there." He pointed. "Add it all up and that's a sack, easy."

"…We don't pick up what falls," I said.

"…Why not?"

I couldn't answer. I'd never once thought about why. You didn't pick up what fell. Everyone did it that way. My grandmother had done it that way, and hers before her, probably.

He tilted his head and wrote something down.

I didn't wonder for a long time what he wrote. Now I can guess. He probably wrote: loss rate.

. . .

I entered that household when I was fourteen.

Outside, marriage comes early. You need hands to work, and you never know when someone might be gone. Some people marry for love, but mostly those two reasons come first.

The household had a mother and two sons. The father, they said, had died some years before. I married the elder son, and not long after, the younger married a girl from another house.

The mother's name was Glyke.

I said that name several times a day for two years. I didn't know it would change into another name. I thought names didn't change. That's how it is outside. Outside, no one ever asks to have their name changed.

Glyke wasn't a talkative person. But she was a person who laughed. She laughed even on days with nothing to laugh about. At first I thought it was forced, but living with her, I learned it wasn't. She really did find things funny.

There was a year we lost the whole crop. A late frost came. In three days the field turned black.

I sat at the edge of the field and cried. I was fourteen.

Glyke came and sat beside me. After a long while, she said,

"…This year's wheat had a temper on it."

I looked at her, not understanding.

"…Everyone else waited, and it came out early, all on its own," Glyke said. "Being in a hurry never pays, anywhere."

And she laughed.

That was the first time I laughed. Someone had once told me you go ugly when you laugh through tears, but Glyke never said that. She just laughed with me.

I think it was that laugh, not the marriage, that made me one of that household.

My own family's house was two doors down. So even married, I hadn't gone far.

My mother said this, the day I married:

"…That mother is a good person."

"…I know."

"…What you know and what I know are different," my mother said. "I've seen that woman laugh after losing something."

That day, I let the remark pass.

Two years later I would remember it again. And a few months after that, I would watch the laugh stop. My mother said she'd seen the woman laugh after losing something. She never told me how much a person has to lose before it stops.

. . .

I won't write my husband's name here.

There's a reason I won't. I'll set it down later. For now I'll only note this: in this record, I will not call him by name, not once.

He had big hands. So big that whatever he held looked small. A water jar looked small in them. A sickle looked small in them.

He spoke slowly. He'd say a word, wait a long while, then say another. At first I couldn't stand the gaps and kept filling them myself. Then at some point I just started waiting.

I learned waiting from him. I became a person who waits, for the rest of my life. A person who watches nothing fall in the corner of a field and still waits for next year. I know where that came from.

We lived together two years.

Some people would call two years short. I don't. Two years is enough to know a person completely — which side he slept on, what sound woke him, which finger moved first when he was angry.

I knew him completely.

In the autumn of our first married year, he taught me to use a sickle. Until then, in my own family, I'd been the one who bound sheaves, not the one who cut.

He watched me for a while, then said,

"…You're doing it too clean."

"…What's wrong with that?"

"…Clean like that, your wrist gives out," he said. "Spill a little."

"…That's a waste."

He waited a long while before answering. As he always did.

"…What you spill isn't wasted."

"…Then what is it?"

Another long while passed.

"…It's left behind."

I took it for a joke, that day. I thought he just meant to spare my wrist. He was good at that — saying something that sounded like nothing, that turned out, later, to be everything.

Two years later I would use that line again, standing in front of a field where nothing fell. By then I knew he hadn't been joking. There was still, in that world, a person who knew that spilling and leaving something behind were the same act.

. . .

The day he died was a day nothing happened.

That's the strangest part. I wish there'd been something — an omen, some unusual word. There wasn't.

He went out in the morning. A section of the channel bank had collapsed, he said, and needed fixing. Three of them went — him, his brother, and a neighbor.

At midday the neighbor came running back alone.

I won't set down what happened after that. I could. I'm choosing not to. This record isn't being written for that.

I'll set down only this. After that day, I could never again say the words a day nothing happened. There is no such day. There's only the evening, when you learn what the day held.

. . .

His brother lived four more months.

The injury from the bank never healed. At first it seemed like it would. By the second month he was walking. By the third he was back in bed, and by the fourth he died.

So this is how Glyke lost them. A husband, two sons. In order, across several years, one at a time.

I used to think losing people one at a time was easier than losing them all at once. I don't think so now. Losing them all at once, you fall apart once. Losing them one at a time, you have to get up again, every time. Getting up is harder than falling.

Glyke got up all three times.

The third time took a long while.

After the brother died, his wife stayed on with us for a while. Her name was Daphne. A year younger than me.

The three of us were left in that house. Three women. Two of us had belonged to that household for less than two years.

At night we didn't talk much. Not for lack of things to say — I think it was that once we started, we wouldn't know where to stop.

Once Daphne woke crying. She bit the blanket to keep from making a sound.

Glyke sat up. But she didn't go to her. She just sat there.

At the time I wondered why she didn't go.

Now I know. It wasn't that she couldn't. It was that she chose not to. Glyke knew that if she went to her, Daphne would stop crying. And she knew that night was not a night that should be stopped.

Everyone in that household knew things like this — when to reach out a hand and when not to. I learned it here. In the city, no one knew it.

. . .

It was some two months after the brother died.

A person came from the city. Someone who came twice a year or so, to do what he called a Roll renewal check. Even living outside, if you were originally from the city your name stayed on the Roll, and it had to be confirmed the name was still valid.

That was the first time I properly heard the word Roll.

He took out a device and entered Glyke's name. He looked at something for a long while. Then he nodded, wrote something down, and left.

Glyke watched his back for a long time.

"…What did he say?" I asked.

"…He didn't say anything," Glyke said.

"…So it's fine, then?"

Glyke looked at me. And for the first time, she didn't laugh.

"…No," Glyke said. "The number went down."

I didn't know what she meant.

"…What number?"

"…Mine," Glyke said.

I really didn't understand what that meant, then. People had died — why would the number of the one left behind go down? The ones who died were them. Why was Glyke the one being cut?

Now I know. That's how this world counts a person. The Roll doesn't count a person alone. It counts a person ***together with what belongs to them.*** *So much for a husband, so much for a son, so much for hands that work. So Glyke hadn't only lost three people. The number attached to those three had vanished along with them.*

The grief came from outside. The arithmetic came from the city.

That night I asked Glyke,

"…What happens when the number goes down?"

"…Nothing happens," Glyke said.

"…Then why worry?"

Glyke looked at me.

"…That nothing happens is exactly the problem," Glyke said. "If someone takes something from you, at least you can say you were robbed. When someone just gives you nothing, there's nowhere to say it."

I didn't understand.

"…What's the difference?"

Glyke thought for a moment, then said,

"…When you married into this house, what did I give you?"

"…A great deal."

"…I gave it because I had something to give," Glyke said. "Once I have nothing to give, I become a person who's done nothing for you. Not a person who's wronged you. A person who's done nothing. But from where you're standing, receiving, it looks exactly the same."

I would think back on this countless times after I entered the city. The Roll never wrongs anyone. It simply does nothing. Glyke already knew that, before she ever went back in.

. . .

That winter, Glyke sat a great deal.

Not that she stopped working. She did everything that needed doing. But when the work was done, she sat in the doorway and looked in one direction. Always the same direction.

I knew which direction it was. Toward the city.

I never said anything. Asking would have meant she had to answer, and I didn't want to make her.

One evening, Glyke spoke first.

"…Xene."

"…Yes."

"…I've been thinking about where I want to be buried."

I set down what I was holding.

"…Don't say things like that."

"…No, listen," Glyke said. "This isn't a sad thing to say. It's a thing you say when you're getting ready."

I couldn't say anything.

I didn't believe, then, that it was a thing you say when you're getting ready. I believe it now. Glyke really was getting ready. I don't think she understood how frightening it is, to be near someone who is getting ready.

Glyke looked toward the city again.

"…My people are all there," Glyke said. "All three of them."

I knew what she meant. All three were in the city cemetery. Even someone who died outside, if they were city-born, was carried back and buried there. It was something like an old agreement between the outside and the city.

"…I'm the only one left here," Glyke said.

And she laughed. This time she laughed, but it was a different laugh than before.

I remember that laugh. It was the last time Glyke ever laughed as Glyke.

After that, she asked to have her name changed.

(Continued in Chapter 2.)

Chapter 2. Three

> *_Previously_ — In the outer settlement, Xene married into Glyke's household at fourteen. She lost her husband, and not long after, his brother, to an accident at the water channel. Glyke lost a husband and two sons in order, and each time, her standing on the city Roll quietly fell. That winter, Glyke looks toward the city and laughs — a*
> *different laugh than before.*

That winter was the first time the number three frightened me.

Three is a small number, ordinarily. Three fingers, three steps. But that winter I learned how large three becomes once it's attached to a person. Glyke lost three — a husband, two sons. I witnessed only two of the losses. The first happened before I was born, or at least before I belonged to that household.

I mean to set down these three losses in order now. There's something you can only understand that way. Told all at once, it becomes she lost a great deal. *Told in order, it becomes* she had to get up, every single time. *Those are different stories.*

I'll set down a great many numbers in the course of this book — standing scores, loss rates, renewal dates. Every one of them will come out clean, precise to the decimal. But I want to note here, in this chapter, that behind every number is something like this three. Numbers don't lie. They simply don't say what stands behind them.

. . .

The first was Glyke's husband.

I never met him. He was already gone by the time I entered the household. When I first heard that the father had died some years before, I took it as a passing detail. If a household you're marrying into has no father, you assume that's simply how it is.

I heard the rest later, from Daphne. Daphne had come to this household around the same time I had — but she'd been from this village before she married in, so she knew more of the story.

"…It was the flood, they say," Daphne told me. "He was fixing the roof."

"…Fixing the roof, and the flood?"

"…He fell while he was up there, and it happened that the ditch below had swollen with the flood."

I had nothing to say to that. Falling from a roof was an accident. The ditch swollen below him was an accident. Two accidents, each one alone nothing, that met and became a death.

For a long time after, I stopped trusting the word accident*. An accident never comes alone. Accidents stack. A roof grown old, rain that particular day, being in that particular place at that particular hour — each one nothing, on its own. Stacked, they kill a person.*

Glyke told me the story herself, just once. I hadn't asked. She brought it up one evening on her own.

"…Even falling off that roof, he was quiet about it," Glyke said. "He didn't cry out."

"…How do you know?"

"…Because I was in the yard," Glyke said. "I watched him fall. There was no sound. He just fell."

That frightened me. A person falling without a sound.

Now I know that wasn't what Glyke meant. She was already, then, telling me what it is like for something to happen so fast there's no time even to cry out. I would come to understand it again, years later — when I learned that this is exactly how the Roll erases a person.

Glyke said she'd managed alone for a long time after that. The boys were still small. The field was more than one person could work, and she never made it smaller.

"…Why didn't you make it smaller?" I asked.

"…Because then it wouldn't be the field he made," Glyke said. "He was the one who laid out its shape. I wanted to leave it as it was."

That made me think of the small pile of stones in the corner of the yard. I'd once asked who had built it, and no one had given me a straight answer. That day I finally understood — it was near the place where he'd been fixing the roof.

I saw that pile of stones for the last time the day we left for the city. No one suggested moving it. That household had a way of drawing the line between what to leave and what to carry. The Roll has no such line. The Roll either takes everything, or erases everything.

. . .

The second and third I've already written. My husband, and his brother.

Both began the same day, at the same channel, with the same accident. What came after was different. My husband's ended that day. His brother's dragged on four more months.

I won't write those four months again. I already have. But there's one thing from those four months I haven't set down yet.

On the second month, someone came from the city again. Not the regular check — this one came separately. News that the brother was injured had already reached the city.

That struck me as strange. It was three days' walk from our settlement to the city. And yet the news had gotten there ahead of me.

"…Who told them?" I asked.

"…No one told them," Glyke said. "They just know."

"…How, if no one went?"

Glyke looked at me for a long while.

"…I don't know either," Glyke said. "I only know that they know."

At the time, that didn't frighten me. Now it does. The Roll knows without sending anyone. By what path it knows, I never learned exactly, not by the end of this book. I only confirmed, again and again, that it does.

The person who came that day took out a device, checked something, and asked,

"…You have two married sons?"

"…Yes."

"…One has already been processed as renewal-ended."

Glyke closed her eyes for a moment at that, then opened them.

"…Yes."

"…The other is under treatment, so I'll mark him pending."

And with that, he left. The word *pending* stayed in my ears for days afterward. The brother was still alive then. He could even still walk. But the Roll had already begun calling him pending.

Pending doesn't mean nothing has been decided yet. I learned this later. Pending *means the decision is already on its way. The Roll never announces anything ahead of time. It only names it ahead of time.*

For those four months, people from the village came in turns. They helped with the field, left food, sat a half-day without a word and went. No one called it help. They just came.

One old man said the same thing every time he came.

"…Three is hard."

That was the first time *three* struck me as strange. We weren't three yet. The brother was still alive. But the villagers were already counting three.

The village had no Roll. But the village counted too. It counted differently than the Roll did. The village counted while grieving. The

Roll counted without grief. The number was the same, but the two things were entirely different.

The day the brother died, that old man came first. He said nothing, just sat beside Glyke. After a long while, he said only this:

"…Now it's really three."

Glyke nodded. And for the first time in front of him, she cried. I had never seen Glyke cry before that.

. . .

After the brother's death, the city's man came a second time. That was the day I wrote of earlier — the day Glyke said, *the number went down.*

I've thought back on that visit many times since. He entered something into his device, looked at the screen for a long while, nodded, and left. He hardly spoke — no unkind word, no word of comfort either.

At the time I thought he was simply curt. Now I know. It wasn't that he had nothing to say. In the Roll's language, that was saying everything there was to say — the number has changed, and that is all. There is no field for grief on the Roll.

That night I asked Glyke — I've already written this exchange, but there's one thing I left out.

After Glyke said, *if someone takes something from you, at least you can say you were robbed*, she added, after a long while,

"…All three times, I never heard a single word."

"…What kind of word?"

"…An apology," Glyke said. "The words I'm sorry. The words we were wrong. I never heard them from anyone. Not when he fell off that roof, not when it happened to our boys. Every time, they just said the number has changed, and left."

I had no answer for that.

"…It was an accident — who is there to blame?" I finally managed, after a long while.

"…That's true," Glyke said. "But Xene, there being no one to blame, and no one being sorry — those are different things."

I remember that sentence exactly, all these years later. I think this whole book began, in the end, from that sentence. The Roll is not something to blame. The Roll does no wrong. And yet no one is sorry. This story lives in the space between those two things.

. . .

That winter, the three of us — Glyke, Daphne, and I — were left in one house.

The work didn't lessen. The field was still there, the goats were still there, and winter had its own work as always. Only the hands had gone down.

Around then, Daphne began talking about her own family's house. At first it was just passing remarks — *my mother says*, followed by something trivial. But it happened more and more.

I didn't understand what that meant, then. Now I know. All that winter, Daphne was counting a way back.

I don't fault her for it. Daphne did nothing wrong. But I first felt, then, that Daphne and I were looking at the same thing and counting something different. Daphne was counting a way back. And I — I honestly don't know what I was counting, then. Probably nothing at all.

Glyke grew quieter that whole winter. Instead, she spent more time sitting in the doorway. Always looking the same direction. Toward the city.

Once I sat beside her. Said nothing, just sat. After a long while Glyke said,

"…Xene."

"…Yes."

"…When was the first time you heard the word standing, in this house?"

I thought for a moment.

"…When that city man said something, looking at our field."

"…That's right," Glyke nodded. "I wonder what he wrote down."

"…I don't know."

"…Neither do I," Glyke said. "But I think I understand now."

I didn't ask what she meant. It felt like I didn't need to.

Now I know. That winter, Glyke was already calculating how far her own number had fallen — a husband, two sons, and how much further it would fall once her daughters-in-law left too. She wasn't afraid of it. She simply counted. Counting was how she bore her grief.

. . .

As spring drew near, Daphne spoke first.

"…Mother," Daphne said. "I don't know what I'm supposed to do."

Glyke looked at her for a long while.

"…Take your time," Glyke said. "There's nothing to decide right now."

Daphne's eyes filled with tears. "…I don't think I should leave you here alone."

"…That isn't for you to worry about," Glyke said.

I said nothing. In Daphne's voice, an undecided heart was still plainly there.

That night, Glyke sat the two of us down and said,

"…I've made my decision too."

Daphne and I waited for it.

"…I'm going back to the city."

Daphne asked, startled. "…But your standing will only go lower there. Here you don't even have to think about standing."

"…I know," Glyke said.

"…Then why?"

Glyke was quiet for a moment. The firelight made shadows on her face, and unmade them.

"…What I know and what I can put into words for you aren't quite the same thing," Glyke said. "I'll tell you one, for now. I don't want to be left alone. If being alone here and being alone there come to the same thing, I'd rather be alone where my people are."

Hearing that, I thought again about the number three. A husband, two sons. All three were in the city cemetery. Glyke wasn't going because she'd calculated her standing. She knew her number would only fall further in the city, and she meant to go regardless, to be near those three.

I didn't know then that this would be the line pulling the whole rest of this book. People always move for reasons that don't add up. The Roll keeps no field for reasons like that. To the Roll, a reason with no field is a reason that doesn't exist. And yet what doesn't exist is what moves a person.

Daphne asked quietly. "…Then what about me? Do I have to go to the city too?"

Glyke looked at her. After a long pause, she said,

"…Come with us for now. Think about it on the way."

That answer struck me as strange, at the time — speaking like a person who'd already decided everything, and then suddenly leaving room, only for Daphne.

Now I know. Glyke had already decided everything, then. She simply hadn't said it yet, not at that moment. Words that release a person don't come out of the mouth until they're ready.

I said nothing there. But that exchange stayed with me a long time. *You have somewhere of your own to go* — words said to Daphne — I didn't wonder, then, whether they applied to me too. Strangely, I didn't wonder.

Looking back now, that's strange. I had a family's house too. Two doors down. And yet that spring, not once did I think of going back to it. Why I didn't, I'll set down in the next chapter. For now I'll only note the fact that I didn't.

I remember this night exactly. Glyke's voice was not a grieving voice. It was the voice of someone who had decided. I didn't know it, that night — that grief was not the only reason behind that decision. I would only come to understand it properly in the next chapter.

(Continued in Chapter 3.)

Chapter 3. I'm Going Back

> *_Previously_ — Having lost her husband and two sons in order, Glyke*
> *declares that winter that she will return to the city. Daphne decides to go back to her own family. Xene knows she has a family's house to*
> *return to as well, but that whole spring, she never once thinks of it.*

I asked Glyke, more than once, why she wanted to go back, after that night. The answer was different every time. At first that struck me as strange. Now I know. Every different answer was true. A person's heart doesn't move for just one reason.

I'll set down those reasons in order, in this chapter. Not that there was an order to them. I'll only set them down in the order I heard them.

Even now, people sometimes ask me, "Why did you go into the city?" I always answer with one of these three reasons. Which one I pick depends on my mood that day. All three are true, so none of them is a lie.

. . .

The first reason I'd already heard. *I don't want to be left alone.*

But the day after I heard it, I noticed there was more to it than that. Glyke had spent the morning picking things up one by one around

the house. She'd lift a bowl, set it down; touch an old blanket, fold it.

"…What are you looking for?" I asked.

"…Nothing," Glyke said. "Just touching things."

"…Why?"

"…Everything here is going to stay here," Glyke said. "There's not much I can carry. So I'm touching it now, while I can."

Hearing that, I looked again at the things in that house — the hearth, the water jars, the sickle he'd used. All of it worn smooth by use. It was only then that it truly hit me — none of it could go to the city.

I return to this scene often. After I came into the city, I had to relearn what it means to own something. In the city, without standing, even what you have isn't fully yours. But the things Glyke was touching that day had been hers since before the word standing existed. I didn't understand the difference then. I do now.

The second reason I heard a few days later, while we were milking the goats in the yard.

"…Xene, do you know what happens here when someone dies?" Glyke asked.

"…You bury them. Here."

"…That's right, you bury them," Glyke said. "But you don't mark it. One stone on top, that's all. A few years on, no one even remembers whose stone it was."

Hearing that, I thought of the pile of stones in the corner of the yard.

"…Is the city different?"

"…In the city they carve the name," Glyke said. "There's a thing called a headstone. They cut the name into the stone. That way, a hundred years on, you can still tell whose place it is."

"…Why does that matter?"

Glyke's hands stopped.

"…I thought it didn't matter," Glyke said. "But after losing them, I understood. If a name doesn't remain, even the fact that they existed starts to blur. I don't want that — the fact of them — to blur."

That answer made sense to me, at the time. It's strange that it did. I had never lost anyone like that, not yet. And still I understood, or felt I did. Maybe there's another road to understanding grief besides grieving yourself. Watching from beside someone might be one of them.

That night I went out alone to the pile of stones in the yard. Moonlight let me make out their shapes — small stones, large ones, square ones, broken ones. Stacked with no order to them.

I touched one with my hand. It was cold. I wondered who had set this stone down first, in the place he'd fallen from the roof. Glyke, or someone from the village. I'd never asked.

Looking back, it's strange. I wasn't a curious person, ordinarily. But that night I truly was curious. Standing in front of that pile of stones, I had a thought for the first time. Without a name, these

stones would just become stones, in time. Stones no one remembers as anyone's place.

. . .

The third reason came latest, and shortest.

It was the day we packed, in spring. I was watching what Glyke packed. Not much. A few clothes, a few bowls, and one small bundle of cloth.

"…What's that?" I asked.

Glyke unwrapped it. Inside were small stones. A few taken from the pile in the corner of the yard.

"…I have to take at least these," Glyke said.

"…That's it? That's the reason?"

Glyke looked at me. After a long while, she said,

"…Xene, honestly, I can't put the whole reason into words. Not wanting to be left alone, that's real. Wanting a name to remain, that's real too. But the truth is just — my feet are going that way. If you go looking for reasons, more keep coming. But my feet are already moving."

I didn't quite understand that, at the time.

I know now. It was the same for me. Whenever people later asked me why I followed, I gave a different answer each time. All of them were true. But the truth was simply that my feet went that way.

. . .

In the last few days before we left, I looked over every corner of that house once more. No one told me to. My feet just moved that way.

The threshold I'd sat on the first day I came to that house. The corner of the yard where my husband taught me the sickle. The corner of the room where Daphne and I had bitten our blankets and cried at night. I went and touched each of those places, one by one.

Glyke did something similar. Once I found her standing a long while in the shed, though there was nothing much there to see.

"…What are you looking at?" I asked.

"…Nothing," Glyke said. "I'm just looking at the time I spent standing here."

I didn't quite follow that, at the time.

Now I know. A place holds the time a person spent there. You can't see that time, but standing in that place, you feel it again. Glyke spent nearly thirty years in that shed. She was leaving that time behind. I was only leaving behind two years, and still there were places my feet wouldn't come away from.

The morning we left, I went into our room one last time. The belongings were already packed; the room stood empty. I stood there a moment.

I said nothing in that room. No prayer, no farewell. I just stood there. I think, looking back, that was the only farewell I had to give that room. Standing without a word.

. . .

Word got around the village, and people came one or two at a time. Most of them hadn't come to talk us out of it. Most of them had simply come to say goodbye.

The old man — the one who'd come every day for those four months — came last.

"…Live well in the city," he said.

"…I don't know if *living well* is even possible there," Glyke said.

The old man laughed. It was a sad laugh.

"…I don't know either," he said. "I've never once been to the city. But every time I've seen people come from there, they always seemed to have more than us and be in more of a hurry."

"…A hurry, how?"

"…They're always measuring something. Measuring time, measuring people," the old man said. "Nobody measures anything here. I don't know what's left over once you're done measuring."

I thought back on this conversation often, after I came into the city. The old man was right. The city measures. What the old man didn't know was this: measuring itself isn't the wrong thing. The problem is what happens after the measuring. The city measures, and then gives nothing to anyone who doesn't fit the standard. That's the frightening part.

The old man turned to go, then pulled me aside.

"…Xene."

"…Yes."

"…Why are you going?" he asked. "You're not one of us, not originally. You were born here — you could stay here."

I couldn't answer right away.

"…No reason," I said.

The old man looked at me a long while, then nodded.

"…No reason is the heaviest answer there is," he said. "A light person gives you a reason. A heavy person says no reason."

I didn't know if that was a compliment. I still don't, really.

Now I understand it this way. A choice you can give a reason for is a choice you can calculate. If you can calculate it, you can calculate it again, later, and go back. A choice you can only call no reason *has no room left to go back to. The old man probably knew that.*

. . .

The night before we left, I had my last talk with Daphne. I didn't know then that it would be the last.

"…Xene," Daphne said. "Are you really going all the way to the city?"

"…Yes. Following Mother."

"…I might too," Daphne said. "But I'm scared. You've heard the stories. They say people from outside get ranked low."

"…I've heard."

"…And still?"

"…I don't know," I said. "I just want to be near Mother."

Daphne looked at me a long while, then said, "…You're strange, Xene. Not kind. Strange."

I didn't take it badly. If anything, it felt true.

Looking back now, Daphne had it exactly right. I didn't follow because I was kind. Kindness is a matter of enduring or bearing something, and I wasn't enduring or bearing anything. I simply thought it was what I was meant to do. The two are different things.

. . .

The next morning, the three of us set out together, our packs on our backs.

Daphne still hadn't made up her mind, but she came with us anyway. The road to the city ran alongside the road to her own village for a long stretch, she said. They'd walk together to the fork and decide there.

A few people from the village came out to see us off. The old man was among them. No one cried. Instead, everyone pressed something into our hands — a loaf of dry bread, a pinch of salt, a spool of thread. Glyke took it all, saying thank you some twenty times.

We walked all that day. The road, familiar at first, turned strange around noon. I had never before been more than half a day from our settlement.

I don't remember that day in much detail. That we walked, that the sun rose and set, that our feet ached. That's about it. But a few scenes remain.

Around noon we rested by a dry streambed. Daphne shared out the bread she'd been given earlier. As the three of us ate, Daphne said, out of nowhere,

"…I think I've been on this road once before. When I was little."

"…When?" I asked.

"…Following my mother. We went to see the city. Just the once," Daphne said. "But I didn't like it at all. Everyone was in such a hurry."

Glyke laughed quietly at that. "…That's just how it is there."

"…Then why are you going?"

Glyke walked on without answering.

I watched her back, and asked Daphne quietly,

"…How old were you then?"

"…Around eight. Why?"

"…Just curious. What do you remember most?"

Daphne thought for a moment, then said,

"…That people didn't call each other by name," she said. "Here everyone calls everyone by name. There, they call out something like numbers. That scared me."

I had nothing to say to that.

I would remember this conversation again, a few days later, at the city gate. What Daphne had seen wasn't numbers. I learned, later. It was standing rank. That an eight-year-old's eyes had found it strange too — I still find that remarkable, thinking of it now.

By afternoon, fields began appearing on either side of the road. Far more evenly divided than the fields back home. The furrows ran straight as though drawn with a ruler.

"…Are those city fields too?" I asked.

"…Not quite yet," Glyke said. "That's just the edge of the city's reach. The real city fields are further along — straighter than this. Quieter, too."

"…What does it mean for a field to be quiet?"

Glyke thought a moment.

"…You'll see when we get there."

I didn't think much of it at the time. I thought it was just a manner of speaking, a field being quiet. Days later I learned exactly what it meant. There was hardly any birdsong in the city's fields, or insect sound either. The machines were so precise that whatever lived there couldn't seem to find a place to settle.

As evening came and the fork drew near, Glyke stopped walking.

"…Let's rest a while here," Glyke said.

We set our packs down under a large tree by the road. I can still draw that tree exactly, even now. An old tree, its trunk split into two. The road split into two there as well. At the time, I thought it was only coincidence.

Now I don't think it was coincidence. In this world, every place where a road forks seems to carry some mark of a fork — a tree, a rock, a river. No one made the mark. It's only that, in a place like that, even the world itself seems to take a forked shape.

The sun hung low. Daphne set her pack down and sat first. I sat down too. Glyke didn't sit. She stood.

I felt something strange, then. Glyke had been silent the whole way here. But I sensed, in that moment, that her silence wasn't the silence of exhaustion — it was the silence of someone preparing something.

Glyke looked back and forth between the two of us, then, after a long while, opened her mouth. Her voice was different from usual.

"…Girls," Glyke said. "From here, each of you goes your own way."

(Continued in Chapter 4.)

Chapter 4. Three Times

> *_Previously_ — Glyke, Xene, and Daphne set out together on the road*
> *to the city. Daphne still hasn't decided where she'll go. As evening comes and the fork in the road draws near, Glyke stops walking and speaks in a voice they don't recognize: "From here, each of you goes*
> *your own way."*

At first I didn't understand what she meant. Go your own way. I already had somewhere to go — following my mother, into the city. That already-decidedness felt so obvious that it hadn't once occurred to me that it might need deciding again.

Daphne wore the same face I did. Neither of us said anything.

Glyke leaned back against the tree.

"…Go back," Glyke said. "Both of you. Each to your own family."

I remember this sentence exactly. I only learned, years later, how strangely close what followed was to a story that appears, whole, in the first chapter of the book of Ruth. I didn't know such a book existed, then. I'm only setting down what happened to me.

The sun had nearly gone down. The tree's shadow had stretched long enough to cover the three of us. When the wind blew, the leaves made a sound. I remember that sound still. Without it, I don't think I'd have felt how quiet that evening was.

Glyke didn't wear the face of someone trying to persuade us. She wore the face of someone who had already decided everything, and only needed to put it into words now. Seeing that face, I knew this hadn't come to her suddenly. She'd probably been preparing it the whole way here.

That evening, Glyke said it three times. I wasn't counting as I listened. But looking back, it strikes me strangely that it was exactly three times. The last chapter set down the story of losing three. This chapter sets down three sayings. The number three kept following this household.

I thought it was coincidence. I still think so. But when a coincidence repeats, a person tries to read something into it. So did I.

. . .

The first saying.

"…Mother." Daphne spoke first. "Why should we?"

"…You were my sons' wives, not my daughters," Glyke said. "My sons are dead. Whatever bound you to me is gone."

"…Even so."

"…Listen," Glyke said. "I can't bear you another son now, and you're not at an age to wait for one even if I could. There's nothing left for you here, staying by me."

I listened to that. It was arithmetic. Precise arithmetic. Glyke was speaking in numbers, not in grief.

I know now. That wasn't because there was no grief. Wrapping grief in arithmetic was, in that moment, the only way Glyke could manage to speak at all. Spoken as arithmetic, you can say it without crying.

Daphne began to cry. Silently, just the tears.

"…I married your son partly because I liked him," Daphne managed. "But partly because I liked you too, Mother."

Glyke's face wavered for a moment at that. Then it set again.

"…I'm grateful for that," Glyke said. "But gratitude and your life are two different questions."

I said nothing. I just stood beside Daphne, listening. I think, by then, I'd already decided what I would do. It only took a little more time to turn it into words.

. . .

The second saying.

Glyke looked at the two of us again. This time her voice shook a little.

"…Go back," Glyke said again. "To your mothers. I know how hard it is for a woman to live alone. You don't need to walk that road too."

Daphne said through her sobbing, "…What about you? Who looks after you?"

"…I'm going to the city," Glyke said. "It doesn't matter to me if there's no one there. I'm just going to my own place. You're not like

that. You can still find a new place."

I caught something in that, then. Glyke was drawing a line between herself and us. Herself, a person already finished. Us, people who could still begin. That distinction struck me, strangely, as sad.

I would meet this same distinction again later, in the Roll. The Roll divides people too — those still usable, and those already finished. The only difference is, Glyke drew that line only against herself. The Roll draws it against others.

Daphne wiped her tears and said, "…So you're going to the city alone? It's days away."

"…I'm not going alone," Glyke said. Then she glanced at me. Something complicated was in that look — wanting me, and being sorry for wanting me, both at once.

Seeing that look, I understood for the first time. Glyke was trying to send me back, and at the same time hoping I wouldn't go. I learned that day that a person can want two things at once, fully, in the same moment.

Daphne finally broke down and sobbed. I stood beside her, stroking her back. My hand was trembling.

"…Mother, are we really parting like this?" Daphne asked.

Glyke couldn't answer. After a long while, she said,

"…It isn't parting," Glyke said. "Each of us is going back to where we live. *Parting* is too sad a word."

I knew that wasn't comfort. It was something Glyke was saying to herself.

. . .

The third saying.

This time Glyke said nothing for a long while, just looking at the two of us. Then, slowly, she said,

"…Listen to me," Glyke said. "Even if I took a new husband tonight, you couldn't wait around for his sons. You're young. I have no right to hold your lives back."

This was the strangest thing she said, to my ear. At the time I took it for some old-fashioned figure of speech. Now I know. This was the language of an old law — the law by which a dead man's brother takes his widow, to carry on the line. Something like that custom must still survive somewhere outside, in this world too. Glyke was speaking in that law's own language, to say that the law was no longer possible for her.

Daphne heard that and, through her tears, half laughed.

"…Oh, Mother," Daphne said. "I never thought you'd go that far."

"…I never thought I'd say it either," Glyke said. "But once I started looking for reasons to hold you back, I ended up here. That's what happens when you go hunting for reasons that aren't there."

I felt, for the first time, that I was seeing Glyke's true heart. She knew she had no reason to hold us — and still she was manufacturing reasons to let us go. I sensed, dimly, in that moment, that the reasons to hold on and the reasons to let go come from the same place.

"…I'm old," Glyke said. "There's nothing more I can do for you. This is the last of it. Go."

Daphne collapsed into Glyke's arms. She cried like that for a long while. Then she pulled away.

Daphne kissed Glyke's face — her forehead, then both cheeks.

"…I'm sorry," Daphne said. "I can't do it."

"…It's all right," Glyke said. "It's nothing for you to be sorry for."

Daphne looked at me. She kissed me too, briefly.

"…Take care, Xene."

And Daphne walked off from the fork, toward her own family. She looked back several times. She waved. I watched until she was entirely out of sight.

Glyke watched that same retreating figure alongside me. When Daphne was completely gone, Glyke let out a short breath. I couldn't tell if it was relief or grief. Probably both.

"…That girl will do well," Glyke said, almost to herself. "Her family is good people. She'll marry well again too."

I said nothing. Listening to Glyke speak with such certainty about Daphne's future, I felt there was something else behind that certainty. It was a comfort to herself. A voice telling herself that what she'd just done had been right.

I never saw Daphne again after that. I don't know how her life went. But I've never once thought the choice she made that day was wrong. It

was her choice, and it was the right one.

. . .

Now it was just Glyke and me.

The sun had nearly set. One road at the fork was the one Daphne had vanished down. The other led to the city. We still stood at that fork. Neither of us had taken a step, either way.

Glyke looked at me. Her eyes were red.

"…Xene, you heard that too," Glyke said. "Your sister-in-law's going back. You go back too."

I said nothing.

"…Why aren't you going?" Glyke said. Her voice rose a little.

I still said nothing.

"…Xene." Glyke stepped toward me. "Didn't you hear me? Do you know what happens if you follow me?"

"…Yes."

"…And you still won't?"

I couldn't answer that question. Not exactly that I had no words for it — I simply wasn't ready yet to speak it.

"…You're just being stubborn right now," Glyke said. "It's because you're attached. Attachment fades with time. Go back to your family

and within half a year a good match will turn up. That's how it goes, here."

"…That's not what this is."

"…Then what is it?" Glyke asked. "Say something, so I know."

I still couldn't answer. What I felt in that moment wasn't that I had no answer to the question — it was that saying the whole answer out loud, right there, would make it too small.

Glyke suddenly grew angry. I had almost never seen her angry, until then.

"…If you follow me, your standing goes to zero," Glyke said. "Zero, Xene. Do you understand? You don't become a city person. You become nobody at all. I don't mind that for myself. I've already lost everything there was to lose. But you — you haven't lost anything yet!"

I listened to that quietly.

"…I didn't take you into this family to make you into that," Glyke said. Her voice shook. "Go, Xene. Please, go."

"…Mother," I said.

"…Don't listen to me, just go," Glyke said. It was nearly a plea now. "What are you going to do, being nobody at all, at your age? I'm old, it's fine. When an old person is nobody, well, that's just how it goes. But you're sixteen. If a sixteen-year-old lives as nobody, that isn't living at all."

Listening to her, I felt that Glyke wasn't talking about me anymore. She was talking about herself. In those words — *when an old person*

is nobody, that's just how it goes — was already the trace of someone who had accepted that this was what she herself would become.

I thought, for the first time, then: this woman is pushing me away and settling her own future at the same time. Setting me, who would become a zero, and herself, whose standing would fall to the floor, side by side, hoping that at least one of us could avoid it.

I count this the scene I've returned to most often in this whole book. Glyke wasn't angry to push me away. I know now. That was love, come out as anger. There are moments when a person is angriest in front of the one they cherish most. That was one.

I looked at Glyke's face. She was angry, but underneath the anger was something else. Fear. The face of someone afraid I might ruin my life because of her.

The road around us had gone quiet. Daphne was already far off. Even the birds had stopped. I felt, in that moment, as if Glyke and I were truly the only two people left in the world.

"…Answer me," Glyke said again. Her voice was smaller now than before. Closer to a plea than to anger. "Why won't you say anything."

I still couldn't answer. Not because there was no answer. I didn't know how to say it out loud.

I remember that silence exactly, even now. I don't know how many seconds it was. I only know it felt long. In those seconds, I was confirming something already settled inside me. It wasn't a time for deciding. It was a time for finding what had already been decided.

Glyke took my hand. It was cold.

"…Xene," Glyke said. Her voice was very small now. "I really don't want to make you into this."

I took her hand in return. This was the hand that had taught me to grip a sickle, that autumn I learned. Two years ago that hand had led me. Now it was trying to push me away. The same hand, pointed the opposite direction.

Looking at that hand, I knew what I had to say didn't need to be long. Say it at length, and it becomes a reason, and Glyke would knock down every reason, one by one. I wanted to say something that couldn't be argued against.

"…Listen," I said.

Glyke looked at me. Her face was waiting.

(Continued in Chapter 5.)

Chapter 5. Your People

> *_Previously_ — At the fork in the road, Glyke tells her daughters-in-*
> *law three times to go back. Daphne weeps, kisses them both, and leaves for her own family. Xene stays. Glyke grows angry — if she follows, her standing will fall to zero. Xene sees the fear beneath that anger. Glyke takes her hand and asks, "Why won't you say anything." Xene tries to answer.*

I didn't say much, standing there.

People still ask me, even now, why I answered so briefly. It was such an important moment — why didn't I say more? I always give the same answer. There wasn't more to say.

Once, someone I met here in the city asked me, "You made a decision that big and didn't explain yourself? Didn't anyone ask?" I told him Glyke had asked. And that I hadn't answered. He looked at me as if that were a strange thing.

I understand that look. In this city, an explanation is proof itself. No explanation means no grounds, and no grounds means nothing to trust. I would learn that rule the hard way, later. But at the fork that evening, I didn't know it yet. I only spoke the way I knew how to speak.

I was most careful, writing this chapter. There was a temptation to write this scene large — as though I'd said something momentous. But that would be a lie. I didn't say anything momentous. I said something short.

Up to that very moment, I hadn't decided in advance what I would say. Not while I watched Daphne's back walking away, not while Glyke's hand held mine. I wasn't choosing words in my head. My mouth simply opened, and the words came.

I've found this strange, many times since. Shouldn't the more important the words, the more you need to prepare them? For me it was the reverse. Every prepared answer came attached to a reason. Only the unprepared answer came with no reason attached. And a reasonless answer, in the end, was the one that never wavered.

. . .

"…I go where you go," I said.

Glyke looked at me. Her face waited for more.

I said nothing more.

"…That's all?" Glyke asked.

"…Yes."

"…Why?"

I didn't answer that question either. Not because there was no reason. If I gave the reason, the choice would become a choice made for a reason, and a choice made for a reason can waver once the reason is gone. I didn't want to make a choice that could waver.

Glyke started to ask again, then stopped. Whatever she'd meant to say, she closed her mouth on it, and looked at me a long while instead. I didn't look away. There was no reason to.

I can describe that silence more precisely now. I hadn't failed to say the reason, then. I had decided not to say it. Those are two different things.

I didn't know, at the time, how important that distinction would become across this whole book. Not being able to say something, and choosing not to say it. The Roll makes no distinction between the two. To the Roll, silence with no explanation is all the same silence. But to a person, the two are entirely different things.

Glyke looked at me a long while more, then asked again.

"…Have you decided where to stay, too? I might not even be able to feed myself, once we get there. With you along."

"…That's all right."

"…What's all right about it. Were you even listening to what I said?"

"…Yes."

"…Then answer me."

"…I did," I said. "I go where you go."

. . .

Glyke let go of my hand. She stepped back a few paces.

For a moment I thought it was a refusal, and my heart dropped. It wasn't. Glyke simply wanted to see me from a little further off.

For a long while neither of us said anything. The wind moved the branches. I was afraid of that silence. Wondering if I'd said something wrong, I began to open my mouth again.

But just then, an expression I'd never seen before crossed Glyke's face. Not anger, not grief. Something like acceptance. Like the face of someone who had finally finished a calculation they'd long put off.

I still haven't found the right words to describe that expression exactly. But after seeing it, I understood something. This woman had never meant to win against me, not from the start. Stopping us three times wasn't because she truly wanted to stop us — it was because she needed to fulfill the duty of trying. And a person who has fulfilled their duty is, after that, free to accept.

"…You really are stubborn," Glyke said at last. There was no anger in her voice.

"…Yes."

"…I never taught you to be this stubborn."

"…I learned it from you," I said.

Glyke laughed shortly at that, as if it were absurd. There were still tears in her eyes.

"…When did I ever."

"…All the time," I said. "Not shrinking the field. Standing in the shed. Taking the stones. That's all the same thing, isn't it."

Glyke had no answer to that.

That was the first time I felt like I had won. I hadn't spoken to win. Maybe it wasn't a matter of winning or losing at all. I was simply handing back what I'd learned from her.

I thought, in that moment, of what my husband had told me too. That what you spill isn't wasted, it's left behind. I'd taken it, at the time, for a joke told in a field. That evening it sounded different. Leaving something behind isn't a loss. It's the making of a place where something remains. I thought, right then, that staying beside Glyke was exactly that kind of act. Not a loss — the making of a place.

These two things — what I learned in a field, and the stubbornness I learned in that house — seemed to arrive together, at that fork in the road. I didn't connect them, at the time. Only now, writing this down, do they connect.

. . .

Glyke came close again and took my face in both hands. Her hands were rough.

"…Xene," Glyke said. "I have nothing to give you. I'm not taking you because I have something to give. You understand that?"

"…I understand."

"…In the city, people will treat you carelessly. They might not even call you by name — just a number."

"…I understand."

"…When it's cold, no one will help you. You won't starve, but you won't be full either."

"…I understand."

"…There, I might not be able to protect you either. My own standing is on the floor."

"…I understand."

"…Xene, this isn't me taking you because I can do something for you. It's the opposite. I'm going to become someone who can do nothing for you."

"…That's all right."

"…Why is everything all right with you. Don't you know any words besides all right."

I nearly laughed at that. I held it back.

"…And still you'll come."

"…Yes."

Glyke looked at me a long while. Then she lowered her hands and nodded.

"…Then let's go," Glyke said. Her voice had completely changed. It was no longer a voice trying to stop me.

I've pictured this moment many times since. Some days it feels like consent. Some days it feels like surrender. I think now the two are the same thing. Ceasing to let go of someone, and taking someone in — in the end, it's the same motion.

. . .

We slept on the road that night, near the fork. We had no strength to go further.

We built a fire and shared out the dry bread. Daphne's absence felt strangely large. Neither of us looked at that empty space. The habit of dividing our load three ways was still in my body — I caught myself, more than once, holding out bread toward where Daphne would have sat, then stopping.

Many stars were out. The same stars we'd watched back at the settlement, and yet they felt different, seen from this unfamiliar road.

"…Aren't you cold?" Glyke asked.

"…I'm fine."

"…*Fine* again," Glyke said, laughing a little. It was the first time she'd laughed since that evening.

I was glad of that laugh. I'd thought I might never see it again. It wasn't the same laugh as before, but a laugh was still a laugh.

I added another branch to the fire. Sparks rose and faded out.

"…Mother," I asked. "Will Daphne be all right?"

"…She'll be fine," Glyke said. "She has somewhere to go back to. People like that are usually fine."

"…What about me?"

Glyke looked at me. "…You'll be fine because you have nowhere to go back to."

I looked at her, not understanding.

"…When you have somewhere to go back to, you keep looking back," Glyke said. "You won't look back anymore. There's nothing behind you to look back at. That'll make you harder, in the end."

I took that as comfort at the time. Now I hear it differently. It was comfort and an exact prophecy, both at once. I really have never looked back, not once, since. Whether that made me hard, or whether it was simply that I had nothing to look back at, I still don't quite know.

"…Xene," Glyke said, across the firelight.

"…Yes."

"…Can I ask you one thing."

"…Yes."

"…What's your real reason. You didn't have to say back there. Can you tell just me, now?"

I looked at the fire a long while.

"…I don't know," I said. "I honestly don't know. It just felt stranger, the thought of not being wherever you are."

Glyke listened to that and nodded quietly. She didn't press further.

I think this is the most precise account I can give, in this whole book, of my own choice. I didn't go for a reason. It only felt

stranger not to go. Some choices are made that way — not by a force pulling forward, but by the force of not going another way.

. . .

I lay awake late into that night. Glyke fell asleep first. I sat up a long while, watching the fire die down.

I'll set down here that I wavered, once, that night. Only for a moment. As the fire was nearly out, I found myself thinking, for a moment, of which direction Daphne's road had gone. The thought crossed me that I could have gone that way too. It was very brief. I didn't hold onto it. I knew that holding it would only make it grow.

I set down that wavering because I don't want to say I never wavered. I did waver. I simply didn't follow where it led. Those are different things.

Before dawn I slept a little, then woke to the sound of Glyke packing. The sky was still dark.

"…Sleep more," Glyke said.

"…No, I'll get up."

We set off again without much of a breakfast. My legs were stiff.

. . .

The next morning, we shouldered our packs and started walking toward the city again.

It was just the two of us on the road now. The space Daphne had walked was empty. I was aware of that empty space all day.

The road widened as we went. More people passed us. Unfamiliar faces, all of them. They glanced at us and kept walking. I kept lowering my head at their unfamiliar looks.

"…Lift your head," Glyke said. "No need to look down."

"…People are looking."

"…Let them look. We haven't done anything wrong."

I lifted my head at that. I didn't know, then, how often I'd think back on those words in the days to come.

Around noon, Glyke said, out of nowhere,

"…Xene."

"…Yes."

"…Thank you."

That was all. I didn't answer. It wasn't a thing that needed answering.

That afternoon, we saw a field far off for the first time. Larger and straighter than anything we'd passed the day before. The furrows seemed to run all the way to the horizon.

"…That's where the city's jurisdiction begins," Glyke said.

I looked at that field for a long while. It was strangely quiet. Even with the wind blowing, there was no sound but the wheat itself moving.

"…No birds," I said.

Glyke said nothing and kept walking. I didn't know, then, what that silence meant.

Now I know. Glyke already knew that field. How much it had changed from the one she'd left thirty-some years before — she must have taken it in at a glance. I couldn't read her expression, then. Only later did I call it back to mind, and read it properly.

I've named this chapter Your People. *Those weren't words I spoke that day. I read them, much later, in a certain book. And when I read them, I knew that what happened at that fork was exactly those words. I went where my mother went. Which meant her people had become my people. I didn't know the words then, but I was already living them.*

I cried a long while after reading that book. The woman in it spoke briefly too, the way I did. Gave no reason, the way I didn't. Reading it, I thought that the choice I'd made that day might not have been mine alone to make. Maybe someone had already walked that road, and I only walked behind her. I didn't know that, then. There are roads you can walk without knowing.

(Continued in Chapter 6.)

Chapter 6. Pikra

> *_Previously_ — Xene answers briefly: "I go where you go." She gives*
> *no reason. Glyke accepts the answer. Daphne has gone back to her own*
> *family. Xene and Glyke, now alone, keep walking toward the city. In the distance, they see a city-jurisdiction field for the first*
> *time — strangely quiet.*

The first time I heard the request to change a name, it was the third day of walking.

I wrote in Chapter 1 that outside, no one ever asks to have their name changed. And the very person who'd said that did exactly that thing, barely three days later. Sometimes a person does fastest the thing they were sure they'd never do.

We walked the whole day again. The road kept widening and hardening. It was no longer dirt but paved stone. Our soles hadn't adjusted to that hardness, and we had to rest often.

I'll set down the naming in this chapter. But first there's something I should note. That third day, I saw Glyke stop walking, for the first time. It wasn't from pain. She'd stopped because she'd seen something.

Stone roads wore a person down the longer you walked them. Dirt gave a little under the foot and absorbed the shock; stone sent it straight up through the legs. That day, for the first time, I learned what it meant for it to be your bones aching, not just your legs.

More people passed us, day by day. Someone pulling a cart, someone carrying a load, someone walking fast alone. None of them looked our way. I found that strange. Outside, when a stranger passed, everyone looked at least once. Here, no one did.

"…Why does no one look at us?" I asked.

"…No reason to," Glyke said. "There are too many strangers here for strange to feel strange anymore."

I turned the phrase over. A place where strange isn't strange. I couldn't decide whether that was a comfort or a fright.

Now I know. It was neither comfort nor fright. It was simply nothing. Strangeness not feeling strange means no one reacts to a stranger. A place with no reaction has no welcome and no rejection either. It just has nothing.

We sat by the road at noon to rest our feet. Pikra looked at my foot and clicked her tongue.

"…You've got a blister."

"…It's fine."

"…Fine, sure. Give it here." Pikra set my foot on her knee and wrapped it in a strip of cloth. Her hands moved with practice. She'd probably done the same for her own sons' feet, once.

As I felt her hands, I thought that these small things might be all this woman had left to give me from now on. And somehow that didn't feel like nearly enough at all.

. . .

A little past noon, there was a small grave marker beside the road. A name was carved into the stone. An unfamiliar name.

Glyke stopped in front of it. Looked at it a long while.

"…Someone you know?" I asked.

"…No," Glyke said. "A stranger."

"…Then why look so long?"

Glyke answered after a while.

"…There's a name," Glyke said. "A dead person, and their name remains. I find that remarkable."

I thought of the settlement's pile of nameless stones.

"…Is that how it is everywhere in the city?"

"…Probably. If you have money," Glyke said. "Even without money, at least the name is kept. That's the law."

I felt relieved, hearing that. At least a name remains.

I would learn how naive that relief was, later. A name remaining, and what that name comes to mean — those are two different questions. I didn't yet know what the word standing does to a name.

We passed the marker and walked on. After a few steps, Glyke spoke again.

"…Xene, do you know what your name means? Your own name."

I was a little startled by the question. "…No. It's just my name."

"…I don't know what mine means either," Glyke said. "I don't know who named me, or why. It was just there, when I was born."

"…That's odd, come to think of it."

"…It is," Glyke said. "The word you use most, in your whole life, and you spend your whole life not knowing what it means."

I remember this exchange for a long time. At the time I took it for a passing remark. Now I know. The meaning of names is revealed only very late in this book. That day on the road, we were planting the tiniest seed of that story, without knowing it.

. . .

That evening we lodged in something like a roadside shed. It seemed built for travelers passing through. Old straw was heaped inside.

Glyke lay down on the straw and stayed a long while without sleeping. I had my eyes closed beside her, but I wasn't really asleep either.

"…Xene," Glyke called.

"…Yes." I opened my eyes.

"…Asleep or not."

"…Not asleep."

Glyke sat up. In the dark, I couldn't make out her face well.

"…I have a favor to ask."

"…Yes."

"…Once we're in the city, don't call me Glyke."

I didn't understand and stayed still a moment.

"…Then what should I call you?"

"…Pikra," Glyke said.

. . .

The instant I heard that name, my tongue felt as if it had stiffened. I didn't know what it meant, but the sound itself was foreign.

"…What does it mean?" I asked.

"…You don't need to know the meaning," Glyke said. "Just call me that."

"…But why all of a sudden—"

"…It isn't sudden," Glyke said. Her voice was firm. "I've been thinking about it the whole way. Glyke is the name he called me by. The name my sons called me by. There's no one left to call me by that name. I don't want to be called by it anymore."

"…But I still know you as that name—"

"…That's exactly why I'm asking," Glyke said. "If you don't call me by that name, I can consider it truly ended. But if you keep calling me by it, I'll keep having to answer to it. Every time I answer to it, I'll know all over again that the people who used to call me by it are gone."

I had no answer to that.

Now I know. This wasn't abandoning a name. It was changing the weight a name had to carry. Glyke had been the name of someone who was loved. To go on using that name where the love no longer existed was to confirm, every time, that the love was absent.

That night I thought of my husband's name. I've never once written it in this record. I decided that from the start. But that night, for the first time, I asked myself why.

I won't give the full reason here either. But writing this chapter, I realized something. By not writing that name, I was doing the opposite of what Pikra was doing. Pikra was letting go of an old name to be called by a new one. I hid the old name away so that no one could ever call it at all. The methods were opposite. What we were trying to do may have been the same. Some way of managing the weight a name carries.

. . .

"…You really won't tell me what Pikra means?" I asked.

"…No."

"…Where does the word come from, then?"

"…It's an old word," Pikra said. "My grandmother's generation used it, I'm told. I don't know it exactly myself. I heard the elders use it, sometimes, when they were angry."

"…Then why do you want it as your name?"

"…The sound fits," Pikra said. "You don't need the meaning. You hear the sound and you know. This is my sound now."

I found that explanation strange, and understood it too. Some words reach you through their sound before their meaning does.

"…Why?"

Glyke — I should write Pikra from here on, though that night I still couldn't say the name aloud — was quiet a long while, then said,

"…If you knew, you'd look at me with pity," Pikra said. "I don't want that."

"…I wouldn't look at you with pity."

"…You would. Once you knew. So just call me by the sound."

I never once managed to say that name aloud that night. My mouth wouldn't form it.

Instead, I asked,

"…Then what do I get called? If you're changing your name..."

"…No, your name stays yours," Pikra said. I'll use that name for the rest of this chapter, even just in writing. "I don't want to change your name. It's mine I want to change."

"…Why not mine too?"

Pikra was quiet a moment.

"…You haven't lost anything yet," Pikra said. "Your name is still only carrying the weight your name can carry. Mine isn't. Mine is carrying weight it can't carry anymore."

Hearing that, I suddenly felt like a person who'd lost nothing. Even though I'd lost my husband. That thought felt strange.

"…I lost something too," I said quietly.

Pikra reached over and took my hand at that.

"…You did too," Pikra said. "But Xene, the size of what was lost is different. I lost everyone who made my life. You still have your life left. I won't pretend that's the same."

I couldn't answer that. It sounded right, and it sounded wrong, both at once.

I think now that the distinction was right. Grief has size. Admitting that isn't cruel. Flattening it all into the same thing is crueler. Pikra already knew that, that night.

. . .

The next morning, I tried it.

"…M-mother." I started, then stopped.

"…That's fine as it is," Pikra said. "Keep calling me Mother. It's the name I want changed."

"…Right." I took a breath. "……Pi—Pikra……."

The sound came out awkward. As if it hadn't come from my own mouth, but someone else's.

Pikra heard it and laughed quietly. A sad laugh, but a laugh.

"…Everyone's like that at first," Pikra said. "You'll get used to it."

I practiced the name all that day as we walked. Silently, in my mouth, not aloud. Pikra. Pikra. However many times I repeated it, it still felt like someone else's name.

Around noon, without thinking, I said,

"…Gly—" and stopped myself.

Pikra looked at me. Not a scolding look. Just a waiting one.

"…Sorry," I said.

"…It's fine," Pikra said. "I'm still not used to being that name myself. We're both learning it new."

That put me a little more at ease. I wasn't the only one failing at it. She wasn't used to her own new name either.

By afternoon I'd gotten a little better. Once, I got it right, right on time — "Pikra" — and Pikra answered. In that moment I felt I'd crossed something.

"…There," Pikra said quietly. Almost to herself.

"…What is?"

"…Nothing." Pikra shook her head. "Just — there."

Now I know. In that moment Pikra was confirming that her name had finally been accepted by someone new. Changing a name isn't something you can do alone. It needs someone to call it. That afternoon, I put my hand to that completion for the first time.

I noticed that afternoon that Pikra's walk had changed a little. Not in any obvious way. But something in it was straighter. Before, she'd kept glancing back as she walked; from that afternoon on, she only looked ahead.

"…Are you uncomfortable somewhere?" I asked.

"…No, why?"

"…Your walk seems a little different."

Pikra thought for a moment, then said,

"…Maybe it is," Pikra said. "Once you take a new name, it feels like you have to walk as the kind of person who carries it."

I didn't fully understand what she meant, but I got the gist. A name wasn't just a sound you were called by. It changed how the person carrying it stood, how they walked.

It took me a very long time to get used to it. Even months later I'd still catch, for a moment, before that name. I don't catch anymore. Now it comes out as naturally as if it had always been her name. That fact strikes me as strange, sometimes. A person can get used to anything. Good things and sad things both.

. . .

Late that afternoon, we finally saw the city in the distance.

I'll write that moment in the next chapter. In this chapter I'll set down only one thing first. Seeing the city for the first time, the first thought that came to me wasn't its size, or its splendor.

I looked at the person beside me. Pikra. I was already calling her by that name aloud. In three days. She stood narrowing her eyes toward that city. I saw fear and longing pass across her face at the same time. It was the first time I'd seen two feelings fight like that on the same face.

Names change that fast. People change that slowly. Walking toward that city, I felt, dimly, for the first time, that it takes far longer for a person to change than for a name to.

(Continued in Chapter 7.)

Chapter 7. On the Road

> *_Previously_ — On the third night, Glyke asks Xene to stop calling her Glyke and call her Pikra instead. She won't say what it means. Xene can't say the name aloud at first, then finally speaks it that afternoon. The two see the city for the first time, in the distance.*

I can still draw the moment I saw that city, exactly, even now.

We were crossing a low hill. Pikra reached the crest first. I was a few steps behind. Seeing her stop, I hurried up after her.

And I saw it.

I tried writing this scene several different ways before settling on this one. I tried magnificent. *I tried* dazzling. *I crossed them both out. Neither word holds what I felt, that moment. It took me a long time to find the right word. Here it is — I was afraid.*

. . .

It was an unusually hot afternoon. The season was turning. Four or five days into our walk, the air had begun to change. Mornings still cool, but by noon the heat rising off the ground reached you through the soles of your feet.

The dust had gotten worse from around then too. The dirt roads back at the settlement turned to mud in rain and hardened when it was dry, but they never raised much dust. The closer we got to the city, the more

dust gathered on the road. Every cart that passed kicked up a pale cloud, and before it settled, the next cart was already through it.

"…Is this all dirt dust?" I asked Pikra.

"…No. A little different," Pikra said. "This time of year, threshing dust mixes in too. It means someone's already beating grain, somewhere. It rides the wind all the way out here."

I rubbed my nose. The inside of it felt gritty.

I took that dust, at the time, for nothing but an annoyance. I learned later. That dust meant the harvest was close. This whole city was entering its busiest season of the year. We had arrived, as it happened, right into that season.

Fields stretched along both sides of the road. What had been scattered patches at first grew closer together, until it all looked like one endless plain. And that whole plain, every part of it, without exception, had ripened to the same color.

That struck me as strange. Back at the settlement, even within one field, the ripening speed differed — sunny patches came in first, shaded ones later. Here there was none of that. It looked as if everything had agreed to be planted the same day and ripen the same day.

"…Here the whole field ripens together," I said.

"…That way you reap it all at once," Pikra said. After a moment she added, "The seed is matched. The water's matched. The feed's matched. It's all calculation."

I took that, that day, for a remark about farming technique. Now I know. It wasn't about technique at all. It was a miniature of what this city does to people too. Matching everything. Refusing to let anything grow differently.

. . .

The Harvest was vast. It looked dozens of times larger than my whole settlement. There was a wall, and even the wall alone was larger than any building I'd ever seen.

Inside the wall, roofs packed close together. Roofs of every height, overlapping into one great mass. And beyond that, fields spread out. Even all the fields I'd ever seen put together seemed like they wouldn't match this one.

The wheat was ripe. Golden, as far as the eye could see.

"…So much wheat..." I couldn't finish.

"…Yes," Pikra said. Something complicated was in her voice.

I looked at that field a long while. When the wind blew, the wheat rippled like water. But the ripple felt strange. Too even. As if someone had calculated exactly how it should be planted.

Now I know. It really had been calculated exactly. That even ripple was the beginning of the fear I first felt. I couldn't put it into words then. I only felt that something was wrong.

. . .

We stood a long while at the top of that hill. Pikra spoke first.

"…Thirty-some years," Pikra said. "Since I left there."

"…That long?"

"…It was before I married," Pikra said. "The walls weren't so high then. The fields weren't so wide either."

"…The city grew bigger?"

"…Much bigger," Pikra said. "See that field there. That wasn't there when I was a girl. There used to be a small woods, there."

I looked at the field again. Where a woods had been, there was now wheat. Not a single tree, all even.

"…Where did the woods go?"

Pikra didn't answer. Probably she didn't know. Or knew and didn't want to say.

I got the answer later, from someone else. The woods had been cleared. As the Harvest grew, the woods, the marshes, the fallow ground — all of it became field. Nothing was left unused. I took that, at first, for diligence. Later I found another word for it. Leaving-nothing.

. . .

We started down the hill. The road grew more crowded the closer we came to the city.

Carts went back and forth. Carts loaded with wheat, empty carts, carts carrying people. Everyone looked busy. No one slowed their pace.

One cart passed close by us without stopping and splashed us with muddy water. Mud spattered Pikra's skirt. The driver didn't even look back.

"…He didn't even say sorry," I said, a little angry.

"…They're busy," Pikra said, brushing off her skirt. No anger in her voice. "Everyone's like that here. There's more to be gained from one more step forward than from stopping to apologize."

That remark stayed with me.

I took that exchange, that day, for nothing but a passing annoyance. Later I learned this was a sentence that summed up how the whole city runs. There's more to be gained from one more step than from an apology — that's exactly how the Roll treats people, too. That's precisely why there's no field for sorry.

. . .

We walked the fields road all afternoon. Some sections had already begun harvest.

I saw a machine cut wheat for the first time. It wasn't a person with a sickle. A great piece of iron moved at a steady pace from one end of the field to the other. Behind it came sacks filled not with bound sheaves, but with grain already threshed clean.

I watched that machine a long while. It was far faster than any sickle. What our household's three of us would have taken all day to

cut, that thing would probably finish in an hour.

"…Is that all wheat?" I asked, pointing at the sacks piled beside the machine.

"…Yes," Pikra said.

"…One of those would feed our whole settlement for years."

Pikra said nothing. I didn't understand, then, what that silence meant.

Now I know. The arithmetic was right — one of those sacks could feed our settlement for years. But something was missing from that arithmetic. That sack was never going to our settlement. It already had somewhere else to go. Abundance wasn't something shared. It was something calculated, and assigned.

A few people followed behind the machine, checking something. I thought they were gleaners.

"…What are those people doing?" I asked.

"…Checking if anything fell," Pikra said. "Not gleaners from below — that's Roll work. They're checking there's nothing left, because there shouldn't be."

"…Why shouldn't anything fall?"

Pikra looked at me for a moment before answering.

"…Because it's a loss," Pikra said. "Wheat on the ground goes to no one. They don't like that, here."

I turned that over as we walked. Wheat that goes to no one. I didn't know, then, that the phrase held another meaning too. Fallen wheat wasn't wheat that went to no one. It was wheat that was, by rights, meant to go to someone like me.

I would learn that a few chapters later. That afternoon, I only marveled at the machine and walked on.

. . .

As we neared the gate, a different kind of line came into view. Not a line of people — a line of carts.

Carts loaded with grain stretched in a long queue before a smaller gate beside the main one. Each one went in, someone came out and counted the sacks, wrote something down somewhere, and only then let it through.

I watched that scene a long while. It didn't take long for each cart to pass. The counter's hands were fast. They didn't even touch each sack. Their eyes swept it, they called a number, and wrote it down.

"…What are those people measuring?" I asked.

"…Quantity," Pikra said. "Which field it's from, how much came in. That all goes into the record too."

"…There are records even for wheat?"

"…For wheat, and for people," Pikra said. Her voice dropped. "Here, everything has a record. That's how this city runs."

Hearing that, I thought that tomorrow would be our turn to be counted that way. Eyes sweeping, a number called, written down. It looked quick and simple, for a cart. Whether it would be the same for a person, I didn't know yet.

I learned the answer the next day. A person is counted exactly the same as a cart. The only difference is that a cart isn't afraid of being counted.

. . .

As the sun sank, we reached a village not far from the gate. Just outside the wall, a settlement of people who made their living from those passing through it.

A small market stood at the edge of the village. I'd never seen one like it.

Every stall was piled with goods. Bread, dried fruit, cheese, vegetables preserved in oil. One stall sold nothing but white bread. Back at the settlement, we saw white bread once or twice a year, only on holidays. Here it was just being sold, every day. Anyone could buy it.

"…They sell that every day?" I asked.

"…Seems so," Pikra said.

I stopped a moment in front of the stall. The smell was good. Fresh-baked bread. Breathing it in, I felt something that wasn't quite hunger. I didn't know exactly what it was, then.

Now I know. It wasn't envy. It was something stranger than envy. The thought that something so common had never once, not once, been this plentiful at our settlement. I'd thought scarcity was simply how things were. Standing there, I felt for the first time that scarcity wasn't the natural state of things — we had simply been on the side where things were scarce.

Pikra gave my hand a light tug.

"…Let's go," Pikra said. "We can't afford it."

I felt ashamed at that. Had I looked like I meant to buy something?

"…I was just smelling it."

"…I know," Pikra said. And smiled a little. "Smelling's free, so that's fine."

We left the market and walked toward an inn. Walking, I kept glancing back. The white bread on the stall stayed in my sight. No one hesitated in front of it. People just came, set down money, and took the bread. I found that ease strange. So common, and yet so at ease with it.

I would meet that ease again, later. People were just as at ease in front of the Roll. To someone who possesses the common thing, it looks as though it was always naturally theirs. Someone who's never gone without is clumsy at even imagining what it is to go without.

We decided to stay there that night. Something like a small inn. We had almost no money, but what Pikra had covered one night.

At night I looked at the city wall through the window. Lights were lit in a row along the top. Those lights felt, somehow, like eyes watching us.

"…We go in tomorrow?" I asked.

"…Yes. In the morning," Pikra said.

"…Are you scared?"

Pikra was quiet a long while before answering.

"…If you ask am I scared, I'm scared," Pikra said at last. "But scared doesn't mean I'm not going."

I liked that. Admitting you're scared, and going anyway. I think that was the day I first learned that this is what courage is.

Courage isn't the absence of fear. I would confirm that sentence again and again through the rest of this book. There wasn't a single person who stood before the Roll unafraid. There were only those who stood there afraid, and those who were too afraid to come at all.

. . .

Before sleep that night, I asked one more thing.

"…Pikra." The name came fairly naturally now. "What will I be called tomorrow?"

"…What do you mean?"

"…My name isn't on the Roll. What do they write, when I'm registered?"

Pikra looked a little flustered by the question, for the first time.

"…They'll write Xene," Pikra said. "It's your name."

"…That's all? No more questions?"

"…There will be," Pikra said. "Where you're from, whose daughter you are, who you married. They'll ask things like that."

I didn't know, then, how my answers to those questions would be turned into arithmetic.

I'll write, in the next chapter, about standing at the gate. Before I close this one, I'll set down one thing. That night, before I fell asleep, I said my own name aloud a few times. Xene. Xene. I sensed, dimly, that the sound would carry a different meaning from tomorrow on. I didn't know exactly what meaning.

Outside the window I could hear insects crying. The same sound I used to hear at the settlement. That gave me a strange comfort. However large the city was, the insects that cried at night made the same sound they'd made in our field.

I remember that insect sound for a long time. After that night, I could never again listen to it so easily. After I went into the city, I developed a habit — even hearing insects cry at night, trying to tell whether the field they came from had standing or not. That night was the last night I ever slept without calculating anything.

(Continued in Chapter 8.)

Chapter 8. The Gate

> *_Previously_ — The two lodge overnight in the village outside the gate. Xene wonders how her name will be entered on the Roll, then falls asleep. Listening to the insects cry, she spends her last night sleeping without calculating anything.*

I woke to find Pikra already packed.

"…Sleep well?" I asked.

"…Not really," Pikra said. The shadows under her eyes were darker than the day before.

We shared bread and left the inn. The gate was less than half an hour's walk. As soon as we left the village, the crowd thickened. Everyone was walking the same direction.

I looked at their faces. All of them wore no expression. Some looked bored, some looked set hard. I wondered if we would look like one of those faces too, from the outside.

The gate wasn't what I'd imagined.

I'd pictured a door — a great gate with someone standing before it, letting some through and turning others away. But there was no door, not separately. Or rather, there was one, but it stood always open. What kept people out wasn't the gate. It was something inside the gate.

A line.

. . .

The line split in two. One short, one long. A sign hung over the short one: RENEWAL. Over the long one, a different sign: NEW REGISTRATION.

Looking at those two words, something struck me as wrong. That the short line was the renewal side. Confirming someone already there took no time; bringing someone new in took a long while.

"…Which one?" I asked Pikra.

"…That one, for me." Pikra pointed to the short line. "That one, for you." And the long line.

That was the moment I first truly understood that from today, we would stand in different lines. Until yesterday, we'd walked the same road.

I can still draw those two lines with my eyes closed. The short one and the long one. I would meet those same two lines again, many times, later in my life. The names changed every time. The shape never did.

. . .

We each stood in our own line, close enough to see each other. I spent the time watching the people ahead of me.

Inside the line stood a wide roof. No walls, only pillars, so you could see clear through. A device was mounted on every pillar. I'd never seen anything like it. A smooth, polished panel — letters appeared on it without anyone touching it.

Beside each device sat another box, about waist height. A low sound came from inside it. A humming sound — not from just one, but from the whole line, so the space under the roof was filled with it.

Now I know. That was the Roll. Part of it, at least. No one ever told me where the Roll as a whole was kept. But that day, I could tell at least this much — that sound was the sound the Roll made. The calculating never stopped. For every person standing in that line, at once.

A large board hung on the inner wall under the roof. Numbers kept changing on it. PROCESSED TODAY. The number beneath climbed slowly. I learned later that the number was how many people had passed through that gate that day.

I watched that board a long while. Each time the number climbed by one, it struck me as strange — that one number was one person. I would soon be added to that number too.

At the front of the line, a man stood before a device. The person watching the device asked him something. He answered briefly. The screen changed a few times. He nodded and walked on. It took barely five minutes.

I was surprised at how brief it was. I'd imagined something far more complicated.

Now I know. Renewal was meant to be that fast. There's no reason it should take long to confirm a name already there. What takes long is making a name that doesn't exist yet. And my line was the line doing that work.

Several people sat in a row at the devices. All dressed alike. There were as many screens as people, and every screen kept shifting numbers

and letters without pause. Watching those screens, I saw with my own eyes, for the first time, what the city called the Roll.

It was quieter than I'd expected. I'd imagined something loud — bells ringing, people shouting. It wasn't. Fingers tapping screens, low voices, that was all. That quiet made me more tense, if anything.

. . .

Pikra's line moved first. I watched from my own line.

The person seated at the device was young. A few years older than me, maybe. When Pikra stepped up, the person looked at the screen and asked,

"…Your name."

Pikra paused a moment. I knew what that pause meant.

"…Glyke," Pikra said. Her voice was low.

Hearing that name come out of her mouth, something in me felt strange. For three days I'd been practicing not calling her by that name — and here, the very owner of the name had to speak it herself, today.

That was the first time I understood something. Even wanting to change a name, there are names you cannot change before the Roll. The Roll doesn't know a new name. It only knows the old one. Pikra had to call, with her own mouth, at that gate, the very name she wanted to be rid of.

The person tapped the screen a few times. "…There's a prior registration. Some thirty-some years back. Exited by marriage,

relocated to an outer settlement."

"…Yes."

"…And the reason for returning?"

Pikra paused again, then said,

"…My husband died, and both my sons. I'm alone now."

The person showed no reaction to that at all. No change of expression. He entered something into the screen.

"…Confirmed," the person said. "I'll process the re-registration."

The screen changed a few more times. A number came up. I couldn't see it from where I stood. The angle was wrong.

"…This should keep your housing," the person said. "Though it's lower than before. Fewer dependents."

Pikra nodded. "…I know."

I thought about that moment for a long time afterward. Fewer dependents. The person said it without any weight at all. That was the first time I heard a husband and two sons called dependents.

The person handed Pikra a small card. About the size of a palm. Numbers and letters were etched on one side.

"…What's this?" Pikra asked.

"…A confirmation card," the person said. "Show it when you claim housing or rations. If you lose it, you'll need to have it reissued."

Pikra took the card in her hand. I didn't fully understand what she was holding, but I understood at least this — it was the object that proved Pikra existed, as a person, in this city.

I saw that card for the first time that day. And for a long time after, I wanted something like it, for myself. I wanted to be someone with something to show as proof. How long that wish would last, I didn't know then.

. . .

Pikra stepped aside and waited for me. I kept moving forward in my own line the whole time.

Most of the people ahead of me took long. New registration meant a lot of questions. Listening to their answers, I tried to guess what I would be asked myself.

"…Where are you from?"
"…Your parents' names?"
"…Marital status?"

One person couldn't answer any of it. Said they didn't know their parents. The person at the device checked something a few more times, then sent that person to a third line. I only noticed then that this third line had no sign at all.

I would meet that third line again, later. I'll only note its name here for now. It had no sign. It was more frightening for having none.

Another couple stood ahead of me. Young, holding an infant. As the husband answered, the wife kept rocking the baby to sleep. The person

at the device pointed at the child and asked,

"…No birth registration on this child."

"…Born outside," the husband said. "There was nowhere to register."

"…Would you like to register today, together?"

The couple looked at each other. Neither spoke for a moment. Then the wife nodded.

"…Yes."

The person entered something into the screen. I didn't see what number appeared. I only saw the wife hold the baby a little tighter.

I never saw that couple again. I don't know what number the child was given that day. But I remember, still, the hands with which the wife held her child a little tighter. Even at the moment a person's own child becomes a number, they hold the child with their body first.

. . .

My turn finally came.

Seen close up, the device was simpler than I'd expected. One panel, beside it a small box with a few holes in it, and thin lines running from the box down under the floor. I wondered where those lines led. Probably not just to this line — probably connected to every other line, all across the city.

The person at the device smiled at me. A courtesy smile. Not an unkind smile, but that only made it stranger to me. Outside, no one

smiled at a stranger like that.

"…Your name."

"…Xene."

"…Family name?"

I was caught off guard by that question. "…We don't have family names. We just use one name."

The person marked something on the screen. I didn't know what it meant.

"…Where are you from?"

"…Outside. A settlement. It doesn't have a name."

"…The settlement has no name?"

"…No."

The person tapped the screen, then stopped. "…It's not on the registered settlement list. I'll substitute coordinates."

That struck me as strange. That the place I was born and raised would be written down as coordinates instead of a name.

"…Your parents?"

I gave their names. The person tapped, then shook their head. "…No registration record. I'm guessing they were born and raised outside too?"

"…Yes."

"…Marital status?"

"…I was married. My husband died."

"…Your husband's name?"

I couldn't answer right away. I said earlier that I never once write that name in this record. That day at the gate, I hesitated too. But it was for a different reason than this record's. I was afraid to say the name. Afraid that saying it would turn it into a handful of numbers.

Now I know. The name did turn into numbers, in the end. Whether I said it or not made no difference. The Roll is a place that turns names into numbers. My hesitation changed nothing.

I said the name at last. The person entered it into the screen.

"…No marriage record," the person said, looking at the screen. "A marriage outside isn't subject to registration. Neither is a death."

Something inside me felt like it was collapsing. A person I'd lived with two years had, inside the Roll, simply never happened.

"…What about the fact I was married?"

"…It doesn't stay on record," the person said. No apology in their voice. A voice simply stating a fact. "What happens outside doesn't count, by our standard."

"…What about him dying?"

"…That too," the person said. And then, just for a moment, looked at me again. For the first time, not a purely clerical look. "I'm sorry.

I'm not saying it didn't happen. I'm only saying it doesn't count, by our standard."

That struck me, strangely, as honest. The person hadn't said my husband never died. They'd only said that death held no place inside this screen.

I didn't understand that distinction, that day. Now I do. The Roll doesn't lie. The Roll simply doesn't build a place to count certain things. The two are very different acts, but the result feels identical.

Pikra had been listening to that exchange, standing behind me. I didn't turn around, but I could feel it. Her breathing had quickened, a little, from its usual pace.

. . .

The person pressed one last screen. A small mark in the middle of it began to spin. A circle, turning.

"…Calculating," the person said. "One moment."

I watched that spinning mark. It looked like nothing much, but those few seconds felt longer than any I'd ever known.

Pikra took my hand beside me. Only then did I realize my hand had been shaking.

Outside the roof, the sound of carts, of people passing, went on as before. None of those sounds cared what state I was in. The city wasn't going to wait for my calculation to finish. In another line, someone was already giving their name for the next turn.

I felt that, strangely, as sorrow. The most important seconds of my life, and to someone else, just a scrap of passing noise.

I would meet that sorrow again and again, after that. This city never stopped for my circumstances. It never stopped for anyone's circumstances. I thought, at first, that this was unfair. Later I learned that the city took pride in exactly that. No special treatment for anyone. That fairness never once felt fair to me.

I remember those few seconds precisely, even now. My whole life, as I'd known it, was inside them. The settlement. The summer I learned the sickle. My husband. The three days Glyke became Pikra. All of it was, in that moment, turning into a single number on a screen.

The spinning stopped.

(Continued in Chapter 9.)

Chapter 9. No Standing

> *_Previously_ — At the gate, Xene finishes the new-registration process. Name, origin, parents, marital status — all of it goes into the screen. The mark in the center of the screen spins, the calculation beginning. Pikra takes her hand. The spinning stops.*

A number came up.

0

I looked at it a long while. Thinking I might have misread it, I looked again. It was still 0.

The person at the device stopped for a moment, looking at the screen. I didn't miss that pause. Up to then, the person hadn't stopped once.

"…One moment," the person said. And signaled to someone else nearby.

. . .

A moment later, another person came.

This one walked unhurried. No trace of rushing at all. Their clothes were different from the first person's too — a darker color, with a small insignia on the collar.

"…What's the matter," the person asked. Their voice was low and even.

"…New registration, output value zero," the first person said.

"…Let me confirm."

The new person took over the screen. Fingers moved across it a few times. I couldn't read anything from those movements.

"…That's correct," the person said. Still the same even voice. "Zero is correct."

I remember that moment still. The person said the number without lowering their voice at all. No trace of apology. Just a plain statement of fact. I found that stranger than any comfort would have been.

. . .

"…Miss Xene." The person looked at me and spoke. It was the first time all day anyone had called me by my name that way. "May I explain a little?"

I nodded. My voice wouldn't come.

"…A standing of zero isn't rare," the person said. "It happens when there's no origin record, when a marriage occurred outside and isn't recognized, and when there's no inherited value. The calculation isn't wrong."

"…So what happens to me?"

"…Nothing happens," the person said.

I didn't understand what that meant.

"…Are you expelling me?"

"…No." The person shook their head. Very slightly. "We don't expel anyone."

This is a sentence I probably return to more often than any other in this whole book. We don't expel anyone. *I heard it many more times after that. Every time, it was true. And every time, the fact that it was true was the most frightening part of it.*

. . .

A few people waiting nearby glanced over at the exchange. No one interrupted. Everyone simply waited their turn. I found that strange. That someone receiving a zero wasn't, here, a particularly unusual event.

"…Does this happen often?" I asked.

The person glanced at a corner of the screen for a moment. I saw a small table there. A column of numbers.

"…This is the seventeenth today," the person said. As casually as checking the time. "It varies by season, but ten to twenty a day, usually."

I lost my words at that number. Twenty a day. Then, in a year. I couldn't finish the calculation.

That was the first time I understood I wasn't suffering some special misfortune. That fact should have been a comfort. It wasn't. It frightened me more. This city was already very much used to manufacturing twenty people like me, every single day.

I looked around. Here and there in the line, a few people took their confirmation cards and quietly stepped away. I couldn't tell, from the outside, which of them had received a zero. Everyone walked at the same pace, the same gait. No one cried. No one raised their voice.

That quiet struck me as the strangest part of all. I learned later. Those people already knew that shouting would do nothing. A person who knows it's pointless goes quiet. I read that quiet, that day, as grief. Now I know it was resignation as well. The two wear similar faces. They aren't the same thing.

. . .

"…Expulsion isn't within our authority," the person said. "What we do is renewal. If you have standing, we renew you. If you don't, we don't. That's all."

"…What happens if it's not renewed?"

The person looked at me a moment before answering.

"…No rations will come. You can't apply for housing. You can't take formal work, either," the person said, one item at a time, as if reading a list. "Your name doesn't go onto the Roll. That's all."

"…That's the same as expelling me."

"…No," the person said again. No anger in it, no change in tone. "We aren't telling you to leave, Miss Xene. You may stay here. We simply have nothing to give you."

I turned that sentence over many times, that night. Nothing to give you. Not taking something away — giving nothing. The person knew that

distinction with total precision, and said it precisely. That precision was what frightened me.

. . .

"…What did I do wrong?" I asked. The question came out of me before I'd meant to ask it.

The person looked at me for a moment. For the first time, the answer was a little slow.

"…No," the person said. "You've done nothing wrong. Standing isn't a measure of wrongdoing. It's a measure of what you have and what you don't."

"…So this happened because I have nothing?"

"…That's right," the person said. Calmly. "No possessions, zero. It isn't meant unkindly. It's simply arithmetic."

"…Can I see how it was calculated?"

The person looked at me a moment, then turned the screen so I could see. I hadn't expected that.

A short list was on the screen.

Origin contribution — 0
Inherited value — 0
Marital union value — not recognized
Residency history — 0
Total — 0

I read it line by line. Each line had a number, and every number was zero. None of the lines looked miscalculated. That was what made it harder.

"…That's everything?" I asked.

"…That's everything," the person said. "Five fields. You had no value in any of the five."

"…What about the marriage? I was married."

"…Marital union value is a field that combines two people's standing," the person said. "But it only applies to a marriage registered on the Roll. Your marriage took place outside, and your husband died before registration. There was no standing inside the Roll for it to combine with."

Listening to that explanation, I watched the two years of my life shrink into five lines. And every one of those five lines, zero.

I still have that list memorized. I tried to forget it. It wouldn't let go. Some numbers cling to a person that way.

Hearing that, I felt, oddly, a little relieved. And that relief shamed me at once. I was feeling relieved by the words of someone who had just told me they would give me nothing.

Now I know. That relief wasn't my fault. A person finds it easier to bear being calculated without feeling than being told they are hated. The Roll didn't know that and speak that way on purpose. It only happens that speaking that way moves a person's heart that direction, regardless.

. . .

"…Can it change?" I asked. My voice shook.

"…Standing is a calculated value," the person said. "If the calculation changes, the value changes. If you marry, or a relation forms with someone who has standing, or the value comes through some other channel."

"…And right now?"

"…Right now, it's zero," the person said. Very simply. "That's all there is."

I looked at their face. Not angry, not sorry. Just the face of someone doing their job.

"…This was done according to the law?" I asked. I didn't know why I asked. I just wanted to ask it.

"…Of course," the person said. And for the first time, smiled a little. A kind smile. "We don't do anything outside the law."

I remember that smile for a long time. It wasn't an unkind smile. It was truly a kind one. And yet every time I saw that smile, a chill ran through me. That person genuinely believed they were doing something right. And they were right — at least, before the law.

Behind that person, on the wall, I saw a small placard, tucked among other notices. "Roll Law, Article 2 — All residency standing is determined by calculation, and shall be neither granted nor revoked for any reason outside that calculation."

I read that sentence twice. I understood about half of it.

Now I know. That article was the sentence holding up this whole city. Neither granted nor revoked for reasons outside calculation. So the

person giving me nothing wasn't doing it from hatred — they were keeping that article. And if I was ever to receive something, later, it too would have to be arithmetic, not pity, not hatred. I read that article that day without yet knowing what this city truly feared.

. . .

"…Any further questions?" the person asked.

I said no. In truth there were many, but none of them would form into words, right then. *Why me* rose to my throat and went back down. I knew, even without being told, that it wasn't a question.

"…Then that's all," the person said. "Thank you for coming such a distance."

I turned that last remark over for a long time. Thank you for coming such a distance. A courteous thing to say. Perhaps meant sincerely. But that courtesy was the most frightening part of all. If the person had been throwing me out, I could have hated them. But they didn't throw me out. They simply gave me nothing, and said goodbye, politely.

Pikra came and took my arm. She said nothing. I could tell, from the strength in her grip, how worried she was.

We walked a few more steps into the city and stopped, just off the main flow of people.

"…Are you all right?" Pikra asked.

"…Yes," I said. It wasn't a lie. It wasn't the whole truth, either.

Pikra studied my face for a long while.

"…I tried to stop you three times," Pikra said. Not an angry voice. "Go, go, go, I said. And you didn't."

"…I don't regret it."

"…I know," Pikra said. "But I'm still sorry."

I shook my head at that.

"…It wasn't something you made me do. I chose it."

Pikra said nothing for a moment, then gripped my hand a little tighter.

"…That's true," Pikra said. "You chose it. That doesn't make the sorry go away."

I didn't understand that, at the time. Why Pikra should be sorry for something I'd chosen. Now I know. Some people, seeing another person carry something in their place, don't let go of the sorry even knowing it was that person's own choice. That sorry wasn't guilt. It was love, turned into weight.

. . .

I glanced back once as we passed through the gate. The person was already looking at the next in line. Whatever had happened to me was already, to them, something past.

At the far end of the line, I saw that couple again. The one with the baby. The wife stood with the child in her arms, receiving something onto her confirmation card. I didn't know what number they'd received. Only that their faces looked a little brighter than ours.

I envied that. And the envy shamed me.

I remember that retreating figure for a long time. Not a bad person. I still think that, even now. That person had simply done their job exactly, precisely as they'd set out to do it. But inside that precision, there was no room for mercy to stand. Mercy had no field in the calculation. There was no reason it should.

Pikra kept walking, not letting go of my hand. Walking beside her, I felt that something had gone missing, between the self I'd known this morning and the self I was now. I didn't know, then, exactly what it was.

Now I know. What was gone wasn't standing. I never had standing to begin with. What was gone was the self I'd been before I knew I would be recorded nowhere in this city. That self doesn't come back.

"…We don't expel anyone." Walking, I said the words over to myself again, silently. However many times I repeated them, they sounded strange. How could not expelling and giving nothing live inside the same sentence at all — I didn't know the answer, that day.

I would come to know the answer a little at a time, in the next chapter — going deeper into the city, seeing how people like me actually lived. The answer was inside the gate. It only took a few days for me to learn to recognize it.

Pikra walked on ahead. I followed, and felt, freshly, that I was holding nothing in my hands. No confirmation card, no small tablet, nothing. Nothing to receive meant nothing to hold. I kept telling myself that was only natural, and still that day I learned, for the first time, how heavy empty hands could be.

(Continued in Chapter 10.)

Chapter 10. Nobody Drove Us Out

> *_Previously_ — Xene's standing computes to zero. The administrator*
> *explains: it isn't expulsion, only a refusal to renew. He was courteous. That courtesy frightened Xene more than anything else had.*

Inside the gate was another city again.

Seen from outside, the city had been one great, distant mass. Inside, that mass became roads, became houses, became people. Among all of it I lost my footing for a moment.

Pikra took my hand and led me.

"…Housing first," Pikra said.

. . .

The housing office wasn't far from the gate. Another device stood there. That was the third device I'd seen that day alone.

Pikra held up her confirmation card. Something appeared on the screen.

"…Alone?" the person at the device asked.

Pikra glanced at me. Very briefly.

"…Yes," Pikra said.

I said nothing to that answer. I knew it wasn't a lie. On paper, Pikra really was alone. I was a person who existed nowhere on paper.

I remember that moment still. It would be a lie to say it didn't hurt. But I didn't resent Pikra for it, even then. She'd only stated a fact. It was the fact that hurt me, not her.

. . .

The room was small. One room. Near the wall, in an old building, on the third floor. The stairs were narrow and dark.

Inside, Pikra set down our things first. Then she looked at me.

"…I was worried whether we could live here at all," Pikra said. "Even if the paper only says me, no one comes in and tells you to leave. No one checks inside a room."

"…Are you sure?"

"…I'm sure," Pikra said. "That isn't what this city does. This city only asks at the door. It doesn't ask what's inside."

Strangely, that gave me comfort.

I would learn how shallow that comfort was, later. No one checking inside the room wasn't kindness. It was indifference. Not thinking something worth checking is also a form of indifference.

. . .

That evening, Pikra came back with our first ration, using her confirmation card. One sack. A little flour mixed with dried beans.

"…This is one person's share," Pikra said, setting the sack down. "There isn't a separate share for you."

I heard that and tried not to think about being hungry. It didn't work well.

We shared that one person's share between the two of us, that night. The amount was cut in half. Pikra kept pushing more of her own portion toward me. I let her, pretending I wasn't giving in easily.

That night I learned hunger all over again. There'd been hungry days at the settlement too. But that was from a failed harvest. It wasn't that here. The fields were overflowing with wheat. That wheat simply had no road that led to me.

. . .

The next day, I went out alone. Pikra had come down with a fever and was lying in. No surprise, after a full day's walk.

I just walked. No destination. I only wanted to see what shape this city took.

The streets were clean. That was the first thing I noticed. Back at the settlement, the road was always mixed with dirt and animal dung. Here there was none of that. The pavement was smooth. No litter in sight.

Now I know. It wasn't that there was no trash — it was that there were people who cleaned it. I didn't see a single one of them that

day. They worked in hours no one watched.

At the edge of the market, I saw people carrying loads. Sacks on their backs, hauling. They didn't seem to be paid on any regular wage. When the work was done, the owner of the goods pressed something into their hand and walked off. A few coins.

I watched that scene a long while. The one who'd carried the load didn't even count the coins before pocketing them. I found that strange. If the money were precious enough to count, you'd count it.

Now I know. There was no need to count. Whatever the amount, they already knew it was all they'd get that day. Where there's no set wage for a job, there's no room to dispute it either.

I watched that porter walk off looking for the next load. No one asked his name. Once the work was done, he simply became a nobody again.

In another alley, a few children were picking up things off the ground. Fruit peels, wood scraps, unidentifiable things. At first I thought it was a game. Coming closer, I saw it wasn't. Some of the things they picked were genuinely useful, and went into a sack.

I watched those children, and my eyes met one child's for a moment. The child looked at me briefly, then turned away without any expression. Not wariness, not welcome. Just a look that knew I was nothing to it at all.

At the mouth of one alley, I saw someone like myself for the first time.

An old man. Sitting against a wall. His clothes were worn but clean. He was thin, but not the wasted look of someone starving to death.

I passed by and slowed my step. The old man looked up at me.

"…First time here?" the old man asked.

"…Yes," I said. "…How did you know?"

"…Your shoes," the old man said. "Worn different from ours."

I didn't understand and stayed quiet.

"…We all wear our shoes about the same way," the old man said. "We walk the same rounds, over and over. Yours are still shoes that go anywhere."

. . .

"…What do you do for food?" I asked.

"…Go by the market around closing time," the old man said. "What didn't sell, what's a shame to throw out — some people set it aside. Not bad people. Kind, if anything."

"…If kind people are giving it to you, isn't that all right?"

The old man looked at me a moment, then laughed. A bitter laugh.

"…Giving from kindness and giving you a place are two different things," the old man said. "They'll give food. But no one registers you here. No one gives you a room. It just keeps you from going hungry that one day."

"…Where do you sleep?"

"…Here," the old man said. He gestured at the spot he sat in. "This wall blocks the wind. When it rains I go to that eave over there."

"…What about the cold days?"

The old man was quiet a moment.

"…Some people didn't make it through the cold ones," the old man said. Calmly. As though it weren't about himself. "But that wasn't the city killing them, either. The city didn't do a thing."

I only found that strange, that day. Now I know. That's the sentence that became this chapter's title. Nobody drove us out. Nobody killed anyone. And yet people die. With no one having done anything.

. . .

Just then, two people who looked like patrol officers passed through the alley. Tidy clothes. An unhurried walk.

One of them stopped in front of the old man. I tensed for a moment. Outside, that kind of stopping usually meant someone about to be driven off.

"…Good morning, sir," the officer said. Genuinely wishing a good morning, by the sound of it.

"…So it is," the old man said. As if used to this.

"…Nothing happened overnight?"

"…Nothing."

"…Good to hear." The officer smiled and walked on. Talking with their partner about something else entirely, in a voice that had already moved on.

I watched their backs for a long while.

"…What were they here for?" I asked.

"…A patrol," the old man said. "Comes by a couple times a day. Asks if anything's wrong, and goes."

"…That's all?"

"…Yes, that's all," the old man said. "They're not bad people. They really do ask because they're concerned. But after asking, they don't do anything about it. There's nothing for them to do. That isn't their job."

I remember that moment precisely, even now. That was the first time this city's kindness gave me a chill. Those people were sincerely kind. They genuinely wanted to know if the old man was all right. And that kindness changed nothing at all. That kindness and indifference could wear the same face — I saw that for the first time, that day.

. . .

"…I've lived here going on fifteen years," the old man said. "In all that time, no one's ever once told me to leave. Truly. Not once."

"…Then why live this way, here?"

"…Because it's the same everywhere you go," the old man said. "It isn't that this city is cruel to me. This city does nothing to me at

all. It just doesn't give me anything either. How long that can go on, you'll find out for yourself soon enough."

I found that frightening. That word, *soon*.

"…Were you born here?"

"…No," the old man said. "I came from somewhere too. Doesn't matter where, anymore. It's been too long since I came."

"…What's your name?"

The old man smiled a little at that.

"…I have one. No one asks it here. No reason to," the old man said. "You asked, so I'll tell you sometime."

"…What was it like at first, for you?"

The old man looked up at the sky for a moment.

"…Everyone was kind to me at first," the old man said. "Gave me bread in passing, told me directions. I thought that was a good sign. But that was all there was to it. Plenty of kind people. No one gives you a place."

. . .

The old man held out half a piece of bread to me.

"…It's all right," I said. "I still have food."

"…Today," the old man said. "Tomorrow, who knows. Take it."

I took it, unable to refuse. Holding it, my hand shook. Not from hunger.

I thought a long time that night about why my hand had shaken. I'd just received help from someone. And it gave me no comfort at all. The city hadn't driven me out. And this old man had fed me. Both were true at once. Between those two truths, I felt a chill. This city's kindness came from people like this old man. It didn't come from the city itself. The city only hadn't stopped this old man from feeding me.

. . .

I sat a while longer, watching people pass. The old man kept talking.

"…See that one there." He pointed to someone walking quickly, device in hand. "People like that don't see people like us. Not that they won't look — they truly don't see. To someone with standing, we look about the same as a road, or a wall."

"…Because they're bad people?"

"…No," the old man shook his head. "If they were bad, that'd be better, even. A bad person at least sees you. Those people don't. No reason to."

I turned that over. I thought of what Pikra had said, on the road. *Strange isn't strange here.* I'd taken that, then, for nothing at all. Now I was learning how heavy that nothing could be. Not being seen, and being chosen not to be seen — the results looked the same, but they were different things. From then on I tried to tell the two apart.

I stayed with the old man a little longer. The sun was going down. People's steps quickened around us. Everyone was on their way back somewhere.

"…Aren't you going back somewhere?" I asked.

The old man smiled.

"…This is where I go back to," the old man said. "While everyone else is going back to their own place, I'm already at mine. Sometimes that's a good thing. Sometimes it's a sad one."

I had nothing to say to that.

"…It's right there in the law, you know. That article," the old man said, suddenly.

"…Which article?"

The old man looked at me, then waved a hand.

"…Next time," the old man said. "I've talked too much today."

I kept thinking about that, that night. Some article. I didn't know what it was, then. I only felt, from the old man's eyes, that it wasn't a bad thing. For the first time, a different light passed through his eyes. Not resignation, not kindness. Something else. I had no name for it, then.

. . .

I came home to find Pikra awake.

"…Where were you?" Pikra asked.

"…Just walking," I said. I didn't mention the old man. I didn't know, even then, why I didn't.

Pikra studied my face.

"…Did something happen?"

"…No." I quietly hid the half a loaf in my hand. "…Just seeing the city."

I ate that bread that night, in secret, while Pikra slept. Guilt came with it. I didn't quite know why. Maybe it was that this was the first thing I'd received in this city, and it hadn't come from the city at all, but from some stranger, an old man. That fact left me strangely ashamed.

Pikra pushed herself up against the wall.

"…Xene," Pikra called.

"…Yes."

"…If it's hard, say it's hard," Pikra said. "You can, with me."

I couldn't answer that. Saying it wasn't hard would be a lie, and saying it was hard would only make Pikra feel worse. In the end I said nothing at all.

Looking back, I should have said something, then. But I was already learning, by then, that in this city, sometimes not speaking is safer. I didn't know, then, how long that lesson would follow me.

That night, before sleep, I thought again of the old man's words. An article in the law. I would learn what it was within a few days.

(Continued in Chapter 11.)

Chapter 11. Article Nine

> *_Previously_ — From an old man she meets in the city, Xene hears how*
> *people without standing actually live. No one drives them out. No one simply gives them anything. Even the patrol was kind. The old man mentions "an article in the law," then puts it off for another time.*

I did nothing much, those three days. Pikra and I set the room in order. I baked bread from the flour we'd been given. I learned where to draw water. Becoming a city person, it turned out, meant a succession of small, ordinary tasks like these.

Pikra grew quieter over those few days. That worried me, but I didn't ask. I was already learning, by then, that asking also takes a kind of strength.

Those three days looked like nothing happened, on the outside. But the whole time, inside, I was turning the old man's words over and over. An article in the law. I pretended to forget it. I never did. At night, closing my eyes, it was the first thing that came to mind, and in the morning, opening them, it was still there.

Three days later I went back to that alley.

I told myself, at the time, that I hadn't gone on purpose. That I'd just been walking and my feet happened to go that way. Looking back now, that was a lie. I went on purpose, wanting to know what that article was.

The old man was in the same spot. Same wall, same posture. As if not three days but a single hour had passed.

"…Back again," the old man said. No surprise in it.

"…Yes." I sat down beside him. "…Will you tell me about that article?"

The old man looked at me for a moment. Something gauging in his eyes.

"…In a hurry, aren't you," the old man said. And laughed.

. . .

"…It's called the corner clause," the old man said. "Ever heard of it?"

"…No."

"…When they harvest, they're supposed to leave the corners of the field," the old man said. "By law. A very old law. They say it's been there since this city was founded, though I don't know that for certain."

"…What does *leave the corner* mean?"

"…That the designated corners of a field — the four corners — are left unreaped," the old man said. "And they're not supposed to gather the fallen grain, either. It isn't the harvesters' share."

That struck me as strange. At the settlement, not gathering what fell was simply how things were. Here, they'd made it a law. That felt foreign.

"…So whose share is it, then?"

The old man looked at me and said, slowly,

"…Ours," the old man said. "The share of those with no standing."

. . .

Something inside my chest lifted a little, in that moment. The first feeling like that since the zero I'd been handed at the gate.

"…Is that true? So if I go there, there's actually something?"

"…There's supposed to be," the old man said. His voice sank a little. "By law."

I let that phrase — *by law* — catch in me, but not enough to weigh it down, not then.

"…Why is there a law like this?"

The old man thought for a moment.

"…I don't know the real reason either," the old man said. "I only know it's a rule from way back. Not to reap it all clean, at harvest. Something about the ones who have leaving a little for the ones who don't. Something like that, I think."

"…Was it ever abolished?"

"…Not as far as I know," the old man said. "This city's remade and changed a hundred other laws in that time. That one stayed. Maybe it's just too old for anyone to think of touching."

"…Strange, isn't it. Why wouldn't an old law like that just disappear."

The old man shrugged.

"…Maybe because no one loses anything by leaving it be," the old man said. "Now that the Roll handles the reaping, that clause hardly changes anything, whether it's there or not. So no one bothers taking it out."

I let that pass, lightly, at the time. I didn't yet see the distance between *no reason to remove it* and the real reason being that it left nothing behind anyway.

Now I know. The old man already knew the answer, then. He simply didn't say it to me straight out. I think he wanted me to go see for myself. He knew there's a difference between being told a thing and seeing it with your own eyes.

I remember that moment for a long time. It was the first thing I could call hope, since coming into this city. A very small hope. And still, that smallness was large, to me, that day. Up to then I'd only thought in terms of receiving — receiving, or not receiving. But Article Nine told me not of receiving, but of a place to go and glean. The difference didn't feel large, then. Now I know it is. Gleaning carries a share that's mine — the walking there, and the bending down.

. . .

"…Where do I go, then?" I asked.

The old man gestured roughly in a direction.

"…All around the city is field," the old man said. "Somewhere in there are the marked-off sections. Stakes driven in, they said. I haven't been myself, not in a long while."

"…Is it at every field, this spot?"

"…Probably. There's more than one field, so probably more than one spot," the old man said. "Start with the near ones. I heard there are a few within half an hour's walk of the wall."

I gauged that distance. Half an hour meant a place I could go every day.

"…Can I go every day?"

"…There's no law against going every day," the old man said. "Whether there's anything there, every day — that I don't know."

I let that too — *what's there, I don't know* — pass, lightly. I was already picturing tomorrow morning.

"…Why don't you go?"

The old man paused a moment at that question.

"…No point," the old man said. His voice went low.

I didn't quite catch what he meant, then.

"…No point, how?"

"…I've been a few times. Not much there," the old man said. "The law's the law, but these days the machines do the reaping. When it was done by hand, there was always something dropped. These days…" He let the words trail off.

"…It was different, before?"

The old man looked into the distance.

"…Before — when I first came here," the old man said. "You'd go to the corner and there really would be something. Stalks, grain. A day's worth, off that. Because a person cutting with a sickle naturally spilled some."

"…And now?"

"…Now the machines reap," the old man said. "A machine doesn't spill. No reason to. I've watched it with my own eyes. What's left in the corner shrinking, year by year. First a sack. Then half a sack. Then a handful. These days…"

The old man stopped there.

"…These days what?"

"…Go see for yourself. Better than my telling you," the old man said.

Writing this exchange down now, I understand why the old man didn't finish it, that day. Some facts, heard in words, become only information. Seen with your own eyes, they become something else. The old man didn't want to hand me information. He wanted me to know it myself.

. . .

That comment troubled me, but the hope that had just risen in me was larger.

"…I'll go anyway," I said.

The old man looked at me. Not a face trying to stop me. Not a face egging me on, either.

"…Go," the old man said. "Go see for yourself. I just don't have the strength for it anymore. That doesn't mean you shouldn't go."

"…If it's a place set by law, it's no trouble for someone with no standing to glean there, is it?"

"…None at all," the old man said. "That's ground set aside as ours from the start. Even the Roll doesn't touch that far. It's the law."

I felt easier, hearing that. At least going to that place, itself, couldn't be stopped by anyone.

I didn't really hear the old man's no point *that day. I only heard what I wanted to hear. There's a law. There's a place. That place is ours. Those three sentences were enough for me. I let every condition attached to them pass, that day.*

. . .

"…What's it called, that law? The proper name," I asked.

The old man thought for a moment, searching his memory.

"…I've heard it called Article Nine," the old man said. "I don't know if that's exactly right. I've only heard the people working the fields call it that."

Article Nine. I said the number over to myself.

"…I'll remember that number," I said.

The old man smiled a little at that.

"…You've got the face of someone who could live on that alone, for months," the old man said.

I didn't understand what that meant, then. Now I do. The old man already knew, that day, how long I'd cling to that single hope.

. . .

On my way home, I passed through the market. In front of a bakery I saw again the person carrying a basket I'd seen before. I worked up the nerve to approach.

"…Excuse me, I have something to ask."

The person looked at me and nodded.

"…Have you heard of the corner clause?"

"…Oh, that." No surprise showed on their face. "It's in the law, yes. The corners of a field, unreaped."

I felt relieved all over again, that it was real.

"…So it's all right for someone with no standing to glean there?"

"…By law, yes," the person said. "That's how it's always been, I've heard."

"…Is it still kept, these days?"

The person looked at me a moment and made an odd face.

"…It's kept, sure," the person said. Their tone was strange. "The corners get left, for certain. I've seen the markers myself, passing by."

"…That's a relief, then."

"…Yes, well," the person said. Without saying more, they went on their way.

I took that well *for nothing but a vague answer, that day. Looking back now, that person hadn't told me everything either, just like the old man. It's kept — but whether there's anything inside it is a different question. Everyone in this city seemed to know that difference. I was the only one who didn't.*

. . .

I hurried home that night. I went back and forth for a long while over whether to tell Pikra.

In the end I didn't. I still don't quite know why. Maybe this hope was too small and fragile, and speaking it aloud felt like it might break it.

Pikra glanced at me as she prepared dinner.

"…You look different today," Pikra said.

"…Do I?"

"…Yes. Something happen?"

I hesitated a moment, then shook my head.

"…I just walked around a bit."

Pikra didn't press further. Instead, she put an extra ladle of soup in my bowl.

"…Whatever it was," Pikra said. "If it's good, it's good, and if not, it's not. I can tell, mostly, from your face."

I smiled a little at that. "…Then why not ask?"

"…If I ask, you'll have to make up an answer," Pikra said. "You'll tell me, when it's time."

I didn't fully understand that kindness, then. Now I know. Pikra had already learned not to rush me. Probably raising her sons, or maybe just on herself, she'd learned that lesson first.

Looking back, that was a wrong call, on my part. I went on carrying things alone like this, often, after that. Good news and bad both. Pikra didn't know, that day, what I'd found. What she would have said, if she had, I still wonder sometimes.

Before sleep that night, I kept repeating the words to myself. The corner clause. Article Nine of the law. The share set aside for us.

I pictured that place in the dark. I didn't know exactly what it looked like. I only imagined a corner of a field, untouched, quiet wheat standing there. The wind would blow, and it would sway too. Just imagining that sway made me feel, for the first time in days, that my body had grown lighter.

Looking back now, that imagining was naive. I don't regret the naivety. There are days a person can only bear by imagining naively.

That was one of those days for me.

I thought again of what I'd heard at the gate. *We don't expel anyone.* At the time, that had sounded only bleak. That night, it sounded different. Not expelling might also mean not stopping me from standing in that corner. If the Roll gave me nothing, I wanted to believe, at least, that no one could take away that small place the law had set aside.

I remember that night precisely, even now. It was the first night in this city I fell asleep waiting for something, rather than afraid. Fell asleep on expectation instead of fear, for the first time. The next morning, I made up my mind to go to that field before anything else.

I set down here that this was the first of a resolve that would repeat, many times, through this book. I would go on making this same resolve, again and again, after that. Some days the resolve was right. Some days it wasn't. That night, I didn't know which it would be. I only looked forward to tomorrow.

(Continued in Chapter 12.)

Chapter 12. The First Day

> *_Previously_ — From the old man, Xene hears of the corner clause,*
> *Article Nine of the law — that the corners of a field are to be left for those without standing. For the first time since entering the city, she feels something like hope, and falls asleep looking forward to the day ahead.*

The next morning, I woke before the sun had fully risen.

Pikra was still asleep. I got up quietly, drank a mouthful of water, and went out the door. I didn't say where I was going. Nothing was certain yet, and I thought there was no good in speaking it.

I tried, more than once, to write this morning differently — more reverently, or more full of feeling. I crossed it all out. That morning I simply woke, ordinarily, and put on my shoes, ordinarily. There was no special premonition.

. . .

Almost no one was out yet when I left. Traces of water still lay on the street. I couldn't tell if someone had sprinkled it in the night, or if it was only dew.

The air was cool. I liked that coolness, even knowing the heat would come back by noon. I liked walking through that early chill. The dust hadn't risen yet either. The pale haze I'd seen on the road lay still that morning.

It had been a long time since I'd set out to do something. Since coming into the city, I'd always been either dragged somewhere or pushed out of somewhere. This time I was walking toward a destination I'd chosen myself.

I walked about half an hour from the wall. The direction the old man had pointed.

The road was different from the market street I'd seen the day before. Fewer people. Grain warehouses stood in a row instead, their doors all shut. I passed those doors trying not to imagine how much lay stacked inside. I didn't manage it well.

Past the warehouses, the fields began. I was struck again by their size. Seeing it from the hill and walking straight into it were entirely different feelings.

The wheat was nearly all ripe. A deep gold color. Seeing that color, I knew the harvest would begin soon.

I remember that color still, even now. That field, that morning, was truly beautiful. I'll call this city frightening, many times, in this book. But that fright and that beauty don't cancel each other out. Both were true. I carried both truths with me, walking, that day.

. . .

I walked along the edge of the field. Not knowing which corner was which, I circled it for a long while.

Once I spotted something that looked like a stake and ran toward it. It was only a marker for the water channel. I swallowed the disappointment and kept walking.

People were already moving inside the field. The harvest hadn't properly begun yet, but some were checking something. I tried not to meet their eyes. I didn't know why, myself. Probably I wasn't sure I was even allowed to be there.

After a long while walking, I saw a wooden stake. Visible even from a distance. It looked different from the other stakes.

I hurried my steps toward it.

Coming close, I saw small letters carved into the stake. I read them slowly. Some article, some clause — I couldn't take in the exact wording, then. But I knew, at least, that this was the clause the old man had spoken of.

I had pictured this moment for a long time. Every night, for three days. Now that the moment had actually come, I found, strangely, that I could only stand there, saying nothing. The stake wasn't old. It looked freshly new. That newness comforted me, at the time. It looked, to me, like proof that this law was still being carefully kept, even now.

. . .

I stood before the stake and looked inside.

There was ground.

No wheat.

At first I thought I'd seen it wrong. I blinked a few times and looked again. Still nothing. Only dirt, and the marks of things pressed into it.

I crouched down. My hand dug through the dirt. Something hard came under my fingers. A stalk. A wheat stalk, trampled and broken. Some had only the stem left, the head torn away. Some still had the head attached, but crushed flat, the grain nowhere to be seen.

I found a few more like that. Gathered in my palm. It didn't come to more than a few handfuls.

There were footprints in the ground too. Not human footprints. Broad, flat tracks. I recognized them — the marks of a machine that had come to the boundary and turned back. The line stopped exactly at the stake. Not a hand's width over.

I stared at that track for a long while. That precision was what hurt worse. If the machine had drifted a little further in by accident and then turned back, I could at least have understood the accident. But that line was straight, as if drawn with a ruler. It wasn't an accident. It was arithmetic.

I walked the rest of the inside of the corner too, in case there was more in the opposite side. There wasn't. Every corner was the same. Trampled stalks, crushed heads, and dirt.

In one spot, the earth had been dug through, more than anywhere else. It looked like the trace of someone who'd been there before me. A handprint remained. I laid my own hand over it. It was about the same size.

I never learned whose hand that was. I still don't. I only know they crouched, as I did, and dug through this same dirt, as I did. And probably went home empty-handed, as I would. I never met that person. But that one handprint made me feel, somehow, as if I'd shared something with them. They too, probably, had heard of this place from

someone like the old man. And come, hoping, as I had, and crouched before this same dirt, as I did.

. . .

I stayed crouched there a long while.

I looked around further. Wondering if I'd come to the wrong place, if the real corner was somewhere else. I checked the stake again. It was the right place. The mark was exact. The boundary was clear.

The law was being kept. That place had, in fact, been left. There were no marks of any machine ever having been brought inside it. Only, there was nothing worth leaving, in there.

That was the first time, I think, that I saw this city's true face. Until then, I'd believed that if the law wasn't broken, everything was all right. That day I learned that a law can go unbroken and still leave a place entirely empty.

. . .

I sat there a long while, then wrapped the few handfuls I'd gathered in a small cloth. Better than nothing. I told myself I should still carry it home.

As I gathered it, I did a strange arithmetic. How many spoonfuls of gruel these few handfuls would make. It didn't look like it would come to even one day's worth. I found myself a stranger, doing that arithmetic. A few days before, I hadn't known how to make calculations like this at all. This city was teaching me.

Now I know. This was the first skill a person without standing learns in this city. The arithmetic of making what little you have last through days you have nothing. I learned that arithmetic for the first time that day, and for a very long time after, I couldn't put it down.

Getting up, my legs had gone numb. I didn't know how long I'd been sitting. The sun had climbed high.

Voices carried from far off. Someone working, on the other side of the field. Machine sounds mixed in. I felt, freshly, how close that empty place stood to those sounds. Over there, abundance. Here, emptiness. The line between them was a single stake.

I've never forgotten that distance. A few steps, that was all. A few steps, and abundance and emptiness were divided. And crossing those few steps was forbidden by law. Cross it, and you became a thief. I didn't want to become a thief.

I thought, suddenly, of the day my husband taught me the sickle. Don't cut too clean, he'd said, spill a little. What you spill isn't wasted, he'd told me. It's left behind.

I'd said, before, that I took that for a joke, that day. I never thought I'd stand here, before this empty corner, and think of it again.

He knew that spilling and leaving something behind were the same act. This city had turned the two exactly backward. It took pride in never spilling, never leaving anything. That was the first time I felt, in my body, how different the world he'd lived in was from this city's. The law used the same words. Leave the corner of the field. But the meaning of that leaving had changed entirely.

A single grain came up out of the dirt. Half broken. I set it on my palm and looked at it a long while. This was the whole of what the law had left for me. I searched for someone to blame it on. I couldn't find anyone. Blaming the machine was pointless — the machine was only a machine. Blaming the law was pointless — the law was being kept. Blaming a person was pointless — I didn't even know who that person would be.

That was the first time I understood there is a grief with no one to blame. It's far heavier than a grief with someone to blame. With nowhere to send your anger, that anger, in the end, turns back inward.

. . .

Walking home, I thought again of the old man's words. *No point.* I'd let it pass, at the time. Now I knew exactly what it meant.

I tried not to cry, walking. Whether I managed it, I don't know. My face was hot.

I won't say, in this passage, whether I cried or not. There's a reason. Whether I cried or not isn't what matters here. What mattered was whether I would go back to that place again. That day, I walked home without having decided that yet. I kept holding that one grain in my hand the whole way.

. . .

I came home to find Pikra waiting at the door.

"…Where were you?" Pikra asked. Worry was plain in her voice.

I slipped the cloth in my hand into my pocket.

"…Just went for a walk," I said.

Pikra studied my face. She looked as if she wanted to ask something, and held it back.

"…Dinner's ready," Pikra said. "Let's eat."

We ate together again that evening. I said nothing. Pikra asked nothing. We ate dinner like that, and lay down like that. As if nothing had happened at all.

I set the few handfuls, wrapped in cloth, down quietly in one corner of the room. I don't know if Pikra saw them. Even if she had, she wouldn't have said anything. I didn't eat that handful that night. Only the next morning did I mix it into the gruel. The amount was so small I could barely tell it was there at all.

At the time, I thought that was consideration. I learned later. It wasn't consideration. It was that Pikra didn't know the answer either. It had been too long since she'd left this city. She only knew the corner clause was still there. She didn't know what was left in the corner.

. . .

I lay awake in the dark, eyes open. Beside me, Pikra's breathing was steady.

I went back over the day in my mind. Waking before dawn. Walking half an hour. Seeing the stake. Seeing there was nothing there. Gathering a few handfuls. Walking home again.

The law had been kept. That was the strangest part. I thought I would rather have been deceived by someone — then I could have hated the one who deceived me. But no one had deceived me. The corner really had been left. There was simply nothing inside it.

I lay in the dark thinking whether to go again tomorrow. At first I leaned toward not going. The old man had been right. *No point.* It had been a wasted trip. But thinking a little further, another question rose. If I don't go, then what will I do. Sit in this room, taking my half-portion from whatever Pikra shares out, day after day?

I found no answer to that question. Without an answer, I made up my mind to go again. Not because the hope had returned. Whatever hope I'd felt that day, I'd already spent it, entirely, in that field. I decided to go again simply because going would shame me less than not going.

I thought little of this decision, at the time. Now I know. This decision made the months that followed. I didn't go out because hope was there — I went out to test whether I could go, even with no hope at all. I didn't know the difference, then. Now I think it's the most important difference in this whole book.

I turned onto my side and looked at Pikra's back. I had come this far, following her. When she told me three times to go back, I hadn't gone. If someone asked whether I regretted that choice, I would have said no, even that night. Only that night was the first time I paid the price of that choice, in my own body.

I close the first part of this book on this chapter. Part One was the story of my following this woman into the city. Following my mother, into a place I knew would cost me my standing. I didn't know, then, exactly what that price was. Now I do. The price wasn't expulsion. It was standing, every day, before an empty corner.

A different story begins from here. The story of going out, day after day, to a field where nothing falls. I set down that first day today. I went out the next day too. And the day after that. Why, I'll let come clear, little by little, in the part that follows. For now I'll only set down this much — I came home empty-handed, and said nothing, and the next day, went out again.

(Continued in Part Two.)

The Gleaning Ground, Part Two

The Field Where Nothing Falls

Chapter 13. The Loss Rate

> *_Previously_ — Xene went looking for the corner of the field that was supposed to be left, even for those with no standing. What she found there was a few handfuls of trampled, broken stalks.*

That night I didn't ask Pikra anything.

She must have seen me come in empty-handed. Our room was one room; there was nowhere to hide it. But Pikra didn't ask either. We split what there was for supper, and both lay down as if nothing had happened.

I thought, at the time, that this was consideration. I learned later that it wasn't. Pikra didn't know the answer any more than I did. She had been gone from this city too long. She still believed the corner clause was there — she just didn't know what the corner actually held.

In the night, the machines were running out toward the fields. The same sound as by day. I found that strange. Outside, we put the sickle down when the sun went down. Cutting in the dark meant cutting your own hand. The machines here didn't know it was dark.

The sound went on all night. It never cut off and started again. It just went, level and continuous. I lay listening to it and thought of our field back home. Our field went quiet when the sun set. I learned that night, for the first time, how precious that quiet was.

There was no light in the room, so I couldn't see the ceiling. I lay in the dark replaying what I'd seen that day. Trampled stalks. Broken grain. Things so

mixed into the dirt I couldn't tell grain from clod.

Outside, that would have meant someone had stolen the place bare. If there was a thief, you could curse the thief. Here there was no thief. Nobody had simply left anything there.

I didn't know that night how large that difference was. When you're robbed, you know whose fault it is. When nothing at all is left, you go looking for someone to blame, and eventually you end up wondering whether you came to the wrong place, whether the fault is your own. I kept turning that thought over for a long time afterward.

. . .

The next day I went out again.

This time I didn't go to the field. I went toward the market. Not to buy anything. I thought if I went where the crowds were, I might be able to ask something.

The Harvest's market was bigger than any market I had ever seen. Outside, there had been nothing you could call a market — a few households bartering, that was all. Here the lines went on without end, and every line had something piled behind it. Sacks of flour stacked as high as a person in some places, fruit sorted by color in others.

I walked past trying not to think about being hungry. It didn't work well.

There was a bakery too. Every time the oven door opened, the smell reached to the end of the street. The line wasn't long. People stood as a matter of course, bought as a matter of course, left as a matter of course. Nobody looked at that bread as if it were anything special.

I still remember that bakery. I remember its name too. I won't write it here. I'll only note that I stood in front of it for a few seconds without moving. It wasn't only hunger. Well — it was hunger too. But more than that, it was the strangeness of the fact that this was nothing at all, to everyone but me.

There was a board standing at the market's entrance. I had never seen anything like it. A wide flat screen, and numbers on it that kept changing. People glanced at it in passing and kept walking. Nobody stood there long. It was just always there.

I stood there a long time.

At the top of the screen was the city's name. Underneath were several lines, most of them words I didn't understand. But one line caught my eye.

Harvest efficiency: 99.98%

I didn't even know at first whether that was a good number or a bad one. Ninety-nine point ninety-eight out of a hundred was close enough to a hundred that I assumed it must be good. But I didn't know what it was an efficiency of.

An older person was standing beside me, a shopping basket on their arm — someone who lived nearby, by the look of it. I worked up the nerve to ask.

"…What's that number?"

The person glanced at me, then at the screen, and answered without much thought.

"…Ratio of what's brought in to what's spilled. That close to the top, it means almost nothing's spilled."

"…How much is spilled?"

"…Point-oh-two out of a hundred." the person said. "They used to be nowhere near this good at bringing it all in. Machines are better now."

Then they went on their way. Without a second thought.

I don't resent that person. I still don't. They were only passing along good news. In this city, that really was good news. It only became bad news on the side where people like me stood.

I read the small print under the board further. There was a line comparing it to last year's figure. Last year it had been 99.91 percent. The year before, 99.7. I traced the numbers below that with my finger. Five years back, the high 98s. Ten years back, the high 96s.

I didn't understand what that meant at the time. I understand now. It was a record of how, year after year, less and less had been falling in this field. No one had made it happen suddenly, in a single season. It had been reduced, little by little, steadily, over a very long time. Every time I look at this number, it's that steadiness that frightens me most.

Another person standing nearby glanced at me, took in my clothes, and added a word.

"…First time here, huh."

"…Yes."

"…What are you going to do with that number?"

I couldn't answer. I didn't know myself what I meant to do with it.

The person shrugged and walked off. There didn't seem to be any unkindness in it. They'd just been curious, and when no answer came, the curiosity went with them.

. . .

I stood there and did the arithmetic.

A hundred minus point-oh-two left ninety-nine point ninety-eight. Which meant those who did the harvesting took ninety-nine point ninety-eight parts out of a hundred, and what was left for people like me was point-oh-two.

I had no feel for what point-oh-two meant at the time. I saw it later, out in the field, with my own hands. One sack out of one plot — that was roughly what was left over: a little more than a single grain.

That was the day I first started wondering who had set this number. If a person had set it, there would be someone to be angry at. But that wasn't how it turned out. It wasn't that a person had decided who should be angry. It was that a person had arranged things so no one would need to be.

. . .

There was more small print beside the board. I read that too.

"This figure is refreshed each season by the Roll's harvest management system, and continues to improve through the optimization of path, speed, and machine placement."

I read that sentence over several times. Path. Speed. Placement. Improve.

Outside, we harvested with sickles. There was always spillage. Like the summer my husband taught me to cut and told me, *leave a little.* A hand doing the work would always miss something — that was only natural.

Here, it wasn't a hand.

It was only then that I understood what those words meant. Optimizing the path meant the machine left no stretch of the plot uncrossed. Optimizing the speed meant it never moved too fast for a stalk to be cut and passed over uncut. The places where a person would have made a mistake — the machine did not make.

Spillage is a mistake. The Roll had made mistakes impossible. That was all it was.

. . .

I left the market and walked toward the field.

It was a long walk. The Harvest's fields ringed the whole city; whichever direction you went, you eventually arrived at field. Outside, the field had belonged to the village. Here it felt like the city belonged to the field.

I could see the harvester moving far off — large and slow, and yet not a single degree off true. That was the first day I watched it for any length of time. Before that I'd only thought of it as a big machine.

Coming closer, I saw it wasn't one machine but several. First came one with a wide blade fanned out in front; a little behind it, a narrower, taller machine followed; behind that, another leveled the soil. Three machines in a single line, spaced exactly apart. No one stood near them. Off in the distance, a handful of people stood watching.

That was when it hit me that none of them was holding a sickle.

Where the machines had passed, a row was left with nothing on it. No stalk, no grain, nothing. I walked the length of it. Only dirt and stubble. The stubble was all cut to the same height.

I remember that height. Wrist height. Lower than where my husband's sickle used to cut. A person cuts a little high, to save their strength. The machine had no strength to save.

I walked to the end of the row. There I found the corner marker — a wooden stake, small letters carved near the top: "Article 9 Preservation Zone." The stake was clean as new. Even the little guard plate hadn't lost its paint.

Someone was standing beside the stake, measuring something with a ruler. I went over.

"…What are you doing?"

The person answered without looking up.

"…Checking the boundary. Every season." They set the ruler down again. "It has to be exactly twenty paces from this stake to that one. If it's off by even a little, I have to report it."

"…Why so exact, when it doesn't even matter here—"

I didn't finish the sentence. The person looked up at me then, for the first time.

"…Because it's the law." they said, as if it weren't an odd question at all. "The corner designation falls under Article 9. If it's not kept exact, that's a violation."

Then they bent back to the ruler. I could see they were conscientious. They were genuinely trying to keep those twenty paces exact. The exactness seemed to have nothing to do with what lay inside the boundary, and they didn't appear to care. Or maybe they'd learned it wasn't something to care about.

I've remembered that person a long time. I never learned their name. They did nothing wrong. They only did their part exactly. But that exactness felt colder to me than any laziness could have. A lazy person will spill something by

accident, eventually. An exact person doesn't spill. And this city, at least in this one matter, kept no lazy people on.

I walked to the end of the row. On a hunch, I crouched and dug through the dirt. One grain came up. Just one. Half-buried, cracked.

I set it in my palm and looked at it for a long time.

That was everything I gleaned that day. The point-oh-two percent, sitting in the palm of my hand. I didn't eat it. I carried it home. I still know where it is.

. . .

Back home, I set the grain down in front of Pikra.

Pikra looked at it, then at me.

"…Is this all?" she asked.

"…Yes."

"…Why are you smiling?"

I hadn't known I was smiling. I touched my face. I really was.

"…I don't know." I said. "It's just — it's strange, that this is a number now."

I told her about the board in the market. The number, the small print beside it, last year's figure, the year before that. Pikra listened without a word.

"…It wasn't like this before." Pikra said, after a while.

"…What wasn't?"

"…The corner." she said. "When I lived here, there really used to be something at the corner. Not much — but enough to fill a hand."

I didn't know what to say to that.

"…When did it stop?"

"…I don't know." Pikra said. "I left before then. It was still there when I left. When it stopped, I never knew."

Pikra picked up the grain. She held it in her hand a moment, then split it and ate half, giving me the other. Her half tasted mostly of dirt.

It wasn't until that night that I understood why I'd smiled. It wasn't that the number was strange. It was that the number didn't hate me. If a person starves me, I can hate that person. But that number starved me in a way that left no one to hate. I should have known that was the frightening part. That night I only found it strange.

It took me a few more days to learn the difference. It was all right not to know yet. I could go out every day whether I knew it or not.

. . .

Outside, when a bad harvest came, everyone went hungry together. It was sad, but it wasn't strange. Heaven hadn't given. You could resent heaven, but you couldn't take heaven to court.

Here, heaven gives. The wheat grows well. The rain comes on time. The harvesters don't rest a single day. No one intends to starve anyone.

And yet I was starving.

It took me a long time to put that difference into words. I can now. Hunger outside was hunger no one had made. Hunger here was hunger that came from no one making anything otherwise. The first is a disaster. The second is a design. Only, if you ask who did the designing, no one raises a hand. That's the difference.

I fell asleep that night with the taste of dirt from that grain still in my mouth. I meant to go out the next day, and the day after that. Knowing full well that nothing would change.

I thought, at the time, that it was stubbornness. Looking back now, it wasn't. I simply didn't want to let that number decide for me, even after I'd seen it with my own eyes. The Roll had decided that 0.02 percent was my portion. That didn't mean I had to stop going to claim it. If I didn't go, the number won. If I went, the number still didn't lose. But I chose not to be the one who didn't go. That's all it was.

Writing this chapter, I went and looked the number up again. It's still sitting right where it was. Much later, a day comes when that number really does change. But that's a later story, and before I tell it I need to set down, first, how long and how calmly this number kept its place.

(Continued in Chapter 14.)

Chapter 14. The Second Day

> *_Previously_ — Xene learned why nothing was left at the corner of the*
> *field. The Roll had optimized the harvest until the loss rate was 0.02 percent. And that it was no one's fault.*

The next day I went out again.

I could write a reason here. It would sound convincing on the page. But what I actually thought that morning wasn't convincing at all. I simply opened my eyes, sat up, and put on my shoes. The thinking came trailing slowly along behind.

Writing this book, I keep finding myself checking that order. People assume the reason comes first and the action follows. I lived through the reverse of that, too many times over. My body got up first, and the reason caught up with it later. On some days the reason never came at all.

Past the door there was a road. I had it memorized within a day. Past the well, through an alley hemmed by a low wall, past three grain silos, and the field began. The silos always had their doors shut. I tried not to imagine how much was piled up inside them. That didn't work well either.

On the way to the corner I always stopped in the same spot to retie my shoelaces. Some days I stopped there and retied them even when there was no need. I learned then, for the first time, that habit can arrive before reason does.

There was a low stone at that spot. I would sit and catch my breath there. Its surface was worn smooth — which meant plenty of others had sat on it before me. I often wondered who they'd been.

. . .

Pikra saw me leaving. She said nothing.

The third day was the same. I woke before dawn, drank a mouthful of water, and went. Pikra pretended to be asleep. I knew it was pretense. She must have known that I knew. We never spoke a single word about it.

I still can't explain that silence. Anyone watching would have thought we were indifferent to each other. We weren't. Pikra didn't know why I went out, and neither did I. When two people who don't know say it aloud, they end up lying to each other. So we didn't say it.

Instead Pikra did something else. Before I left, she always had a bowl of water waiting. She never said anything about it. I'd simply wake to find the bowl full. I never once caught her getting up to fill it. She must have risen before me.

I'm writing about that water bowl in this book for the first time. I thought it was nothing at the time. I don't think that now. When Pikra couldn't find words to stop me, she left water instead. That was the whole of what she could do, and I took it.

. . .

By the fourth day, I knew there were others who went out around the same hour.

An old man was sitting on the path to the corner, ahead of me. A sack lay across his knees, empty.

We didn't greet each other. We just happened to walk the same direction, and at the corner, we each took our own place. He sat in one corner as if it were the seat he always took.

I learned his name later, but I won't write it here. What matters in this chapter isn't who he was, but the fact that he was there. I wasn't strange for being the only one. There were others who came, every day, already knowing there was nothing there.

From then on I started counting how many came to the corner. On the busiest days, five or six. They scattered themselves as though each had a fixed seat. Few spoke to one another. Everyone kept their eyes on their own patch of dirt.

I thought that was strange. People in the same situation might be expected to help each other, but no one did. I understood later. It wasn't that there was nothing worth helping with. It was that there was so completely nothing, that no one could face the others.

I'd been told that poverty binds people together. I only half believe that now. Poverty binds people when there's still something, however little, to share. When there's truly nothing left to share, poverty scatters them. I learned that at the corner.

. . .

On the fifth day, I timed it for the first time.

Half an hour to walk from home to the corner. Another half hour standing there sifting the dirt. Another half hour to walk back. An hour and a half spent, and for that hour and a half, what I gained was usually nothing at all.

I did the arithmetic and asked myself what use it was.

No answer came.

Outside, I had never timed anything that way. Work was something you did until it was finished. You went out when the sun rose and came in when it set. Counting the hours you'd spent didn't matter. Here, for the first time, I turned my time into a number. An hour and a half. From the moment I made that number, I began to price that time. And I came to see that the price was traded, always, for nothing.

It took time even to stop doing that arithmetic. Once a person starts measuring, they want to keep measuring. I kept timing myself for several more days after that. Then one day I stopped looking at my wrist. My body seemed to understand, before my mind did, that not timing it made the loss hurt less. There were more and more things, around then, that my body knew before my head did.

Looking back now, I think the question itself was wrong. I'd already decided it had to be useful before I asked, and that's why no answer came. I was doing something else entirely then, something other than use. I still don't fully know, even having finished this book, what that was. But I need to set down two things together — that I found no answer to that question that day, and that I went out again the next day regardless.

. . .

On the sixth day, a little rain fell.

Not much. Just enough to wet my clothes. I went out anyway. The corner looked no different from any other day. Trampled stalks, dirt, an occasional broken grain. Only the color was a little darker for the wet.

Standing in that rain, a thought crossed my mind. If the rain got heavier, the machines wouldn't be able to come in. Wouldn't something be left, then? I

didn't hold that thought long. The rain stopped soon after. I forgot it.

I'm setting this thought down in advance. A day comes, later, when it actually happens. On that day I remember this sixth day again.

I came home soaked, and Pikra held out a dry cloth. I took it and dried my hair first.

"…You'll catch cold." Pikra said.

"…I'm fine."

"…Stop saying that." Pikra said. Her voice wasn't angry. "You never look fine when you say it."

I laughed. Pikra laughed a little too.

I remember that brief laugh. Laughter had grown scarce between us by then. That was the first one in days.

. . .

On the seventh day, I saw a stranger far off in the field for the first time.

He was standing beside a harvester, looking something over. What he held wasn't a spade or a sickle — something flat. His clothes were different too. Not sweat-soaked like the other hired hands, but clean.

I didn't watch him long. I decided he had nothing to do with me. He didn't seem to notice me either.

I don't remember his face from that day. It was too far. What I remember is the way he stood. The stance of someone checking something. Not the stance of someone fixing something. I couldn't tell the difference then. Later I could.

He kept turning up in that same spot after that. Some mornings, some evenings. I guessed it must be his job — tending the harvesters, or watching over them. I didn't think further than that.

I'll write no more of him than this in this chapter. Anything more would be a lie. That was all I knew about him then. I didn't know his name. I didn't know his face. Only in the next chapter do I hear his name, and learn it belongs to him.

. . .

On the eighth day, I thought for the first time about giving up.

My feet ached badly that morning. My shoes were worn through at the heel. Walking was hard. I stood at the door a long while, hesitating.

Pikra didn't pretend to sleep that day.

"…Rest today." Pikra said, her voice thick with sleep.

"…I'm fine."

"…I can see your feet."

I said nothing.

"…Resting won't change anything anyway." Pikra said. It was impossible to tell whether that meant *stay* or *go.*

In the end I went out. I wrapped my feet in rags instead of shoes.

I still can't explain exactly why I went that day. It wasn't that my feet had stopped hurting. It wasn't that I was expecting anything either. I simply felt

that if I didn't go, everything I'd gone out for until now would become, from that moment, as if it had never happened. I didn't want that.

I walked slowly that day, twice as long as usual. I stopped several times to rub my feet. And at some point it struck me, all over again, that I was going through all this to reach a place with nothing in it.

I laughed then. A strange laugh. Not sad, not happy. I just found what I was doing so absurd that laughter came out of me. Aching feet, dragging myself toward a place with nothing — for a moment I looked like a stranger to myself.

I agonized a long time over whether to write this laugh into the book. I worried it would look comic. But I decided to write it in. Because that laughter was really there, in that spot, that day. This book doesn't pretend nothing but sorrow happened.

. . .

On the ninth day, I spoke with the old man for the first time.

I wasn't the one who started it. He looked at his sack and said, seemingly to no one in particular:

"…Why do you come every day, miss?"

I wasn't ready with an answer.

"…I don't know." I said. "What about you, sir?"

He laughed a little — silently.

"…I don't know either." he said. "Been at it years now. Still don't know."

"…So why do you keep coming?"

"…Good question." He gathered a fistful of dirt and let it fall again. "If somebody asks, I just say it's habit. A habit probably had a reason once. Where the reason went, I couldn't tell you. Just the habit's left."

"…How many years?"

"…Counted long enough, then quit." He set the sack back on his knee. "What's the point of counting."

That frightened me a little — that he'd come every day for years and still didn't know why. But it comforted me a little too. I wasn't the only one without an answer.

I met him often after that. We never became friends. Just two people who came to the same place. But I learned later that this could be steadier than friendship, some days. Standing beside someone who doesn't ask you why is, sometimes, its own kind of strength.

From that day I started watching his sack more closely. It was always empty. Occasionally there was a thin layer at the bottom, but I never once saw it take on the shape of a full sack. I wondered when it had last been full. I didn't ask. We'd only exchanged a single conversation in nine days. That wasn't a question you asked, at that stage.

I still think of that man's sack, even now. What shape an empty sack takes after years of being carried empty — I learned that by watching him. A sack, like a person, comes to fold a certain way if it goes unused long enough.

. . .

On the evening of the tenth day, I stopped counting for the first time.

I mean I stopped counting the days. Until then I'd walked along ticking off the number on my fingers. From that day I didn't.

I think that's the true end of this chapter. As long as I was counting the days, I was proving something to myself — how many days I'd held out, how many more I could hold out. When I stopped counting, I stopped proving. I simply became someone whose body rose at the same hour every day. What was left where the proving used to be wasn't much of anything. Just the one fact that morning would come again, and I would get up again.

I think this is the easiest chapter in the whole book to write, and at the same time the hardest. Easiest because nothing happened. Hardest because I know that, even so, it's the most important chapter. Beginning in the next one, things start to happen. Someone recognizes me. But the reason that person could recognize me is that I had been there, at the same hour, in the same spot, every single day.

Ten days on, the corner was still exactly as it had been. The dirt was the same color, the stubble the same height, and what my hand found there was still next to nothing. I could feel that fact growing duller with every day that passed. The first few days, every time I came home empty-handed, something had tightened just below my ribs. By the tenth day, that tightness had settled into something more like the ordinary weight of a day. Not a special grief anymore — just a burden I carried around all the time.

I don't think that was getting better. Growing dull and getting better are not the same thing. I was only learning how to carry that weight while I walked. And that walk, without my knowing it, had already caught someone's eye. Someone had been watching me, day after day, in the same spot — and had begun, day by day, to find me strange. I didn't know that yet.

I went, every day. That's the whole of this chapter.

(Continued in Chapter 15.)

Chapter 15. Lytron

> *_Previously_ — Xene went to the corner every day. She stopped counting*
> *the days. Then, one day, she saw a stranger on the far side of the field. She didn't know, at the time, that he had been watching her too.*

On the twelfth day, that man walked over to me.

The morning was unusually clear. The whole field was visible at a glance — wheat ripened the same gold color out to the far edge, and above it three harvesters moved, small and distant. I was sitting in my usual spot at the corner, sifting the dirt as always.

I heard footsteps. At first I assumed they were only passing by. But they were heading straight for me. I hesitated over whether to stand or stay seated, and in the end just stayed as I was. There was nowhere to hide my dirt-covered hands.

Up close, his clothes were plainly different — no fading anywhere, good material. His shoes weren't worn at the toe either. In his hand was something flat, and it was only then that I learned what it was: a Roll terminal. He looked a year or two older than me. His expression was calm in a way that didn't match his age. Nothing hurried about him at all.

That was the first time in this city that I saw someone walking straight toward me. Until then, people had always passed beside me or gone out of their way around me. No one had come toward me. So it took a few seconds before I even recognized that the steps were meant for me.

. . .

"…What are you doing there?"

His voice wasn't loud. Not angry either. Just the voice of someone curious.

"…Gleaning." I said.

"…What?"

I opened my palm to show him. Two grains. One of them cracked.

He looked at it a moment. His expression didn't change. Not surprised, not mocking. He simply looked.

"…What do you do with that?"

"…Eat it."

He looked at me again. Longer this time. As if he were repeating what I'd said to himself, more than once.

"…Two grains?"

"…I gather this much every day." I said. "Some days not even this much."

He tilted his head slightly. Less confused than someone hearing an unfamiliar sum for the first time.

"…That must be hard." he said.

There was no pity in it. It was the tone of someone confirming a fact. I found that easier, actually. If it had been pity, I wouldn't have known how to answer.

. . .

"…You've been coming here for days." he said. It wasn't a question. It sounded like confirmation.

I found that strange. I thought this was my first time seeing him, but it meant he'd already known about me for days.

"…How do you know?"

"…It's in the records." he said, lifting the terminal slightly. "Entry logs for this zone. If the same person comes in and out at the same time every day for more than ten days, it gets flagged."

That was when I first learned that my going out every day hadn't been mine alone to know. It had all been recorded somewhere. I found it strange more than frightening. I'd thought no one paid me any attention — but a machine had. Before any person did. I didn't know whether that record was kept under my name or just a spot number. I didn't have the nerve to ask.

"…I'm assisting with management of this zone." he added. "I check the traffic, the entry logs, the loss rate, that kind of thing, every day. Things end up catching your eye that way. Like someone coming in and out of the same spot at the same hour for more than ten days."

"…There are other people who come every day too, besides me."

"…I know. There are records for them too." he said, unconcerned. "But yours was a little different."

"…What was?"

"…The others taper off after a while. A few days coming, then gone, then a few more, then gone again. You didn't miss a single day."

Hearing that, I felt all over again the fact that I'd been under observation. And at the same time I could tell he hadn't said it to make me out as especially wrong for it. It was simply the tone of someone remarking on a figure that stood out.

. . .

"…Why do you come every day to a place with nothing in it?"

He asked it without any malice at all, and that was what unsettled me more. If it had been asked unkindly, I'd have found it easier to answer — I could have gotten angry, or ignored him. But he was genuinely curious.

I had no answer.

"…Is it because of the corner clause?" he went on. "The one that says people without standing can glean there."

"…Yes."

"…That is what that place is for." he said. "I know that. Article 9. Only…" he chose his next words. "Only, these days there isn't much left there. Efficiency's improved."

I noticed he said "efficiency's improved" in a tone that was neither boasting nor apologizing. Simply stating a fact.

. . .

"…Do you know?" I asked. "How high the loss rate is?"

My voice came out sharper than I'd expected, sharp enough to surprise even me. He looked slightly startled. For the first time his expression moved.

"…0.02 percent." he answered. Without hesitation. "It's the figure for the zone I manage."

"…Then you'd know. That I can come every day and get nothing."

"…I know." he said. "But separate from that, I'm still curious. Knowing that, why you still come."

I had no answer to that question. Truly none. Not then.

Writing this now, I find myself wondering what would have happened if I'd made something up that day. Something like, "I still think there might be something someday," or "It's a right the law gives me." Those kinds of lines did cross my mind at the time. I said none of them out loud. Because they weren't true.

The silence went on a while. Lytron didn't press. He didn't seem to be waiting for an answer either — he looked more like someone considering his next question.

"…Have you thought about trying a different field?" he asked. "There might be zones with a higher loss rate than this one, not this one."

That question surprised me a little. That he knew loss rates differed from field to field, and that he'd think to tell someone like me.

"…I didn't know there was such a thing." I said.

"…It's not a big difference." he added right away. "They're all similarly low. It won't be very different wherever you go."

I couldn't tell whether that was meant to comfort me or was just information. Thinking about it now, I'd say it was both. In him, the wish to comfort and the wish to state facts precisely didn't seem to be two separate things.

"…Have you been to other fields yourself?" I asked.

"…I manage this one." he said. "I only see the other zones as numbers. I don't go out to them myself."

"…Then how do you know they're all similar?"

Lytron went quiet a moment. It was the first time an answer hadn't come right away.

"…From the reports." he finally said. Something about the answer must have sounded insufficient even to him, because he glanced down at his terminal for a moment after saying it.

I remember that brief pause. It was the first time I saw that even he didn't know everything. What he knew was numbers, and numbers could be known without ever going out to the field. But what those numbers turned into, once they were sitting in a person's palm — numbers alone couldn't show him that.

. . .

He looked at me a moment, then wrote something on the terminal. I felt a stab of unease — wondering what sort of record he was making about me.

"…What are you writing?"

"…Oh, this is something else." he said. "Time of today's zone inspection."

The answer was so ordinary that I felt myself sag a little. I'd thought something significant was happening. It wasn't. To him, I was just one person he'd crossed paths with during that day's inspection.

"…What's your name?" I asked. I don't know why I asked.

"…Lytron." he said. Then he asked back, "And you?"

"…Xene."

Lytron didn't write the name down anywhere. He just nodded once.

"…Xene." he repeated it once. Not the face of someone curious about what it meant. Just the face of someone committing a name to memory.

"…What's your standing?" he asked. Casually, the way you'd ask about the weather.

"…None."

"…Ah." he said, shortly. He didn't look surprised. He might already have known — with an entry log on the terminal, he could hardly have missed it.

He didn't ask anything further. He didn't wear the expression that usually followed hearing someone had no standing — not pity, not wariness. He simply took in one more piece of information. Up to that point, I'd watched people's faces change, however slightly, at the words *no standing.* Some looked away. Some walked faster. Lytron did neither. His was the face of someone confirming what he'd already understood.

I turned that "ah" over in my mind for a long time. There had truly been nothing in it. I couldn't decide, for a long while, whether that nothing frightened me or was a relief.

And then he went on his way.

. . .

I watched his back for a long time.

His walk was unhurried — the walk of someone with nowhere urgent to be. Watching it, I thought: he probably won't think of me again for the rest of today. For me, that conversation had been the first time in twelve days that I'd exchanged words with anyone. For him, it had been one thing among many during an inspection.

I thought about this a long time that night. How many words does a person exchange in a day? Around then, I rarely crossed ten words in a whole day. Someone like Lytron probably exchanged hundreds. So the few words we'd traded took up a completely different amount of room in his day than they did in mine. I'm not writing this to resent him for it. I'm only recording that it was true.

I won't write that this was a bad thing. He hadn't done anything wrong. He'd asked what he was curious about, heard the answer, and gone off to his work. The trouble was that his day and my day didn't rest on the same scale — and that this was no one's fault.

I sat at the corner a little longer than usual that day. I stopped sifting the dirt and watched the direction he'd walked. Far off, the three harvesters were still moving at the same steady pace. Lytron walked up to one of them and bent over his terminal. He seemed to be checking something, correcting something. The motion looked entirely familiar. Clearly something he did every day.

I thought about how well he must know those machines. If I'd never touched a sickle in my life and were handed one of those, I'd have been afraid. Lytron wasn't afraid of it at all. He handled it the way a person handles their own hand.

That difference stayed with me a long time. I knew the field by hand. Lytron knew the field by numbers. The same field, and yet we were looking at two different fields.

. . .

At home, I told Pikra what had happened. It was the first time I'd told her anything that had happened out in the field.

"…I met someone named Lytron."

Pikra's hands went still.

"…Lytron?"

"…Yes. Why?"

"…Nothing." She started moving again. "The family name sounds familiar. I heard it when I lived here."

"…What kind of family is it?"

Pikra thought for a moment.

"…A good family." she said. "Very high standing. Strange, that a son from a family like that would ask about you."

"…What's a family like that doing out in the field?" I asked. "He didn't look like the people who work out here."

"…High-standing families put their sons through a stretch of that hands-on work sooner or later." Pikra said. "It's supposed to teach them, so that when they end up in a higher seat later, they understand what's below them. That was already the talk when I lived here."

"…So he really does understand it, then?"

Pikra looked at me a moment.

"…Knowing and living through it are different things." she said. "That boy has a house to go home to in the evening. Not sleeping here, the way we do."

I thought she was right. And at the same time it was also true that Lytron hadn't seemed like a bad person. That both of those could exist together — I learned that for the first time that day.

I lay awake a long time that night. That Lytron wasn't a bad person, and that what Lytron lived through was not what I lived through — these two things didn't clash against each other. I'd believed, up to then, that only bad people made bad things happen. From that day I began, slowly, to learn how wrong that was.

I didn't quite understand, at the time, why that should be strange at all.

I understand now. A meeting of two people at the corner of a field, one with the highest standing and one with none, was not a common thing in this city. Rare enough that even he had been curious. I didn't know that then, and so I simply fell asleep thinking I'd met an odd sort of person. I found myself, that night, repeating his name to myself a few times, silently. A name I'd never heard before, and yet, oddly, it fixed itself in my memory the first time.

(Continued in Chapter 16.)

Chapter 16. I Haven't Done Anything Wrong

> *_Previously_ — Xene met Lytron. He was not unkind to her. He simply*
> *couldn't understand why she came every day to a place with nothing in*
> *it. Pikra said his was a high-standing family.*

This is a chapter I wasn't there for.

Most of what's written here, I didn't live through myself. Some of it I heard, much later, from Lytron directly. Some of it I learned only sideways, while Mena was researching this city's records. I hesitated a long time over whether to write it at all. Setting down something I never saw felt like it went against how I learned to keep this record.

Mena once said to me, "If you only write what you saw, you end up with a story that has only the person who saw it in it. But this world isn't a place where only one person lives." This is the chapter where I first felt the truth of that.

So this chapter isn't my memory. It's a day I pieced together afterward. But nothing in it is invented. I made up none of the conversation. What I set down here is only what Lytron told me himself, and what Mena confirmed as fact.

. . .

Lytron's morning began earlier than mine.

His house stood in the innermost part of the city, the district farthest from the field. I passed through that neighborhood once, much later, and remember it — wide streets, quiet. Every house had a high wall, and behind every wall, the sound of running water. It was a neighborhood with no reason to conserve it.

Lytron woke before dawn and checked his terminal first thing. Reading through the overnight zone reports was always his first task. Loss rate, machine uptime, labor assignment. If the numbers looked like yesterday's, he was at ease. If anything was even slightly off, he went looking for the cause.

I was a little surprised, hearing this. I'd assumed Lytron woke each morning and started his day at leisure — the son of a high-standing family, after all. He didn't. He too had numbers to check every morning. The only difference between us was that when those numbers went bad, he didn't go hungry for it.

His house had many rooms, I was told — though I never learned exactly how many. Lytron himself didn't seem to have counted. I found that strange. Our room was one room, and I had every corner of it memorized. A house with several rooms would have some that went mostly unused, and I could only imagine what it would feel like not to need to count them at all.

There was a small irrigation channel running through the yard. It was ornamental — not dug out of any need, but simply because it was pleasant to look at. Hearing that, I went quiet for a while. Back at our settlement, people had come to blows over a single water channel. Here, letting water simply run for no reason at all was enough to make a yard.

. . .

At breakfast, his father would ask for the day's report.

"…Yesterday's loss rate."

"…0.02 percent. No change."

"…Good work."

That was often the whole of the conversation. Lytron's father wasn't a man of many words. Though on days the numbers turned bad, the words multiplied.

I've imagined that short exchange many times over. What "good work" must have meant to Lytron. I've never once heard those words myself, so at first I felt a pang of envy. I see it a little differently now. That phrase was praise and standard at once — it also meant that on a day the numbers turned bad, that phrase wouldn't come.

. . .

Lytron's family had done harvest management work for three generations.

His great-grandfather's generation had already had a hand in this city's fields, I was told. The family's standing score had been built up over those generations. Not gained by theft. Not gained by deceiving anyone. Earned steadily, over a long time, by doing the work well.

I write this part carefully. I don't want anyone reading this book to hate Lytron for it. That family really had worked hard. Generation after generation rising early, generation after generation reading the numbers closely, generation after generation trying not to make mistakes. They hadn't reached their position by doing anything wrong. They had simply done well.

But I also came to understand, later, that this "doing well" stood in exact opposition to what was left for someone else. In a structure where one side's doing better always meant less remaining for the other, I doubt that family had ever once thought of it in those terms.

Lytron had an older brother. His brother already managed a different zone and lived independently. The two weren't on bad terms — they ate together on holidays, sometimes walked the fields together. What the brother usually told him came down to the same thing: *Keep the numbers right, and everything else falls into place.*

Lytron believed it. It had been true for him, so far, exactly as he'd been told.

I thought about this a long time. "Keep the numbers right and everything falls into place" — that was true for those two brothers. In their world, it really was. The trouble is that a world where that sentence isn't true was laid directly over the same city, the same ground. Writing this chapter, I came to see most clearly of all how those two worlds could sit on the same soil and almost never see each other.

. . .

Lytron was seventeen. A year older than me.

Already, at that age, he was handling zone management support work. The Roll set children of high-standing families to real work early. The reason was simple: they would sit in bigger seats later, so best to learn it now.

Lytron didn't dislike the work. He was good at it, actually. He had a feel for reading numbers, and he was quick at adjusting machine placement. His superiors trusted him. His reputation among his peers wasn't bad either — conscientious, courteous, never one to treat anyone carelessly, people said.

Hearing this reputation, I didn't believe it at first. But over time I came to understand it was true. Lytron really was that sort of person. What I'm trying to do in this book isn't to erase that fact. It's the opposite — to let it stand as it is.

Lytron had a few friends, all children of similarly placed families. On their days off, they gathered and shared meals together. I once heard the list of dishes at one of those gatherings — it was more than I'd eaten in a whole year. Lytron didn't think of it as anything special. Just what he usually ate.

Among his friends, he was sometimes teased for being too conscientious, too meticulous. *You like numbers more than people,* they'd joke. Lytron only laughed at it. He never denied it. He had no reason to deny it.

I think this is the most important part of this chapter. Lytron was someone who could hear that he liked numbers more than people, and laugh. Because he didn't think it made him a bad person. I think that's the face of harmlessness. A bad person bristles at a remark like that. A harmless person laughs it off. Because he feels no reason to bristle.

. . .

That afternoon, Lytron made his rounds of the zone. It was the day he met me.

The rounds followed a set order: check machine condition, check zone boundaries, check labor assignments. Somewhere in that order was the corner zone. Since it fell under Article 9, it was on the list of things to be checked regularly.

So the fact that I met Lytron that day wasn't a coincidence, I learned later. It was a coincidence, in a sense — that I was there that day, and that it happened to be inspection day, was a coincidence. But the round itself wasn't. It was his job. I had been in that spot at the same hour every day for twelve days, and Lytron passed through it following a fixed order. Two repetitions simply collided.

Lytron logged me in that day's inspection record like this: "One unregistered individual within zone, repeated access confirmed. No irregularities."

I saw that sentence later. "No irregularities." I laughed, seeing it. Whether I laughed because it was sad, or because it was absurd, I still don't quite know. That day had been the biggest thing that happened to me — and in his record it was a day with nothing irregular in it at all.

Once the round ended, Lytron went back to the office and drew up a summary of what he'd checked that day. Loss rate summaries by zone, machine uptime, changes in labor assignment. That report was written every single day, and every single day it went up to his superiors. Lytron liked that work. He said it felt good when everything fit together exactly, when not a single number was off.

"…What's good about that?" I asked him once, later.

"…Hard to explain." Lytron said. "When something fits together exactly, it feels like I've done something well."

I said nothing to that. For him, it must really have been an achievement. I don't think that achievement was a bad thing in itself. Only that it seemed strange to me that I had been standing right where that achievement completed itself.

. . .

That evening, back home, Lytron said a few words to his father about the day — the round, the machines. Among it, a brief mention of me.

"…There's someone who comes every day, out by the corner."

"…Unregistered?"

"…Yes."

"…Report it if it's something. Otherwise, don't worry about it." his father said. "That's just what that spot is for."

And that was the end of it. In that room, I'd been a story that lasted a few seconds.

I never feel angry, picturing that scene. I know that sounds strange to hear. But it's true. His father said nothing unkind. Even "don't worry about it" wasn't said out of dislike. It was simply that he'd judged it an unimportant item in his son's day. I think the judgment was wrong. But I don't want to paint the man who made it as a villain.

. . .

That night, Lytron went over the day's round record once more in his room. He said he'd paused, briefly, at the entry for my access log.

He told me this much later.

"…I felt strange that night." he said.

"…Strange how?" I asked. Much later.

"…Hard to explain." Lytron said. "Looking at your access log, it suddenly hit me — for the first time — that there was a person behind that number. Before then it had just been an entry."

"…And then?"

"…And then no conclusion came of it." Lytron said. "I just felt that, for a while, and then forgot about it the next day, reading some other report."

I heard this confession much later still. By then a great deal had already changed. I thought it belonged in this chapter. Lytron felt something, very briefly, that night. And then he forgot it. I don't hold that forgetting against him. If I'd been his age, with that many reports to check in a day, I probably would have forgotten too.

That forgetting wasn't especially cruel. After that night, Lytron woke the same way, made his rounds the same way, wrote his reports the same way. Nothing changed. And that nothing-changing, I learned later, is the most common thing in this city. Most people feel something, carry that feeling through a single night, and then set it down the next day because there's work to do. It isn't malice. A day simply passes that way.

I don't want to write this as a bad thing. If I'd been able to live that way, I would have too. Only I never got the chance to live that way. My days had nothing else filling them that I could forget under. So I had no choice but to return, every day, to the same spot in my mind. Maybe that was the biggest difference between him and me. He had the room to forget. I didn't.

. . .

I want to close this chapter with something Lytron said to himself. This too I heard later.

Around that time, he sometimes asked himself: had he done something wrong. The answer was always the same.

"…I haven't done anything wrong."

That was true. Lytron truly hadn't done anything wrong. He hadn't taken anything from anyone. He hadn't deceived anyone. He hadn't broken the law. He hadn't lied. He had only done his own work, in his own place, conscientiously.

I'll write this sentence again more than once in this book. For now I'll only set down this much: that it was true. And that even while it was true, there could still be a day when someone like me sat with two grains of wheat in her palm and had to laugh. That both of these things could be true at the same time — I held onto that longer than anything else while writing this book.

I rewrote this chapter several times. When I first wrote it, I painted Lytron a little worse than this. I thought it would land the book's point more clearly. Reading it back, I saw it was a lie. In the end I cut all of it and settled for only this much.

I tried, more than once while writing this chapter, to make myself hate Lytron. I couldn't manage it. However hard I searched for a place to put that hatred, all I found there was a seventeen-year-old conscientiously checking his numbers. Hating that person wasn't different from hating conscientiousness itself.

I know that's exactly not what this book is aimed at. This book isn't aimed at Lytron. It's aimed at the comfort he never once thought to question. And I am someone who never had that comfort — and so didn't even know it was comfort, when I had none.

(Continued in Chapter 17.)

Chapter 17. Trampled Stalks

> *_Previously_ — Xene learned Lytron's day only afterward. He hadn't*
> *done anything wrong. And that fact stayed true even while she was the*
> *one coming home empty-handed, day after day.*

Even after the day I met Lytron, I kept going out.

Nothing changed. The corner stayed exactly as it had been. Trampled stalks, grain broken up in the dirt, an occasional whole one. I grew steadily more practiced at picking out what could be eaten.

This is the first time I use the word "practiced" in this chapter. Being practiced doesn't mean getting better. I want to be clear about that here. I grew practiced at hunger. Not that the hunger went away — only that I grew better at enduring it.

. . .

The walk to the corner was the same every day.

Out of the lodging, along the main road, then left where the field began. About half an hour on foot. At first that half hour felt like a waste. Later it came to feel like the better part of the day — walking, I didn't have to think about anything.

The field was vast. Too vast to take in at a glance. The machines moved in formation. The first time I saw them, I'd thought them frightening. Now I just

looked at them. What frightened me wasn't the machines — it was what was left behind them. Or rather, precisely: what wasn't.

The corner sat at the field's edge, against a drainage ditch. A single stake stood there: "Zone Under Article 9." I passed that stake every day. The first few days I stopped in front of it and read the letters. Later I stopped reading. There was no longer any need.

I could still walk that path today. With my eyes shut. Half an hour, left, the stake, the ditch. Some roads a person's feet remember. I became someone whose feet remembered that one.

. . .

For the first several days, others came besides me.

An older woman, and a man who brought two children. All of us ran our palms through the dirt the same way. We didn't speak to each other. We shared the same ground and never once met each other's eyes.

After about a week, the older woman stopped coming. The week after that, the man with the children stopped too. I don't know where they went. I didn't ask. It didn't seem like asking would have brought an answer.

I guessed, later. They must have done the arithmetic. That walking half an hour to gather less than half a palmful wasn't worth it, when that half hour could go toward something else. Not a wrong calculation. I was simply the only one who never made it.

I still can't explain exactly why I kept going out. It wasn't a thing arithmetic could explain. Maybe that was precisely why I kept going.

. . .

What I actually gathered at that corner never added up to a full day's food.

I once measured it exactly. On my best day, I gathered enough to fill two cupped palms. Even that was half dirt and broken husk. Sifted down to the grain itself, it was less than a fistful.

On my worst day, there was nothing at all. Some days there were. I don't remember well what we ate on those evenings. Probably just water, before sleep.

I want to set these numbers down exactly. An amount that never came to a full day's food. Some days, nothing at all. This was the whole of what Article 9 put into my hands. The law was being kept. I confirmed that fact more than once. If the law had been broken, that would have been easier to bear.

. . .

Once, I saw two crows at the corner.

They'd arrived before me. Pecking at the dirt. At first I was glad — if there was enough there for birds to peck at, there must be something left for me too.

Up close, it wasn't so. The birds couldn't peck long before moving on either. A few pecks in one spot, and if nothing came of it, they flew to the next. I followed them and checked the places they'd left. Nothing there either.

That was the day I first understood that this corner wasn't stingy with people alone. It was stingy with birds too. I understood why, later. The Roll hadn't been aimed at people. It had simply eliminated spillage. But eliminating spillage meant that people and birds alike came away with nothing, equally.

The Roll didn't starve me out of hatred. It simply hadn't thought about anyone, or anything, at all.

The birds didn't stay long. I never saw a crow at that spot again. They must have found somewhere else. I had nowhere else to go.

. . .

Back home, I shared it with Pikra.

The ritual never changed. I spread what I'd gathered on the floor. Sorted the whole grain from the fragments. Divided the whole grain in two. Ground the fragments and stirred them into water to drink.

We did it without a word. At first I divided it and Pikra received her share. A few days on, Pikra began doing the dividing herself. Her hand was more exact.

"…How do you divide it so evenly?" I asked once.

"…Practice." Pikra said.

I didn't ask further after that.

I learned later. During the years she lost her husband, and then both her sons, Pikra had already divided small portions among survivors many times before. There was a reason her hand had grown that exact.

Sometimes Pikra didn't finish her own share. At first I didn't notice. One night I woke and found her quietly pushing what was left in her bowl toward mine. I pretended to be asleep.

From that night on, I got in the habit of never quite emptying my own bowl. I left a little behind, so Pikra wouldn't see. We shared, that way, by each

pretending to have what we didn't. I don't think that was a lie. It was the only way we knew, in those days, to look after each other.

. . .

One evening, the grain came out to an odd number.

Three. It couldn't be split evenly. I caught my hand before it could reach naturally for two.

"…Pikra, you take two."

"…No." Pikra said. "You're the one who went out and gathered it."

"…Even so."

We sat a moment with the three grains between us, saying nothing.

In the end Pikra picked up one and broke it in half. We each took our half, ending up with two and a half apiece.

I still remember that breaking hand. She pressed it with a fingernail and split it exactly in two — neither half larger nor smaller. I watched, that night, how carefully a person can try to be fair over the smallest possible thing.

. . .

Around then, I noticed my hands had changed.

They had once been hands that held a sickle. Now they were hands that searched the dirt for a single grain. My fingertips had cracked. Only natural, digging through dirt and dry stalks every day.

Standing up sometimes blurred my sight. Not for long. Just a moment. I knew why. I only pretended not to.

I tried to write this passage plainly. I didn't want to look pitiable. I wasn't a pitiable person, then. I was someone who got up every morning and walked that same road again. My body was, in fact, changing. That fact doesn't make me pitiful. I choose to believe that.

. . .

Around then I got in the habit of hiding what I gleaned.

I sewed a small pocket inside my clothes and carried what I gathered there as I walked. No one had ever said anything to me about it. Still, I didn't want to be seen. If I carried it in my hand, someone might notice, so I hid it against my body every time, without fail.

Looking back later, I found that habit strange. I hadn't done anything wrong. What I gathered was what the law allowed. And yet I hid it. No one had ever told me to. I thought a long time about where that habit had come from. I understand now. A person with no standing learns, on her own, without being taught, to carry even what she's been permitted to have where no one can see.

. . .

Trampled stalks couldn't be eaten. Even so, I gathered them up every time.

We used them for fuel — to heat water. Not much, but better than nothing.

One day, burning that trampled straw, a strange thought struck me. These stalks had once stood upright. The machine had laid them down as it passed.

Lying flat, half-buried in dirt, by the time I found them they were already crushed apart.

Every time I saw them, my husband came to mind. That stubble cut off at wrist height. A sickle's cut and a machine's cut had a different grain. A sickle cuts on the slant. A machine cuts straight down. I could feel the difference now with my fingertips. That was the first skill I learned in this city.

. . .

Around then I began a counting of my own.

I gathered small stones and lined them up like tallies — grains gleaned that day, compared to yesterday's. Good days went on the right, bad days on the left. The right side almost never grew.

I realized later what an odd habit this was. I had come into this city and, for the first time, become someone who counted. But what I counted was the exact opposite of what the Roll counted. The Roll didn't count how much I had. It only counted whether I had standing. I counted the opposite — not standing, but what my hands actually held. No one would ever read that tally. I kept counting anyway.

Those stones didn't last. Later I moved on to something else. But the habit stayed. Even now, when I count something, those stones are the first thing that comes to mind.

. . .

Around then I began watching the people who worked the field.

The hired hands. Some drove the harvesters directly; others followed behind, checking their condition. They were different from people like me. Not entirely without standing — they had some standing, however low, enough to take work for a wage.

I envied them. If you were paid, at least you were sure of one day's food.

The hired hands came in early morning and left toward evening. Those handling the machines didn't speak — the noise was too loud for words. Only in their breaks did they gather briefly, drink water, exchange a few words.

I got in the habit of watching those breaks from a distance. I didn't yet have the nerve to go closer. I just watched where they sat, who sat beside whom. That was all I could manage, at that point.

I didn't know then how shallow that envy was. The hired hands' lives weren't comfortable either. They were only better off than mine. I picked up the habit, around then, of measuring people by that standard — better than me. Even now, I can't say that habit has entirely gone.

. . .

On the way home, I began to notice other things.

Some days my route home passed through an inner alley of the city. On those days I'd see what had been set out near back doors. Some of it spoiled, some of it perfectly fine, simply discarded. One day, half a loaf of bread was sitting there, whole, right on the road.

I stood in front of it a long while. Hesitated over whether to take it. In the end I didn't. I don't fully know why, even now. Gleaning at the corner was fine — that was the place the law had marked out. But this was a place no one had marked out at all. I couldn't explain the difference at the time.

I can explain it now. Gleaning at the corner was a right. Gleaning from the alley was closer to begging. I was a person with no rights left, but I still wasn't willing to beg. That was the last shred of pride I had left, at the time. Looking back it's an absurd distinction — the hunger was exactly the same either way. But I held onto that distinction anyway.

There was something discarded, and something that never fell, both together in this city. I saw that first in that alley. Nothing fell in the field. But something was thrown away in the alley. The two things were happening, at once, inside the same city.

. . .

One evening, Pikra asked me something for the first time.

"…Do you see people out there?"

"…Yes. There are a lot who work there."

"…Talked to anyone yet?"

"…Not yet."

Pikra thought a moment, then said:

"…Talk to them. Can't hurt."

I found that unexpected. Pikra had always told me to be careful — never before to reach out.

"…Why?"

"…Might be better than gleaning alone." Pikra said. Then, after a pause, she added, "When I picture you sitting there by yourself every day, I feel a little

__"

Pikra didn't finish the sentence.

I still wonder, sometimes, what that unfinished sentence would have been. I think Pikra believed she had no right to be angry, no right to worry — not after having tried three times to stop me from coming with her at all. So the sentence never came all the way out. I never finished it for her. Some sentences are right left unfinished.

. . .

That night, I decided that the next day, in the field, I'd try speaking to whoever I could.

It wasn't a grand resolution. Pikra's words had simply stayed with me. That it might be better than gleaning alone.

I didn't decide beforehand who I'd speak to, or what I'd say. I just thought that in the morning, whoever happened to be nearby, I'd at least say hello. That was all.

I don't want to write this decision as though it were momentous. In the next chapter I get a little closer to the people working the field. One of them later becomes very important. But I didn't know that that night. I just fell asleep thinking, tomorrow, maybe I'll say hello to someone.

(Continued in Chapter 18.)

Chapter 18. The Hired Hands

> *_Previously_ — Xene gathered less than a day's food at the corner and*
> *shared it with Pikra. Neither spoke of it. On Pikra's word, Xene decided to try speaking to the people who worked the field.*

The next morning, I went out earlier than usual.

The reason was simple. I wanted to arrive when the workers gathered. At the corner there was never anyone at all. I had to go closer to where the machines stood, into the field itself, to find people.

I don't think it's like me to have carried out that resolve within a single day. I was, by nature, someone who put things off. But there was no reason to put it off, just then. Putting it off didn't seem likely to make tomorrow any better than today.

The whole walk there, I rehearsed what to say. I ran a few greetings through my head. All of them sounded awkward. Outside, greetings hadn't been necessary — you simply opened whoever's door and went in. The city wasn't like that. Here, speaking to a stranger felt like asking permission first.

I understood later where that feeling came from. Outside, no one needed standing to speak to another person. In the city, somewhere along the way, it had come to feel like something you needed. No one had ever told me I needed permission to check. I was already feeling it, regardless.

. . .

The hired hands gathered before dawn.

I learned that for the first time that day. They gathered in front of a small storehouse at the edge of the field and received their assignments for the day — who would take which zone, who would follow which machine. It was decided fresh each morning.

Someone else handed out the assignments. Not part of the Roll — I learned later he worked under the administrator. He called names one by one and handed out slips of paper. I didn't recognize a single name.

Watching that morning scene, a strange thought struck me. These people had names. I didn't. More precisely: I had a name too, but it wasn't in the Roll. If you have a name but it's never called, is that having one, or not. I still haven't answered that question.

. . .

I stood some distance from the storehouse and watched.

I couldn't quite bring myself to go closer. I'd decided the night before to greet someone, anyone — but standing there, my legs wouldn't carry me forward.

One group took their assignments and scattered. I followed one direction — people heading toward the corner. Since we were going the same way, I naturally ended up walking beside them.

The first person I spoke to didn't even look at me.

"…Excuse me, hello." I said to the man walking beside me.

He glanced at me and quickened his pace. No answer. I stopped and watched his back.

I remember that moment for a long time. It wasn't the being ignored that stung. I was already used to that. What stayed with me was that he'd quickened his pace. I wasn't a dangerous person. But in his eyes, maybe I'd looked like something better avoided. Being unregistered meant that just standing still could make you something someone needed to steer around.

I almost gave up. But I started walking again.

A young woman was the first to actually see me.

"…What is it?" she asked. Not unkindly. Just curious.

"…Oh, just — walking the same way." I said. I heard, as soon as I said it, how foolish that sounded.

She laughed. Not a mocking laugh.

"…Unregistered, right?" she said. "We know about you people, coming here every day. We know."

I didn't know what to say, so I just nodded.

That was the first day I learned that I was called "you people." I wasn't anonymous. I'd thought I went unnoticed, but I'd already been sorted into a category. The one who comes every day. Those people. I was inside that category.

. . .

Her name was Damia. A few years older than me.

Damia had low standing, but she was registered — some points inherited from her parents' generation, enough to let her take wage work in the city. She said

her household wasn't well off. But she had a day's food, without fail.

"…I envy that." I said, without thinking.

Damia looked at me a moment.

"…Nothing to envy." Damia said. "We're day-to-day too. Only difference is, we work today, we get paid today, for sure. You don't."

I had no answer to that.

That was the first time I heard the phrase "day-to-day." I learned later it was common among the hired hands — people living off what they earned that same day. I heard it and thought I was day-to-day too. Except I was day-to-day without even the day part certain.

. . .

Walking a while longer beside Damia, the man who'd been handing out assignments came over.

"…That's an unregistered, isn't it?" he asked Damia. He didn't ask me directly.

"…Yes, she is." Damia answered.

"…Can't come further into the field. Know that?"

"…We're heading to the corner." I answered for myself. "Just walking together, that's all."

He looked at me a moment. Not looking me up and down — just checking.

"…The corner's fine." he said. "That's what it's for. Just don't come into the work zones. It's in the law too."

"…All right."

He turned away, satisfied.

I think that brief exchange is the most important thing in this chapter. He didn't chase me off. He didn't hate me. He simply confirmed a distinction laid out in the law. The corner is fine. The work zones aren't. I saw, for the first time that day, that distinction being kept exact. No one pushed me back any further than that. Exactly as much as the law allowed — no more, no less.

. . .

There were a great many people in the field that day.

Three driving the machines directly. Six following behind, checking their condition. Some carried tools from the storehouse; others drove boundary stakes. That was the first day I saw their faces one by one. Before, I'd only seen them, from a distance, as a mass.

Toward noon the sun grew fierce. The machines never stopped. Only the people took turns going in and out of the shade. Watching that rhythm, I thought of the outer settlement. There had been a rhythm to work there too. Only there, when people rested, the field rested with them. Here, when people rested, the field didn't. The machine kept going in their place.

I saw that difference clearly, for the first time, that day. Outside, people and field lived at the same pace. In the city, the field moved faster than the people. People were allowed to rest; the field wasn't allowed to. I didn't know, then, whose sake that pace was for.

Damia was assigned to follow one of the machines. I followed her out toward that zone and stood off to the side while she worked.

When break came, people gathered in the shade by the storehouse. Drank water, traded a few words, scattered again. I stood at the edge of the group.

"…Come sit." Damia called to me.

I went over carefully. No one said anything. I sat down beside Damia.

. . .

There was a man in that shade.

I saw him then for the first time. I couldn't guess his age — neither young nor old. His clothes were no different from anyone else's. Nothing distinctive about his face. He just sat quietly, drinking water.

While the others traded jokes back and forth, he said little. He laughed when there was something to laugh at, but he never spoke first.

"…Has he worked here long too?" I asked Damia, low.

"…Don't know." Damia shrugged. "Doesn't say much. But he's good at the work. Handles the machines, drives the stakes — whatever you ask, he does it."

"…What's his name?"

Damia thought a moment.

"…No idea, actually. Everyone just calls him 'him.'"

Hearing that answer, I didn't think it strange. I didn't yet know it was strange. The field was full of people whose names I never learned. I was one of them myself. One more nameless person didn't seem worth remarking on.

. . .

He looked at me once.

Our eyes met. Flustered, I looked away. But he showed no particular expression — just gave one small nod. Something like a greeting.

I nodded back, awkwardly.

That was all. No conversation followed. He finished his water, and when the break ended, he got up quietly and went back to his zone.

I've gone back over this scene many times since. Nothing at all remarkable about it. One nod. That was it. I didn't hold onto any special memory of him that day. Just — there's a quiet one, I thought. Nothing more than that.

Toward the end of the break, someone carrying tools dropped a spade handle. It had split. He was turning it over in his hands with a troubled look when the quiet man walked over, without a word, and took it from him.

He turned it a few times, then bound the crack with cord. It didn't take long. He handed it back and returned to his own spot without another word.

"…Thanks." the man who'd received it said, to his back.

He didn't turn around. Just raised one hand.

I didn't think much of this scene either, that day. There was always one person like that in a field — quick-handed, fixing things before being asked. I put it down to just how he was, nothing more than that.

. . .

That afternoon, I went back to the corner.

The time with the hired hands lasted only through the break. The rest of the time, they worked, and I sifted dirt alone as always. Nothing had changed. I filled about half a palm again that day.

But something felt a little different. Sifting the dirt, I wasn't lonely. Voices carried faintly from a distance — the machines, people calling out to one another. Before, those sounds had had nothing to do with me. That day they did.

I don't want to make too much of this small change. Nothing was solved. I was still unregistered, still someone who came home with half a palm and no more. Only, that day, for the first time, sifting the dirt didn't feel like something I was doing alone. That was all.

. . .

That evening I told Pikra about the day. Not right when I walked in — after supper, after the bowls were cleared away. Pikra never asked about things like that before we'd eaten. A conversation had on an empty stomach, she said, never gets properly heard by either side.

"…Did you talk to anyone?" Pikra asked.

"…Yes. Someone named Damia."

"…And?"

"…Not bad." I said. "She says she's day-to-day too. Same as us."

Pikra nodded.

"…That's true." Pikra said. "Everyone's day-to-day, in one way or another. Only for some, today's certain. For others, even today's not certain."

I sat a long while without answering.

That night I only talked about Damia. I said nothing about the quiet man. Not that I meant to hide him — I just had nothing much to say. How do you describe a single nod to someone? I didn't think about him again, not once, that night.

Now I know. That was my first meeting with him. And that the meeting began as quietly as anything in this book begins. I noticed nothing that day. There was nothing to notice.

. . .

The next day, I went back to the storehouse.

Damia was there again. We exchanged a few words. She treated me, by then, as someone she knew a little. That felt good.

The quiet man was there too. That day too, I just nodded and went on. He went to his zone; I went to the corner.

The days that followed went much the same. Stop by the storehouse in the morning, trade a few words with Damia, nod to the quiet man, go on to the corner and sift the dirt. In the evening, tell Pikra briefly what had happened that day. It was mostly about Damia. There was rarely much to say about the quiet man.

In those days I also learned a few of the other hired hands' names. The one who drove the stakes was called Nicol; the one who carried tools, Petros. I

memorized those names. It had been a long time since I'd memorized a new name. I'd hardly learned a new one since leaving the outer settlement.

Writing these names down again now, I feel something strange. Nicol and Petros never appear again in this record. They were only people who stood near me for a few days. I set their names down here so as not to forget them. A person doesn't stop having existed just because this record has no name for them.

There were a few others in the field whose names I never heard. The quiet man was one. I never thought it strange. Seeing a face every day without ever learning its name — that was common enough in the city.

Around then I started walking, every day, the same path — a stop at the storehouse, then on to the corner. On that path, I saw him every day. Nodded every day. That was all. I thought he was just a quiet person. I thought nothing more than that.

(Continued in Chapter 19.)

Chapter 19. The One Who Gleans Beside Me

> *_Previously_ — Xene began to break the ice with the hired hands. She*
> *got to know Damia. There was a quiet man there too. She never learned*
> *his name. She thought nothing of it.*

It was about ten days later.

Through those ten days, stopping by the storehouse before heading to the corner had become my fixed routine. Greet Damia, exchange a few words, nod to the quiet man, go on to the corner. That order almost never changed. Even the weather stayed much the same — hard sun, dry wind, the smell of dust every evening.

But that day, the quiet man was heading not toward the storehouse but toward the corner.

His assignment must have changed, I thought. That was all I made of it.

I haven't written those ten days in any detail here. There was little enough to write. The fact that every day was much like the last is, I think, the most accurate picture of what my days were like then. I never found that repetition tedious. Being able to repeat at all was, itself, a rare thing, after I'd left the outside.

. . .

The corner was never officially a work zone. But now and then it needed tending — clearing the ditch, straightening the marker, redriving a boundary stake. When there was work like that, one of the hired hands would be assigned.

That day, it was him.

I sat as always at one side of the corner and began sifting the dirt. He worked over by the ditch. Our spots didn't overlap. I didn't pay him any particular mind and kept at what I was doing.

I don't remember that day as a special one. Looking back now, this whole chapter is special. But to me, that day, it was just an ordinary day. Nothing different, except that there happened to be one more person there.

At one point, in the middle of leveling the dirt, he reached a hand toward me. I flinched. But what he was pointing at wasn't me — it was the ground by my foot.

A grain lay half-buried in the dirt beneath me. I'd have walked right past it.

"…There." he said, briefly.

I bent and picked it up. Before I could say thank you, he'd already turned back to the ditch.

I thought, that day, that he simply had a sharp eye. Someone who handles dirt every day might well spot a single grain before anyone else. I thought nothing more than that.

. . .

Sifting the dirt for a long while, I noticed at some point that he had drifted a little closer to me.

He hadn't said anything. The distance had simply narrowed naturally, as he tended the ditch. I felt uneasy at first. But he never looked at me — just kept at his own work. I settled again and went back to mine.

About half a day passed that way, and near where he'd been working, I began finding more grains.

More than usual.

. . .

I didn't think it strange.

Working a ditch turns up dirt — that was only natural, I thought. Whatever had been buried had come up with the churned soil. That seemed the obvious explanation. I believed it. I had good enough reason to.

I'm careful writing this part. I didn't notice a thing that day. Truly, I didn't. Whoever reads this chapter later will already know. I want to say this to them in advance: I didn't know, then. If I write that I knew, that would be a lie.

That evening, I gathered a little more than usual. More than two cupped palms. Even after sharing with Pikra, a few grains were left over.

"…Bit more today." Pikra said.

"…Must be from working the ditch." I said.

"…Must be." Pikra said.

We didn't press it further. Pikra wrapped the extra in a small cloth and set it aside for the next morning's share. We were learning, around then, to stretch a day's worth over two.

. . .

He was at the corner the next day too.

I wondered if his assignment had changed again. I didn't know whether that was common or not. I was curious, but I didn't ask. He was still as quiet as ever. He did his work. I did mine.

That day too, more grains than usual turned up near where I sifted — especially near where he'd been.

That was when I first thought, briefly, that it was strange. But the thought didn't hold. I was hungry, and a hungry person doesn't examine strange things too closely. I just gathered them.

I've gone back over that moment many times since. Why didn't I press further? The answer is simple. Nothing good could have come of it. If it wasn't a coincidence, asking might have made him stop. I wasn't calculating that carefully at the time. But some instinct told me that looking too closely at a good thing breaks it.

. . .

He still hardly spoke.

If I asked something, he gave short answers. "…Yes." "…No." Rarely more than that. At first I found it uncomfortable. A few days on, I found it a relief instead. There was no pressure to keep a conversation going.

"…Do you come here often?" I asked him once.

"…Sometimes." he said.

"…What brought you here today?"

"…Fixing the ditch."

That was the whole conversation. He went back to his work.

Reading those short answers again now, I smile. There's no lie in any of them. "Sometimes" was true. "Fixing the ditch" was true. He never once lied to me. He simply never told me what I hadn't asked.

. . .

Around then, Damia said something to me.

"…You're looking better these days." she said, when we crossed paths near the storehouse.

"…Am I."

"…Eating well?"

I didn't know what to say, so I just smiled. It wasn't as if I was eating well. But it was true things had improved.

"…Corner working out for you lately?" Damia asked again.

"…A bit better these days."

Damia nodded and went back to her work without pressing further. I watched her go and felt that her idle question had made the day a little lighter. Someone

being curious about my day, at all, was a rare thing for me then.

I think Damia's question was just a passing pleasantry. We weren't close enough yet for her to press into my circumstances. I didn't say more than that either. I didn't think it rude, at the time. Some questions are complete just by being asked, without needing an answer in full.

. . .

A few days on, I noticed a difference between the days he came and the days he didn't.

The days he came were, on the whole, better. The days he didn't were like before — very little, or nothing at all.

I put it down to the assignment. Days the corner needed tending, things got more disturbed, so naturally more turned up. I repeated that explanation to myself more than once. Not because I was trying not to doubt it. At the time, it really did seem the most plausible one.

I understand now that it wasn't that I tried not to doubt. It's more accurate to say I felt no need to doubt at all. It was enough, at the time, that my days had gotten a little better. Why they'd gotten better was a question for later. For a hungry person, later questions always get pushed back.

. . .

Pikra seemed to notice too.

One evening, she paused for a moment over what I'd laid out — more grain than usual. She said nothing, and went back to dividing it.

I saw that pause. I knew she'd seen it too.

"…Better lately." Pikra said, as she divided it. Not a prying tone.

"…Yes."

"…Good."

That was all. Pikra never asked why it had gotten better. I never explained. We divided the grain in half that evening, as always, ground the fragments and shared them in water, as always.

Looking back on that evening now, I wonder why Pikra didn't ask. Whether she didn't know, or knew and chose not to ask. I still can't say for certain. Pikra was someone who knew when not to ask, her whole life through. Whichever it was, that evening, she chose not to.

. . .

Once, an unusual amount of grain had gathered around where he'd been working.

I was gathering it when I happened to look up. He'd already moved off to another spot. Not looking at me.

"…There's a lot here." I said.

He glanced my way. Only briefly.

"…Is there." he said.

His expression stayed the same. Not startled, not concealing anything. Just — *is there.* That was all.

I can still picture that expression exactly. An expression holding nothing at all. I read it, at the time, as indifference. I read it differently now. It wasn't indifference — it was the face of someone who had decided not to answer. I couldn't tell the difference then.

. . .

I learned something from him, too.

At first I just brushed my fingers over the dirt carelessly. Then one day I happened to watch the way he sifted it. Fingers laid flat instead of stiffly upright, sweeping like a rake. Done that way, the grains caught against the fingertips far more easily.

From that day I started sifting the same way. Within a few days my hands had taken to it. My gathering grew a little faster.

"…This works better." I told him once.

"…Yes." he said. Nothing in his manner suggested he'd taught me anything. I didn't make a show of having learned it either. We simply both became people who sifted that way.

I still use that technique now. Fingers laid flat, sweeping the dirt like a rake. For years I never had occasion to explain to anyone who taught it to me. Some memories don't need explaining. There are things a hand simply knows.

. . .

Once, I nearly saw something.

Looking up, I caught his hand moving from near his waistband toward the dirt. It was a very brief motion. I didn't quite make out what it was. The next moment he was already gathering his tools, his hands empty.

"…Drop something?" I asked.

"…No." he said.

I accepted the answer without question. There was no particular reason to doubt it. A person's hands move around, working. I thought of that moment once, that night, and forgot it the next day.

I'm setting this scene down again now. I nearly saw something that time. Truly, only nearly. I didn't see it. Writing this book, I didn't want to inflate what I might have seen. I confirmed nothing. Not writing something unconfirmed as though it were confirmed — I believe that's one of the principles this record has to keep.

. . .

Around then, working beside him at the corner came to feel natural to me.

We'd never made any arrangement. It was simply that he came to be assigned to the corner more and more often, and I was there every day regardless, and at some point we became two people doing separate work in the same spot.

We still spoke little. But the silence stopped being uncomfortable. I found that strange. With Damia, silence felt like something that needed filling. Not with him. Quiet could just stay quiet, and it was fine.

I still don't know what to call this feeling. Comfort seems too large a word. I'll only set it down as this much: that there was now someone beside whom it wasn't strange to say nothing at all.

. . .

That evening, I told Pikra a little more about him.

"…There's someone who's been at the corner with me lately."

"…A hired hand?"

"…Yes. Doesn't say much, but he just works quietly nearby."

Pikra looked at me a moment.

"…Is he all right?"

"…Yes. He doesn't seem like a bad person."

Pikra nodded. She didn't ask anything further.

That night, lying down, I went back over those last few days. Nothing much had changed. I still went out every day, still got my hands into the dirt, still shared with Pikra in the evening. Only now, somewhere in that day, there was one more quiet person. He'd said hardly a word, but those few words had lifted a little of the day's weight.

Looking back on this stretch of time, I think it matters that I didn't feel, then, as though I were gaining anything remarkable. I only felt that the day was a little less lonely. I never wanted more than that, never suspected more than that. I don't know now what kind of beginning that might have been. At the time it was just one day after another.

I didn't mention that night, either, that there'd been more grain around his spot again. It didn't seem like something worth saying. I still believed, then, that it was only the ditch work turning things up. There was no need to put into words a thing I already believed.

Writing this chapter now, I think it's fortunate, in a way, that I didn't know then. If I had known, I wouldn't have been able to accept it. I believed it was chance, so I simply took it. And that, I think, was exactly what he wanted.

(Continued in Chapter 20.)

Chapter 20. The Administrator

> *_Previously_ — At the corner, Xene spent more and more time near the*
> *quiet man. Somehow, there always seemed to be a little more when he*
> *was around. Xene believed it was chance.*

The first time I met the administrator was the first time since my registration review. I'd only heard the name before that — the one who scores standing, who oversees the Roll. It had never once occurred to me that the position had a face.

The day I received a standing of zero at the gate, I learned that a post called "the administrator" existed. The one who assessed me that day wasn't the administrator himself, but someone working beneath him. The first time I actually saw the administrator was that day.

. . .

That day there happened to be a routine inspection at the corner zone.

I learned later that zones under Article 9 are inspected in person by the administrator several times a year — checking that the marker stands correctly, that the boundary is exact, that the clause is being kept. A formality.

I was sifting the dirt as usual that day. In the distance, I saw a few people walking my way. The one at the center was the administrator. I didn't know it at the time — his clothes were different from the other hired hands', and I only guessed he must be someone important.

The party numbered four. The administrator, two people carrying clipboards, and behind them, a young person walking a little apart. All of them moved slowly. No reason to hurry, it seemed. I only learned afterward that the young person was Lytron. That day I simply took him for one more attendant. Lytron said nothing that day. He stood near the administrator, looking over documents, occasionally jotting something down.

The two with clipboards worked through the zone item by item. Marker condition, boundary stake spacing, ditch drainage. Each time, they said "no irregularities" and made a note. I started counting how many times I heard that phrase that day, then gave up. Everything was without irregularity. There seemed nothing on that clipboard to note, besides the fact that I'd been sitting there for days.

. . .

The administrator was well along in years. His hair had gone half gray, his walk slow. Slow, but unwavering.

When the party reached the corner's boundary, the administrator stopped and looked over the whole zone. Checked the marker. Checked the ditch. Then he looked at me.

My body went rigid in that instant. There was no reason to run. I hadn't done anything wrong. But my body stiffened before I could think.

"…Unregistered?" the administrator asked one of the others. Not directly to me.

"…Yes. Comes every day, apparently." the other answered.

The administrator nodded.

. . .

The administrator walked closer to me. I stood where I was and waited. Part of me wanted to run, part of me wanted to ask something. In the end I chose not to run.

"…What's your name?" the administrator asked. The first thing he'd said to me directly.

"…Xene."

"…Xene." The administrator repeated it once. Not as though committing it to memory. Just confirming it.

"…I'm told you come here every day."

"…Yes."

"…What do you get?"

I hesitated a moment before answering.

"…Often not even a full day's food."

The administrator wasn't surprised by the answer. His expression didn't shift at all.

"…That would follow." the administrator said. "The loss rate is 0.02 percent."

I found the nerve, in that moment.

"…Why is my standing zero?"

The administrator looked at me a moment. This didn't seem to be the first time he'd heard the question.

"…It's a figure calculated from origin, history, relations." the administrator said. "You came from outside the city. You have no history here. And no registered relation to vouch for you. The calculation is exact."

"…So the calculation isn't wrong."

"…It isn't wrong." the administrator said. "It's only low. Wrong and low are different problems."

I couldn't help but admit that distinction was exact too. Admitting it only left me more frustrated. It would have been easier if I could have said he was wrong.

. . .

I felt, in that moment, as though I might be allowed to ask something more. Looking back, it was a strange feeling to have had. The administrator hadn't treated me unkindly. Nor had he been warm. But something in his manner seemed to draw speech out of a person.

"…Article 9 says the corner has to be left." I said. "The corner is there. Why is there nothing in it?"

The administrator looked at me a moment. Not eyes of anger.

"…The corner is there." the administrator said. "You can see it — the boundary stakes, the marker, a precisely designated zone. The law says to designate the corner. It never says how much is to fall there."

I turned that over in my mind.

"…So it's within the law, even if nothing's there?"

"…That's right." the administrator said. "The loss rate falling isn't a violation of law. It's a good harvest. The law says to leave the corner. It doesn't say to harvest poorly."

. . .

I've gone back over this conversation many times. I was looking, then, for some crack in what the administrator said. A lie, a stretch, a dodge. There was none. Everything he said was true. I had nothing to say, standing before that truth.

"…Then what am I supposed to do?" I asked.

For the first time, the administrator tilted his head, just slightly. He looked almost interested.

"…What do you mean, what are you supposed to do?"

"…The law is being kept. And I still can't eat."

"…The law is being kept." the administrator said.

I remember that tone even now. Not angry, not apologetic. The tone of someone stating a fact.

. . .

I hold onto that sentence as though it were the title of this chapter. "The law is being kept." I hear that sentence again, many times, through the rest of this city's story. Always in the same tone. I never once found a flaw in that tone. That there was no flaw was the frightening part.

The overseer in Book Two was ashamed of his own work, I learned later, from Mena. He'd stay behind at night, going back over the ledgers alone. The adjudicator in Book Three faltered too, in the end — his hand shook, I was told, standing before the scales. Every time I heard those two stories, I thought: at least there was something, inside those two, that snagged.

This administrator was different. I never once saw him waver. His voice never rose. He never looked away, never hesitated over an answer. A few days later, passing that spot again, I tried, on the chance of it, to recall his expression. However hard I searched, I found nothing that snagged. The reason he never wavered was simple. He had no reason to. He truly hadn't broken anything.

. . .

"…Do you know why the corner clause exists?" the administrator asked.

"…To leave something for those in need."

"…Correct." the administrator said. "And that's still exactly how it stands. No one blocks that place. No one drives you out of it. You can come every day. That is a right the law guarantees."

"…But there's nothing there."

"…That falls outside what the law guarantees." the administrator said. "The law guarantees the place. It never guaranteed how much would be in it."

I felt, in that moment, for the first time, how exact that distinction was — and how completely that exactness could leave a person with nowhere to stand.

"…Then who decides how much is left there?" I asked again.

The administrator looked at me a moment. For the first time, his face looked as if he were choosing his words.

"…That's a matter for harvest operations." the administrator said. "There are people who adjust machine placement, harvest speed, that sort of thing. I only confirm that the law is being kept. How much is left is not my remit."

It struck me as odd that this answer didn't sound like an evasion. It really was structured that way. This city had divided the work among so many hands that no one needed to answer for the whole of it.

"…Who are those people?"

The administrator glanced back, briefly. That was the moment Lytron looked up from his documents. I didn't know, at the time, what that meant. I only registered that the administrator had glanced at someone.

"…No need to concern yourself with that." the administrator said, turning back to me. "They're within regulation too. No one here has broken any rule."

Writing this over again later, I've come back, many times, to that moment Lytron briefly looked up. Lytron told me, much later, that he remembered that day. He said it was the first time he'd ever seen, in the same frame, the number that was the loss rate and the person standing in the place that had made it.

. . .

The administrator said a few words more, then turned to leave.

"…Keep coming." the administrator said, last of all. "No reason for me to stop you."

That could have sounded kind. I knew, even then, that it wasn't. It was simply a statement of fact. No reason to stop you meant, equally, no reason to help you.

I turned that sentence over many times that night. "No reason to stop you." I came to think that sentence explained this entire city. No one stopped me. No one helped me either. Someone like me stood in the space between those two.

The party left as they'd come. The ones with clipboards went first, the administrator following slowly behind. Lytron, moving last, turned back once. Our eyes met.

I thought, in that instant, that I'd seen that face somewhere before. I couldn't place it exactly. I let the thought pass, a stray one.

I didn't learn until later that this was the same face that had first found me in Chapter 15. I didn't know it that day. My head was too full of the administrator to spare Lytron any thought. In this city, I kept crossing faces I would only recognize later.

. . .

Back home, I told Pikra what had happened.

"…I met the administrator today."

Pikra's expression tightened slightly.

"…What did he say?"

"…That the law is being kept."

Pikra was quiet a long while before she spoke.

"…That's the most frightening thing he could say." Pikra said. "The overseer, the adjudicator — people like that at least know what they're doing, and it eats at them. That one doesn't."

"…Why not?"

"…Because he has nothing to feel bad about." Pikra said. "Because everything he says is right."

"…If it's right, why is that frightening?"

Pikra looked at me a long moment.

"…You can't even get angry at someone who's right." Pikra said. "You can fight back against someone who's wrong. Shout that it's unjust. Against someone who's right, you can't even do that. All you can do is sit there and listen."

I sat a long while, saying nothing, after she said that.

I wondered, that day, how Pikra could know so exactly, without ever having met the administrator herself. I understand now. Pikra had already lived it, more than once. Standing in front of someone who is never wrong. Through those years — losing her husband, losing both sons, watching her own standing whittled away — Pikra must have met people like that many times over. People who did nothing wrong at all, and gave nothing at all.

. . .

I kept going out to the corner after that.

Nothing changed. I filled about half a palm again the next day, and he still worked quietly beside me. All the administrator's visit had left behind was a

marker standing a little straighter than before.

For days after, I kept turning his words over. "The law guarantees the place. It never guaranteed how much would be in it." I kept coming back to that sentence — walking, sifting the dirt, even lying down to sleep. It felt as though there had to be some gap in it somewhere. However hard I looked, there wasn't.

I realized, around then, that this had been the first time I tried to argue with this city over something. The argument never got off the ground. An argument requires the other side to say something wrong, and the administrator never once did. That was the day I first learned that against something true, there's no argument to be had at all.

I met the administrator again much later. By then I had different questions. That day, I only walked home turning over why the words "the law is being kept" could leave a person feeling so utterly without ground beneath her.

Writing this chapter, I felt the pull, more than once, to paint the administrator as worse than he was — to write his voice cold, his expression scornful. That would have been a lie. The administrator never once raised his voice at me. He never mocked me. He was simply exact. That day I learned, for the first time, how frightening an exact person can be.

I will never, anywhere in this book, write a scene where the Roll breaks the law. The helplessness I felt that day, standing before the administrator, is exactly why. If it had been unlawful, I'd at least have had somewhere to fight — someone to appeal to, someone to protest against. Before what is lawful, there is no such place at all. I felt that absence of a place, that day, with my whole body. And that absence of a place is what this book, from beginning to end, turns out to be about. I didn't know that then. I know it now.

(Continued in Chapter 21.)

Chapter 21. The Arithmetic

> *_Previously_ — Xene met the administrator. He was not ashamed of his*
> *own system. "The law is being kept." That sentence was true, and so*
> *it could not be argued with.*

This is a chapter I didn't live through.

Like Chapter 16, this one is pieced together from what Lytron told me directly, much later, and what Mena confirmed. What Lytron saw and thought that night — without his own words, I would never have known any of it.

Every time I write a chapter like this, I ask myself: do I have the right to set down something I never saw. Mena answered that question for me once. "Don't ask about the right. Ask about the honesty." I hold to that standard here as well.

. . .

The night of the administrator's round, Lytron stayed at the office later than usual.

He couldn't quite explain why, even to himself. He only said that something he'd seen that afternoon kept nagging at him. Me, standing before the administrator. And the question I'd asked. *Why is my standing zero.*

I was careful writing this chapter. If I wrote that Lytron stayed at the office because of me, this story would look more dramatic than it really was. Lytron

told me, later: "It wasn't only because of you. The numbers just happened to catch my eye that day." I take him at his word.

That afternoon, accompanying the administrator, Lytron had filled out the round's paperwork. "Zone under Article 9, no irregularities." He'd written that line as always — one line, no different from any other item.

But writing it, he found himself going back over the question I'd asked the administrator. *Why is my standing zero.* And the administrator's answer. *The calculation is exact.* Lytron said he'd felt no unease at all, hearing that answer. Not at the time.

I think this detail matters. Lytron felt nothing strange about it that afternoon. What snagged at him only surfaced that evening. I first learned, through Lytron, that a person's feelings can move on that kind of delay.

. . .

That night, Lytron spent a long while looking over the harvest settings screen.

It wasn't within the scope of his job. A zone management assistant had no authority to touch loss-rate settings. But viewing them was allowed. Seeing a number and changing a number were different permissions.

Lytron opened the loss-rate item. Several figures filled the screen. Current loss rate, 0.02 percent. Target loss rate, 0.02 percent. Tolerance range, zone-by-zone breakdowns, a graph correlating machine uptime with loss rate. Numbers, and numbers, and numbers.

He said he sat looking at that screen for a long while. He'd seen it many times before. It was exactly this screen that produced the number he reported to his father every morning. But that night, he said, the numbers looked different

than they had before. "It didn't look like numbers anymore. It looked like a fence, holding something in." Much later, that was how he put it to me.

Beside it was a record of past figures. This number hadn't always been 0.02 percent.

. . .

A decade or so earlier, the loss rate had been far higher.

There had been years in the low 3 percent range. Then, over the course of several years, adjustments had brought it down to today's 0.02 percent. Optimizing machine paths, adjusting harvest speed, changing labor placement. Begun in his grandfather's generation, I was told, and completed in his father's.

Hearing that number for the first time, a chill ran through me. Three percent. Up to then I'd only known the number 0.02. But there had once been a time when a hundred times that much had fallen at the corner. That hundredfold hadn't simply vanished. Someone had erased it, deliberately, over the span of two generations.

To one side of the screen was a short summary of the adjustment process. Below the year-by-year graph, a note: "Two-generation zone optimization; registered as a best-practice case within the Harvest." Lytron said he read that sentence over several times. It was the story he'd grown up hearing. His grandfather had first fixed the machine paths; his father had finished the job. And that story had been reduced, on the screen, to a short phrase: "best-practice case." Looking at that phrase, he said, he felt for the first time as if he were seeing, laid out beside a number, the true nature of the thing his family had long taken pride in.

Lytron noticed, at the corner of the screen, a button for adjusting the setting value. He'd never pressed it before. There had never been any occasion to, in his line of work. But that night, he found himself curious what it might do.

. . .

He hesitated a moment, then pressed the setting value, just to see.

The number didn't change immediately. A confirmation window appeared. "Change the loss-rate setting? Projected harvest yield will be adjusted accordingly." Below it, the projected decrease in yield was shown.

Reverting from 0.02 percent to 3 percent would drop the yield sharply. I won't write the exact figure here. I learned it later, but even now it unsettles me every time I write it down.

Below the confirmation window was another item: "Projected impact on linked indices." Lytron pressed that as well. Numbers unfolded. Zone performance score, family-linked score, and beside them a small arrow. Pointing down. He said he looked at that arrow for a long while. The screen, helpfully, had already calculated exactly how far it would fall. Lytron told me he never once looked that number up again, after that night. Once was enough. He never needed to look again.

I want to explain why I'm not writing that number down. Not because the number itself doesn't matter — the opposite. If I wrote it, a reader would use it as a calculator. Too much, too little, worth bearing, not worth bearing. I don't want this chapter read that way. What Lytron saw that night wasn't a number. It was a fork in the road. That's the only thing I want to set down here.

Lytron sat a long while looking at that confirmation window. He didn't press it.

. . .

I don't want to write this scene as though Lytron had done something wrong. He did nothing. He looked at a confirmation window and closed it. That's all there was. I've rewritten this chapter more than once, trying not to paint that "doing nothing" as a bad thing.

Before closing the screen, Lytron ran a few calculations. His family's standing score had, for generations, been tied directly to this field's harvest efficiency. The number his grandfather had built and his father had held. If that number wavered, the whole family's score would waver with it.

"…What does this have to do with our score?" he asked himself, that night. The answer came quickly. It had everything to do with it. Very directly.

His brother's words came to mind. *Keep the numbers right, and everything else falls into place.* Lytron had lived his life believing that. But that night, for the first time, he noticed it was a conditional. Keep the numbers right, and it falls into place — that sentence also meant that if you didn't, it wouldn't. He said he'd never once thought through that second half before.

I've rewritten this passage several times. There was a temptation to write that Lytron had begun to doubt his brother's words. That would be an exaggeration. He hadn't doubted. He had simply seen, for the first time, that the sentence had another side to it. Seeing and doubting are not the same thing.

. . .

That night, Lytron followed the thread of what would happen if he reverted the loss rate, one step at a time.

The yield falls. The zone's performance worsens. His father learns of it. His father asks why. Lytron has to answer. *There's someone who comes to the corner every day.* He already knew, that night, how that answer would sound to his father.

He said he ran that imagined scene through his head more than once. His father asks, "And?" Lytron can't find the next words. "Because I felt sorry for her" sounds too sentimental. "Because of Article 9" would be a lie — Article 9 was already being kept. What he really meant was simpler than either: that it bothered him, that this person sat there at the corner every single day. But that reason looked far too small to justify cutting into the family's standing score.

I think I saw Lytron most clearly in this scene. He was someone whose calculations moved fast. And his calculations weren't wrong. His family's score really would have fallen. His father really would have asked. That answer really would have sounded strange. What Lytron feared wasn't imagination. It was fact.

Lytron thought, for a moment, of telling a friend about it. There was someone among his fellow zone-management assistants he was close with. But he had no idea even how to start. *I'm thinking about reverting the corner's loss rate.* The moment that sentence left his mouth, it would no longer be his alone. Someone would ask why, and he would have to answer.

In the end, Lytron told no one at all.

I understand Lytron in this part. Some thoughts change weight the moment they're spoken aloud. Held privately, they're only thoughts. Spoken, they become something that demands a decision. I don't think that kind of silence is bad in itself. I only think it needs to be recorded, honestly, what that silence ultimately protected.

. . .

That night, Lytron closed the confirmation window.

He didn't press the button. He turned off the screen. He got up from his seat and went home.

Writing this chapter, I don't want to sit in judgment of Lytron. I won't write that he should have pressed that button. I wasn't there in that seat, and I don't know, the way he did, what that seat demanded of him. I only set down what happened. He looked at the window, and he closed it.

Lytron never opened that settings screen again after that night. Not for some time, at least.

He walked home from the office. The hour was late, and the street was quiet. Water was running behind the wall. A sound he heard all the time — but that night, he said, it sounded unusually loud. The water was only there for the yard's sake, let to run freely for no purpose at all. Lytron thought, for the first time that night, about where that water had come from. Water drawn from somewhere, passing through this yard, running straight out into the ditch, unused.

Lytron told me this scene himself. His voice dropped a little, telling it. I didn't ask what that meant. Some realizations can't fully be explained even by the person who has them. Some nights leave behind nothing more than this: that the water sounded loud.

. . .

The next morning, at breakfast, his father asked as he always did.

"…Yesterday's loss rate."

"…0.02 percent. No change."

"…Good work."

Lytron said no lie in giving that answer. There really had been no change. He hadn't changed anything. But he said that "good work" sounded strange to him that morning, in a way it never had before. He couldn't have said, exactly, what it was he'd done well.

I've set this breakfast scene down again here to place it beside Chapter 16. Same table, same question, same answer, same praise. Not a single thing had changed on the surface. But something different had passed through the person giving that answer than had the day before. Outwardly, nothing at all had happened. Writing this chapter, I confirm again that this "nothing happening" is the most frequently repeated fact in this whole book.

. . .

A few days later, Lytron passed me again on his rounds.

I was sifting the dirt as always. It was a hot day. Lytron paused for a moment, then went on. He said nothing. I had no idea, then, what he knew.

Picturing that moment now, I find myself wondering what his expression must have been. He only ever told me this much: "I just passed by. There was nothing to say." I believe him. There truly would have been nothing to say. He was carrying a problem with no answer to offer for it.

. . .

I want to close this chapter with something Lytron said much later.

"…At the time, I just thought I had no reason to take a loss." he told me, much later. "Strange, thinking back on it now. That I called it a loss. You didn't even

have a day's food, and I called it a loss."

I said nothing to that.

"…I thought I was right, at the time." Lytron went on. "Protecting the family was my job. I still can't say that was wrong, even now. Only — I know now that what I closed that night wasn't only a window."

"…What did you close?" I asked.

Lytron was quiet a long while before answering.

"…I don't know." he said. "That's probably why I still keep bringing it up."

Hearing that answer, I understood that Lytron was still looking for it. I have no intention of handing him that answer. This book isn't written to give it. I only set down, together, these two facts: that he closed a window that night, and that even years later, he still hadn't been able to put that question down.

I've rewritten this chapter several times. The first time, I wrote that not pressing the button had been cowardice. Reading it back, I saw it wasn't honest. I've never stood before that button myself. I was someone with nothing to lose. I won't pretend to understand how someone with something to lose hesitates before it — but I won't judge it carelessly either.

The night he closed that window, I knew nothing. I came home that day too with half a palm's worth and shared it with Pikra. Two evenings existed, separately, in the same city, the same night. One was an evening of calculation. One was an evening of sharing.

Writing this chapter, I keep coming back to that downward arrow. I've never seen an arrow like that. I had no score to fall, to begin with. So I know I have no right to judge how heavy that arrow was. I only leave here, as it was, the fact that someone looked at it with his own two eyes, and closed the window.

(Continued in Chapter 22.)

Chapter 22. Transfer

> *_Previously_ — Lytron learned that the loss-rate setting could be reverted. He also learned that reverting it would lower his family's score. He closed the window.*

A few days later, I had reason to go to the administration office again.

It was for Pikra's registration renewal. Once a year, the procedure required a confirmation. Pikra wasn't feeling well that day, so it was I who went to collect the paperwork.

. . .

Around this time, I'd begun to sense that Pikra's health was slipping a little. She sat down to rest more often, and sometimes had to catch her breath in the middle of supper. I couldn't quite tell whether it was age, or the amount we were splitting between us every evening. Probably both. The whole walk to the office that day, that was what occupied me. It worried me more than the paperwork did.

Pikra hadn't objected when I offered to go in her place. Once, she'd have insisted on going herself — said she couldn't ask that of a daughter-in-law. That day she only said, "…Be careful, go on," and nothing more. The shortness of it worried me more than any protest would have.

The office stood near the gate, in the same building where I'd first been reviewed for registration. I wasn't eager to walk back into that building. The memory wasn't a good one.

I stood in front of it a moment, hesitating. If I opened that door, I felt, the feeling I'd had standing before that counter would come rushing back. Standing zero. I took a breath and went in.

I would end up in that building many more times after that. Every time, I paused a moment at the door. The habit never went away, even years later. Some places never grow familiar, however often you visit them.

. . .

I waited a long while in line at the window. Everyone ahead of me carried similar paperwork. Renewals, corrections, confirmations. All their faces wore the same tired look.

The man in front of me said he'd come about a relocation procedure. Moving to a different zone meant re-registering your residence too, he grumbled to the person beside him. Ahead of him stood a woman holding a baby, there about the child's birth registration. She was arguing at length with the clerk — the paperwork had come back wrong.

I killed time listening to that argument. This city seemed to have an endless number of things that required paperwork. Once at birth, once at marriage, once at each move, once at every renewal. Listening to that list, I found myself thinking, again, that outside, none of that paperwork had ever been necessary.

The line behind me kept growing. An old man stood leaning on a cane, shifting his weight from leg to leg, looking for somewhere to sit. Eventually the clerk came out and offered him a chair. The man thanked her, over and over. I thought the thanks a little excessive, at first — then understood it. Inside that building, even a small kindness was rare.

I still remember that old man's face. I never learned his name, never saw him again after that day. But the way he thanked her, so gratefully, for a single chair — it seemed to say something about how stingy this city was, ordinarily, with its people.

The woman with the baby was eventually directed to a different window. Watching her walk away, I thought: even a child born into this city has to be met with paperwork before anything else. It struck me as strange. Outside, when a child was born, you simply gave it a name, and that was the end of it. Here, apart from the name, you had to receive a number too.

At the next window, a young man was arguing in a low voice with a clerk. He seemed to be asking why his history score had dropped a little in this renewal. The clerk flipped through the screen a few times and explained that he'd changed residence twice in the past year. The man said it hadn't been a move — just a temporary relocation for work. The clerk answered that the reason wasn't considered; only the number of relocations counted. The man argued a while longer, then finally said he understood and left with his papers. Watching him go, I thought: in this building, even a grievance only amounts to a single sheet of paper.

When my turn came, the clerk handed over the form and began explaining it. The administrator, passing by just then, recognized me and stopped.

"…The one who comes to the corner." the administrator said.

"…Yes. I'm here for my mother-in-law's renewal papers."

The administrator nodded and gave a brief instruction to the clerk. Then, seeing I wasn't familiar with the procedure, he explained a few things to me himself.

. . .

"…Renewal has to be done by the person themselves; a proxy is only allowed in limited cases." the administrator said. "Marriage relations, direct family relations — cases like that."

"…Does a mother-in-law count as family?"

"…A daughter-in-law isn't counted as direct. Marriage relations are handled under a different procedure. Doesn't matter today, though — you're only collecting the form."

I went a little blank, hearing that. Two years living under the same roof, and by this city's rules, that still didn't count as direct family. I thought the distinction strange, but it didn't seem worth arguing over.

. . .

The administrator kept going, working through the rest as someone who knew the whole procedure by heart, several items at once.

"…There are a few more things to confirm besides this form." the administrator said. "Residence confirmation, relationship confirmation, and whether there's been any change to history within the past year. As I understand it, your mother-in-law's side has had none — is that right?"

"…Yes, none."

"…Then this one will be simple enough."

"…Score assessment moves through a few different channels." the administrator went on. "The origin item is fixed once, at registration, and adjusted afterward by history and relation. On marriage, it's combined with the spouse's score; on having children, it's inherited by a fixed ratio; on death, an attrition ratio applies. And there's also a thing called registration-item

adjustment — transfer's possible too, technically, though in practice it's almost never used. There's a separate application form for it, but I understand there haven't been any filings in recent years."

The administrator said all this while already sorting the next form with his hands.

"…Once a marriage relation is dissolved, it's automatically reassessed, and the appeal period's one month, and appeals only go through the dedicated window, and processing usually takes two to four weeks once filed." the administrator kept on. "Right, write your mother-in-law's name and registration number on this form and take it along. Get the confirmation stamp at that window over there — I'm not sure how late that window stays open today, so you'd best hurry."

The administrator added a few more things in the meantime — notes printed on the back of the form, the reassessment cycle, the correction procedure, which cases were fee-exempt and which weren't. I couldn't hold onto any of it separately. One regulation overlapped another until I lost track of where one item ended and the next began. The administrator's voice moved through all of it at exactly the same pitch. Not a single inflection that told you which parts mattered and which didn't.

. . .

I let most of the explanation slide past me. What form to fill in mattered more, just then. The clerk handed me another sheet, and I wrote Pikra's name and registration number on it. I got a digit wrong and had to write it again.

I remember how stifling the dry air in that office felt that day, more than usual. There were no windows in the room. Just the sound of people breathing and paper turning. All I wanted was to finish the form and get out.

. . .

It took a long while to get the confirmation stamp. I was sent to two more windows. At the first, they said the registration number I'd written didn't match the required format, and I had to rewrite it. At the second, the clerk was away from the desk and I waited more than ten minutes. Only at the third window did I finally get the stamp.

By the time I got through it all, most of what the administrator had explained earlier had slipped from my mind. One thing stuck: that a daughter-in-law wasn't counted as direct family. Only that.

I kept turning that over as I walked. I didn't even know the name Ruth then. That was a name from an old story I'd only learn much later, from Mena. But in that moment, it struck me all over again how this city sorted me. Two years living here, and I was still, in its eyes, someone "joined by marriage."

I heard, from Mena much later, about an old regulation this city drew on. There'd been a long-standing dispute, apparently, over how to count a relationship like a daughter-in-law's. In the end it had been settled on the side of marriage. Hearing that, I thought back to what I'd been told at that window. At the time I'd taken it for nothing more than paperwork procedure. I hadn't known that someone, long before, had argued over that very distinction.

The light had slanted low by the time I left the building. I'd spent nearly half a day inside. My legs ached the whole walk home. Standing still, waiting, I learned that day, could wear a person down every bit as much as sifting dirt in the field.

On my way back I passed through the market alley. The sounds of people preparing supper drifted by. Listening to them, I tried to reckon up how much of what I'd heard that day was really mine to keep. Not much. Most of it had been regulation with nothing to do with me; the only part that touched me was

that single line — *a daughter-in-law isn't direct family.* At the end of the alley I caught a familiar back — Lytron, carrying a clipboard, apparently on his way back from a round. He didn't seem to see me. I didn't call out either. I just watched his back disappear around the corner, then turned toward the cottage.

. . .

Back home, I handed the papers to Pikra.

"…That took a while." Pikra said. Her color looked a little better.

"…The line was long. And they said a daughter-in-law isn't direct, so I couldn't be proxy — I just brought back the form."

"…That's how it goes." Pikra said, looking the form over. "Always has been."

"…They explained a lot of other things too, but I couldn't follow most of it."

"…Don't worry about it." Pikra said. "As long as the paperwork's right, that's what matters. No need to follow everything they say."

We didn't discuss it further.

I studied Pikra's face again. Better than that morning, but still pale.

"…How are you feeling today?" I asked.

"…Fine. Just a little dizzy, that's all."

"…Tell me if it happens again tomorrow."

"…All right." Pikra said. Then, as if changing the subject, she folded the form away. "Better keep this safe. We'll need it again next year's renewal."

That night, I watched Pikra's hands as she folded the form. Her fingertips looked thinner than before. I noticed it and said nothing. Around that time I was learning that noticing something doesn't mean you have to say it out loud.

. . .

A few days later, I mentioned the long wait at the office to Damia too.

"…I had no idea the renewal process was that complicated." I said.

"…Everyone says that." Damia said. "I spent half a day at the window myself last year doing mine. Nobody actually understands all the regulations. You just fill in the form the way they tell you and get your stamp, that's all."

"…Is there anyone who actually knows all of it?"

"…Probably just the administrator." Damia laughed. "People like us don't need to."

I agreed.

"…Still, it took forever." I said. "I got sent to three different windows."

"…That's just how it is there." Damia laughed. "I spent half a day there last year too. Next time I'm going first thing in the morning."

"…I should do that too."

"…Funny thing, though." Damia said. "All that complication, and what actually matters comes down to a few lines. The rest you can go your whole life not knowing and be fine."

"…So how do you know which few lines matter?"

Damia shrugged.

"…You just learn it, living long enough." she said. "Or you never learn it at all. I've seen both."

We moved on, after that, to talk about the day's work. Damia had a machine inspection scheduled; I had to get to the corner.

. . .

The next day, I went to the corner later than usual. The morning had been eaten up by the paperwork.

He was already working the ditch when I arrived. He saw me and gave one nod. I nodded back.

"…I'm late." I said. There wasn't really any need to explain, but the words came out anyway.

"…That's all right." he said.

I didn't tell him about the office. There wasn't much to tell, and he didn't seem particularly curious either. We each sifted our own patch of dirt that day, same as always. Late start or not, my basket filled to about the usual amount by evening.

It still strikes me as a little odd that I never told him what had happened that day. I'd told him a fair amount, by then. But what I'd heard that day just didn't seem like it would mean anything to him. Paperwork talk. I thought, at the time, it had just been a dull day, nothing more.

Partway through, Damia stopped by and asked again about the office windows. I told her how many tries it had taken me to get the stamp. She

clicked her tongue.

"…Longer than me, even." Damia said. "Come with me next time. I know the order of those windows."

"…I'll take you up on that, next time."

Only after I'd said it did it occur to me that I now had one more person in this city I could ask a favor of.

Writing this chapter, I tried to set that day down exactly as it was. Nothing remarkable happened. I picked up a form, stood in line, went home. Some days just pass that way. Without leaving any mark at all.

(Continued in Chapter 23.)

Chapter 23. Why Don't You Leave

> *_Previously_ — Xene went to the office for Pikra's renewal papers. Somewhere in the administrator's explanation of the procedure was a*
> *brief line about the possibility of transferring standing to someone else. No one lingered on it. Xene soon forgot it too.*

Around that time, Lytron began coming to the corner even on days he wasn't scheduled to inspect it.

At first I didn't notice. I assumed the inspection schedule had simply shifted. Then one day, Damia mentioned it in passing.

"…He's not on rounds today." Damia said, tipping her chin toward Lytron. "Wasn't last week either."

"…How do you know?"

"…The round roster's posted, by the storehouse." Damia said. "He came on a day his name wasn't on it."

I gave the remark little thought. I'd never counted the days he came against the days he didn't. To me, he was just someone who occasionally stopped by in passing.

. . .

After mentioning that, Damia asked me something else.

"…Why don't you leave, anyway, Xene?"

I'd heard that question before. But coming from Damia, it sounded a little different.

"…Leave where?"

"…Here. This city." Damia said. "I'd have left long ago, in your place. No standing out there, right? Better to stretch your legs out there than sit here like this every day."

"…Why don't you leave, then?" I asked back.

Damia laughed.

"…I've got standing." she said. "Low, but I've got it. If I left, even that would be gone. Staying here, at least there's something."

I thought her answer was exact. Damia had something in this city worth holding onto. I had nothing. And yet I still didn't leave. Damia didn't seem to notice that difference and turned back to her own work.

I couldn't give Damia a proper answer that day. She didn't seem to be waiting for one either — just a remark thrown out in passing. I didn't know, then, that the same question would come back to me, far heavier, from someone else's mouth just a few days later.

. . .

And that day was one of those.

The light was overcast. No wind, so the dust hung low. I was sifting the dirt in my usual spot. He wasn't at the ditch that day — assigned elsewhere, I'd heard.

Lytron came over and stood beside me. At first he said nothing. Just stood there. I found that odd. Lytron was always someone who came with something to say. Not that day.

"…Did you have something to say?" I asked first.

"…No." he said. "Just passing through."

I didn't believe him. It wasn't a day for inspection; there was no reason to be passing through here at all. But I didn't press. I'd already learned, by then, that pressing rarely led anywhere good.

. . .

He stood a long while, watching me sift.

"…You lay your fingers flat for that." he said.

I stopped my hand.

"…Yes."

"…You used to keep them up."

I was a little startled. I hadn't expected him to remember a detail that small.

"…I learned it." I said. "It's faster this way."

"…From whom?"

I hesitated over the answer. I didn't want to bring up the quiet man in front of Lytron. I couldn't quite explain why, even to myself.

"…Just picked it up." I said.

Lytron looked at that answer a moment, as if turning it over. He didn't seem to believe it. But he didn't press further either.

I still remember that small lie. It wasn't that I was trying to protect him. It was only that something felt like it would break if I brought him up in front of Lytron. By then, I already understood — some good things only last if you don't describe them too closely.

. . .

"…Xene." Lytron said, abruptly.

I stopped my hand and looked up at him. That was the first time he'd used my name alone, without any title attached.

"…Yes."

Lytron chose his next words carefully. An unfamiliar hesitation, for him. Usually his questions came right out.

"…Could you not go somewhere else, instead of here?"

I didn't understand the question at first.

"…The corner? Somewhere with a higher loss rate, like you mentioned before?"

"…No." he shook his head. "Not that either. I mean the city."

. . .

I let my dirt-covered hand rest still on my knee.

"…What do you mean?"

"…Outside." Lytron said. "You came from outside originally, I heard. There's no such thing as standing out there."

"…That's right."

"…Then you wouldn't have to sit here like this every day, out there." he said. "Here, however long you stay, your standing never rises. I know that calculation — I run it. If your origin is outside, once and for all, that outside never changes."

I couldn't say anything for a moment, hearing that.

"…Are you telling me to go back?"

"…That's not what I mean." Lytron said, a little flustered. "I'm just curious. Whether it's actually better for you, being here."

"…Better how?" I asked.

That question stopped him.

"…Full, and safe." he finally managed. "That kind of thing."

"…You can be full outside too." I said. "As long as it's not a bad year. Safe's about the same too. There's no Roll out there, so no one judges me by standing, either."

"…Then it's better, isn't it." Lytron said. "So why are you here?"

I thought, for a moment, of that settlement. Twenty-two houses, once. How many of them were still standing now, I didn't know. Since my husband died, and then his brother too, I hadn't heard a single word from that settlement.

"…Going back wouldn't be the same as before." I said. "No husband. Neither of that family's sons left."

"…Even so, you could live without standing."

"…Yes, I could live." I said. "But that's not why I'm here."

. . .

I turned that question over a long time, that night. Even now I don't think Lytron meant it unkindly. He really would have seen it as a matter of numbers. Outside, no standing, none needed. Inside, no standing, and it's a problem. The same nothing, and yet it's not a problem out there, and it is in here. To him, it must have been a perfectly simple calculation.

I can't say that calculation was wrong. It wasn't. Only, there was something that calculation didn't include. It took me a long while, that day, to put it into words.

Lytron waited for my answer. He didn't press. As he always did.

"…I'm not here because I have nowhere else to go." I finally said.

"…Then why?"

I set my hand back down on the dirt. As if preparing the answer in my hand first.

"…Pikra is here."

. . .

Lytron looked, for a moment, like he didn't quite understand the answer.

"…Your mother-in-law?"

"…Yes."

"…Couldn't she come with you?" he said. "You both came from outside, didn't you?"

"…Pikra's not going."

"…Why not?"

I didn't answer that right away. Not because I didn't know the answer. Because I didn't know how to say it, in front of Lytron.

"…It's where she'll be buried." I said. "Her whole family's in this city's graveyard. Husband, both sons. Pikra wants to be laid beside them."

Lytron was quiet a moment.

"…That's the reason." he finally said, just that much.

"…Yes."

. . .

"…Then what about you?" Lytron asked again. "You're not someone who belongs buried outside. Couldn't you leave on your own?"

I thought the question was exact. Exact enough that it was harder to answer.

"…That's right." I said. "I could leave, on my own."

"…But you don't."

"…No."

"…Why?"

I held onto that *why* for a long while. I had several answers ready for it, at the time. All of them true, and all of them incomplete. *I can't leave her alone* was true but wasn't everything. *There's nowhere particularly better to go to* was also true, and also not everything.

I've rewritten this passage several times. At first I tried to explain it at greater length — laying out reasons one by one. But what I actually said that day was much shorter. I decided to leave that shortness as it was. Long reasons are usually invented afterward.

. . .

"…I go where you go." I said.

Lytron looked at me a moment, hearing that.

"…That's it?"

"…Yes."

"…I don't quite understand." he said, honestly. "You gave up standing, and you sit here every day, and that's all because of that one thing?"

"…Yes."

Lytron looked like a man who couldn't find any words to turn that answer around. I recognized that look. It was close to the look I'd worn myself, in

front of the administrator. The look of someone who can't find where to object, standing before something true.

I understood, in that moment, for the first time, that I could put that same look on someone else's face. Until then it had always been my turn to wear it — before the administrator, before this city. That day, for the first time, the seats changed.

. . .

"…Isn't it a loss?" Lytron asked. He looked a little surprised at himself for saying it.

"…What is?"

"…You're not gaining anything. Being here."

I turned that over.

"…I'm not here to gain anything." I said.

"…Then what?"

I had no answer. Truly none. There was no right word in me for that question, then. If I wasn't there to gain something, why was I there — I couldn't find the words for that either.

Lytron didn't ask further. We stood, for a while, without speaking. A little wind stirred, and the dust drifted low along the ground.

. . .

"…I don't understand it." Lytron said, after a long while. His tone was sincere. "But not understanding it doesn't mean I think it's strange."

I was grateful for that distinction.

"…It's just how it is, that's all." he went on. "I've lived thinking it was natural, not to take a loss. Whether that's strange or not — today was the first time I've ever really thought about it."

I didn't know what to say to that.

I heard this conversation again, years later, from Lytron himself. He added, that time: "That day, I thought you were the strange one. I don't think that anymore. Now I think it was me who was strange. That not taking a loss isn't just naturally right — that was the first time I ever heard it." I set that down here. That was something I hadn't heard, that day.

. . .

Lytron got to his feet.

"…I'll head off." he said.

"…All right."

A few steps away, he turned back.

"…Xene." he called.

"…Yes."

"…How's your mother-in-law's health?"

The question surprised me. I hadn't expected him to ask that.

"…Not so good, lately." I said. "Not badly, though."

"…I see."

He didn't ask anything further, and went. Watching his back, I only later understood that the question hadn't been mere pleasantry.

. . .

That evening, Pikra sat down by the hearth first and asked.

"…Late today."

"…Lytron came by." I said. I mentioned Lytron; I left out what we'd said.

"…What did he want?"

"…Nothing much." I said. "Just asked this and that."

Pikra looked at me for a moment. She seemed to sense there was more to it. But she didn't press.

"…Things are hard for you here, aren't they." Pikra said instead. Not a question — a confirmation.

"…No, they're not."

"…Liar." Pikra said. There was no anger in her voice. "I know. You're here because of me."

I couldn't say anything to that.

"…Not only because of you." I managed at last.

"…Not only, sure." Pikra said. "But I'm one of the reasons, aren't I."

I didn't deny it. I couldn't have.

I don't think it was chance that Pikra brought that up first, that night. She must have known I'd heard something that day. She may not have known exactly what, but she likely guessed that someone had asked me a question along those lines. Pikra was someone who could guess things like that.

. . .

I didn't repeat to Pikra the exact words Lytron had used. *That's it?* — if she'd heard that, I had no idea how she'd have reacted. Pikra would surely be angry, if she believed I'd given up my standing because of her. So for the rest of that evening, I kept to the usual talk — sifting dirt, the weather.

Pikra went to bed early that night. She coughed a little. I lay awake a long while, listening to it.

That night I went back over Lytron's question. "If you're not here to gain something, then what?" I wrote that I couldn't find the answer, then. I know a little of it now. I wasn't there to gain something. I was there because I couldn't leave her behind. Those are two different sentences. I didn't know, then, how to put that difference into words.

I didn't know the book of Ruth yet, at the time. I first heard that name from Mena, months later. And learned that the answer the woman in that book gave was, almost word for word, the same answer I'd given Lytron at the corner. I don't think that coincidence is a coincidence at all. Some answers cross centuries in exactly the same shape. The gleanings at the corner of the field don't fall, by design. But some things don't fall even though no one ever designed them to.

(Continued in Chapter 24.)

Chapter 24. The Day It Rained

> *_Previously_ — Lytron asked whether she couldn't go somewhere else,*
> *instead of here. Xene answered that she wasn't there because she had*
> *nowhere else to go — she was there because Pikra was. Lytron couldn't*
> *understand the answer, but he didn't call it strange either.*

The rains came late that year.

They usually ran late anyway. I watched this city's sky for weeks that season. Day after day without a single cloud. The wheat only ripened better for it. Good sun means good wheat, Damia told me.

"…Rain would actually be a disaster." Damia said. "If it hits grain that's already fully headed, the weight bends the stalks over. Then the machines can't harvest it."

I let the remark pass without much thought. Being afraid of rain sounded strange to me. Outside, rain had always been welcome. Here, even rain was a variable to be calculated.

. . .

The clouds rolled in late that afternoon.

At first no one thought much of it. A cloud passing through on a summer afternoon was common enough. But this one didn't pass. One whole side of

the sky darkened fast. The wind suddenly shifted direction. The smell of dust gave way, all at once, to the smell of wet earth.

I knew that smell. Outside, it came before a late frost too. The smell of something on its way.

Somewhere across the field, something like a horn sounded. I didn't know what it meant. Damia heard it and shot to her feet.

"…Machine-stop signal." Damia said. "It means rain's coming."

. . .

It wasn't long before the rain began falling in heavy drops.

The first few were large. They left round marks in the dry dirt. Then, all at once, it poured. I had never seen rain arrive that suddenly. Outside, rain always gave some warning first. Here it came with none at all.

The whole field turned loud in an instant. People running. The harvesters stopping. I had never seen those enormous machines come to a halt so abruptly. Things that had always moved at the same speed, with the same sound, simply went still, all at once.

I remember that moment by its sound, even now. The machine noise cut off, and rain filled the space where it had been. That was the first time I heard this city fall so quiet. A field that had always been full of something running was, for a few seconds, nothing but the sound of rain.

. . .

People were shouting, running everywhere.

"…Clear the front rows first! Whatever's already cut!"

Someone yelled that. I didn't know who. Someone in charge, it seemed. The workers surged in one direction at the call. There were sheaves already cut but not yet loaded onto the carts. If the rain got them, they'd spoil, I was told.

I stood in the middle of that chaos, not knowing what to do. I wasn't someone called on for work like this. The unregistered weren't mobilized for urgent tasks. I just stood there in the rain.

Far off, I spotted Lytron. In a raincoat, a terminal in a waterproof sleeve in his hand, running among the workers. Giving directions, checking things, running again. He didn't seem to have any room to notice me. I didn't call out to him either.

I heard later how busy Lytron had been that day. It was a crisis that struck directly at the whole field's yield. It must have been the most frantic hour of his day. I caught a glimpse of his face, briefly, in the middle of that chaos. None of his usual composure left in it. That was the first time I learned that he had a face like that too.

. . .

I walked toward the corner, letting the rain fall on me.

No particular reason. It was simply the place I always went. There was nowhere else to go. Pikra was home in the cottage that day. Once the rain stopped I'd have to head back there anyway, and it seemed natural enough to pass by the corner on the way.

As I neared the corner, I saw something strange.

The ground was yellow.

. . .

Ordinarily, the corner's ground was the color of dirt, apart from a few handfuls of trampled stalks. Not that day. Grain lay scattered across the rain-soaked earth. Whole stalks of wheat lay flattened too. For a moment I thought I was seeing it wrong.

I knelt down and touched it with my hand. It was real.

I've gone back over that moment hundreds of times since. The weight against my fingertips. Up until then, whatever I'd touched at that corner had always been one or two grains, at most half a palm's worth. That day, wherever my hand landed, there was something there.

I didn't understand why, at first. A moment later, hearing the sound of people running toward the front of the field, I guessed.

. . .

That day's final harvest stretch had happened to be the section nearest the corner.

The machine was halfway through that stretch when the rain signal stopped it, I learned afterward from Lytron. Half the cut wheat lay right where it had fallen. On an ordinary day, the machine would have finished crossing and taken every one of those grains with it. That final, precise pass was exactly what made the 0.02 percent loss rate what it was.

That day, the pass never happened.

Everyone was too busy scrambling to save the sheaves already cut and waiting to be carted off. The rows near the corner, still standing uncut, flattened by the

rain, had been pushed entirely off that day's list of priorities. That stretch had never counted toward the Roll's harvest tally to begin with. There had been no reason to protect it.

I confirmed this more than once. I asked Lytron, and later the administrator too. Both gave me the same answer. No one had left that section on purpose. No one had thought of me. It had rained, the machines had stopped, people had rushed to save what was urgent, and the corner had never been on that urgent list. That was all there was to it.

. . .

I sat there a long while, letting the rain fall on me.

At first I gathered it grain by grain. Then I realized there was no need. I set my sack down entirely and began sweeping it up with both hands. Whole stalks and all — I could thresh them at home later.

I could see the sack filling. I had never, in my whole life, seen a sack fill that fast. Or — I had, once. Back at the outer settlement, gleaning a field others had already harvested, with our own hands. But that had been a different kind of filling. That field had been marked, then, as ours. This one wasn't.

I didn't cry, filling that sack, strangely enough. I'd thought I'd been waiting a long time for a moment like this. But when it finally came, no tears came with it. Instead my hands moved faster. I had no idea how long the rain would last. All I thought was that I had to gather as much as I could before it stopped.

For a long while I was at it like that, when another hand appeared beside mine.

It was him. I didn't notice when he'd arrived. Soaked through with rain, wordlessly gathering fallen stalks beside me. I didn't know what zone he'd

been assigned to that day. He might have been called in to help carry the urgent sheaves. But at that spot, it was just the two of us.

"…Isn't this a place they need you more?" I asked. I had to raise my voice over the rain.

"…This is needed too." he said, briefly. He didn't explain what he meant.

After that, we worked in silence. Rain ran down our faces. Our fingers went numb with cold. But I don't think my hands had ever been this busy and felt this good, before that day.

I've turned that brief "this is needed too" over in my mind a long time. I couldn't ask, that day, what it meant. I'm still not certain, even now. I only know this much: that he spent his time that day on work no one had assigned to him. Whether that went beyond the chance the rain had made, or whether he was simply someone conscientious who couldn't walk past grain lying in plain sight — I still don't have that answer either.

. . .

In the middle of the rain, I looked up, once.

Far off, Lytron was looking this way. Only for a moment. He was still running back and forth, and that glance lasted no more than a few seconds. I didn't know what was in that gaze. There was no chance, that day, to ask.

I asked him about that look much later. Lytron said this: "That day I'd actually forgotten you were there at all. Then I happened to glance over. You were filling a sack. I didn't think anything, in that moment. I just thought — good, I'm glad. That's all there was to it." I believe that answer, precisely because it wasn't any bigger than that. For him, that's really all it would have been.

. . .

The rain stopped toward evening.

The machines didn't run again that day. They'd start up again the next morning, I was told. People carried what wet sheaves they could salvage back to the storehouses. I stood off to the side, holding my sack.

It was more than half full. I kept feeling its weight the whole walk home. I carried it in my arms rather than over my shoulder. I didn't want to let go of it.

On the way to the cottage, I ran into Damia. Her eyes went wide at the sight of my sack.

"…You gathered all that today?"

"…Yes."

"…The rain did you a favor." Damia said. She meant nothing much by it.

"…Yes." I said. "It did."

Saying that, I knew it was exactly right. It was the rain, and nothing else.

. . .

Pikra was standing outside the door when I arrived. She seemed to have come out to catch the air, after the rain.

Pikra looked at my sack. She couldn't say anything at first.

"…It rained." I said. There was no other explanation I could find.

Pikra reached a hand toward the sack, stopped, reached again. Her fingers trembled. I didn't stop, then, to think whether it was her age, or something else.

"…Let's go inside and talk." Pikra said.

That night, for the first time, we emptied the whole sack out inside the cottage and sifted through it together. The two of us sat there by a single lamp for a long while. Sorting grain from stalk, picking out the flattened straw, separating out what could really be eaten.

. . .

By the time we finished, it was past midnight. In front of us sat more grain than I had ever seen in one place.

Pikra looked at it for a long while.

"…How long has it been, since I saw this much." Pikra said. I couldn't tell if she was speaking to me or to herself.

I didn't answer. Instead I went back, one by one, through what I'd seen that day. The machines stopping. The direction the people ran. No one so much as looking toward the corner. All of it had happened because it rained.

"…Will there be more of this tomorrow?" Pikra asked.

"…I don't know." I said. "I don't think it'll rain tomorrow."

Pikra nodded. She asked nothing further.

. . .

I write this night as carefully as anything in this book. I was glad, that day. Truly glad. We ate our fill for once, and there was enough left to divide over the coming days. But alongside that gladness, from the very first, I set down something else too.

This was not mercy.

No one had left that wheat behind for my sake. The administrator hadn't broken the law that day, either. No one had changed the loss-rate rule. Lytron hadn't done anything for me that day, not really. The Roll had been exact that day too. Only the sky had stood outside the Roll's arithmetic. The rain never asked about standing. The rain had never, to begin with, calculated any such thing.

I said none of this to Pikra that night. She probably knew it too. We simply gave ourselves over to dividing the grain. Some truths, even known, have to be set aside — for one night, at least.

. . .

The next day, it truly didn't rain.

The sky cleared again. The machines ran again. I went out to the corner at the usual hour. The ground was dirt-colored again. It was hard to believe that so much had been there, in that same spot, the day before. A few handfuls of trampled stalks. Same as it always was.

I sat down and began sifting the dirt, fingers laid flat as always. The same motion as the day before. Only, the day before, that motion hadn't been needed.

That morning I confirmed, all over again, that this city had given me nothing. What I'd received the day before hadn't come from the city. It had come from

the sky. And this city would go on giving me nothing, tomorrow, the day after, until the sky chose to do that again. I set this fact down without resentment. There was no one to resent. The administrator had been right. The law had been kept. Yesterday and today, both.

A few days later, I ran into the administrator near the office. Unable to hold back my curiosity, I asked.

"…That day it rained — some wheat was left at the corner. Does that count toward the loss rate?"

The administrator thought a moment.

"…No." the administrator said. "That's pre-harvest scattering. It happened in a section that hadn't yet been logged as harvested, so it doesn't figure into the loss-rate calculation. It's recorded separately, under weather exceptions."

"…So that day just gets treated as if it never happened?"

"…The record stays." the administrator said. "But the loss-rate figure holds. 0.02 percent. That day, and today."

I didn't ask anything further after that. There was nothing left to ask.

I had to set that conversation down here. For a while, I'd hoped that the day it rained had shaken the Roll's number, even a little. It hadn't. That day remained, in this city's record, nothing more than a weather exception. The number never moved at all. Only hearing that answer did I fully understand how much of what I'd received that day had come from outside this city.

. . .

That sack was the biggest topic in our house for days afterward.

Pikra stretched it out, using it sparingly. Not using it all in one meal, dividing it instead across nearly ten days. For those ten days I was less hungry. Once they'd passed, it went back to the way it had always been.

I remember those ten days as something special. But the real reason they were special is that they were an exception. I never met rain like that again — not, at least, within the span of time this book covers. I think that fact is one of the most important things to know about this city. The good things came from outside this city, from places it couldn't calculate. What was calculated inside this city was always 0.02 percent.

. . .

I close this chapter here.

The story turns a little different from here on. I'm soon to meet a woman. The one who writes things down. She'll tell me a great many things I never knew, about this city, and about myself. I'd thought, until then, that I had been carrying this record alone. I learn, at that point, that this wasn't so.

I'll write that meeting in the next part. For now I set down only this: the sack, on the day it rained. It was not mercy. I knew that, and I was grateful anyway. The two could exist together. I learned that, that day.

(Continued in Part Three.)

The Gleaning Ground, Part Three

Mena's Record

Chapter 25. Someone Passing Through

> *_Previously_ — On the day the rain stopped the machines, grain was left*
> *in the corner of the field for the first time. I filled a sack that day.*
> *And I understood it was the sky's doing, not the city's mercy.*

The first time I saw her, it wasn't at the corner.

It was at the well near the gate. I was on my way to draw water, and she was sitting there writing something. A flat wooden board across her knees, paper spread on top of it, a pen in her hand.

It wasn't the first time I'd seen someone write. Most city people used handheld terminals — small enough to fit a palm, letters arranging themselves at a touch. But someone writing by hand, on paper, I had hardly seen in this city at all.

I thought, at the time, that she was strange. Paper was a precious thing here. Writing by hand was slow, too. And yet she sat there as if she had nowhere else to be.

Her clothes didn't look like a city person's either. City people mostly wore clean clothes — the lower your standing, the less true that was. Hers were neither. Worn, but neat. Worn from long use, not from carelessness.

At her feet sat a thick leather case, bound with cord in several places. One of the cords was a different color from the rest, as if it had recently been replaced.

She looked up. Our eyes met.

"…Come for water?" she asked.

"…Yes," I said.

"…There's room here. You can share it."

I set down my water jar and sat beside her. I had no particular reason. There was something in her voice that put a person off their guard. I hadn't sat this easily beside a stranger since coming into the city.

. . .

"…What are you writing?" I asked.

She tilted the paper slightly so I could see. I read the letters. A few names, and beside each one a short line.

One line caught my eye.

"One sack a day at the corner. Only on rainy days."

I knew at once it was about me.

"…Me?" I asked.

"…Yes," she said. "I saw you a few days ago. Filling a sack at the corner."

"…Why write that down?"

She thought a moment, then set her pen down.

"…That's my work," she said. "My name is Mena."

I thought I'd heard the name somewhere before. But I couldn't place it then.

I had no idea, in that moment, how many times that name would come to my lips later on. I only thought I'd met a strange woman writing something on paper by a well.

"…I'm Xene," I said.

"…I know," Mena said. "I saw it on the gate registry."

I was a little startled.

"…You look at that too?"

"…I do. It's my work," Mena said. "Who's come into this city, and with what standing. I keep all of that."

"…Why?"

"…I'll tell you later." Mena smiled. "For now, go and get your water. It's a waste to let that jar sit empty."

I laughed. It was strange how right that sounded.

. . .

When I came back with the water, Mena was still there. Watching someone else now — an old man coming out through the gate. He had a pack on his back and a slow step. Mena watched him a long while, then wrote something down.

I sat beside her again and watched her hand move. Not fast. Not hurried either. Just certain. Each stroke made a small, steady sound as the pen tip pressed into the paper. The sound never varied.

"…You don't know that man either," I said.

"…I don't know most of them," Mena said. "I'm not from this city."

"…Then where are you from?"

She smiled a little at the question.

"…Nowhere, really," she said. "I go between cities. I don't stay long in any one place."

"…Doesn't it wear you out? Walking all the time?"

"…It does," Mena said. But her voice didn't sound worn out. "But if you stay too long in one place, there's something you stop being able to see."

"…What's that?"

"…How the same thing happens differently, and also the same, in city after city," Mena said. "If you only ever live in one, you think everything that happens there belongs only to that city."

I didn't fully understand what she meant, not then. I had lived outside the city walls before. But I had never met anyone who moved between cities the way she did. Later I would learn that what she meant, that day, had to do with this city's Roll.

The old man passed through the gate and vanished into the city. Mena watched until his back disappeared from sight.

"…Do you know what'll happen to him?" I asked.

"…No," Mena said. "I'm not the kind of person who knows that."

"…Then what kind of person are you?"

"…The kind who knows he passed through here today," Mena said. "That's all I know. But that's enough."

. . .

A few days later, I met Mena again on my way to the corner.

She was standing at the edge of the field, the wooden board still in her hand. This time she was watching the whole field — the machines' paths, the workers moving sacks, the men weighing grain at the scales.

"…What are you watching?" I asked.

"…The field," Mena said. "How it turns."

"…Nothing ever falls in it."

Mena looked at me.

"…I know," she said. "That's why I came to watch."

Something about that struck me as strange. Since coming into the city I'd hardly met anyone who knew that nothing was left at the corner. Everyone knew the corner clause was being kept. No one asked why, if it was being kept, there was nothing there.

"…Lytron knows too," I said. "But he won't say why either."

"…Who's Lytron?"

"…The harvest-management assistant."

Mena wrote the name in a corner of her paper. I watched her hand move. No judgment attached itself to the name. No good person, no bad person. Just a name, and what he did.

"…Mena," I said. "Why did you come here?"

She looked up at the sky for a moment.

"…I heard a rumor," Mena said. "That this city's Roll is unusually precise. A precise Roll always catches my interest."

"…Why?"

"…The more precise something is, the more exactly it leaves something out," Mena said. "I wanted to see what that was."

I thought that was a frightening thing to say. But there was nothing frightening in Mena's face. Just a plain, even calm — the look of someone asking how wide a field was.

That was the first time I had any real sense of what kind of person Mena was. She hadn't come to fix something in this city. She had come to see what the city had left out. Fixing and seeing were different things. I didn't know the difference then. I would come to know it very clearly.

. . .

That evening, Lytron passed by our cabin and stopped.

"…Who was that, earlier?" he asked.

"…Mena," I said. "She writes things down."

"…Writes what?"

"…People."

Something odd crossed his face.

"…The Roll writes people down too," he said.

"…It's different," I said. I had no words then to explain exactly how. I just knew that it was.

Lytron stood there a moment, shook his head, and walked on. I watched him go and thought: someday Lytron will meet Mena too. I wondered what his face would look like then.

I had no idea, then, how soon my curiosity would be satisfied.

But he turned back after a few steps.

"…Is she registered in the Roll?" he asked.

"…I don't know," I said. "I never asked."

"…That's strange," he said. "Can someone who isn't registered really move this freely through a city?"

"…Mena seems to."

Lytron's face went thoughtful for a moment. I saw something uneasy in it. He was someone who liked everything kept in order. An unregistered person moving about freely was, to him, like an unfilled box.

"…I'll check on it," he said. And this time he actually left.

I heard that so lightly, at the time. Lytron saying he'd check on something was nothing unusual. I didn't know yet where that checking would lead him.

That evening, standing over the water jar, I turned the conversation over again. Lytron had found it strange that an unregistered person could move so freely. I didn't think that reaction was his fault. He'd been born into a world that was kept in order. Of course something unordered would unsettle him. I only didn't yet guess where that unsettled feeling would eventually take him.

. . .

The next day, at noon, I met Mena at the corner again. This time she wasn't alone. The administrator stood beside her, explaining something.

I watched them from a little distance.

"…This is the designated corner," the administrator said, gesturing. "Under Article 9, we leave it exactly, every year."

"…May I look at what's left?" Mena asked.

The administrator smiled. There wasn't the slightest discomfort in that smile.

"…As much as you like," he said. "We have nothing to hide."

Mena walked to the corner and crouched down, sifting the soil with her fingertips. Nothing came up but a few handfuls of trampled, broken stalks.

"…What's the loss rate?" Mena asked.

"…0.02 percent," the administrator said. "As far as we know, the lowest figure in the region."

"…Are you proud of it?"

The administrator paused at the question before he answered.

"…Not proud, exactly. Accurate, I'd say," he said. "We've never broken the law. Not then, and not now."

Mena said nothing to that. She only nodded and wrote something down.

I still think back on that scene often. The administrator hadn't lied. The Roll really hadn't broken the law. And yet there was nothing at all in the dirt on Mena's fingertips. That day, for the first time, I saw with my own eyes that both of those things could be true at once.

When the administrator had gone, Mena called to me.

"…Xene," she said. "That man didn't lie."

"…I know," I said.

"…That's the more frightening part," Mena said. "If it were a lie, you could catch it. If it isn't a lie, there's nothing to catch."

I didn't fully understand what she meant then. Later I would return to those words more than once.

. . .

That afternoon, the man who quietly gleaned among the workers passed near us. Mena's eyes followed him a moment.

"…And him?" Mena asked.

"…He gleans alongside me," I said. "One of the hired hands."

"…His name?"

"…I don't know. I never asked."

Mena nodded, and instead of a name, wrote a short line: *Name unknown — gleans alongside her.*

I felt something strange, watching those words settle onto the page. Mena never pretended to know what she didn't. When she didn't know, she wrote that she didn't know.

The man glanced our way for a moment. He seemed to know someone had been watching him, writing something down. He didn't get angry, wasn't curious either. He just gave a small nod and went back to his place. A trampled stalk snapped under his foot.

I heard the sound and looked at Mena. She seemed to have heard it too — turned her head that way for a second, then back to the paper. She wrote nothing. I didn't understand, then, why that was worth noticing. Mena wasn't someone who wrote down everything she saw. She wrote what was worth writing. What the standard for that was, I didn't ask that day.

I didn't know then why that was so unusual. In this city, nothing was ever simply let pass unknown. The Roll always filled every blank. There was no box for "unknown." With Mena, there was.

Mena hoisted the case back onto her shoulder and asked me,

"…What are you doing tomorrow?"

"…Going out to glean. Same as always."

"…Tomorrow I think I'll look inside the Roll," Mena said. "There's something called the reputation field, apparently. Where people's histories collect."

"…Why there?"

Mena looked at me for a moment. For the first time something heavy passed through her eyes.

"…Because things I wrote long ago might be somewhere in there," Mena said. "I've never checked what's being done with them now."

I didn't understand, then, why she said that so carefully. Her voice was the same as always. But her fingers were gripping the wooden board just slightly tighter. I noticed it by chance. And it would be the next day before I understood that the chance had been no accident at all.

I didn't know, then, what face that carefulness would turn into by the next day. I only knew that Mena would be somewhere in this city tomorrow, watching something.

. . .

That night, setting down the water jar, I told Pikra about the woman I'd met.

Pikra was sitting by the hearth, working over dried stalks — a handful gathered that day at the corner. Many of them had been trampled and broken, and it took time to pick out the whole ones.

"…I met someone new today," I said.

Pikra looked up without stopping her hands.

"…What kind of person?"

"…Someone who writes. She watches people at the well and writes things down."

Pikra listened a long while, then said,

"…Mena?"

"…Yes. You know her?"

Pikra shook her head.

"…No. I think I've only heard the name," Pikra said. "There's supposed to be someone like that. Going between cities, writing things down. Has been for a very long time."

"…Doesn't that scare you?"

Pikra smiled — a smile I hadn't seen much of lately.

"…No. If anything, it's a relief," Pikra said. "Someone who writes isn't someone who takes."

"…What's the difference?"

Pikra thought a moment.

"…The Roll takes a number from me," Pikra said. "Someone who writes takes nothing from me. They just sit beside you."

I let that pass, that night. Now I know. Pikra already knew, even then, that what made this city frightening wasn't what it took away. It was what it never gave. And a person who only writes is neither of those things.

. . .

The next day, I went out to the corner earlier than usual.

Mena was already there. Not at the field, but on the low bank beside it, watching the morning workers come in.

I sat beside her. Neither of us said anything.

We sat a long while like that, watching the field come to life. The machines starting up, the scales chiming, the line of workers forming.

Then Mena said quietly,

"…It's loud."

"…Yes," I said.

"…With all this noise, there's not one sound in this field that's grain falling."

I thought about that for a long time.

After that, every time I went out to the field, I listened. The machines, the scales, the voices. And there really was never a sound of anything falling. Mena was the first person who had ever confirmed that for me — by sound.

Mena stood and brushed the dirt from her clothes.

"…I'll look over that way today," she said. "You go on as you always do. I'm only someone passing through."

That phrase stayed with me strangely. Someone passing through. And yet a few days later, that someone passing through would find something no one in this city had ever seen.

Watching her hoist the leather case onto her shoulder, I tried to guess how many names must be inside it. I couldn't guess.

I watched her walk away along the bank for a long time. Her step was neither slow nor fast. It was the step of someone who knew exactly where she was going, and yet was in no hurry at all.

Carrying my water jar back to the cabin, I counted through, one by one, the people I'd met that day. The administrator. Lytron. The man. Mena. Four people, watching the same field, and all four had seen something different. The administrator saw a law that had been kept. Lytron saw one unregistered name. The man saw a few unspoken stalks of grain. Mena saw dirt with nothing in it.

It struck me as strange that none of them were seeing it wrong. Each of them had seen exactly what they'd seen. And yet even added all together, their accuracies hadn't put a single more grain on that ground.

I thought, for the first time, that day: if people looking at the same spot could see such different things, could any one of them be called wrong? I fell asleep that night without an answer.

At the cabin door I stopped a moment and looked up. A few stars were scattered thin across the sky. Not so different from the sky I'd known outside the settlement. That, at least, seemed to be something even this city couldn't touch.

He had told me once that what you spill and what you leave behind were the same thing. I turned that over again that night. Maybe the names Mena was writing down were something like that, too. Nothing changed — things were only left behind. I didn't yet know why that was necessary. But strangely, it eased my mind a little. Somewhere, someone had written down that I had been at the corner that day.

I didn't know, then, that the woman I'd met at the well would be the one who made it possible for me to write this record at all. I only thought, that night, that her case must be heavy.

(Continued in Chapter 26.)

Chapter 26. The One Who Writes It Down

> *_Previously_ — I met Mena. Someone who wrote things down without*
> *judging anyone. The administrator hadn't lied, and there was still nothing at the corner. Mena said she would look into the Roll's reputation field the next day.*

The next day, instead of going to the corner, I went to find Mena first.

I wasn't entirely sure why. It was just that the carefulness in her voice the night before had stayed with me. I didn't realize until I reached the well that I hadn't even brought my water jar.

Mena wasn't there. Instead, she was standing in front of a low building near the gate, a wooden sign reading "The Archive" over its door. The door was smaller than the city's other buildings, and looked old.

"…What is this place?" I asked.

"…This city's archive," Mena said. "A place where a person can look into what the Roll has piled up. Every city has one."

"…Can we go in?"

"…I can," Mena said. "I'm a recorder. You come sit inside with me. Quietly."

An older man came out from inside — someone who seemed to keep the place. He gave Mena a small nod.

"…Back again," he said. "Staying long this time?"

"…A few days, maybe," Mena said.

"…Whatever you need, just ask. We have nothing to hide in this city," the man said.

I felt like I'd heard those words somewhere before. It was almost exactly what the administrator had said at the corner.

That was the first time I noticed it. People in this city worked in different corners of it, and yet they all said the same thing. Nothing to hide. What struck me was that it was true — and that made it sound stranger still.

The man stepped aside, and we went in.

. . .

Inside was narrow. A screen sat against one wall, with a single chair in front of it. Drawers lined the opposite wall — the old-fashioned kind, opened by hand.

Mena sat down and turned the screen on. Her fingers moved through several screens, and then she looked back at me.

"…Ask if you're curious about anything. I'm working right now, so my answers might be short."

"…That's fine."

Mena turned back to the screen. Her hand moved the same way it had moved over paper the day before. Unhurried. Certain.

I sat beside her and looked at the screen. Names in rows. Numbers beside the names, short phrases beside the numbers. I read a few. *Commendation for diligence. Cooperative. Compliant with regulations.* All good words.

"…This is all good things," I said.

"…That's the entry for people with high standing," Mena said. "Yours will be different."

I tensed a little at that.

"…I have one too?"

"…You do." She scrolled a few times. My name came up. Standing zero. Beside it, a single short line.

"Newly registered. Below threshold for standing. Nothing out of the ordinary."

I read that sentence twice.

"…I have nothing out of the ordinary about me," I laughed.

Mena didn't laugh.

"…There's plenty. It's just not written down," Mena said. "The Roll only calls something unusual by its own standard. Going to the corner every day isn't unusual, by the Roll's standard."

"…Why not?"

"…Because nothing comes of it," Mena said. "The Roll sees people by their outcomes. If there's no outcome, it treats everything before it as if it never happened."

I thought about that for a long time.

. . .

"…How do you see it?" I asked.

For the first time, Mena took her hand off the screen.

"…I watch what people do," Mena said. "Whether it comes to anything or not."

Mena pulled a sheet of paper from her case. My name was on it too. Beside it was written:

"Xene. Goes to the corner without fail, every day. Gives no reason. Most days, comes home empty-handed."

Reading that line, I felt something strange. It wasn't longer than the Roll's sentence. But there was something more in it.

"…Why is this different?" I asked.

"…The Roll thinks I'm not there," Mena said. "I think I am. Even when nothing comes of it, the fact that the person was there — that's still true."

I didn't fully understand that then. I do now. The Roll saw a person by numbers. If the numbers didn't move, the fact that the person had even stood in that place was erased. Mena was the opposite. Even when

the numbers didn't move, the fact that the person had been there was never erased.

"…Is Pikra in there too?" I asked.

Mena searched the name and found it. Pikra's number was low. Higher than mine, but far below the city average. Beside it, a short line.

"Standing reduced due to death of spouse and children. Renewal approved."

Something turned in me, reading that. Losing a husband and two sons — here, it had been reduced to five words. *Standing reduced.*

Mena pulled another page from her stack of paper. Pikra's name was there too. But beside it was a much longer sentence.

"Glyke. Lost her husband first, then two sons in succession within two years. Even so, told her two daughters-in-law three times to go back. One stayed, one went."

"…Is this the same person?" I asked.

"…Yes," Mena said. "The same person. But the Roll only writes what this person lost. It doesn't write what this person did."

That was the first time I understood, in exact words, the difference between the Roll and Mena. The Roll wrote what was lost. Mena wrote what the person had chosen to do in front of that loss. One was subtraction. The other was a person.

. . .

"…Why do you write?" I asked.

Mena stopped and looked at me. I'd tossed the question out lightly, but her face didn't take it lightly at all.

"…Because if it's forgotten, it never happened," Mena said.

I echoed the words back.

"…If it's forgotten, it never happened."

"…Yes," Mena said. "People think that when a memory fades, the thing itself fades. It isn't so. The thing stayed exactly as it was. It's the memory that fades, not the thing."

"…But why does that have to be you?"

Mena smiled a little. The first smile of the day.

"…If I don't, no one does," Mena said. "The Roll only writes outcomes. The administrator only keeps the code. The city only worries about the city running smoothly. In between all that, there are people no one writes down."

"…Like me?"

"…Yes," Mena said. "And like me."

. . .

I wanted to ask something more about that answer, but I didn't know exactly what.

"…Are you someone no one writes down too?"

Mena turned the screen off for a moment.

"…Somewhere, probably," Mena said. "I never stay long in any one city. No one's watched me long enough."

"…Doesn't that lonely you?"

Mena didn't answer right away. The silence felt long to me.

"…Sometimes," she said at last. "But instead of just enduring that loneliness, I gained something from it."

"…What?"

"…Eyes that don't belong to anyone," Mena said. "If I were from this city, I'd want to believe it was a good city. It's hard to live otherwise. I'm not from here, so I don't have to believe that."

Hearing that, I thought I finally understood why Mena carried that plain, even face wherever she went. It wasn't indifference. It was a face working hard not to take any side. I didn't know then how much effort that took.

"…So you're on no one's side?" I asked.

"…There's no side," Mena said. "I'm not someone who decides right and wrong."

"…Then what are you?"

Mena thought a moment.

"…Someone who leaves behind the fact that something happened," Mena said. "Whether it was good or bad — the person reading it decides that. I don't stand in front of the judgment."

"…Isn't that hard? There must be times you want to judge."

For the first time, Mena smiled a little at that. A bitter smile.

"…Every time," Mena said. "Especially when it's someone I know. But the moment I write down a judgment, I become the same as the Roll. The Roll believes it's right, too, when it cuts a person down."

I turned that over for a long time.

"…So you don't even write that the Roll is wrong?"

Mena looked straight at me.

"…That's different," Mena said. "Calling something wrong when it's wrong isn't judgment. It's fact. I write facts. I just don't lay my own feelings on top of the facts."

At the time, that distinction felt only faintly there. Later I would learn it was the most important distinction in this city.

. . .

Mena turned the screen back on. A different one this time. A list of city names.

"…What's this?" I asked.

"…The reputation field," Mena said. "What I told you about yesterday. Each city's Roll exchanges information with the others. Whatever evaluation a person received elsewhere follows them here — it all collects in this."

"…So?"

"…So there are things in here that never happened in this city," Mena said. "Records that came from other places."

I asked, more or less idly,

"…Is anything you wrote in there too?"

Mena's hand stopped.

"…It's possible," Mena said. "I've done this work a long time. I don't even know how far the things I've written have traveled."

I didn't know then why that answer came out so thin. I do now. Mena already sensed something, in that moment. She was about to confirm, for the first time with her own eyes, how the work of a lifetime had changed somewhere she couldn't see.

Mena got up from her chair and went to the window. The field showed outside it, the machines still turning. She watched the scene for a while, then came back to her seat.

"…Xene," Mena said. "I've done this work a long time. There's one thing you come to know, doing it that long."

"…What's that?"

"…What I write, the moment I write it, stops being mine," Mena said. "Other people read it, copy it, summarize it, copy it again. I can't control any of that."

"…Then why write it? If you can't hold onto it anyway."

Mena paused at the question.

"…Even if I can't hold onto it, I have to leave behind what was right at the start," Mena said. "So that someone, someday, has something to compare it against."

I didn't fully understand that answer then. Leaving behind what was right at the start, and stopping something being twisted into wrong later, sounded like two different things to me. I would come to understand the difference far more clearly, a few days later.

. . .

"…Can I watch with you?" I asked.

Mena looked at me for a moment.

"…You can," she said. "But it might take a while. Once I'm in this, I don't come out easily."

"…That's fine. I don't have to go to the corner today."

Mena smiled a little at that.

"…You go every day, you said."

"…Today I'll watch something else," I said.

Mena nodded and pulled her chair closer to the screen. Her finger touched it. A list unfolded, long — city names, dates beside them, case numbers beside the dates. Too many to count.

"…Are you reading all of it?" I asked.

"…Not all of it," Mena said. "Until a name I recognize comes up."

I sat beside her and watched her hand move down the list, line by line. Her eyes ran over each row at a steady pace. She never hurried.

I didn't find that slowness tedious. If anything, there was something like respect in it. Mena never skimmed a single line — even when it wasn't the name she was looking for.

. . .

After a long while, Mena's hand stopped.

A single name sat in one line on the screen. The city wasn't this one — a different city, a name I'd never heard. Beside it, in small letters, were the words:

"Source: Recorder Mena. Quoted."

"…Is this you?" I asked.

"…Yes," Mena said. "I remember being in that city. A very long time ago."

"…Strange, seeing your name here again."

Mena's face wasn't one of surprise. It was the face of someone measuring something.

"…It isn't strange," Mena said. "I'd only ever heard, as a rumor, that my records flow into other cities this way. This is the first time I've seen it myself."

"…So now you've confirmed it, that's that, isn't it?"

Mena turned the screen again at that. The quoted sentence was short and smooth. It looked flawless.

"…There's one more thing I have to confirm," Mena said. "Whether this matches the sentence I actually wrote."

"…Could they be different?"

"…I don't know," Mena said. "That's why I have to look."

Mena opened her case. She took out a bundle of old paper. Her fingers moved through it a little faster than before. She didn't show any hurry outwardly, but I could feel the change in pace beside her.

I didn't know exactly why that speed had changed, not then. I know now. In that moment, Mena was already doubting something. It was the kind of doubt only someone who had done this work a long time could carry. I didn't know, that night, what that doubt would turn out to be the next day.

Mena found a sheet of paper that looked like the original. But by then the day was already fading. The archive began to darken around us.

"…That's enough for today," Mena said, carefully returning the paper to her case. "I'll look again tomorrow morning, in the light. This kind of thing shouldn't be checked carelessly in the dark."

I felt something heavy in that. Mena might have stayed up all night holding onto that paper. But she didn't. I don't know why, but not checking it carelessly in the dark stayed with me a strangely long time.

. . .

We left the archive together. The sun hung low. The shadows of workers walking back toward the gate had stretched long.

"…Can I come again tomorrow?" I asked.

Mena looked at me for a moment.

"…You can," she said. "But Xene."

"…Yes."

"…Tomorrow might not be about confirming something good," Mena said. "That's the feeling I have."

"…What kind of feeling?"

Mena stopped walking for a second.

"…A very long time ago, I saw something I'd written twisted in a strange way," Mena said. "In another city. I thought it was something that belonged only to that city."

"…And?"

"…Now I think I'm seeing the same thing in this one," Mena said. "I'm not sure yet. I'll only know once I check."

Something cold ran through me, hearing that. I didn't know exactly why at the time.

That evening, for the first time, I saw the plainness fall entirely from Mena's face. Only for a moment. It settled back into place almost at once. But I saw the crack. I would come to know what that crack held the next day.

. . .

On the way home, I turned over, one by one, the screens I'd seen that day. My name. Pikra's name. Lives arranged into numbers.

I passed by the field. The sun was setting, and the machines had already stopped. A quiet field. The place that was so loud by day made no sound at all in the evening.

In that quiet, I found myself remembering something my husband used to say. *What you spill isn't wasted. It's left behind.* I set that phrase beside the screens I'd seen that day. The Roll spilled nothing. So nothing was left behind. Mena spilled nothing either. And yet something was left behind. I couldn't put into words, then, what that difference was.

I can say it now. The Roll didn't spill, so that nothing would be left. Mena, instead of spilling, copied it down by hand. The results looked similar. Neither had lost anything. But in one case there was nothing at all left in that place, and in the other, everything was there, on paper.

When I got home, Pikra was sitting by the hearth, working the stalks she'd gathered that day.

"…You didn't go to the corner today, they say," Pikra said.

"…No. I went with Mena to the archive."

"…What did you see?"

I paused, choosing how to put it.

"…I saw your name too," I said. "It was in the Roll, and it was on Mena's paper too."

Pikra's hands stopped.

"…What did it say?"

"…In the Roll, it said 'standing reduced,'" I said. "On Mena's paper it said... the story about you telling your two daughters-in-law, three times, to go back."

Pikra was quiet for a long while. She started working the stalks again, her fingers moving a little slower than before.

"…So she goes around watching everything," Pikra said at last.

"…Yes."

"…And yet somehow, it's not frightening," Pikra said. "A person who watches everything."

I laughed a little at that. I'd been thinking the same thing.

Before I fell asleep that night, I turned that question over for a long time. Why wasn't Mena frightening? I know now. The Roll decided something after it watched. Mena decided nothing after she watched. She just wrote it down. Eyes that decide nothing aren't frightening, no matter how much they see.

I lay awake late into the night. I looked out the window toward the field. Nothing was visible in the darkness. But I knew that even in the dark, that field was still letting nothing fall. Even at night, that fact didn't change.

I remember that night clearly, even now. I didn't know yet that what Mena would discover the next day wasn't a problem belonging only to this one city. I only meant to remember that day as the day I saw my mother-in-law's name reduced to a few numbers. But that day was only the beginning of something far larger than that.

(Continued in Chapter 27.)

Chapter 27. The Reputation Field

> *_Previously_ — Mena searched the Roll's reputation field in the archive. The Roll wrote what was lost; Mena wrote the choices people*
> *made in front of that loss. Turning through the list, Mena found an entry that quoted her own name. "There's one more thing I have to confirm. Whether this matches the sentence I actually wrote."*

The next morning, I went to the archive before I'd even drawn the water.

The door was already open. The old man was outside sweeping.

"…Is Mena inside?" I asked.

"…She's been here since before sunrise," the man said. "That room faces east, you know. She said she'd come with the light, and here she is, right along with it."

I went in. Mena sat in the same seat as the day before. But something was different from yesterday. Papers pulled from her case lay spread in neat order across the table. In sequence. By date, it looked like.

The skin under Mena's eyes was a shade darker than yesterday's. Not the face of someone who hadn't slept at all. But not the face of someone who'd slept well, either.

I stood a moment in the doorway and looked around the room. Morning light lay thin across the papers from the window. Dust drifted slowly through it. The room felt far quieter than it had the day before.

"…Were you here all night?" I asked.

"…No," Mena said. "I slept at the lodging house last night. I just came out early, before dawn."

"…What did you find?"

Mena looked at me and shifted her seat to the side.

"…Sit down," she said. "What I'm about to tell you will take a while."

. . .

Mena pointed to the papers on the table.

"…These are all things I wrote in different cities," Mena said. "I've laid them out by date. From yesterday through this morning, I've been finding and comparing everything in this city's reputation field that quotes me, one by one."

I tried to count the sheets and gave up. There looked to be more than twenty.

"…Have you gone through all of them?"

"…No," Mena said. "Only a few. But there's something strange."

"…What?"

"…The wording is all a little off," Mena said. "Not completely wrong. But always, somewhere, a phrase or two has changed."

"…How does it change?"

Mena laid two sheets side by side. One was old, one relatively new.

I leaned in and looked at them. The old one was handwritten; the new one had the Roll's smooth printed form. Set side by side, even their shape was different. One bore the marks of a human hand. The other looked as if no hand had ever touched it at all.

"…This smooth one is the problem," Mena said. "If a person had copied it by hand, the one doing the copying would have felt what they were doing. You have to look at each letter to move it. But this one has no trace of that."

"…So it wasn't a person who copied it?"

"…I don't know," Mena said. "It could be someone copied it and was too practiced to feel it. Or it might truly never have passed through a hand at all. The Roll might have summarized it on its own."

"…Does the Roll do that too?"

"…It does," Mena said. "Shortening a long testimony — the Roll is very good at that. But shortening and changing are different things. I want to see exactly where the two started becoming the same thing."

Listening, I wondered for the first time: whom do you even ask about a wrong when you don't know who committed it? I never found the answer to that by the end of this chapter. In truth, the answer never comes out cleanly across this whole book.

"…None of this is confirmed yet," Mena said. "I don't want to say anything too soon. I might be misremembering."

I found that carefulness puzzling at the time. Mena always spoke with certainty. That moment alone was unusually cautious. I didn't grasp,

then, that it was because this was something about Mena herself.

"…Mena," I asked. "Has this happened before?"

Mena's hand stopped.

"…Once," she said. "A long time ago."

"…What happened then?"

Mena glanced out the window for a moment.

"…I'm not going to talk about that now," Mena said. "Let me finish what I'm confirming first. I don't want the old story to blur what's in front of me now."

That sounded a little contradictory to me. She'd said the old thing was similar to what was happening now, and yet she wouldn't talk about the old thing right now.

I didn't understand that contradiction then. I do now. Mena didn't want the old thing to make her prejudge what was in front of her. If she assumed it was the same shape too soon, she might miss what was different about it. Mena doubted herself to that degree.

Watching that carefulness, I felt that the Roll and Mena were exact opposites. The Roll judged fast. The faster the judgment, the more precise it was said to be. Mena was slow. The slower she went, the harder she seemed to be trying to be exact. I wondered, for the first time, which of the two carried the heavier weight. I found no easy answer that night, or afterward.

. . .

Mena found a few more quotations bearing her name. None from this city — people from other cities. Unfamiliar names scrolled past on the screen.

"…These people have nothing to do with this city," I said. "So why are they all in here?"

"…The Roll doesn't only see a person inside this city," Mena said. "Wherever they came from, whatever they were judged to be before, it carries that along too. It thinks it can't fully judge a person otherwise."

"…So that's true for me too?"

"…You came from outside the city, so there's no city record for you," Mena said. "But if you ever leave for another city, whatever this city has written about you will follow you there."

That was the first time I truly felt the size of this system. I'd thought of the Roll, until then, as something belonging to this one city. It wasn't. The Roll was like a river running between cities. If the water in one city clouded, the city downstream clouded with it.

I thought suddenly of the settlement outside. There was nothing like this out there. What someone said about you didn't follow you around. People judged each other face to face. They were wrong sometimes, but the wrongness ended right there. It never crossed into a city and built up.

"…It's not like this outside," I said.

"…I know," Mena said. "I've spent a lot of time outside too. There's nothing like this out there. But there's something else instead."

"…What?"

"…When there are fewer people to remember, forgetting comes faster," Mena said. "How many people in the world do you suppose still remember your husband's name?"

Something went cold in my chest at that. Mena hadn't meant it unkindly. She was only stating a fact. But the fact hurt.

"…The city doesn't forget," Mena said. "Instead, it remembers wrong. I still don't know which is better."

That was the first time I felt real fear that day. I'd thought it was frightening that nothing was left at the corner. This was a different kind of fear. The fear that when one city goes wrong, the wrong doesn't stay inside that one city.

"…Are all the cities connected like this?" I asked.

"…To some degree," Mena said. "Everyone says they're independent cities. But their Rolls aren't independent from each other, not like that."

"…Why was it made that way?"

Mena gave a small shrug.

"…Convenience," Mena said. "It's faster for a city to receive what another city already knows than for it to learn a person from scratch. The Roll likes fast."

"…It wasn't meant with any ill intent."

"…No, probably not," Mena said. "That's what frightens me more. That something made with no ill intent at all can produce a bad result."

I turned that over for a long time. I remembered the first thing I'd felt when I came into this city. The city hadn't driven me out. It had simply given me nothing. What Mena was describing felt similar. No one had done anything with ill intent, and yet only the result came out bad.

That was the first time I dimly sensed how this world turned. It wasn't that bad people existed and made bad things happen. No one was bad, and yet the bad thing made itself.

. . .

Mena paused a moment and looked at me.

"…Xene, let's stop here for today," she said. "There's more I need to check. My own things."

"…Your own?"

"…Something I wrote once, long ago, in another city," Mena said. "I saw it twisted this same way once before. I thought it belonged only to that city."

Something caught in me at that.

"…And?"

"…Now I think I'm catching the same scent here," Mena said. "I have to check to know. A scent alone is nothing."

I didn't understand, then, why that last line mattered so much. A scent alone is nothing — I thought it was something Mena was telling

herself. A few days later I would know exactly what that scent was. And that it wouldn't end at a scent.

I looked at Mena's face again in that moment. Beneath its calm, something was pulled taut. Like a thread on the verge of snapping. I had no way of knowing, then, when it would.

I got up to leave, then sat back down.

"…Mena," I said. "Is there anything I can help with?"

Mena looked at me. Her face showed a little surprise for the first time.

"…Why do you want to help?" she asked.

I couldn't answer right away. I'd never thought about the reason.

"…I don't know," I finally said. "It just seemed strange that you'd carry all of this alone."

Mena smiled a little. The first smile of the day.

"…Thank you," she said. "But this is something I have to do alone right now. It's something I have to confirm with my own eyes, from my own hand. If there's something you can help with, I'll be sure to ask."

I nodded. And I believed her.

I didn't know, then, that the promise Mena made — that there would be something I could help with — would come back to me, much later, in a very different shape. It wasn't handing over pages. It was handing over this whole record.

. . .

That afternoon, I went to the corner for a little while. Habit carried my feet there. Nothing was there, as usual.

On my way back I ran into Lytron.

"…You were at the archive today, weren't you," Lytron said. "That woman's registered. I just confirmed it."

"…Registered?"

"…Mena," Lytron said. "As an outside recorder. It's some old arrangement, apparently. I only found out about it today myself."

I was a little surprised at that. I only then realized that what Lytron had said the day before had been true.

"…So it's all fine now?" I asked.

"…It was never really a problem," Lytron said. "I just hadn't checked it before."

Something complicated crossed Lytron's face. I couldn't quite read it at the time.

"…Do you know what Mena's looking into?" Lytron asked.

"…The reputation field."

"…Do you know what that is?"

"…A little."

Lytron looked at me for a moment.

"…I should go take a look too," Lytron said. "My name must be in there somewhere."

"…Are you curious?"

"…No," Lytron said. "It's just, I've never once thought about how my name is written there."

That struck me as a little odd.

"…Why not? You talk about standing every day."

"…Standing is a number," Lytron said. "I always look at numbers. But what words sit beside that number — I've never actually read them."

"…Why not?"

Lytron thought for a moment.

"…I assumed it would be good, whatever it said," he said. "Since my number's high."

I felt something catch at that answer. Lytron had never wondered why his number was high, what stood behind it. A high number was simply taken as given.

I didn't judge that indifference badly at the time. It wasn't ill intent that kept him from wondering. There was simply no reason for him to wonder. That day, I saw clearly for the first time what Lytron's world was. A world where you never have to wonder.

"…Can I go see Mena about it?" Lytron asked.

"…Go ask her. I think she'll say yes."

Lytron nodded and started toward the archive, then stopped again.

"…Xene," he said.

"…Yes."

"…What's written beside your name?"

I found myself briefly at a loss for words.

"…'Nothing out of the ordinary,'" I said.

Lytron said nothing to that. He just looked at me a moment, then left.

Watching him go, I wondered whether Lytron felt that sentence as strange as I did. I didn't know, then. Later I would learn that it stayed with him that day, longer than I ever guessed.

. . .

That evening I stopped by the archive again. Mena was still in her seat. The papers on the table had grown more numerous.

"…Find anything more?" I asked.

Mena nodded. But her expression was more complicated than it had been that afternoon.

"…I'll tell you tomorrow," Mena said. "It isn't sorted out yet today."

"…Are you all right?"

Mena looked at me. She started to smile, and couldn't.

"…Trying to be," Mena said.

That answer sounded more honest to me than anything else I'd heard that day.

Before I left the archive, I turned back once from the door. Mena was leaning over her papers again. No lamp lit. Just the last of the evening light. I watched her back for a long while before quietly closing the door.

. . .

When I got home, Pikra was waiting at the door. She seemed to have been waiting for me, later than usual.

"…With that recording woman again today?" Pikra asked.

"…Yes."

"…What are you spending so much time looking at?"

I thought a moment about how to put it.

"…Something Mena wrote a long time ago has apparently turned up strange in another city," I said. "She's checking on it now."

Pikra's hand stopped at that.

"…Her own words changed?"

"…Yes."

Pikra said nothing for a long time. I could feel that she was remembering something in that silence.

"…Something similar happened to me too," Pikra said at last.

I looked up at her, startled.

"…What was it?"

"…Something I said once came back to me later, out of someone else's mouth, meaning something completely different," Pikra said. "No one did it with a bad heart. It just happened, passed along enough times."

"…What did you do, then?"

Pikra shook her head.

"…Nothing I could do," Pikra said. "I didn't even know who to be angry at. Not the first person who said it, not the last one who passed it on. Everyone had only changed it a little."

I thought of what Mena had said that day. *There's no place left to be angry.* I felt, right then, that this wasn't something only this city did. Wherever words pass through many mouths, it could happen anywhere. Only here, it had turned into numbers, and truly moved a person's place.

"…So how did you get through it, then?" I asked.

Pikra set down the stalks she'd been working.

"…I just lived," Pikra said. "When there's no way to set it right, you live instead of setting it right. That's the only way I know."

"…Weren't you bitter about it?"

"…I was," Pikra said. "I still am, sometimes. But Xene, carrying bitterness and being eaten alive by it are different things. I worked

hard not to be eaten."

I held that for a long time. The hearth fire made shadows on Pikra's face, and erased them, over and over. I saw, in that face, an old bitterness, and the face of someone who had endured it.

That night, before sleep, I remembered Mena's hands arranging the papers in order. Those hands hadn't come apart, even when she'd been angry. I didn't know then that it was simply how she worked. I would watch, the very next day, exactly what those hands found.

I lay awake a long time. Beside me, I could hear Pikra's breathing, even and steady. I stared at the ceiling and counted through, one by one, the things I'd heard that day. *Nothing out of the ordinary. A scent alone is nothing. I worked hard not to be eaten.*

I felt that those three sentences, though they'd come from three different mouths, strangely lined up into a single thread. The Roll had told me I was nothing out of the ordinary. Mena refused to say anything until she was certain. Pikra had worked hard not to be devoured by her own bitterness. That night I couldn't say, in words, what those three had in common. I can now. All three were a fight against jumping too fast to a conclusion.

Outside, the wind brushed against the roof. I listened to it and slowly closed my eyes. Tomorrow, Mena would finish her confirmation. I hoped the result would turn out well. But some part of me already knew — if it had been going to turn out well, Mena wouldn't have been so careful.

(Continued in Chapter 28.)

Chapter 28. That Isn't What I Wrote

> *_Previously_ — Mena found a record in this city's reputation field that quoted her name. The sentence was smooth. It looked flawless. Mena said she needed to confirm whether it matched what she had actually written, and decided to wait until daylight.*

The next morning, I went straight to the archive without even filling the water jar.

The walk was short, but I slowed my steps more than once along the way. I didn't know exactly why. My heart simply didn't want to go forward. I couldn't explain it to myself then. I know now. I already knew it wasn't going to be good news. And knowing that, I still walked as if arriving late might make the news arrive a little later too.

The archive door stood open. The old man wasn't sweeping this time; he just stood in the doorway. He saw me and, without a word, tipped his head toward the inside.

Mena sat in the same seat as the day before. More paper had piled up on the table. It looked like it had come from some compartment deep in the case I'd never seen before. Every sheet was old. Some had crumbling edges; some were splitting along their folds.

"…Did you find it?" I asked.

Mena nodded. The answer didn't come right away.

I could tell this silence was different from yesterday's. Yesterday's silence had been careful. Today's was the silence of someone who

already knew something. I stood a moment in the doorway and waited. It seemed right to wait for Mena to speak first.

. . .

"…Sit down," Mena said at last.

I sat beside her. The papers on the table were far more orderly than yesterday. Somehow that made me more uneasy, not less. I learned that day, for the first time, that things arranged too neatly can be more frightening than things scattered in haste. Watching Mena, I learned that when a person's mind is unsteady, they reach instead for something they can set right with their hands. That neatness wasn't calm. It was a gesture reaching for calm.

Mena slid two sheets to the middle of the table.

One was handwritten. The ink had faded, the letters tilted slightly. Not the writing of someone rushing — the writing of a hand worn into its shape by long use. I thought the handwriting looked familiar. It matched the other pages Mena had shown me exactly.

"…This is what I wrote," Mena said. "A long time ago. I won't say the name. It doesn't matter now. Or which city."

I read the line.

"He did not explain what he had done. I did not ask why. That was not my work to do."

A short sentence. I didn't know what event it was about. It didn't seem necessary to know. The sentence said everything on its own. What someone had done, and what Mena hadn't done.

"…What's wrong with this?" I asked. "It's just stating the facts."

"…That's right," Mena said. "There's nothing wrong with this. Looking at it again now, I wouldn't change a word. The problem is this one."

Mena slid the other sheet in front of me.

. . .

This one wasn't handwritten. It was printed — the Roll's distinctive, smooth typeface. I read the sentence beneath it.

"Witness testimony, Mena, cited. Subject refused to explain the act. [Assessment: no remorse.]"

I read that sentence twice and still couldn't quite place what was wrong with it. It looked similar. It looked like the same story, told differently.

"…Isn't this saying about the same thing?" I asked.

Mena looked at me. For the first time, I saw something give way in her face. Not a collapse. Only, briefly, beneath the calm, something shook.

"…It isn't the same," Mena said. Her voice was lower than usual. "I didn't write that he refused to explain. I wrote that he didn't explain. I didn't know why he hadn't spoken. I never even asked. That wasn't my work to do."

I still hadn't quite caught the difference.

"…Is refusing and not explaining really different?" I asked.

"…Very different," Mena said. "Not explaining tells you nothing at all. There might have been a reason, or there might not. He might not have been able to, or he might have chosen not to. I didn't know, so I didn't write it. Leaving it not-known was my work."

"…And this one?"

"…This one decided, without knowing," Mena said. "It says he 'refused' to explain. Refusal means you could, and chose not to. I didn't even know whether he could have. But here, that's already been decided."

. . .

I read the last line again as I listened.

[Assessment: no remorse.]

"…What's this? This part in the brackets."

"…A classification," Mena said. "The Roll adds it. Below my testimony. I never once wrote the word remorse in that sentence. I never even looked at whether he felt remorse or not. That's a matter of the heart. I don't write the heart. I only write what was done."

"…And the Roll wrote the heart in for you?"

"…In effect, yes," Mena said. "I write 'he did not explain,' and somewhere — someone, or something — turns that into 'refused to explain,' and attaches the assessment 'no remorse' beside it. I only wrote the first of those three steps. The other two aren't mine."

I read the three steps aloud to myself. *Did not explain. Refused to explain. No remorse.* With each step, the man became a little worse. And

yet at no point between them was there any new fact about what he had actually done. There had only ever been one fact from the start. That he had said nothing at all. That single fact had grown three times heavier by the time it passed through those three steps.

"…Who does this?" I asked. "Is it a person doing it, or does the Roll just do it on its own?"

"…I don't know either," Mena said. "That's the part that maddens me most. If a person did it, I could go find that person and ask. If the Roll did it on its own, I have nowhere to go. Right now I don't even know which it is."

That was the first time I began to guess, dimly, at what whoever wrote Book 3 must have gone through. I won't set down here exactly what that person discovered — Mena herself never told me the whole of it. I'll only note what she said that morning: "It wasn't the same shape. But the direction was the same."

. . .

"…What direction?" I asked.

Mena looked out the window for a moment. Morning light lay long across the papers.

"…The direction that turns an absence of explanation into an absence of remorse," Mena said. "The direction that turns silence into guilt."

I turned that over for a long time.

"…You said this happened before, once," I said. "What shape did it take, then?"

Mena looked at me a moment, then shook her head.

"…I won't talk about it today," Mena said. "What I want to say right now is that this happened in a completely different city, in a completely different way, and the result is identical. I wanted to think it was coincidence."

"…And now?"

Instead of answering, Mena set down the paper in her hand.

. . .

I saw Mena's hand shaking.

It wasn't a large tremor. Just a small slip as she set the paper down. I had never once seen Mena's hand shake before that. Not pouring water, not surveying an unfamiliar field, not standing before the administrator. That hand had always moved the same way. I think I'd been quietly relying on that, without realizing it — on the hand always moving at the same pace. Seeing it shake, I felt something I'd been standing on shake with it.

"…Are you all right?" I asked.

Mena didn't answer. Instead, she laid the two sheets side by side again. Handwritten and printed. What she had written, and what she had not. The gesture of laying them side by side was the same gesture as yesterday. But yesterday it had been the gesture of confirming something. Today it looked like the gesture of someone enduring something.

"…This sentence," Mena said at last. "This isn't what I wrote."

Her voice wasn't loud. But something was in it. I couldn't put a name to it then.

"…That isn't what I wrote." Mena said it again. This time she wasn't speaking to me. She seemed to be speaking to the paper.

I remember those words exactly, even now. That isn't what I wrote. So few syllables. And yet I dimly felt, in that moment, that it was a sentence shaking the whole of what Mena had done with her life. Mena was someone who wrote things down. For someone who writes, to find words she never wrote still standing under her own name — that was a kind of theft no one else could quite feel.

. . .

"…What happened to that person?" I asked. "The one written about here."

"…I don't know," Mena said. "I don't even know who he is. There's no name. Only a case number."

"…Can't you find him?"

Mena shook her head.

"…I looked by the case number. He's not from this city. He must have passed through here once, or this city took in the record from somewhere else."

"…So you don't even know where he is now?"

"…No," Mena said. "I have no idea what standing he received after this, what he was made to go through, where. There's exactly one thing I know. That my sentence changed, somewhere along the way."

I felt, for the first time, the full size of that helplessness. Mena couldn't resent anyone. Couldn't go find anyone. A wrong had clearly happened. But whose hands it had happened in, no one knew. A wrong with no face to it.

I had always thought, until that day, that a wrong always had someone's face attached to it. That was how it had been outside the settlement. If someone blocked a water channel, that person had a face. If someone stole grain, that person had a face. If there was a face, you could go and confront it. You could get angry. That day, for the first time, I learned there was such a thing as a faceless wrong. And that it lasted far longer than a wrong with a face.

After that, I began to see everything in this city differently. The nothing at the corner. The "nothing out of the ordinary" beside my name. All of it was a faceless wrong. A wrong you couldn't grab hold of anyone and ask why about. I was, that day, only just beginning to understand that this was the thing this city did best.

"…If you can't find him," I asked, "does this just stay this way forever?"

Mena gave no answer. I understood the silence was the answer.

. . .

Something else occurred to me, and it frightened me.

"…Mena," I said. "Could my story get twisted like this in some other city someday?"

Mena looked at me. She hadn't expected the question.

"…Why do you think that?" Mena asked.

"…I might leave this city someday too," I said. "Then whatever gets written about me would flow somewhere else. If someone changed it there, I wouldn't have any way of knowing."

Mena was quiet a moment.

"…It's possible," she said at last. "I don't lie to you. It's possible, Xene."

"…Then why do you keep writing? It might all get changed anyway."

For the first time, Mena smiled a little at that. A sad smile.

"…If I stop writing because it might get changed," Mena said, "then there's no original left to be changed in the first place. I'm the one who leaves the original. I can't stop what anyone does with it later. But if there were no original at all, I couldn't have laid these two sentences side by side today and compared them."

Listening, I began to understand a little why Mena spent so long arranging her papers in order. That order was the only thread that might let someone, later — maybe Mena herself — compare something against something else.

That was the first time I dimly felt that recording wasn't a matter of protecting something. It was a matter of leaving it behind. You might not be able to protect it. But you could leave it. I would hold onto the difference between those two for a long time to come.

. . .

Mena carefully returned the papers to her case.

"…Xene," she said. "I spent the whole day yesterday confirming this. I wanted to be certain. I kept hoping I'd made a mistake."

"…It wasn't a mistake."

"…No," Mena said. "It wasn't a mistake."

Mena closed the lid of the case. The sound was quiet. But it felt to me like it would stay in the room a long time.

"…What will you do now?" I asked.

Mena looked at me for a moment. What remained of the tremor in her face was slowly settling. She was returning to her usual calm. But not completely. I chose not to press further, out of some respect for that incompleteness.

"…I have to keep looking," Mena said. "This won't be the only one. That's what frightens me most."

I didn't fully understand what that meant then. The next day I would know exactly the size of it. What Mena found that day wasn't just one thing at all.

. . .

Mena said she wanted to be alone for a while. I knew there was no ill will in that. I thought of my water jar and went outside.

The sun was strong. I started toward the well, then found my feet turning toward the field instead. Habit. I walked all the way to the

corner without even the jar.

Lytron was there. On patrol, it looked like — a handheld terminal in his hand, watching the machines. He raised a hand to wave at me, then stopped.

"…Is something wrong?" he asked. He'd asked as soon as he saw my face.

"…No," I said. It was a lie. I hadn't wanted to lie that day, but I didn't know how to explain, so I said it anyway.

"…You're coming from the archive," he said. Not a question. A statement.

"…How did you know?"

"…There's talk going around," he said. "That Mena found something serious. I heard the archive keeper reported something to a superior this afternoon."

I was startled at that. I hadn't even thought yet that this might leak outside.

"…What did he report?" I asked.

"…I don't know that much," he said. "I only heard the rumor."

That was the first time I felt that what Mena had found no longer belonged only to Mena. What had happened behind the archive door was already walking around out here, wearing a different shape entirely. I saw, that very day, with my own eyes, how quickly something like that could deform.

"…I don't know the details either," I said. "It's Mena's business."

Lytron nodded. He didn't press further. But after a moment's hesitation, he spoke again.

"…I should go see Mena myself soon," he said. "You said my name's in there somewhere too."

"…Yes. You should."

I let that pass lightly at the time. I had no idea that the day he actually went to see her would become another starting point for everything that followed.

I crouched at the corner for a moment. I sifted a few handfuls of dirt with my fingertips. Nothing there, same as always. Strangely, that nothing was a comfort to me that day. At least this dirt was the same today as it had been yesterday.

. . .

That evening I went home empty-handed, without even the water jar. Pikra noticed first.

"…Where's the water?" Pikra asked.

Only then did I remember I hadn't taken the jar out that morning.

"…I forgot," I said.

Pikra looked at me a moment by the hearth. Her eyes read something in my face.

"…That recording woman again?" Pikra asked.

"…Yes."

I told her, briefly, what had happened that day. That Mena had confirmed her own sentence had been changed. How it had been changed. Pikra listened without stopping her hands. Only once I'd finished did her hands slow.

"…She must have had a hard day, that woman," Pikra said.

"…Yes. Her hand was shaking. I'd never seen that before."

Pikra nodded. She was quiet a moment, then spoke.

"…I know that feeling," Pikra said. "Something not yours going around in your own mouth. How hollow it feels."

"…Has that happened to you too?"

Pikra's hands stopped. The hearth fire cast a brief shadow across her face.

"…It has," Pikra said. "But I never tried to find a way to fix it. I didn't have the strength for that. She's different. She has the strength to search. That might be harder for her, not easier."

"…Why?"

"…Without strength, you give up quickly," Pikra said. "With strength, you have to try everything you can before you give up. You don't know yet how long that takes, or how many times you break along the way."

I thought of Mena's shaking hand again, listening to that. Pikra's words felt true. Mena wasn't someone who could give up yet. I couldn't decide, that night, whether that was fortunate or something to grieve over.

I thought about that sentence late into the night. That isn't what I wrote. I didn't know, then, that those five words would carry the weight of this entire book. I only fell asleep hoping Mena would return to that plain, calm face again.

I saw the two sentences in my dreams that night too. Did not explain. Refused to explain. Two sentences lying side by side, and then, quietly, one settling over the other. When I woke that morning, I still couldn't quite shake the dream.

Writing this chapter, I find myself circling back, again and again, to those five words. That isn't what I wrote. I'll hear that same sentence, later on, from a mouth other than Mena's. That is much later. For now, I'll only set down Mena's trembling hand that night, and the way that hand worked to steady itself again.

(Continued in Chapter 29.)

Chapter 29. The Same Pattern

> *_Previously_ — Mena confirmed her own testimony had been changed.*
> *"Did not explain" had become "refused to explain," which fed into the assessment "no remorse." Mena said this wouldn't be the only one. That was what frightened her most.*

The next morning, I smelled the paper before I even opened the archive door.

The smell was stronger than usual. Old paper, mixed with the scent of a lamp that had burned all night. From the smell alone, I could guess what kind of night had passed in that room.

The old man at the door hadn't swept or wiped anything down that morning. He was just leaning against the doorframe. He spoke to me in a low voice.

"…She's been in there the whole time. I haven't gone in myself, this morning."

"…Why not?"

"…The air in there." He gave a small shrug. "I just felt like I shouldn't disturb it."

I hesitated a moment at the door, then pushed it open quietly.

Mena didn't look like she'd slept at all. Her eyes were red, and twice as much paper as yesterday was spread across the table.

"…Were you here all night?" I asked.

"…Yes," Mena said. She didn't hide it. "This time I couldn't wait, the way I did yesterday."

I sat beside her. The papers on the table were lined up differently from the day before. On the left, city names; on the right, pairs of short sentences. I recognized it as a table. Mena must have spent the whole night building it.

I thought, suddenly, that the room felt narrower than it had yesterday. It wasn't the paper making it feel that way. It was the weight of what that paper held, grown heavier overnight.

"…Can I help?" I asked.

"…Just don't let the order get mixed up," Mena said. Her voice had no strength in it. "Take the next one from that case and hand it to me. From the top, in order."

I did that. I pulled the sheets out one by one and handed them to her. Mena took each one, checked it against the original, and wrote a line into the table. We didn't talk much. I didn't find the silence uncomfortable. If anything, moving my hands helped. If I'd had to sit there doing nothing, I think I would have found it hard to bear.

The light from the window crept slowly across the room. By the time it reached the floor past the table's legs, I'd stopped counting how many sheets we'd gone through. Counting felt pointless. What mattered wasn't the number, but the direction.

. . .

"…How many have you found?" I asked.

"…Seven," Mena said. "Five of them certain. Two I haven't been able to find the original for, so those aren't confirmed."

I read down through the table. Most of the city names were ones I'd never heard before. A few sounded vaguely familiar, but I couldn't place where.

The first line.

Original: "He stood without kneeling."
Quoted: "He refused submission and displayed a defiant attitude."

The second line.

Original: "The woman said nothing about how she would repay the debt."
Quoted: "Debtor: expressed no intent to repay."

The third line.

Original: "He did not explain what he had done. I did not ask why."
Quoted: "Witness testimony, Mena, cited. Subject refused to explain the act. [Assessment: no remorse.]"

That third one was the one I'd already seen.

I ran my finger along the line.

"…This is yesterday's."

"…That's right," Mena said. "But this line turned up again today. In a different place. I only realized yesterday that a single sentence,

once made, gets reused across different cases. Once one is twisted, it gets recycled again and again, the way a precedent does."

. . .

I read on through the rest of the table.

The fourth line.

Original: "The child covered for her sibling. I didn't ask why."
Quoted: "Guardian: withheld information regarding harboring of accomplice."

"…Is this about a child too?" I asked.

"…Yes," Mena said. "When I wrote it, it was just about a child covering for a sibling. I didn't even say whether it was good or bad. But here, the word 'harboring' has been attached. I didn't even know what she'd covered up."

The fifth line was shorter still.

Original: "He said nothing that day."
Quoted: "Silent. Deemed to be evading testimony."

Reading that line, a chill ran through me. The original sentence was nothing at all. He said nothing that day. Everyone has days like that. I'd had many days like that myself. And yet that one sentence had become, on the other side, "evading testimony."

"…I have plenty of days I say nothing too," I said. My voice shook without my meaning it to. "So could that happen to me someday too?"

Mena looked at me for a moment. She didn't answer. I didn't want to know, right then, that the silence was the answer.

I stopped at the sixth line.

Mena's hand had stopped there too. I read it aloud.

Original: "This one never explained himself."
Quoted: "This one never repented."

"…This," I said. "This one feels familiar, somehow."

Mena looked at me. Her face had gone strangely pale.

"…It can't feel familiar," Mena said. "This isn't about anyone in this city. It isn't from any event in this city."

"…Then why does it feel familiar?"

I didn't know why, then. I had no way of knowing what happened outside this city, in a book that wasn't mine to know. I only thought, at the time, that the shape of this sentence resembled the shape of the one I'd seen yesterday, and that was why it struck me as familiar. I know now. What I felt wasn't familiarity. This sentence, in the whole of this world, had truly happened exactly once. I was only standing at the far end of its ripples.

. . .

Mena quietly laid another sheet beside that line. A sheet far older than the others.

"…This isn't something I wrote three years ago," Mena said. "It's much older than that. I wrote this sentence, a very long time ago, in another city. Or rather — I didn't write it exactly. Someone took what I'd written."

"…Took it?"

"…Yes," Mena said. "At the time, I didn't think of it as theft. I just thought it had flowed away somewhere. Records flow, that's how it works. I didn't know how far it had gone."

"…And now it's turned up here."

Mena nodded, very slowly.

"…It's turned up here," Mena said. "A single sentence that started in a city before I was even born has made its way into this Harvest's reputation data. I find that frightening, Xene."

That was the first time I dimly sensed what this whole book was heading toward. This wasn't the story of one city. I couldn't put that feeling into exact words that night. Even now, years later, I still choose my words very carefully around it.

. . .

"…Mena," I asked. "Are all seven of these going the same direction?"

Mena scanned through the table again.

"…Yes," she said. "Every single one."

"…None the other way? Someone who did something wrong, and it got turned into something good?"

Mena shook her head.

"…No," Mena said. "I checked for that too. All seven lean the same way, without exception. Absence of explanation becomes absence of remorse. Silence becomes guilt. Never once the other direction."

I slowly felt the weight of that. If it were one, you could call it a mistake. If it were two, you could call it coincidence. If seven, and all seven leaned the same way, it was no longer either.

"…If it were a mistake," I said, "shouldn't it sometimes go wrong the other way too?"

Mena looked at me. Something in her face, for the first time, acknowledged the point.

"…That's right," Mena said. "I spent all night thinking that too. Mistakes scatter both ways. This only ever leans one way. Something that only ever leans one way isn't a mistake."

. . .

Mena tucked those two sheets away into the deepest compartment of her case, apart from the others, so they wouldn't mix.

"…Mena," I asked. "Is this the story from before? The one you didn't tell me yesterday?"

Mena looked at me for a moment, then nodded. Very slightly.

"…That's right," Mena said. "I thought, at the time, that this sentence had ended in exactly one city, exactly one case. I never went back to that city after that. I couldn't."

"…Why not?"

Instead of answering, Mena slowly ran her hand over the lid of the case.

"…I'll tell you later," Mena said. "For now, just know that this sentence has traveled all the way here. Even after I left that city, this sentence kept walking on, without me."

That struck me as strange, hearing it talked about like a person. A sentence walking. But from that day on, I really did begin to feel that way. As if sentences had feet, and even when the one who wrote them stopped, they kept walking on their own.

. . .

"…So what is this?" I asked. "Is someone doing it on purpose?"

Mena didn't answer for a long time.

"…I don't know that yet either," Mena said at last. "If it's deliberate, then who? I don't think there's a single hand behind these seven. The cities are too far apart, and too much time separates them."

"…But the direction is the same."

"…Yes. That's the strangest part," Mena said. "Many hands. One direction."

"…Doesn't that frighten you?" I asked.

Mena closed her eyes for a moment.

"…It does," Mena said. "I always believed that if I ran into a wrong, that wrong would have a face. So I kept looking for the face. This city's administrator's face. That city's archivist's face. But right now, I'm facing something with no face at all."

"…Can you even run into something like that?"

"…You can," Mena said. "The most frightening things, most of the time, have no face. When there's a face, a person can hate it, or fear it — and that makes it, in a way, less dangerous. When there's no face, there's nowhere for the hatred to land, and so no one ever tries to stop it."

I held onto those words for a long time. Many hands, one direction. It struck me as even more frightening than if someone had simply ordered it. If there were an order-giver, you could find him. If no one had ordered anything, and everyone still leaned the same way, there was no one to go and find at all.

I ran my eyes back over the sentences once more. Did not explain, refused to explain. Said nothing about repayment, expressed no intent to repay. Covered for her sibling, harbored an accomplice. Said nothing that day, evading testimony. Laid side by side, the four pairs looked like they'd been struck from the same mold. Different cities, different eras, and yet one and the same mold.

"…Then why does it only ever lean this way?" I asked. "Why never the other?"

Mena thought for a moment.

"…I've thought about this a long time too," Mena said. "My guess is, it's easier to see the side with no explanation as bad. Hearing an explanation makes a person complicated. You come to know the reason. With no explanation, you can just decide. Fast, and simple."

"…What does that have to do with it?"

"…I told you the Roll likes fast," Mena said. "A fast judgment always leans toward the simple. And the simple side is almost always the bad one. To see something as good, you have to look a long time. Seeing it as bad, you can do at a glance."

I thought of Lytron, hearing that. What he'd written about me. *Nothing out of the ordinary.* Maybe that had come from the very same laziness. Not laziness that decided to write something bad — laziness that never bothered to write something good, either, because there was nothing bad to write.

I didn't understand all of that, that day. I still can't say I understand it completely. But I think of it every time I look at this world since. Many hands. One direction.

. . .

Mena wrote one more line at the bottom of the table. I watched her hand move.

"No explanation → no remorse. Silence → guilt. Seven for seven. No counter-example."

"…What will you do with this?" I asked.

"…I don't know yet," Mena said. "I'm not trying to fix this right now. I don't even think I'll be able to."

"…Then why go this far?"

Mena set down her pen and looked at me.

"…So that later, someone can say the wrong thing was wrong, you have to leave behind what was right," Mena said. "I'm not building this table to change anything right now. I'm building it so that someone, someday, can compare against it — and for that, I have to leave this shape exactly as it is, right now."

I remembered something Mena had told me before. *Even if I can't hold onto it, I have to leave behind what was right at the start.* I hadn't understood that well then. Now I thought I understood it a little.

. . .

I heard the field outside the window. Machines running, scales chiming. I realized, suddenly, that out there, today was flowing on exactly as any other day. While seven sentences lay side by side in this room, the field kept ripening without a care.

"…Not going to the corner today?" Mena asked.

"…I'll stay here today."

Mena nodded, and leaned back over her papers. Her hand began to move again. Slow, and certain. From last night until now, without rest, that hand had never changed its pace.

I sat beside her and pictured something like a river flowing between this city and every other one. Mena had said something like that before — that cities seemed independent, but their Rolls weren't independent from each other at all. That day, for the first time, I knew which way that river flowed. Always the same way. From silence toward guilt.

. . .

I left the archive close to evening. Mena stayed behind. For the first time, I told her I would go on ahead, and left.

On the way home through the field, I stopped by the corner for a moment. He was there, as always, moving his hands quietly.

"…You didn't come today," he said. Not a scolding tone.

"…I was helping Mena with something," I said.

He stopped his hands and looked at me.

"…What kind of something?"

I thought for a moment about how to explain.

"…Something Mena wrote keeps getting twisted into something worse in different cities," I said. "Seven times now. All the same direction."

He was quiet a moment, hearing that. He looked down at the few stalks of grain in his hand.

"…Seven times," he repeated. It sounded like a thought spoken aloud.

"…Do you know about this? This kind of thing?"

He looked at me. There was something old in that look. It wasn't the first time I'd seen it. But that day it lingered unusually long.

"…I know," he said at last. "For a very long time."

"…Then why doesn't anyone fix it?" I asked again. My voice came out sharper than I meant.

He slowly added the stalks in his hand to my sack. A little more than he needed to.

"…Fixing and leaving something behind are different things," he said. "I've watched that difference for a very long time."

He started moving his hands again.

"…Ask Mena directly about that," he said. "She knows it better than I do."

I found that answer strange at the time. He always spoke like someone who knew more than he was saying. That day, he took what he knew and handed it off to Mena instead. I would only come to understand, much later, why that was.

. . .

At home, Pikra was waiting by the door.

"…Late again today," Pikra said.

"…Mena found something overnight," I said. "Seven. Her own words, twisted. All in the same direction."

Pikra set down what she'd been working on.

"…Seven of them." Pikra's voice was low.

"…You don't seem surprised."

"…It's not something to be surprised at," Pikra said. "One, it's a mistake. Two, coincidence. Seven, and it already means those cities are all connected to each other somewhere. I've had a dim sense of that since I was young."

I was startled at that.

"…How?"

Pikra looked at the hearth fire for a moment.

"…When I was young, something I heard in one city came back to follow me around in a completely different one, years later," Pikra said. "At the time I thought rumor just travels fast. Hearing your story now, I think maybe it wasn't rumor at all."

I held that thought for a long time.

"…Why didn't you tell me that back then?" I asked. "You'd gone through something like that."

Pikra smiled a little. A bitter smile.

"…Would telling you have changed anything," Pikra said. "You were young, and I didn't want to hand you that weight along with it. Some things, staying quiet is how you share the burden."

I had no answer to that. I had always thought Pikra's silences were just her nature. They weren't. Some silences were a choice.

That night, before sleep, I thought again of that river. Flowing between city and city, invisible. That night, for the first time, I felt its true size, and it frightened me. Something I could never have imagined, living outside these walls.

I kept coming back that evening to that table. Seven lines. No counter-example. I think those two lines run straight through the middle of this book. I didn't feel their size that night. I do now.

I fell asleep having already decided the first thing I'd say to Mena the next morning. Then just fix it. I thought it was an obvious question. I wouldn't learn how naive it was until the following day.

(Continued in Chapter 30.)

Chapter 30. Then Why Not Fix It

> *_Previously_ — The quotations Mena found overnight came to seven. All*
> *the same direction. No explanation becoming no remorse, silence becoming guilt. He said he'd known about this for a very long time. Xene decided on the question she'd ask Mena the next day.*

That morning, before I'd even reached the archive door, I ran the question through my head several times.

Then why not fix it.

I thought it was an obvious question. I wasn't so naive, at sixteen, as to not know how hard it is to set right something you know is wrong. And yet in that moment it felt simply obvious. If you'd found seven wrongs, the next step was to fix seven wrongs.

Mena was there. She looked a little better than the day before. A face that had slept some. The case sat closed beside her. I felt a small relief seeing the lid shut. At least this morning, no new sentence seemed about to leap out of it.

The old man was drawing water in the yard. He saw me and gave a light wave. It felt different from yesterday's wave — yesterday's had been careful; today's was just an ordinary greeting. This was a city that didn't carry yesterday's weight into today. Whether that was fortunate or something to regret, I still don't fully know.

"…Mena," I said, from the doorway. "Then why not fix it."

Mena looked at me. Not a surprised look. If anything, it seemed she'd been expecting that exact question.

"…Sit down," Mena said. "It'll take sitting down, to talk about this."

. . .

I sat beside her. The table was cleaner than yesterday. All the paper had gone back into the case. I guessed that meant Mena had made some kind of peace with it, overnight.

"…What do you want to fix?" Mena asked first.

"…Those sentences," I said. "They were twisted, weren't they? Just set them back the way they were."

"…Where would you fix it?" Mena asked again.

I couldn't answer right away. Thinking about it, there was no "where."

"…This city?" I finally managed.

"…This city's Roll only quoted my sentence," Mena said. "This city didn't twist it. This city only took what came from another city and used it as it was."

"…Then that other city."

"…That other city is the same," Mena said. "I traced five of the seven back yesterday and this morning. I couldn't find a starting point anywhere. Everyone says they received it from the city before them."

. . .

"…Then the very first city," I said. "It must have started somewhere."

Mena nodded.

"…That's right. It started somewhere," Mena said. "I know one of those. It's the one I lived through myself. But if I went to that city, what would I be able to do?"

I couldn't answer that.

"…Go and confront them," I said. "Tell them they got your words wrong."

"…Say I confront them," Mena said. "Say the city says, 'Yes, we were wrong,' and fixes the sentence. Then what about all the judgments already handed down on the basis of it? What about the other cities that already quoted it? I couldn't even finish counting how many times that sentence has been re-cited."

That was the first time I saw the true size of this problem. I had thought of a wrong, until then, as something like a point — something you find and erase. This wasn't a point. It was water already spilled. Where do you erase water from?

. . .

"…Then from now on," I said. "Just make sure it doesn't happen anymore."

"…How?" Mena asked.

"…Make a rule," I said. "That whoever quotes something has to check the original first."

Mena smiled a little for the first time. A weary smile.

"…Xene, that's a good idea," Mena said. "But who makes that rule?"

"…The administrator."

"…This city's administrator can only make rules for this city," Mena said. "He has no power over another city's administrator. This city could make a rule to always check originals, and it would mean nothing if the other cities didn't follow it."

"…Then what if all the cities decided it together?"

Mena looked at me steadily.

"…For that, every city would have to gather in one place," Mena said. "I've never seen such a gathering. Cities exchange Rolls with each other. They don't meet to decide anything. Exchanging is easy. Meeting to decide is hard."

. . .

Listening, I thought suddenly of the phrase "Book 3." The thing Mena had only called "that other city, a long time ago" the day before. I grew curious about it for the first time.

"…That thing that happened in that city," I asked, carefully. "What happened then? Was there no place to fix it there either?"

Mena looked out the window for a moment.

"…Someone else tried to fix it, back then," Mena said. "Not me. Someone else. Very hard."

"…What happened?"

"…That person ended up at the same place, in the end," Mena said. "The place where there's no place left to fix it. That city's judgment system had never once broken the law. Not a single time. So there was no way to fault the system itself."

Something felt familiar in that.

"…That," I said. "Isn't that the same story as this city?"

Mena looked at me. A little surprised.

"…How did you think of that?"

"…This city's Roll has never broken a law either," I said. "The corner clause is being kept, isn't it. And yet there's nothing at the corner. The administrator said it himself. We've never broken the law."

. . .

Mena looked at me for a long moment. Something else was in her eyes.

"…That's right," Mena said finally. "Exactly that. I've had a feeling of this for a few days now, and just now, Xene, you put it into words before I did."

"…So is it all the same thing? Nothing at the corner, and your words being changed?"

"…The shapes are different," Mena said. "But the frame underneath is the same. No one breaks the law. And yet someone, always, is left empty-handed. It's true for the owner of that sentence. And it's true for you."

I felt a chill hearing that. I had never once thought, until that moment, that the empty hands at the corner and Mena's shaking hand might be the same story.

"…So does the Roll, and the judgment system Mena went through in that city, do exactly the same thing?" I asked.

"…Not exactly the same," Mena said. "The Roll measures people. That city measured guilt. They measure different things. But the manner of measuring is alike. Both are extremely precise, both work hard never to be wrong, and both, within that precision, leave someone out."

"…It's not on purpose, is it."

"…That's right," Mena said. "It isn't on purpose. Which is exactly why it never gets fixed. If it were on purpose, you could change the mind behind it. If it isn't, there's no mind to change at all. No one thinks they've done anything wrong."

I thought of Lytron again, hearing that. He truly didn't think he'd done anything wrong. Neither did the administrator. I already sensed, dimly, that Lytron wasn't the only person in this city like that.

That was the first time I fully felt what this book was really asking. Whether not breaking the law and being good are the same thing. I had no answer to that question then. I don't have a complete one now, either. But I would spend the years after that learning how to go on living while holding that question in my hand.

. . .

"…So there's really nothing at all we can do?" I asked. My voice, even to my own ear, carried something like resentment.

Mena shook her head.

"…It isn't that there's nothing we can do," Mena said. "It's that there's nowhere to fix it. Those are different things."

"…What's different about them?"

"…If there's somewhere to fix it, you go there and fix it, and that's the end," Mena said. "If there's nowhere to fix it, you have to do something else. I don't know exactly what that is yet. But I know one thing. Keep leaving it, exactly, accurately, behind. So that someone, someday — someone with more power than I have — can come and see it."

"…When would that be?"

Mena thought for a moment. The moment felt long to me.

"…I don't know," Mena said. "I'm not the one who gets to decide that. I'm only someone who leaves this accurately behind now, so that whatever there is to see, when that day comes, is there to be seen."

"…What if it takes too long? What if that person never comes?"

Mena looked at me a moment. Sorrow and stubbornness sat together in her face.

"…I'll still leave it behind," Mena said. "If I don't, then even if that person comes, there'll be nothing for them to see. I don't know

when they'll come. But I don't want to send them away empty-handed when they finally do."

Strangely, that made me think of the corner. Nothing in that field, and yet I went out there every day all the same. Mena kept writing, knowing she couldn't fix it. I understood, for the first time, that those two things were the same kind of stubbornness.

I still wasn't satisfied with the answer. But at the same time, I knew Mena wasn't saying it to soothe me. It was what she actually believed.

I stood up.

"…Where are you going?" Mena asked.

"…To the administrator," I said. "I'll ask him myself."

Mena didn't stop me. She only nodded.

"…Go ask him," Mena said. "I'm curious too. What he'll say."

. . .

The administrator was at his office by the gate. I hesitated a moment outside, then went in.

The administrator recognized me. No surprise showed. He offered me a seat, without ceremony.

"…What can I do for you."

"…Mena's own words are getting twisted into something bad, over and over, in different cities," I said. "Seven times now. It's here in this reputation field too. Can't this be fixed?"

The administrator tapped the screen a few times. It seemed he'd found the entry I meant, and looked it over for a moment.

"…I've confirmed it," he said. "This entry came from another city's Roll. We didn't generate it."

"…Can it be deleted, then?"

"…That isn't within our jurisdiction," he said. "We only reference the data we receive. We have no authority to alter it. You'd need to request that from the originating city."

"…I don't even know which city that is."

The administrator looked at me for a moment. For the first time, something like it crossed that plain face. Not sympathy. More the expression of a man hearing a question he'd already heard many times before.

"…That happens often," the administrator said. "Data grows less traceable the more hands it passes through. Our city has committed no violation. We're presenting what we received, honestly."

I thought of what I'd heard at the corner, a few days before, hearing that answer. We have nothing to hide. We've never broken the law. I felt, in that moment, that though those words had come from different mouths, they still sounded, somehow, like a single voice.

"…So this city has no responsibility at all?" I asked.

"…Not legally, no," the administrator said. "I'm not in a position to say anything beyond that."

I had no answer to give him. The administrator wasn't a bad man. He was simply a man who drew, exactly, the line between what he could say and

what he couldn't.

. . .

On my way out of the office, I ran into Lytron. He stopped when he saw my face.

"…Something happen?" he asked.

I told him briefly what had happened with the administrator. Lytron listened to it all and was quiet a moment.

"…I'd have said the same thing, in his place," he finally said.

I felt a flicker of anger at that.

"…You too?"

"…Don't be angry," he said. "I'm not saying the administrator's wrong. I know this city's systems. Tracing where data came from is outside our authority. I don't know anyone who could do that either."

I felt it as evasion and asked again.

"…Then who's the most powerful person in this city? Can't even they do it?"

Lytron thought a moment.

"…Not even my father can," he said. "That much I know for certain. No matter how high our family's score is, we have no authority to touch another city's Roll. Authority isn't something you buy with a score. There's simply no such position at all."

"…So no one can do it?"

Lytron thought again.

"…Unless there's someone who can view every city's Roll," he said. "But there's no such person. Each city manages only its own Roll. They receive what's sent to them, but no one holds the authority to look into another city's Roll."

"…What about Mena? Mena goes between cities."

Lytron looked at me for a moment at that.

"…Mena has no authority either," he said. "As far as I understand it, Mena is someone who watches, not someone who fixes."

I found that strangely exact. Someone who watches, and someone who fixes. That was the first time I heard that distinction stated so plainly.

That day I understood that Lytron hadn't meant it unkindly. He was simply someone who knew this city's structure precisely. And I learned, that day, that the more precisely someone knew it, the faster they arrived at a dead end in front of a question like this.

. . .

I thought of the field for a moment. And what Lytron had said the day before came back to me. He'd said something like the administrator too. That the man hadn't been wrong either. That it wasn't his.

That was the first time I felt that everyone I'd met in this city — the administrator, Mena, even Lytron — stood, in the end, before the

same wall. No law broken. And yet not good. I felt, that day, for the first time, that this wall was the hardest wall in the whole book. As if I had reached out and touched it with my own hand.

Mena had begun putting her papers back in order. Her hands were steadier than yesterday's.

"…Xene," Mena said. "I've carried this question for a very long time. Then why not fix it. I think a person who asks that question is better off than one who doesn't. Not stopping that question is the one resistance I have left."

"…Resistance?"

"…Yes," Mena said. "Not fixing it, but also not accepting it as something natural. I believe there's a very important difference between those two."

I held onto those words for a long time.

. . .

That evening, I told Pikra everything that had happened that day. The administrator, Lytron, what Mena had said.

Pikra listened all the way through and was quiet for a long time.

"…Aren't you angry?" I asked. "Everyone keeps saying it isn't their fault."

"…I'm angry," Pikra said. "But Xene, I spent that anger a long time ago."

"…What do you mean, spent it?"

Pikra set down what she'd been holding.

"…When I was young, I asked the same thing you're asking," Pikra said. "Then why not fix it. I don't remember who I was talking to then. But I remember what they said back. 'There are wrongs you don't even know who to ask about.'"

I was startled at that.

"…You heard the same thing."

"…I did," Pikra said. "At the time, it sounded like an excuse. Now it doesn't. Now I think it was just a plain statement of how this world is actually built."

"…Then what do we do? Just put up with it?"

Pikra shook her head.

"…Putting up with it and going on living are different things," Pikra said. "I don't tell you to put up with it. I tell you to go on living. You'll learn the difference between those two, someday."

"…What was he like?" I asked. The question came out before I meant it to. "Did he carry something he couldn't fix, too?"

Pikra's hands stopped. She looked at me for a long time.

"…He was a little different," Pikra said. "When he saw something he couldn't fix, instead of getting angry, he changed whatever he could reach with his own hands. He couldn't change the whole world, so he gathered his own little plot of field a little differently. Left something behind, spilled something."

Hearing that, something ached in my chest. Longing for that man came over me again.

"…Could I live that way too?" I asked.

Pikra smiled for the first time. A real smile.

"…You already are," Pikra said. "Going out to the corner every day — that's exactly it."

I lay in bed that night and thought of Pikra's smile again. A real smile. Only then did I realize how long it had been since I'd seen one.

I thought about it long into the night. Putting up with it, and going on living. I couldn't quite grasp the difference then. I know a little of it now. Putting up with it is doing nothing and simply enduring. Going on living is doing today's work while still carrying the thing you can't fix. Mena arranged her papers again that day. Pikra worked her stalks again that day. I went out to the field again that day. None of us fixed the wrong. And yet none of us stopped, either.

Since that day, I've asked myself this question, over and over. Then why not fix it. I still haven't found a clean answer to it. But I know now what it means not to stop asking. That's the thing Mena taught me that has stayed with me the longest.

I fell asleep that night having decided to ask Mena a different question the next day. Not how to fix things, but how to leave things behind. I had no idea, then, how far that question would take me.

(Continued in Chapter 31.)

Chapter 31. Learning

> *_Previously_ — Mena said there was nowhere to fix it. Leaving it accurately behind was the only resistance left to her. That night, Xene decided to learn how to leave things behind, instead of how to fix them.*

The next morning, I went to Mena with a different question.

I'd tossed and turned over that question half the night, revising it again and again. First I thought I'd say, "I want to become a recorder too." Too grand. Then, "Teach me how to do that." Also somehow awkward. In the end I opened the archive door with nothing polished at all.

"…Mena," I said. "Can you teach me how to write things down?"

Mena's hand stopped. She looked at me for a long moment. I felt something being weighed in that look. Not weighing me — weighing, I think, how heavy this question was for her to receive. The case on the table still sat closed today. I guessed that the seven sentences inside it had shaped, in some way, how she was receiving this question.

"…Why?" Mena asked.

I couldn't answer right away. I hadn't prepared a reason.

"…I don't know," I finally said. "It just feels like what you do is the most necessary thing in the world. But you won't stay in this

city much longer. If you leave, it feels like no one here will be writing anything down at all."

Mena closed her eyes for a moment. When she opened them, something had been decided in her face.

"…All right," Mena said. "I'll teach you. But it isn't something you learn in a day. Today I'll teach you the most important thing."

. . .

Mena handed me a sheet of paper and an old pen.

"…First rule," Mena said. "Write only what you've seen. Not what you haven't."

"…Isn't that obvious?"

"…It's obvious, and it's the one people break most," Mena said. "When people see something, without realizing it, they attach a story to it afterward. That person must be angry. That person must be sad. But that isn't what you saw. It's what you guessed."

"…So can I never guess at all?"

"…You can guess. Just keep it separate when you write it down," Mena said. "'That person's face was scowling' — that's what you saw. 'That person was angry' — that's a guess. I always attach 'it seemed to me' or 'I guessed' when I write a guess. Otherwise, whoever reads it later will take the guess for a fact."

I wrote that down on the paper. My hand was slow. Mena waited.

. . .

"…Second rule," Mena said. "Write down when you don't know. Say you don't know."

"…Isn't that the same as the first?"

"…Similar, but different," Mena said. "The first is separating what you saw from what you guessed. The second is knowing when to leave something blank because you know nothing at all. People can't stand a blank. They want to fill it with something. I guard against that temptation more than anything else."

Mena pulled out the sheet I'd seen before — the one with no name, only a case number.

"…Remember this?" Mena asked. "The one where there was no name, only a case number."

"…Yes."

"…I could have guessed at his name," Mena said. "If I'd dug through records from around the same period, a few likely names would have come up. I didn't. If I wrote a guessed name, someone later might take it for the real one and copy it further."

That was the first time I understood how heavy those two syllables, "unknown," could be. Until then I had thought not knowing something was a thing to be ashamed of. Mena taught me it was a thing to protect.

. . .

"…Third rule," Mena said. "Write the action. Don't write the heart."

I thought at once of the sentences I'd seen the day before.

"…Like 'no remorse'?" I asked.

Mena nodded. I felt a small pride at having found the question myself.

"…That's right," Mena said. "Whether he repented or didn't — that isn't visible to me. I've never once gone inside another person. I only see what they said, what they did. And that's all I write."

"…But people keep wanting to know the heart."

"…They do," Mena said. "I do too. But if you write down what you want to know, it stops being a record. It becomes a wish. Writing down what you'd like to believe."

I felt that distinction was subtle, and yet, once I'd grasped it, very clear.

. . .

"…Fourth," Mena said. "Don't write everything down."

I was startled at that. Everything until now had been about writing exactly, in detail. This was the opposite.

"…Why?"

"…There's what's worth writing and what isn't," Mena said. "I don't write down what won't be forgotten even if I don't write it. I write down only what would stop having happened, if it were forgotten."

I remembered what Mena had said before, when I'd asked why she wrote. Her answer, then.

"…Because if it's forgotten, it never happened," I said, echoing it.

Mena looked at me. A little surprised.

"…You remembered that."

"…I've been thinking about it ever since," I said.

Mena smiled a little.

"…That's the bottom of every rule I have," Mena said. "All the other rules come out of that one. Writing only what I saw, writing that I don't know when I don't, writing action instead of heart — all of it is so nothing gets forgotten. If you're not exact, something worse than forgetting happens. Being remembered wrong."

. . .

"…Fifth," Mena said. "Write on paper. Not on a screen."

I found that strange. Until then I'd only known paper as slower and more inconvenient than a screen.

"…A screen's faster," I said. "The Roll does everything on a screen too."

"…That's the problem," Mena said. "Anything written on a screen, if someone decides to, can be changed without anyone knowing. Paper isn't like that. Once something's written on paper, erasing it leaves a trace. Scrape marks, overwriting. I like that trace. It's honest."

"…What if the paper's destroyed? Burned, or soaked through?"

"…Then the record is lost," Mena said. "I'm afraid of that too. But I think it's better for something to disappear entirely than to be secretly changed. You can know a thing that's gone is gone. Something changed in secret, you never even know was changed."

I thought of the smooth typeface I'd seen on the screen the day before. Flawless letters, without a single blemish. That flawlessness looked different to me now. Being clean didn't mean no hand had ever touched it. It might mean, instead, that whatever hand had touched it left no trace behind.

. . .

Mena pointed to the paper in front of me.

"…Try writing something," Mena said. "Anything from today."

I hesitated a moment, then picked up the pen. I thought of what Pikra had said that morning.

I wrote:

"Pikra seemed angry this morning."

Mena read the sentence and shook her head.

"…This is a guess," Mena said. "What did you see, to make you say 'seemed angry'?"

I thought again.

"Pikra said only three words this morning. Fewer than usual."

Mena read that one again. This time she nodded.

"…This is good," Mena said. "No one can read this differently. That she said only three words is a fact. Whether that was because she was angry, or tired, or simply had nothing to say — that's for the reader to decide. I don't do that deciding for them."

I looked at the sentence again. Even though I'd written it, it felt far more honest than the first one had.

"…Write one more," Mena said. "Something harder, this time. About someone who matters to you."

I hesitated, then thought of Lytron. I wrote:

"Lytron is not a bad person."

Mena read that one and said nothing for a moment.

"…Is this a guess too?" I asked first.

"…No, this is a different problem," Mena said. "This is a judgment. Whether he's bad or not isn't something you get to decide, Xene. That's for the reader."

I felt a small unfairness at that.

"…But I really do think that."

"…Thinking it is your own business," Mena said. "But if you write it into this record as a fact, whoever reads it will take it as a fact. You can write what he did. Leave out whether it was bad or not."

I wrote again.

"Lytron saw me empty-handed at the corner, and came to check on me more often than others did."

Mena read it and nodded.

"…This is much better," Mena said. "Whoever reads this sentence can decide for themselves whether he's a bad person or not. You don't decide it for them."

I felt something strange in that moment. Once the judgment was taken out, more showed through, not less. *He isn't a bad person* said only one thing. *Came to check on me more often* said far more about who Lytron was. I read the sentence over several times. Each time, I saw something slightly different. First I saw kindness in it. Then I thought — maybe it was only curiosity. I felt that letting those several layers of possibility stand, rather than covering them over with one judgment, was in fact more honest.

That day I learned, for the first time, that judgment actually hides a person. Calling someone good or bad locks that person inside a single word. Writing the action as it was leaves them complicated still. I understood, that day, for the first time, that leaving that complication in place might be the most honest way to treat someone.

. . .

"…Mena," I asked. "What's the use of writing this way? It could get changed somewhere else anyway."

Mena looked at me for a moment.

"…Even so, what it was at the start stays there," Mena said. "I told you yesterday. You have to leave behind what was right at the start,

so someone can compare it later. What you compare against is exactly this kind of exact sentence. A loosely written sentence has no power to be compared against."

I looked again at the paper in my hand. A short single line. And yet there was a different weight to it than there had been a moment before.

That was the day I first learned that this whole record would come to be written in the manner I learned that day. I didn't know, then, that it would become a book. I only started forming the habit of setting down each day this way.

. . .

"…Mena, why teach me?" I asked. "You could teach anyone else."

Mena looked out the window for a moment.

"…I taught this to one other person, a long time ago," Mena said. "She asked me something similar then."

"…What is that person doing now?"

"…Writing, I'd guess," Mena said. There was something warm in her voice. "I haven't seen her in a long time. But I believe she's still writing the way I taught her."

"…Will I become that too, someday?"

Mena looked at me for a long moment.

"…That's up to you," Mena said. "I can only teach. Continuing to write is up to the one who learned."

"…Wasn't it hard? Passing this on to someone else?"

Mena thought a moment.

"…It was hard," Mena said. "I've done this work alone a long time. Handing it to someone means letting go of what I've been holding. I was afraid of that. Afraid of handing it over wrong. Afraid I'd taught it the wrong way."

"…Then why did you hand it over?"

"…If I don't, it ends with me," Mena said. "That frightened me more. If I died, everything I'd seen would disappear along with me. I couldn't bear that."

For the first time, I fully understood why Mena was teaching this, in a strange city, to a stranger like me. It wasn't kindness. It was closer to a struggle to survive. From that day on, I saw Mena a little differently. Behind that calm face was someone just as desperate as I was.

I didn't know, then, who that person from long ago was. Later I would hear the name. For now I'll only set down the expression on Mena's face when she spoke of that name. Half longing, half pride.

. . .

That evening, for the first time, I wrote out the day with my own hand. It was short. Only a few lines. But it took far longer to write than I expected. I revised a single word several times.

Pikra saw and asked.

"…What are you doing?"

"…Practicing what I learned," I said. "Mena taught me."

Pikra glanced at the paper. I didn't hide it from her.

"…What's different about this? Isn't it just a diary?"

"…It's different," I said. "I don't write my feelings here. I write only what happened."

Pikra looked at the paper a moment and nodded.

"…That sounds harder," Pikra said. "Leaving your feelings out."

While Pikra worked her stalks beside me, I recited aloud, one by one, what I'd learned that day.

"…Write only what you saw. Write that you don't know when you don't. Write action, not the heart. Don't write everything. Write on paper."

Pikra listened without stopping her hands.

"…That's five," Pikra said. "Did you memorize them all?"

"…I'm not used to them yet," I said. "But I feel like I shouldn't forget them."

Pikra set down the stalks for a moment.

"…Say them to me again sometime," Pikra said. "So I don't forget either."

. . .

On my way to draw water, I stopped by the corner for a moment. He was there.

"…What did you learn today?" he asked first. That was unusual.

"…How to write things down," I said. "Mena taught me."

He stopped his hands and looked at me. Something glad passed through his eyes.

"…Good," he said.

"…Why is it good?"

"…Someone has to keep doing it," he said. "Mena will leave this city someday too."

I was a little surprised at that.

"…How do you know?"

"…All recorders are like that," he said. "They never stay in one place long. That's their work."

I felt an unexpected sadness at that. It wasn't that I hadn't already thought Mena wouldn't stay in this city forever. But hearing it said outright felt different.

"…Then when Mena leaves, will I have to write alone?"

He nodded. He didn't try to console me. Somehow that was a comfort itself.

"…You won't be doing it alone," he said. "If what's written stays behind, that isn't doing it alone."

I didn't fully understand that, that day. I do now. Even in this moment, I'm not writing alone. The five rules Mena left me are still holding my hand.

. . .

That evening, I wrote out the day with my own hand for the first time. It was short. Only a few lines. But it took far longer to write than I expected. I revised a single word several times.

Pikra saw and asked.

"…What are you doing?"

"…Practicing what I learned," I said. "Mena taught me."

Pikra glanced at the paper. I didn't hide it from her.

"…What's different about this? Isn't it just a diary?"

"…It's different," I said. "I don't write my feelings here. I write only what happened."

Pikra looked at the paper a moment and nodded.

"…That sounds harder," Pikra said. "Leaving your feelings out."

"…It is. My feelings keep jumping out first," I said. "Crossing that out and starting over takes the longest."

"…Maybe I should try it too," Pikra said, half joking. But something sincere seemed folded in under the joke.

"…Try it. I'll teach you. It isn't hard."

Pikra laughed. A real laugh, out loud. I thought it had been a long time since I'd heard that laugh.

"…You, teaching me?" Pikra said. "The world's really changed."

"…Maybe Mena learned from her own student once too."

Pikra laughed even harder at that.

"…Keep at it, anyway," Pikra said. "I want you to keep doing this."

"…Why?"

Pikra looked at the hearth fire for a moment.

"…No one's ever written down exactly what I did, my whole life," Pikra said. "Everyone just guessed at me, however they liked. A sad woman. A pitiable woman. But no one ever wrote down what I actually did. I want you to be the one who does that."

Something caught in my throat at that. I couldn't answer. I only nodded.

I read that paper over many times that night. Short sentences. I had no idea, then, how important those sentences would become to someone, much later, much further on. I had only left the day behind, exactly as it had happened, the way Mena taught me.

I tried to write every sentence of this book by the five rules I learned that day. Whether I succeeded, I can't say. But I can say, at

least, that I tried.

And I'll set down one more thing. That night, for the first time, I gave this bundle of paper a name. Nothing grand. I only wrote, at the top, "Starting today." I think of that as the true first line of this book. Every chapter I've written since has grown out of those two words.

(Continued in Chapter 32.)

Chapter 32. Where There Is Always a Little More

> *_Previously_ — Mena taught Xene the five rules of writing: write only what you've seen, write that you don't know when you don't, write action and not the heart, don't write everything, write on paper. That night, Xene wrote down a day with her own hand for the*
> *first time.*

From that day on, I wrote a few lines every evening.

At first I didn't know what to write, so I wrote anything at all. Today's weather. Three sentences Pikra had said that day. How much I'd gleaned at the corner. I tried to record that last one exactly — not "gleaned a lot," but "a palmful of three," that kind of thing. The way Mena had taught me.

I didn't know, then, what this habit would grow into. I only wrote so as not to forget. But writing exactly, it turned out, was something that eventually made me see things I'd been passing over without knowing it.

I kept that paper behind a wooden frame on one side of the cabin. I took it out from the same spot every night. The first few days, the sentences ran long. Soon they shortened. Just as Mena had said, once I kept only what was worth keeping, that happened on its own.

I never dated the page. Instead, I put the single surest thing about that day first. It rained, or it didn't. Pikra coughed, or she didn't.

Something was gleaned at the corner, or nothing was. I had no idea, then, that this order would become, later on, the thread by which I found my way back into a day. At the time it was only habit.

I keep that old bundle of pages beside me now, writing this book. Some pages are stained; on some the ink has run, barely legible. But without those pages, I couldn't have written this thirty-second chapter. Memory alone would never have given me a sentence like "over two days I confirmed it." Memory blurs things into "it happened several times."

. . .

Damia laughed the first time she saw the paper.

"…What are you writing so hard at?" Damia asked. We were working side by side at the machine.

"…What happened that day," I said.

"…A diary?"

"…Similar, but different," I said. "I don't write my feelings. Just what happened."

Damia tilted her head at that.

"…What's fun about that, if there's no feeling in it?"

I couldn't answer right away. I'd thought the same thing myself, at first. But writing it for a few days, I began to see things that only came into view once the feeling was left out.

"…I'm not writing it for fun," I finally said.

Damia didn't press further. She just gave a shrug and went back to her own work. I wasn't hurt by that. I already knew, by then, that some people would understand this and some wouldn't, and that neither side was wrong for it.

. . .

Within the week, I noticed something strange.

It was the numbers. Setting side by side the days I'd written "a palmful of three" against the days I'd written "a palmful of five," I saw that the days with five always came from the same spot. His spot.

At first I thought it was coincidence. The field was wide, and the machines' paths shifted a little from day to day. It wasn't strange for one side to leave a little more some days, the other side other days.

But writing it down for several more days, it was too consistent to be coincidence. I flipped back through the pages. A week's worth of entries.

Monday: his spot, a palmful of five.
Tuesday: the other side, a palmful of two.
Wednesday: his spot, a palmful of four.
Thursday: the day he didn't come, and his spot, too, a palmful of two.

My hand stopped at that last line. On the day he wasn't there, nothing extra was left at his spot either.

I thought back, at this point, to something further back — Chapter 19, "The One Who Gleans Beside Me." I had already half-noticed this once, back then. I'd taken it for coincidence and let it go. Why hadn't I asked further, then? Thinking of it now, the answer is simple. Back then I didn't yet know how to write exactly. Noticing something by instinct and confirming it with numbers are different things. Instinct can be let go of. A number can't.

. . .

I decided to test it.

The next day, I went early and sat at the spot he always took. He came a little later than usual, and, seeming unconcerned, went and sat somewhere else — a few steps from where I'd been, not his usual spot.

That evening, I counted the palmfuls. The place I'd sat, his old spot, was the same as always. But the new spot he'd taken that day — the place where he'd actually been — had more than usual.

I was certain, in that moment. It wasn't the place that was good. It was the place he was in that became good.

I didn't want to be certain from just one day. I tried the same thing the next day. This time he took his seat first, and I went and sat far off to the side, somewhere he wouldn't be likely to sit. The result was the same. Where I'd been was no different from usual. Where he'd been had a little more than usual.

That night I wrote it in my paper.

"Wherever he sits, that spot always leaves a little more than the others, even when the spot itself changes. Confirmed over two days."

I read that sentence twice. I hadn't mixed in a single guess, and yet what it said was entirely clear.

On the second day I tested it, Lytron happened to pass by on patrol. He stopped and scanned the field — the machines' path, the line at the scales, the placement of the workers. The same routine as always.

"…Anything unusual today?" he asked.

"…No," I said.

I nearly laughed, right then. Just a few steps away, I was running my own experiment, and none of it registered with him at all. He saw only the numbers he always saw, the routes he always saw. What I was watching that day wasn't numbers. It was a person. The same field, and he and I were looking at entirely different things.

I found that fact frightening for the first time, right then. There was so much to see in that field. And yet everyone saw only what they'd been trained to see. Lytron had been trained to see numbers. I was only just then learning to see a person exactly.

. . .

By the end of that week, I told Mena what I'd found.

"…I found something strange," I said. "There's always a little more at his spot. I confirmed it over two days."

Mena stopped and looked at me.

"…Did you ask him?" Mena asked.

"…No. Not yet."

"…If you ask," Mena said, "an answer might not come. Know that going in."

"…Why?"

Mena thought a moment.

"…Some answers aren't a matter of can't. They're a matter of won't," Mena said. "I've worked out that difference over a long time. Someone who can't answer, their face shakes. Someone who won't, doesn't shake. They just go still."

I didn't fully understand that, then. A few days later, at the ditch, I would see exactly what she meant.

. . .

That night before sleep, I thought of something from long ago.

My husband, teaching me to swing the sickle, the first autumn. I was scolded then for reaping too cleanly. "What you spill isn't wasted," he'd said. "It's left behind."

I'd taken that as a joke, at the time. But since finding that a little more always turned up where he sat, that memory kept overlapping, strangely, with this. What my husband had spilled, and what this man left behind. I couldn't be sure, at the time, whether they were the same thing.

I never wrote that thought down on paper that night. It was a guess. But now, setting it down in this book, I've chosen to keep the guess

rather than erase it. This is a thought I actually had, that night. Mena's rule was to separate fact from guess — not to pretend a guess never existed.

. . .

I hesitated for several more days.

Mena had taught me not to write everything. She'd never taught me not to ask. I knew those were different things. Writing, and asking.

Even now, I'm not entirely sure why I hesitated so long. Maybe I wanted to hear the answer, and at the same time didn't want to. Some questions, once answered, you can't go back from. I think I already knew that, on some level.

Once, I sat down beside him meaning to ask, and in the end said nothing at all, just sifting the dirt. That night I wrote in my paper, "Still didn't ask, today." A short line. But it took longer to write than any other line I'd written.

In the end, one evening, I followed him down to the ditch, where he'd gone to wash his hands, and asked.

"…Why does a little more always turn up at your spot?"

I asked it plainly, without dressing it up. Days I'd spent choosing the question, and what came out, in the end, was the shortest sentence of all.

. . .

He stopped washing his hands and looked at me.

It wasn't an angry face. I thought I knew that face well. But that day it was none of the faces I knew. He didn't smile. That struck me as strange. Usually, when a question was hard to answer, he smiled. That day he didn't.

He kept shaking the water from his hands for a long while. He didn't seem to be preparing an answer. He was just shaking off water. Only the sound of the ditch went on for a time.

"…I don't know," he said at last.

"…What does 'I don't know' mean?"

"…It means I'm not sure either," he said.

That didn't sound like a lie to me. But it didn't feel like the whole of it, either.

"…So did I just imagine it, then?" I asked.

He looked at me for a moment. Then turned his eyes back to the ditch.

"…I didn't say you imagined it," he said.

I thought about pressing further. But his shoulders had gone a little stiffer than usual. Not from anger. I couldn't put a name to what it was, then.

"…You don't have to answer if you don't want to," I said.

"…It isn't that I don't want to," he said. "There's just nothing to say."

. . .

I understood there was nothing more I could draw out of that answer.

He wasn't angry, and he didn't leave. He just finished washing his hands and, as always, picked up his basket and walked back toward the field. Watching him go, I felt a strange kind of relief. Watching someone avoid an answer was somehow easier to bear than hearing a lie.

That evening I wrote down the question and the answer exactly as they were. What his face had looked like, how many words he'd said. I wanted to write "he was hiding something." I wrote it down, and crossed it out, several times. It was a guess. In the end, I only left this:

"He said, 'I don't know.' He also said, 'I didn't say you imagined it.' He didn't get angry. He didn't smile."

Writing that sentence, I felt, for the first time in my body, why Mena's fifth rule mattered. Written down on paper, I could take that face back out and look at it again, later. Memory faded. Paper didn't.

. . .

That night, Pikra saw me writing and asked.

"…Him again?"

"…Yes," I said. "There's always a little more where he sits. I asked him. He wouldn't answer."

Pikra set down the stalks she was working.

"…Didn't he get angry?"

"…No. He didn't smile either."

Something in that made Pikra's face turn thoughtful.

"…That's strange," Pikra said. "I've seen him smile plenty of times."

"…That's why it seemed strange to me too."

"…Someone who smiles their way past things is covering something up with the smile," Pikra said. "But not smiling means—"

Pikra stopped there.

"…What does it mean?"

"…Either there's nothing to cover, or there's nothing they can cover it with," Pikra said. "One or the other. I don't know which."

I held onto that a long time.

. . .

I still didn't know, that night, why a little more always turned up at his spot. I can't say I fully know it even now. But since that day, I've come to tell a little more clearly when he was answering and when he was avoiding. It was a small kind of learning. But that small learning became, later, the eye that let me recognize something much larger.

By that point I had already been watching two different kinds of silence for a while. One was the silence Lytron showed in Chapter 16, talking about his family — not silence from having nothing to say, but from having no need to say it. The other was the silence he showed at

the ditch that day — silence with something to say, and a choice not to say it. I hadn't thought to set those two side by side, back then. Only in writing this book do I come to know how different a weight those two silences carried.

The next morning, I went out to the corner as usual. He was there in his usual spot too. As if yesterday had been nothing at all, he gave a single nod, and I nodded back. We sat side by side, as always, sifting the dirt.

I found that calm strangely welcome. Some people, once you ask them something awkward, avoid you afterward. He didn't. He hadn't given me an answer, but he hadn't taken away my place beside him either.

That evening I wrote this down too. "He came to the same spot the day after the question, as always." I think this one line, in its way, says more than that day's "I don't know" did. Avoiding an answer and avoiding a person are different things. He only ever did the first.

(Continued in Chapter 33.)

Chapter 33. Lytron and Mena

> *_Previously_ — Xene confirmed with numbers that a little more always*
> *turned up wherever he sat. When she asked him why, he neither got angry nor smiled — he only said, "I don't know."*

This chapter, too, is a story I didn't live through myself.

I wasn't there for it. This is pieced together from what Lytron told me himself, much later, and from a few things Mena confirmed. I wrote this chapter in the same spirit I wrote Chapters 16 and 21. Even something I didn't witness, if I carry it over without lying, isn't a story I've invented.

. . .

By then, Lytron had already said, three separate times, that he meant to go see Mena.

Once to me, twice to himself. I asked him afterward why he kept putting it off.

"…What was holding you back?" I asked.

"…I don't know," he said. "It just felt like, if I went, I'd learn something."

"…Why was that so unwelcome?"

"…It isn't that it was unwelcome," he said. "It's that I always calculate before I know something. But in front of that woman, I had no idea what there even was to calculate."

In the end, one afternoon, his patrol having ended early, he found his steps turning toward the archive. There hadn't been any particular resolve behind it, he said. His feet had simply gone that way that day.

. . .

The archive door was open.

Mena sat at the table, sorting through paper. Lytron hesitated in the doorway for a moment.

"…Excuse me," he said.

Mena looked up. No surprise showed.

"…Lytron," Mena said. "Xene's told me about you."

Lytron told me, later, that he hadn't given much thought, in that moment, to already being a known quantity to someone. He was used to his own name arriving somewhere before he did.

"…I hear my name is in here somewhere," he said. "May I see it?"

"…Yes," Mena said. That was all.

When I heard about this part from Lytron, I could tell he'd been briefly thrown off by that short answer. He'd expected something to

follow that single word — who are you, why do you want to see it, which household are you from. Nothing followed at all.

. . .

Mena took a thin sheet of paper from a drawer and handed it to him.

Lytron took the page and read it for a long while. His own name, his family's score, three generations of harvest-management history. And beneath all of it, a single short line.

"Zone management assistant. No change in score history."

That was all.

"…Is this all?" he asked.

"…Yes," Mena said.

"…I expected something more."

Mena looked at him for a moment.

"…What did you expect?" Mena asked.

He couldn't answer that right away, he told me later.

"…I don't know. I thought it would say something about me, good or bad."

"…This is saying something about you," Mena said. "You've had no change. I've written that down, exactly as it is."

Lytron set the page down on the table, and his eyes drifted to the papers stacked beside it. Names showed on the pages. One of them caught his eye.

"…Isn't this Xene's name?" he asked.

Mena nodded.

"…Can I see it?"

"…That one, no," Mena said. It was the first real refusal she'd given him. "That belongs to her to show, if she chooses to show it. I won't show it for her."

Lytron nodded at that. He told me, later, "I felt a little ashamed, in that moment. I'd brought up your name first, and now that it was actually your own to keep, I'd asked to see it without thinking twice. I'd never questioned looking at my own — and there I was, asking to see someone else's without a second thought."

Hearing this part, I was struck that he'd even noticed that shame in himself. The Lytron of Chapter 16 probably wouldn't have felt anything about why that question shouldn't be asked. He'd already been changing, in those weeks, in small ways he himself hadn't noticed yet.

. . .

A leather case sat on one side of the table, its lid closed.

"…What's that?" Lytron asked.

Mena glanced toward it for a moment.

"…Things I wrote a long time ago," Mena said.

"…May I see?"

"…That one, no either," Mena said.

This time Lytron didn't ask why. He explained it to me, later, this way: "Looking at her face, I could tell — it wasn't that it was forbidden to me. It was a door not yet open even to her. I didn't know I could sense something like that. That day was the first time I could."

. . .

Lytron studied that sentence for a long time.

"…Is no change a good thing?" he asked.

"…I don't know," Mena said. "I'm not someone who writes good or bad."

"…Then why do you do this work?"

Mena's hand paused.

"…To leave behind, accurately, what someone did and didn't go through," Mena said. "No change, too, is a very exact record, for some people."

I heard this part from Lytron many times over, afterward. He said he hadn't fully understood it, that day. Now I think it was a sentence that quietly foretold the next chapter. But the Lytron standing there that day only felt a small sting — that nothing at all had been written beside his own name.

. . .

He told me, later, that he had tried to do something, right there.

That was simply who he was. Someone who read what another person wanted from him first, and gave it. He assumed Mena would want to know more about his family. So he offered it up himself.

"…My family has managed this field for three generations," he said. "I can tell you more, if it helps. If it's useful for your record—"

"…That's all right," Mena said. "I'll ask if I need to."

Lytron's words trailed off there. He told me he felt as if he'd walked into something, from that small refusal.

"…I felt something strange, right then," he said, later. "I've always given people what they seemed to want from me. But she didn't take what I offered. Not angrily. Just — she didn't need it."

. . .

He tried again.

"…If there's anything I can help with, let me know," he said. "My family has some standing in this city. If you need more material—"

"…I don't," Mena said. Still short. "I don't need anything right now."

Lytron said that was the moment he first truly felt himself standing somewhere he didn't know what to do.

Writing this, I found myself thinking back to Chapter 16 again. There I'd described Lytron's world as one where he never had to wonder. Now I have to add another sentence to that world. Lytron hadn't only lived in a world where he never had to wonder — he'd lived, too, in a world where he'd never once gone unasked-for. People always wanted something from him. Respect, goodwill, a nod to his family's name. He was skilled at giving those things. Mena wanted nothing.

. . .

"…Does this make you uncomfortable?" Mena asked.

Lytron said he was startled by the question. He hadn't known he was showing discomfort.

"…Does it show?" he asked.

"…A little," Mena said. "People make that face, often, when they try to give me something and I don't take it."

"…Why do you think they make that face?"

Mena thought a moment.

"…I'm not certain. I can guess," Mena said. "I guess people feel safe when they give something. If it isn't taken, they lose the sense of what they are."

Lytron had no answer to that, he told me.

. . .

He tried one last time, he said. He'd turned to leave, then turned back and said,

"…Do you need any supplies? Paper, or food. There's some to spare at our house."

Mena looked at him for a moment. Something different crossed her eyes for the first time, Lytron said. Not irritation. More the look of someone hearing a familiar question yet again.

"…That's kind of you," Mena said. "But I carry what I need. I've traveled this way a long time."

"…Still, if there's ever—"

"…Lytron." Mena cut him off. The first time she'd used his name. "You keep trying to give me things. Have you ever thought about why?"

Lytron said the question left him speechless. He walked out without being able to answer it at all.

. . .

I want to pause here and set this down. When I first heard this exchange from Lytron, I thought Mena was testing him on purpose. I don't think that anymore. Mena tests no one. She simply looked, as she always did, at the person in front of her, wanting nothing. Lytron's discomfort didn't come from anything Mena did. It came from her doing nothing at all.

Lytron told me he'd walked out of the archive that day with something unresolved still hanging on him. Normally that wasn't like him at all.

He always left an errand knowing exactly how it had ended. That day wasn't like that.

"…I didn't even know what the problem was," he said, later. "I'd just gone to see what was written beside my name. I came out carrying something completely different."

. . .

He told me he turned that question over the whole walk home. *Have you ever thought about why.*

He stopped for a moment in front of his own gate. He could hear the sound of water running inside, as always — water that simply ran, for show, to dress up the yard.

That evening at dinner, his father asked the question he always asked.

"…Anything unusual today."

"…No," he said.

"…Good."

Lytron said that, hearing that "good," he thought for the first time about what it took for granted. It always came when he'd kept something, when he hadn't lost anything. His father hadn't wanted nothing from him. His father had always wanted exactly one thing. That the number stay the same. That one thing had felt so obvious, for so long, that Lytron had never even recognized it as a demand.

Hearing him describe this dinner, I understood, at last, why what he'd felt at the archive that day had struck him as so foreign. In his own

house, everyone — even the silences — wanted something of him. In Mena's room, no one wanted anything at all. He had never once, in his whole life, had the chance to feel that difference.

. . .

That evening, I ran into him by chance at the corner. He wasn't on patrol. He was simply standing a long while at the edge of the field.

"…Is something wrong?" I asked.

"…No," he said. But his voice wasn't its usual self.

"…Did you see Mena?" I asked.

He looked at me, a little startled.

"…How did you know?"

"…Your face looks strange."

He said nothing for a while, looking out at the field. The evening light lay low, and the stubble cast long shadows.

"…Is Mena a little frightening?" I asked. I'd meant it as a joke, but he took the question seriously.

"…Not frightening," he said. "But none of the things I usually do work in front of her. I find that unfamiliar."

He started to smile, and the smile wouldn't quite come.

"…She didn't ask me for a single thing," he said. I didn't fully understand what he meant, then.

"…Why is that strange?"

Lytron was quiet a long while before answering.

"…I don't know," he said. "But it's the first time in my life. That no one wanted anything from me."

. . .

I didn't think much of that, hearing it that day. I didn't understand why Lytron was carrying those words with such weight. I had lived my whole life never able to demand anything from anyone. It hadn't seemed strange to me at all. But for him, going unasked-for was something he was living for the first time in his life.

I set these two sentences side by side now and look at them a long while. I went out to the corner every day because I could demand nothing. He wavered, for the first time, because nothing was demanded of him. The same city, the same evening, two people standing, each for their own reason, in front of the same word. Demand.

I didn't know, then, what the discomfort he felt that day would come to open up inside him, a few days later.

. . .

That night, writing this down, I found myself, for the first time, careful about how I described Lytron.

I wanted to write, "Lytron was shaken." That would have been a guess. I wrote instead only that his face had looked strange, that he'd spoken differently than usual, that he'd used the phrase "the first

time in my life." Whether he'd really been shaken, he himself probably didn't know that night.

Looking back now, I know. He was shaken. Only the shaking made no sound. Outwardly, nothing at all happened that day. He ate dinner as usual, heard "good" said to him as usual. I'll write this same sentence several more times in this book. Outwardly, nothing happened. But this time, inside that nothing happening, something was, for the first time, quietly changing places.

(Continued in Chapter 34.)

Chapter 34. I Have Never Lost Anything

> *_Previously_ — Lytron met Mena. She wanted nothing from him. In front*
> *of that fact, he was shaken for the first time in his life. "Have you ever thought about why," Mena had asked him.*

This chapter, too, is a story I didn't live through. But this time it's a little different.

The two chapters before this one pieced together a day Lytron had lived. This one pieces together thoughts he carried alone over several days. I know this is a more delicate thing to do. A day is made of events, and easy enough to confirm. A thought has no way to be confirmed. I have filled this whole chapter only with what Lytron told me himself, later, across several separate conversations. I know it's possible he remembers it differently than it truly was. Even so, I believe this much is exact: this is the memory he handed to me.

. . .

The day after meeting Mena, Lytron spent an ordinary day, same as always.

He went on patrol, checked the numbers, wrote up his report. At dinner that evening, his father asked, as he always did, "Anything unusual today," and he answered, "No," and heard, "Good," in return.

But that night, he told me, he couldn't sleep.

"…It was strange," he said, later. "Normally I would have just gone to sleep. But that question kept coming back to me. Have you ever thought about why."

At first he'd tried to brush the question off lightly, the way he had in Chapter 16. Carry something for one night, and when the next day brought something to do, set it down. That had always been his way.

This time he didn't set it down.

I think this difference matters. In Chapter 16, he'd felt something looking over my entry-approach history, and forgot it by the next day, buried under some other report. This time he didn't forget. I thought a long time about where that difference came from. The answer was simple. That earlier question had been about me. This one was about himself. A question about someone else, you can forget. A question about yourself doesn't let go so easily.

. . .

For several days, he told me, he turned that same question over from several angles in his own mind.

Why did I keep trying to give her something. At first he thought it was simple kindness. But he soon knew it wasn't only that. In trying to give Mena something, he'd also been trying to reassure himself of something. He'd wanted confirmation that he was a useful person in that room.

"…I'd always been in a position to give something," he said, later. "I thought that was just my nature. But in that room, once I had nothing left to give, I didn't even know who I was."

He followed that thought and began counting through his own life again from the start.

. . .

He was a man who was quick with numbers. He was used to thinking in them. So he laid his whole life out as figures and went through it, one by one.

From the moment of his birth to now, his family's score had never once gone down. A number his grandfather had built and his father had kept. Not a bad year, not an accident, had ever touched that number. Not when his brother went out on his own, not when he became a zone management assistant — the number had stayed the same or climbed.

He tried to find some point where he had lost something. No matter how far back he searched, nothing came up.

I want to pause here for a moment. I rewrote this passage more times than any other in this book. My first draft read: "In the end he found nothing. That was his problem." I struck that line. It was a judgment. I chose instead to keep only what he actually gave me, word for word.

. . .

He said he thought back, too, on the house he'd grown up in.

The house I'd already described in Chapter 16 — so many rooms he'd never once counted them. The water channel that ran through the yard purely for decoration. Thinking of that channel, he remembered that on that night described in Chapter 21, he had already, once, heard that water differently.

"…That night I wondered, for the first time, where that water even came from," he said. "And even so, afterward, I never once turned it off. Wondering about something and actually doing something about it are different things, it turns out."

He took that channel as one example and looked over his whole life again through it. All the things that existed not because they were needed, but simply because they'd always flowed. He tried to count how many things like that filled his life. He gave up counting. There were too many.

. . .

One evening, his brother came from another zone.

Not for any holiday. It was because their father had asked him to come check in on how Lytron had been lately — something Lytron only learned afterward. He hadn't known that, that day.

His brother spoke to him as easily as ever. "Just keep your numbers straight. Everything else follows."

Lytron said that on hearing those words, for the first time, he asked back.

"…Do you think that's true for everyone?"

His brother paused a moment at the question.

"…What are you talking about?"

"…Xene," he said. "She has no number to keep. She started at zero. Does that hold true for her too?"

His brother couldn't answer. Instead he said,

"…You've been saying strange things lately."

Lytron said he didn't ask anything further after that. But later he told me: "I knew, right then. My brother had never once been asked that question. Neither had I. Both of us had lived our whole lives thinking those words held true for everyone."

. . .

A few days after that, he went to see the administrator.

There was no particular business, he said. He just wanted to ask something.

"…You've said the Roll has never broken the law," he said. "Does that mean it's never taken anything from anyone, either?"

The administrator looked at him for a moment. The same plain expression as always.

"…No," the administrator said. "The Roll takes nothing from anyone."

"…Then why is there nothing for some people?"

For the first time, the administrator paused before answering.

"…Never having taken something, and having given something — those are two different statements," the administrator said. "The Roll only calculates. Calculation is neither taking nor giving."

Lytron said he stood there a long while after hearing that.

Hearing this exchange later, an old scene came back to me. Something Glyke had said in Chapter 1. If someone takes something from you, at least you can say you were robbed. Just being given nothing at all — there's nowhere even to say that. I'd heard those words outside, back then. Lytron heard almost the same words, years later, in the middle of a city, from a different mouth entirely. Setting these two scenes side by side, I confirm again how simple this city's secret was from the very start. Not taking and giving are different things. But to the one on the receiving end, they feel exactly the same.

. . .

"…Do you remember the day it rained?" he asked me once. "The day you filled a sack for the first time."

"…Yes," I said. It was the day I'd written down in Chapter 24.

"…I remember that day too. But I lost nothing that day," he said. "The harvest was only delayed. Our family always keeps reserves for that. One day's delay doesn't take anything away from us."

"…What does that mean?"

"…The same rain fell," he said. "For you it was the first sack you'd ever earned. For me it was nothing at all. I'd never once thought about that difference before."

. . .

From that night on, he started looking for something else. Not what he'd lost, but a moment where he'd taken a risk.

He thought back to that night in Chapter 21. The loss-rate setting screen. The night he'd opened the confirmation window and closed it again. At the time, he'd felt himself standing in front of danger. But thinking it over again, that hadn't been danger at all. As long as he didn't press that button, he was in a position to lose nothing. Not pressing it had always been the safe side. He had stood on that safe side, and called it, to himself, a struggle.

"…I thought, at the time, that I was weighing something," he told me, later. "But really, I wasn't weighing anything. I was just choosing between two safe paths. Press it, and the family score drops. Don't, and nothing happens. There was never a dangerous path for me to begin with."

. . .

He spent several more days holding onto that thought.

Then one day, he thought back to a phrase he'd carried for a long time. *I haven't done anything wrong.* The thing he'd said to himself in Chapter 16.

He looked at that phrase again. It was true. He truly had done nothing wrong. But that day, for the first time, he set another phrase beside it.

I have never lost anything.

He said he read those two sentences over, back and forth, for a long while. At first they seemed like two separate facts. One a proud fact, one simply a lucky one. But at some point, he saw that they were, actually, one and the same.

. . .

"…That day I understood, for the first time," he told me, later. He spoke very slowly, choosing each word. "It wasn't that I hadn't done wrong. It was that I never had to. Every time I made a choice, the right one and the one that benefited me were always the same one. I thought that was my character. It turns out it was my position."

I said nothing for a long while, hearing that. The sound of the machines came faintly from the field. The sound felt louder to me that day than it usually did.

"…What do you mean?" I finally managed.

"…Someone like you," he said, "loses something every time you choose what's right. Every day. I never lost anything, choosing what was right. So the fact that I've done nothing wrong isn't something I paid a price for, the way you did. I was simply never tested."

. . .

Hearing that, I remembered, too, my husband's old words. *What you spill isn't wasted. It's left behind.* I felt his words and Lytron's were pointing, from different directions, at the same thing. My husband, having little, had known what it meant to leave something behind on purpose. Lytron, having so much, was only just then learning that he had never once, truly, left anything behind at all.

I felt the temptation to bind these two into a single sentence. But that would have been too easy a conclusion. I chose instead to lay them only side by side. Not stitched together.

. . .

I write this moment more carefully than any other in this book.

I know that Lytron didn't say these words to punish himself. I found no room to hate him, hearing them. He wasn't saying he'd been a bad person. He was only seeing, for the first time, that his never having been a bad person and his never having paid a price both came from the same place.

I thought longest, of any chapter in this book, about how to write this one. I didn't want this chapter to turn Lytron into someone bad. Nor did I want it to let him off entirely. In the end I chose to carry over exactly what he gave me. Both things were already inside it. He had done nothing wrong. And he had just seen, for the first time, what that absence of wrongdoing had been made of.

. . .

He did nothing right away, after that.

I once thought that strange. Having seen something so large, shouldn't something have changed at once? He answered that question this way.

"…Seeing something large doesn't mean you can do something about it right away," he said. "For those few days, I just carried the fact around with me. It followed me everywhere. Looking at the field, looking at the numbers, going home."

"…Was it hard?"

"…It was hard," he said. "But strangely, I didn't want to go back to before."

Around that time, he said, he started staying alone in his office each evening, opening that same screen from Chapter 21 again. The loss-rate setting. 0.02 percent. The confirm button beside it.

"…You opened it again?" I asked.

"…Yes. A few times," he said. "But I looked at it differently than before."

"…How differently?"

"…Before, I thought that button decided whether I'd lose something," he said. "Now I know. That button is my first chance to actually lose something. I still haven't pressed it. But now I know why I haven't, and it isn't the same reason as before."

I held onto that answer for a long time. Some kinds of knowing don't move a person right away. They only settle inside, quietly, adding weight. I wanted this book to set down the fact that Lytron carried that weight alone, for several days, before anything else happened.

I want to end this chapter here — not as a chapter with an answer, but as a chapter where the shape of a question changed completely. The Lytron of Chapter 21 had asked, "If I press this, do I lose something." The Lytron of Chapter 34 held a different question. *Why have I never once lost anything.* I think the distance between those two questions is the longest road he walks in this book. And he never took a single step to cross it.

(Continued in Chapter 35.)

Chapter 35. Setting It Back

> *_Previously_ — Lytron saw that his never having done wrong and his*
> *never having lost anything were the front and back of the same fact. He had carried that weight alone for days.*

Lytron told me about that morning much later, and very briefly.

"…Nothing special about that day," he said. "I just got up early, as usual, and went to the office, as usual. And then I opened that screen again."

"…And after that?"

"…I pressed it," he said.

That was the whole of his account. I think the brevity itself is more exact than anything longer would have been. Some moments come closer to a lie the longer they're told.

. . .

I felt the temptation, more than once, writing this chapter, to swell that moment out — his hand trembling, a long hesitation, his eyes closing and opening again. I chose not to write it that way. Lytron never told me anything like that. He only said he pressed it. I choose to believe that, exactly as he said it.

I know the days hidden behind that short answer. He'd carried that weight alone through the whole of Chapter 34. I asked him, more than once, what had been different that particular morning. Each time, he answered a little differently.

Once he said, "I just didn't want to put it off any longer."

Another time: "What Mena had said kept staying with me. Have you ever thought about why. That morning, for the first time, I understood that knowing the answer and doing nothing about it would from then on just be pretending not to know."

Another day still: "My father said 'good' again that day too. I heard it, but this time I understood what it meant while I heard it. That was the hardest part."

I want to note that these three answers came on three separate days. I didn't want to stitch them into one tidy reason. A person's reasons for deciding something usually aren't just one. I chose to leave all of them standing.

The confirmation window came up. The same wording as the one in Chapter 21. *Change the loss-rate setting? Projected yield will be adjusted accordingly.*

Beneath it, a number. From 0.02 percent to 3 percent. The same screen, the same figure he'd opened weeks before, one night. What had changed wasn't the number. It was the person standing in front of it.

He said he checked that number once more. It wasn't a large figure. A single decimal point had moved. But the drop in projected yield that followed that small movement wasn't small at all.

He said he didn't look at that window for long.

He pressed *Confirm.*

. . .

I won't set that number down here either, for the same reason I didn't set it down in Chapter 21. Writing the number turns this into a matter of arithmetic. Much, little, worth bearing. I don't want this chapter read that way. I'll only say this. The number was large. Large, measured against everything Lytron's family had spent generations keeping.

The confirmation message appeared. *Setting changed.*

That was all. No alarm sounded. No lock engaged. No request for a superior's approval. The screen flickered once and moved on, without concern, to the next item. The Roll accepted the change at once.

"…It was strange," Lytron told me, later. "I thought there'd be something more. Some procedure to stop it. There wasn't. I pressed it, and it just changed."

He said he left the office that day, and didn't go home right away. Normally, he'd have spent the morning on patrol and then written his report. That day he simply walked toward the field instead.

He watched the corner from a distance. He said he didn't go closer, afraid something might change if he did.

"…What did you see, from there?" I asked.

"…You," he said. "Crouched, looking at something. I couldn't see your face from that far. But your hands kept moving."

"…Did you see him too? The one who glean's beside me."

"…Yes," he said. "He didn't see me. I was too far off. But strangely, what he was doing kept catching my eye. Just his hands moving, next to you. I don't know why that stayed with me so long."

I felt something strange, hearing that. I hadn't known, that day, that Lytron had even been there, or that he'd watched the two of us for so long. Three of us in the same field, that same afternoon, and only one of us had been watching the other two the whole time.

"…What were you thinking, watching me?"

He was quiet a long while before he answered.

"…Nothing came to me," he said. "I just watched. That's all there was."

Hearing this scene, much later, I came to know something I'd never known at all, that day. I'd thought I was crouched alone at the corner, counting grains of fallen wheat. I wasn't. Someone was watching me from a little way off. That person said nothing, and never came closer. I didn't know, then, how heavy that silence would turn out to be.

I thought, too, of something the administrator had said in passing, in Chapter 22. Transfer is possible, in principle, but rarely used in practice. I'd let that pass, at the time. Now I know. This city's doors had never truly been locked. They'd only been closed because no one had ever opened them. That morning, Lytron pushed on a door no one had ever pushed. And it simply opened.

. . .

That day, I went out to the corner as usual.

The sky was clear. No sign of rain. I set about sifting the dirt with no great expectation, same as any other day. Since Chapter 24, I'd known I only ever gained anything on rainy days. That day, it hadn't rained at all.

And yet something was there at that spot.

At first I doubted my eyes. It wasn't trampled, broken stalks. It was whole grain. Scattered here and there, not much, but unmistakably there. I crouched and looked at it for a long while.

"…And no rain fell," I said, half to myself.

. . .

He was there too, that day. I watched his face as he looked down at the dirt in front of him. The same face as always. But that day, that sameness felt strange to me in a way I couldn't place.

"…Doesn't today feel a little different?" I asked.

He glanced for a moment at the few stalks in his hand.

"…It does," he said.

"…Why do you think that is?"

He didn't answer right away. After a moment he only said,

"…I don't know. But it's a good thing, isn't it."

I believed that, plainly, that day. I know better now. He must have known. I've thought a long while about why he didn't just tell me the truth that day. What I guess now is this — he wanted, still, to leave that fact as Lytron's to give. Some news carries its true weight only when it comes from the mouth of the one who lived it.

He paused a moment in gathering his own share. I saw his hand stop.

"…What are you doing?" I asked.

"…Nothing," he said. And then his hand started moving again.

I let that brief pause go, that day, without much thought. But as evening came on, he said, out of nowhere,

"…Days like today don't come often." he said. "Take a good look while it lasts."

"…Why?"

"…There'll be times, later, you'll want to see it again," he said. "And it might not be there to see."

That struck me, strangely, as something to hold onto. But for some reason, I didn't ask any further, right then.

I didn't come back to that remark until much later. I can guess, now, something of what he already knew that day. I don't know exactly what he knew. But I believe, now, that he already knew, that day, that this sight wouldn't last long.

. . .

Damia passed by the corner that afternoon too, and stopped.

"…Oh, there's something here today," Damia said. Not a surprised voice. Just someone noticing, in passing.

"…Yes," I said.

"…Well, how about that. No rain either."

"…I know."

Damia wasn't curious beyond that. She stood a moment, brushed the dirt with her foot a few times, and went on her way, saying only, "…Nice day for it," as she left.

I think that was the most honest response I saw that whole day. Damia hadn't been born and raised in this field. To her, the corner was just a stretch of ground she passed on her way to somewhere else. A good day was just a good day. I didn't envy that lightness. It only felt unfamiliar. To me, that something existed in that spot wasn't a thing you could pass through in a day.

. . .

I filled a sack nearly full that day.

Back home, when I showed it to Pikra, she went quiet for a long while.

"…Did it rain?" Pikra asked.

"…No."

Pikra looked into the sack again.

"…Then why is it like this?"

"…I don't know," I said. "I was just there, at that spot, today."

Pikra didn't look especially glad to hear that. I found that strange.

"…Aren't you happy?" I asked.

"…I am," Pikra said. But there was something careful in her voice. "But I don't much trust something turning good for no reason. When something turns good, there's always a reason behind it. Not knowing that reason unsettles me."

"…Then how do you receive it?" I asked. "You say a good thing unsettles you."

Pikra ran her fingertips once over the grain in the sack.

"…I receive it," Pikra said. "Receiving it without knowing why, and refusing it because you don't know why, are different things. I've never lived a life where I knew all the reasons. Even so, I ate what there was to eat."

Somehow, that felt like comfort to me.

"…Will it be like this tomorrow too?" I asked.

"…I don't know," Pikra said. "But worry about tomorrow tomorrow. Today, eat what's today's."

We ate well that evening, for the first time in a long while. Strangely, that fullness made me uneasy. It felt, somehow, borrowed.

I let that thought pass, that night. Later I would learn how exact that feeling had been. Pikra had lived more than a generation among

this city's numbers. She knew, in her body, long before I did, that there's always a price behind something good.

. . .

Pikra was quiet a long while that night, by the hearth, working the grain. I wasn't unfamiliar with that silence. I'd already learned, in that house, that some people go quiet in front of good things too.

I thought again, that night, of my husband's words.

What you spill isn't wasted. It's left behind. I'd first heard those words two autumns before, in a field. At the time, I'd thought he only meant, go easy on your wrists.

That night, I think, I understood the meaning of those words fully, for the first time. Spilling and leaving something behind come from the same gesture. Only whose hand makes that gesture differs. My husband had made that gesture with his own hand. That day, I still didn't know that another hand, for the first time, had made the same gesture in this field.

I stop long over this sentence as I write it. I didn't know this, that night. I only had a handful of grain in front of me, and pulled up an old, dead man's words again. That those words described, exactly, something that had actually happened that morning in some office in this city — I wouldn't know that for a few days yet.

. . .

I wrote that day down on paper, the way Mena had taught me.

"It didn't rain, and there was grain at the corner. I nearly filled a sack."

I wrote no reason behind that sentence. I didn't know one. That day, I was content with that alone.

Now I can add another sentence beside that one. That day, in some office in this city, a person pressed a confirm button. No one broke the law. The procedure was exact. The Roll accepted the change exactly as it was given. And that person's family score, still unknown to anyone, was quietly changing direction.

I couldn't set these two sentences side by side, that night. I set them side by side now, in this book. One I saw with my own eyes. One I heard of later. But they were a single event, happening the same day, in the same city.

I want to state one thing plainly as I close this chapter. That day, no one broke the law. Lytron only changed a setting within his own authority. The Roll accepted the change precisely, without resistance. The administrator's office, Article 9, none of it was violated. I will write this sentence many times more in this book. No one broke the law. And that day, for the first time in years, grain fell at the corner of this city's field.

I touched that sack once more that night before sleep. Every kernel was rough and solid to the hand. I didn't know where it had come from. I only knew, for certain, that it was truly there in my hands. That night, for the first time in a long while, I waited for the morning without worry.

(Continued in Chapter 36.)

Chapter 36. Found Out

> *_Previously_ — Lytron reverted the loss rate to 3 percent. No one broke the law. That day, for the first time in years, grain fell at the corner. Xene nearly filled a sack.*

The first part of this chapter, too, is a story I didn't live through. I heard it from Lytron himself, much later. He spoke more slowly, telling this one, than any other chapter he ever gave me.

. . .

The next morning, at the Lytron family table, his father asked the question he always asked.

"…Yesterday's loss rate."

This same question had already come up twice before, in Chapters 16 and 21. Each time, Lytron had given the same answer. 0.02 percent. No change.

That morning was different.

"…3 percent," Lytron said. "There was a change."

His father set down his chopsticks. The sound of it, Lytron said, was unusually loud.

"…What did you say?"

"…I changed the setting yesterday," Lytron said.

His father looked as if he couldn't believe it at first, Lytron said. The same table described in Chapter 16, the same seat. For three generations, the same question and the same answer had passed across that table every morning. And now, for the first time, it was that table's turn to hear something other than "good."

"…That was within your authority?" his father asked.

"…Yes. It's within a zone management assistant's authority," Lytron said. "I thought it was view-only. It turned out I could change it too."

"…So it just sat untouched for years, is that what you're telling me?"

"…Yes."

His father was silent for a long moment after that. Lytron said that silence had weighed heavier on him than anger would have.

. . .

I've pictured this scene over more than once. I think Lytron could have lied, in that moment. Called it a system error, or said it was still being confirmed. He didn't. I believe this is the quietest, and also the most courageous, thing he does in this whole book.

His father was silent for a while. Then he asked,

"…Why."

Lytron had already imagined this question many times before. In Chapter 21, he'd rehearsed it in his mind already. Say "because I felt

sorry for her," and it sounds sentimental. Say "because of Article 9," and it becomes a lie. He hadn't found a better answer, even then.

That morning, weeks later, he still hadn't found a better one.

"…I don't know," he said.

. . .

His father looked at him a long while.

"…You don't know," his father said. "You're the one who did it."

"…I'm the one who did it," Lytron said. "But I can't quite put into words why I did it."

"…You did something like that with no reason at all?"

"…There's a reason," Lytron said. "But if I tell you the reason, I don't think you'd understand it."

Hearing this answer, I understood that it wasn't distrust that had made Lytron say it that way. He simply couldn't yet translate his own reason into words. Someone who had just seen, for the first time, that he'd never lost anything — that knowledge needed more time before it could become a sentence. It wasn't a sentence you could use at a morning table, in front of his father.

. . .

His father asked no further.

That same morning, he learned later, his father had sent someone directly to the administrator's office. A request to confirm the change history on the setting.

The administrator met the request plainly. The change history was already recorded, exactly, within the Roll. Who, when, what, by how much. Nothing to hide, nothing to erase.

"…There's no procedural problem," the administrator told his father's man, so Lytron later heard. "Lytron acted within an authority that belonged to him. It wasn't an item that required approval."

"…So you're saying there's no problem at all?"

"…Legally, no," the administrator said. "Though the yield will be affected. That's already been reflected."

. . .

I heard this part directly from the administrator himself. I asked him, at the time, "So nothing at all was done wrong?" The administrator answered, as calmly as ever.

"…There's no violation," the administrator said. "There's a loss. We keep the two separate."

I've thought a long time about that distinction. Violation, and loss. I confirmed again, that day, that this whole book has been unfolding in the space between those two words.

Within days, word went around that Lytron's family score had been adjusted. Not a large drop. But by that household's standard, it was the first thing of its kind in several generations.

. . .

In the field, people's manner toward him began, little by little, to change.

Nothing anyone could point to outright. A greeting arriving half a beat late. People not quite stopping their conversation when he passed, but lowering their voices a little. I only noticed it later. Lytron said he'd noticed it from the very start.

"…People treat me differently now," he told me. "Not badly. Just — not as a given thing, the way they used to."

"…Is it hard?"

"…Yes," he admitted. "But strangely, I think I understand now what that is. I was given respect my whole life as a given thing. I thought that was simply how it was. Now I know it isn't."

His brother, hearing the news, came to see him once. He wasn't angry. He only said,

"…I don't know what you were thinking. But know one thing. This isn't something you can undo. A score falls fast and climbs slowly."

"…I know," Lytron said.

"…You knew, and you did it anyway?"

"…Yes," Lytron said.

His brother seemed about to say something more, then only shook his head and left. Lytron said, watching him go, he couldn't tell if his brother was worried for him or simply couldn't understand him at all.

I don't want to paint his brother badly in this scene either. He was only looking at his brother through the arithmetic he himself had been taught. Within that arithmetic, what Lytron had done had no other name but loss.

. . .

That evening, Lytron sat across from his father again.

This time his father didn't raise his voice. He only looked at him a long while, and asked the same question once more.

"…Why."

Lytron said he still couldn't answer. But this time the silence was different.

"…The first time, I was quiet because I couldn't find the answer," he said. "That evening, I was quiet because the answer was too large. Some things don't shrink down into one sentence."

His father sat with that silence a long while, then rose from the table.

"…I still don't know what it is you've done," his father said. And he walked out.

. . .

I asked Lytron about this more than once. I wanted to know whether he resented his father. He always said no.

"…My father isn't a bad man," he told me. "He spent his whole life believing that keeping the number was the right thing to do, and he taught me the same. I can't say that teaching itself was wrong. That number kept our family standing for generations. I only saw, for the first time, what stood behind that number."

Hearing that, I confirmed again what this book has been trying to say from the very start. This book doesn't paint Lytron's father as a villain. Nor the Roll, nor the administrator. No one here is a bad person. Only, a household that had spent generations teaching itself never to lose anything had, for the first time, raised a son who lost something.

. . .

I heard the news a few days later. Lytron told me himself.

"…It was me," he said. "The loss rate. I'm the one who reverted it."

I couldn't say anything for a long while, hearing that.

"…So that's why grain was at the corner, that day?" I finally managed.

"…Yes," he said.

"…Why didn't you tell me?"

He thought a moment.

"…I don't know," he said. "I thought something would change, if I told you. That you'd come to see it as something you got because of me."

"…And isn't it?"

"…I can't say it isn't," he said. "But I didn't give you anything. I only put it back where it belonged. Back where it should have been all along."

. . .

I turned that over in my mind for a long time.

. . .

That evening, I told Pikra too.

Pikra was quiet a long while by the hearth.

"…He did that?" Pikra asked at last.

"…Yes."

"…Cutting his own family's score to do it?"

"…Yes."

Pikra shook her head. Not an angry face. I saw something old in it.

"…I only ever knew one person like that," Pikra said. "My husband. When he was young, he once paid off another family's debt on their field. A family with no connection to ours at all."

"…Why did he do it?"

"…I don't know," Pikra said. "I asked. He never answered. Thinking of it now, I don't think even he knew. Some things aren't done for a reason you can fully name."

I thought of Lytron again, hearing that. He'd said the same thing to me. *I don't know.*

"…Is that a bad thing, then?" I asked.

"…No," Pikra said. "It isn't bad. But being near someone like that means, someday, there's a price you have to pay along with them too."

I didn't fully understand what she meant, then.

. . .

The next day, at the corner, I told him about it too.

He stopped his hands and listened a long while. He said little, afterward.

"…Did you know?" I asked.

"…I guessed," he said.

"…Why didn't you tell me sooner?"

He brushed the dirt off his hands.

"…It wasn't mine to tell," he said. "That was his to say for himself."

I thought that answer sounded like something he'd said before, in Chapter 35. *Good news carries its true weight only when it comes from*

the mouth of the one who lived it. I understood, only then, that he'd been keeping that same rule with me, and with Lytron, exactly alike.

"…What happens to this place now?" I asked.

"…I don't know," he said. "But once even one person has seen a day like this, this place doesn't go all the way back to what it was before."

I held onto those words for a long time.

. . .

A few days later, I stopped by the archive and told Mena too.

Mena listened to all of it and wrote a few lines on her paper. She attached no judgment at all.

"…What do you think?" I asked. "Have you seen this kind of thing often?"

Mena set down her pen and looked at me.

"…Not often," Mena said. "I've traveled through many cities. Someone who cuts down their own share to give it to another — that's truly rare. But not entirely unheard of, either."

"…What happened to those people, afterward?"

"…All different," Mena said. "Some came to regret it, later. Some didn't. I can't tell you ahead of time which it'll be. I only write down what a person has done, now."

I wasn't satisfied with that answer. But at the same time, I knew it was exactly the kind of answer Mena would give.

That evening, I set these two meetings down side by side. In what Lytron had done, Pikra saw her own husband. Mena saw the names of similar people from several cities. It had only been Lytron's own act. And yet that single act called up, inside each of them, an entirely different memory. I think this is the thing I saw most often, in this third part. That the same fact settles into a different shape inside each person who receives it.

That night, I wrote this on my paper. "Lytron reverted the loss rate. His family's score fell. His father asked why, and he could not answer." I attached no judgment after that. I didn't write that it was good, or that it was a pity. Just as Mena had taught me.

But writing this book now, I want to set one more line beside those sentences. The Roll broke the law not even once, that day. Not Lytron's father, not the administrator, no one at all committed a violation. Every procedure was exact. And within that exactness, a boy lost something, for the first time in his life, and beside him, a girl, for the first time, held something whole and entire in her own hands. I set these two sentences down again now, closing this third part, and confirm once more that both of them were true, the same day, in the same city, at the very same time.

I began this third part with the scene of Mena teaching me how to write. Closing it now, I know I couldn't have written this final chapter without those five rules. I wrote this chapter without hating Lytron, without hating his father, without hating the administrator. That isn't because I'm a good person. I only learned how to write action instead of the heart. And once I had set down only the actions, exactly, there turned out to be, strangely, no place left for hatred to stand at all.

I named this part Mena's Record. I know now. What I truly learned in this part wasn't Mena's five rules. Those were only the method. What I came to know, by that method, was something else entirely. That having done no wrong, and being good, are not the same thing. And that the difference between them never shows itself in any courtroom, or on any screen of the Roll. It shows itself in exactly one place. In who has lost something, and who has not.

(Continued in Part Four.)

The Gleaning Ground, Part Four

The Price

Chapter 37. The Nearer Kinsman

> *_Previously_ — Lytron's tampering with the loss rate was discovered. It*
> *wasn't illegal. It was simply a loss. His family's standing fell, and his*
> *father asked him why he'd done it. Lytron had no answer.*

The Roll measures closeness in two ways.

One is the closeness I know. Seeing a face every day. Eating from the same bowl. Knowing, when you hear someone crying at night, when not to go to them. That kind of closeness is built out of time. It takes long to make, and long to lose.

The other is the closeness the Roll knows. Blood, marriage, and the number the two leave behind. This closeness holds even if you've never seen the face. It holds even if you've never met. Two people who have never once stood in the same room can be recorded, inside the Roll, as the closest of kin.

Until then I had forgotten the second kind of closeness existed. Forgotten isn't quite right — I had never known it at all. There was no such closeness in our settlement. Out there, there was only the one kind. Seeing someone every day.

I mean to write, in this chapter, how different the two kinds of closeness are from each other. And what that difference finally made possible.

Mena told me once, later, that a record only ever keeps the second kind of closeness. The Roll, the paperwork, even this book. The first kind is never written down. I remember that now, writing this chapter.

. . .

That summer was unusually long.

Since Lytron's family standing had fallen, the way people treated him in the field had shifted, little by little. Nothing large. A greeting arriving half a beat slower. People not quite stopping their talk when he passed. Things like that.

I noticed. I didn't tell him. There was nothing to be gained by saying it.

We still went out to the corner every day. The loss rate, set back to 3 percent, hadn't been touched. No one had reset it to 0.02 percent again. Resetting it was work, and no one cared enough to do that work. Lytron's family standing had already fallen; turning the setting back now wouldn't have undone that.

So something kept falling at the corner of the field. Not much. But more than before.

I still remember that summer as a strange season. Something bad had happened, and because of it, there was a little more to eat every evening. It took me a long time to find a way to make sense of that strangeness.

. . .

Pikra brought up the name on an ordinary evening.

We were washing the barley from that week's ration. Water was scarce, so the three of us shared one basin, taking turns. Pikra spoke without stopping her hands.

"…Medon might still be here."

"…Who?" I asked.

"…Your husband's cousin," Pikra said. "The only one of that family who never left."

I stopped my hands.

"…My husband had a cousin?"

"…He did," Pikra said. "You must have seen him a few times as a child. Though you wouldn't remember."

I didn't remember. I had never even heard his name spoken. In two years as that family's daughter-in-law, that name had never once come up. Later I learned it wasn't an accident. The family had chosen not to speak of him.

"…Why didn't he leave?" I asked. "The whole family went outside."

Pikra gave herself, for a moment, entirely to washing. Only the rasp of barley in the basin.

"…He was never blood to this house," she said, finally. "He's my husband's brother's son. That brother died young, and his widow stayed on here with just her boy. We'd already split from that side long before. It happened before he'd turned ten."

"…So he isn't close family."

Pikra looked at me. Water dripped from her hands.

"…He's close to the Roll," Pikra said. "By blood."

"…What's the difference?"

"…That it's a different closeness than the one I know," Pikra said. "Would he know me? Probably not. He wouldn't know my face. But the Roll has us written down as close kin."

I let the words pass by that night. It wasn't unusual for Pikra to bring up a name from the past. I took it for something said over an evening chore. I still thought so the next morning.

. . .

Lytron came out to the field the next day.

He didn't smile much lately. His face had changed a little, since his family standing fell. Not for the worse. Just a face that seemed always to be calculating something.

"…Xene."

"…Yes."

"…I need to ask you something," he said. "On your mother-in-law's side — does anyone still have family left in this city?"

I didn't know why he was asking.

"…There is, apparently. I only heard it yesterday. Someone named Medon."

Something registered on Lytron's face. It was an expression I would learn to recognize only later — not the face of calculating something, but of confirming it.

"…Medon," he repeated. "I know that name."

"…How?"

"…He's in the Harvest management Roll," he said. "His family standing is high. Very high. Among the highest in this district."

"…What does he do?"

"…Supply allocation," Lytron said. "That family's never wavered, generation to generation. They never went outside, and they've never had much occasion to lose anything."

Something in that caught at me, though I couldn't have said what.

I can name it now. Lytron already knew, even then. That a family that had never wavered meant a family that had never lost anything. And that this wasn't only a good thing.

. . .

The administrator sent for us that same week.

Three of us sat before the Roll terminal — Pikra, Lytron, and I. The administrator paged through the screen, explaining something. His voice was even, as always. The same pitch whether the news was bad or good.

"…There's a procedure called standing transfer," the administrator said. "You may already know of it."

I didn't. Lytron looked as though he did.

"…It lets a person lower their own score to add to someone else's," the administrator went on. "It exists in the system. It's rarely used."

"…How rarely?" Lytron asked.

The administrator paged through once more. His fingers moved with practiced ease.

"…According to the record, it has never once been used," the administrator said, still even. "The provision exists, but there is no case of it having been carried out. Not once, since it was created."

That didn't strike me as strange. I didn't yet know how strange it was — that a door could exist and no one had ever tried it.

I know now. It wasn't that the provision existed and nobody used it. It was that nobody used it, and so the provision simply existed. A door no one has ever tried isn't open, even when it's open. I didn't understand the difference then.

The administrator pointed to a corner of the screen.

"…In a case like this, there's a procedural order of priority," the administrator said. "The first opportunity goes to a blood relation. It's not fixed by law — it's custom. And this person" — he pointed to a name on the screen — "is the only one registered as blood kin to you, Miss Xene."

It was Medon.

I looked at the number beside his name. I couldn't read numbers well, but I knew it was a large one. Far larger than Lytron's. Several times larger, it looked like.

"…At this size," Lytron said quietly, "it wouldn't even show. For him."

The administrator gave a small lift of the shoulders.

"…It wouldn't."

"…Then why hasn't anyone done it already?" I asked. "If it wouldn't even show."

The administrator looked at me. For the first time, something crossed that even face. I couldn't name it then.

"…Not showing is still not nothing," the administrator said. "Not in the direction of going down."

I didn't fully understand that at the time. I understand it now. Not showing means others don't see it — not that the person himself doesn't feel it. And a person knows the things others can't see.

I raised my hand.

"…What changes, if I'm entered?" I asked.

The administrator looked at me. He didn't seem surprised by the question.

"…Rations come regularly," he said. "You can apply for housing. You can hold a proper job. And" — a brief pause — "the Roll records you. Right now, the fact that you live here isn't recorded anywhere. Once you're entered, it is."

That caught at me strangely.

"…So right now, my living here isn't recorded anywhere?"

"…A person with zero standing isn't a subject of record," the administrator said. "The Roll doesn't note a birth. It doesn't note a death. It isn't that you're treated as not existing. There's simply no field to write you into."

Hearing that, I understood for the first time what registration actually meant. It wasn't a matter of rations or a place to live. It was whether the fact of my being here was preserved anywhere at all. I had been in this city more than two years by then, and inside the Roll, I was a person who existed nowhere.

. . .

The administrator said he would begin the procedure. Medon would be contacted.

For the first time, I felt something like hope. Relief, more precisely. If someone could do this without any loss at all, Lytron would no longer need to lower his own family standing further. I thought that was a good thing.

I looked over. Lytron's face wasn't relief.

"…What's wrong?" I asked.

"…Nothing," he said. "It's good news."

I believed him, when he said it. Thinking back on it now, what was on his face then wasn't relief but something else. I wouldn't learn what it was for several months.

. . .

Pikra stayed quiet even after hearing the news.

"…They've contacted Medon," I said, on the way home. "The administrator's started the procedure."

Pikra stopped walking.

"…All right," Pikra said. That was all.

"…What's wrong?"

Pikra looked at me for a long time. The evening light touched only half her face.

"…Nothing," Pikra said. "Let's just wait and see."

"…Is Medon a bad person?"

"…He isn't a bad person," Pikra said. She started walking again. "He never was."

The answer struck me as strange. Saying it twice felt like leaving something else unsaid.

"…Then why did the families split?" I asked.

Pikra slowed her steps.

"…His mother — Medon's mother — left our family," Pikra said. "After her husband died. She decided there was nothing to gain by staying. But she didn't go outside. She stayed in the same city. She only split from us."

"…Why?"

"…Because our family's standing was already bad by then," Pikra said. "One of my husband's brothers had already died. She didn't want her son tied to that number. She was a clever woman."

Something went cold in me at that.

"…So Medon's family ran from the bad blood."

"…You could say that," Pikra said. There was no resentment in her voice. Just the tone of someone stating a fact. "She was protecting her son. I might have done the same."

That stayed with me a long time. Pikra didn't resent the choice. I found that more unsettling, somehow — that there are choices in this world one cannot resent. And that the outcome of such a choice could reach all the way to me, decades later.

A person, protecting themselves, often can't see who falls because of it. Or perhaps they can, and simply don't look. I still can't tell the two apart.

I didn't understand then why Pikra was so cautious. I know now. Pikra knew Medon. His face, his voice, the way he chose his words. I didn't know him. Pikra did.

That difference decided the days that followed.

A few days later, an answer came. Medon would see us in person. He asked us to come to his office near the gate.

I couldn't sleep that night. Not the good kind of sleeplessness. It had been a long time since I'd lain awake for a good reason.

Pikra didn't so much as turn over beside me. I knew she was only pretending to sleep.

I didn't know then that it would be the last night I lay awake for a good reason.

. . .

That night, unable to sleep, I thought about my husband.

He had never once mentioned a cousin. I'd taken that for how little he spoke in general. He was the sort of person who said a thing once and let it lie for a long while before saying it again, so there was no particular reason a cousin should have been an exception.

I think differently now. Some silences aren't simply an absence of speech. Someone made them, deliberately. He may not have chosen not to speak of his cousin. He may have been unable to — if the family had already erased that story, long before.

I'd asked him once whether he had relatives in the city. He'd been quiet for a long while, and then said only this.

"…Even if I have one, it's as good as not having one."

I let it go at the time. It catches at me now. To say *even if I have one, it's as good as not having one* is to say you know he exists. That isn't something you say about a man who isn't there at all.

. . .

I went out to the field the next day, at midday, and he was in his usual spot.

I didn't glean much that day. My mind was elsewhere. He worked quietly beside me, and then looked at me once.

"…Something wrong?" he asked.

I was surprised. It was rare for him to ask first.

"…A relative on my mother-in-law's side has turned up," I said. "He might register me."

He nodded. No sign of surprise.

"…That's good news."

"…Then why can't I let myself feel easy about it?"

He paused, hands still.

"…That's how it is, waiting for something big," he said. "Waiting for something small is easy — if it doesn't come, that's the end of it. Waiting for something big, if it doesn't come, that's never the end of it."

I turned that over for a long time.

I didn't understand then why he spoke that way. I didn't know what he had ever waited for. I think now that he must have been waiting a very long time, for something.

. . .

The day Medon was contacted, Lytron didn't come to the field.

He didn't come the next day either. On the third day, when he reappeared, I didn't ask where he'd been. His face was the face of someone who had already come to know something.

"…I went to Medon's office," he said first.

"…What did he say?"

"…He'll meet with you," he said. "You and your mother-in-law."

Something in his tone struck me as wrong. It wasn't the tone of someone delivering good news.

"…And?"

"…Nothing," Lytron said, shaking his head. "See for yourself."

I should have asked more, then. I didn't. I think I wanted only to believe it would go well. A person, sensing that the answer they want is coming, asks fewer questions. I learned that for the first time that day.

. . .

I heard, later, how Lytron's father had taken the news.

His father had been glad. Very glad, apparently. A way had appeared to stop his son's family standing from falling any further — that was reason enough. He'd sent someone directly to the administrator, asking that Medon's side of the procedure be hurried along.

"…My father said something," Lytron told me a few days later. There was something held back in his voice. "That it was good news. That I could

finally stay out of this."

"…Why does that bother you?"

"…It's nothing," he said, shaking his head. "The words just sounded strange to me."

I couldn't name what was strange about it, then. His face wasn't relief. It was closer to a face holding something in.

I can name it now. His father had seen this, from beginning to end, purely as a matter of loss. His son had taken a loss; if a way existed to end it without further loss, that was that. That I was inside that way, that whether I was registered at all hung on it, had no place in his father's arithmetic. Whichever way the answer came out, I was an item that mattered very little to him.

Lytron was the one who had begun this from outside that arithmetic. I didn't know it then. I should have. I learned, very slowly, in that city, how to tell the people inside the arithmetic from the people outside it.

. . .

The morning we were to meet Medon, Pikra took my hand.

It wasn't something she usually did. Her hand was rough, the knuckles thick.

"…Xene."

"…Yes."

"…Whatever happens," Pikra said, "you're already mine. Whatever the Roll says."

I couldn't answer. My throat closed.

I took the words for comfort, that day. Thinking back, it wasn't comfort — it was a warning. Pikra already knew what Medon would say.

We walked toward the gate. It was the same road I had walked when I first entered this city, two years before. Then, I'd been on my way to be assessed for standing. This time, I was on my way to be registered.

It was strange that the two roads were the same road.

Pikra walked without speaking. I walked beside her, watching the office buildings near the gate grow larger as we approached. Medon's office was among the largest of them.

I remember exactly the moment I stood before that building. Before the door opened. Before any answer had been given. Up until that moment, I too had standing enough to hope. I know how strange it is to use that word this way. But that is exactly how it felt, in that moment.

(Continued in Chapter 38.)

Chapter 38. The Refusal

> *_Previously_ — A relative was found who could register Xene — far*
> *better positioned than Lytron to do it without cost. The husband's cousin, Medon. The morning we went to meet him, Pikra took Xene's hand*
> *and said, "You're already mine."*

Medon's office was clean.

Clean wasn't quite the word for it. There was no dust. I had never seen a room without dust before. Outside, a room was always something that came with dust attached.

He rose from his seat to greet us. Tall, well-dressed. Older than Lytron, younger-looking than the administrator.

"…Mrs. Pikra." His voice was gentle. "It's been a long time."

"…Medon."

That was all, from the two of them. No embrace, not even a hand taken. The distance between them struck me as strange. In the Roll they were close kin; in that room, they looked like two strangers meeting for the first time.

I didn't fully understand that distance then. I understand it now. I saw with my own eyes, in that room, how different the Roll's closeness is from a person's.

There were three chairs in the room. They'd known we were coming and set them out ahead of time. I took that for kindness. Thinking back now, it wasn't kindness — it was procedure. Set out three chairs for guests. That was all it was, a rule.

A painting hung on one wall. A field of ripe wheat leaning in the wind. I looked at it and thought, briefly, of our settlement's field. It never lay down that way, like a picture. It was always a little thin somewhere, patchy.

There was no corner in that painted field. I don't know whether the painter had simply not drawn it, or thought there was no need to. I couldn't take my eyes off that painting the whole time we were in the room. I learned later that it's the most common painting in this city. A field with no corner. No one finds that strange.

. . .

He offered us seats. We sat.

"…I've heard the situation," he said. "The administrator explained it in detail. You're Xene, correct?"

"…Yes."

He looked at me for a moment. Not an unkind look. Courteous, if anything. That made it stranger.

"…I understand the circumstances," he said. "It's an unfortunate situation."

The moment I heard that word, something felt wrong. Unfortunate is a word for something already over. I still believed, at that point, that

this thing hadn't ended yet.

"…And how have you been, Mrs. Pikra?" he asked. He didn't go straight to the matter at hand.

"…Getting by," Pikra said.

"…I heard about your husband. And your sons." His voice held something genuine. That confused me more. That a person could be genuinely sorry and do nothing at all — until then, I hadn't known such a person existed.

"…And your mother? Is she well," Pikra asked.

"…She passed away two years ago."

The room went quiet for a moment. I felt something old passing between the two of them. Twenty years, thirty years I knew nothing of, sitting in that room along with us.

. . .

He opened a screen and turned it toward us.

There was a number. His standing. I still couldn't tell, looking at it again, anything more than that it was large. Beside it, a smaller number — the amount required for transfer.

"…At this level," he said, pointing to the screen, "it's true that it would barely register for me. I checked."

My heart jumped at that.

"…Then—"

"…But I'm not going to do it," he said.

The room went quiet.

. . .

"…Why?" I asked. I felt I'd asked something I shouldn't have, and yet the word had come out first.

He looked at me. He didn't grow angry, didn't look uncomfortable. He answered in the same ordinary tone as before.

"…My score would be cut," he said.

I didn't understand the words. Hadn't he just said, himself, that it wouldn't even show?

"…You just said it wouldn't show—"

"…It wouldn't show," he said. "Not to anyone else. But being cut is being cut. I have never, not once, had my score go down. Not since I was born."

The words didn't sound like a boast, to my ear. His face wasn't the face of a man boasting. It was the face of a man stating a fact.

"…Why should I be the first case?" he asked. It seemed half addressed to me, half addressed to himself.

I had no answer then. I have none now. There was, in truth, no reason it had to be him. Nothing in the Roll required it of him. It was purely a door the system had left open, and opening it had never been anyone's obligation.

"…I don't understand," I said again. "If the amount is that small, why is this such a difficult conversation?"

Medon smiled, for the first time. Not a scornful smile. Just a bitter one.

"…It's difficult because it's small," he said. "If this were a request for my entire fortune, I'd have already refused and been done with it. This is small enough that no one could blame me for it. Which means I have no choice but to blame myself."

I felt I might understand that, and didn't want to.

"…Are you saying a small amount weighs more than a large one?" I asked.

"…No," he said. "The weight is the same. It's only that in front of a small amount, there's nowhere to hide. In front of a large amount, you can say it couldn't be helped. In front of a small one, that excuse doesn't hold."

I have never forgotten that answer. He knew exactly how thin the ice was that his refusal stood on. And knowing it, he stood on it anyway.

. . .

Pikra had said nothing this whole time. She looked at the screen, at Medon, back at the screen.

"…Your father," Pikra said, finally, "wouldn't have done this."

Something in Medon's face shifted, for the first time.

"…Mrs. Pikra," he said. "My father was a man who took losses. That's why our family ended up the way it did."

"…So that's why your mother split off."

"…Yes," he said. He wasn't ashamed of it. "I believe my mother was right. I don't live that way."

I felt something solid in that answer. A solidity that couldn't be argued with.

Pikra said nothing more. I understood, at that moment, completely, why she had been so careful these past several days. She had known Medon would say something like this. She had known his mother. And she had known the son took after her.

"…Your mother," Pikra said again, her voice gentler now, "was protecting you. I don't resent her for it. But you're not the one who needs protecting anymore. Your score is already large enough. Larger than large."

Medon lowered his eyes for a moment.

"…Do you know when 'large enough' gets decided?" he asked. "I don't. My father probably thought his was large enough once, too. Then he started taking losses, and it went down and never stopped."

"…That's a different matter."

"…You would think that, Mrs. Pikra," he said. "I don't. I was taught that protecting what you have is a habit it's never too late to start."

Hearing that, I understood he really wasn't a bad man. He was only living the way he'd been taught to live. It was only that what he'd been

taught and what I'd watched, for two years, pointed in completely opposite directions.

Medon closed the screen. He looked at each of us in turn.

"…I'll tell you one thing," he said. "I could have blocked this procedure entirely. If I'd asked the administrator. When the person with priority claim refuses, there are ways to delay how quickly it moves to the next in line. I didn't do that."

"…What difference does that make?" I asked. I don't think I expected the words to bring any comfort.

"…Maybe none," he said. "It only means I won't stand in the way. I can't do this myself. But someone else might."

I took those words, at the time, for one more excuse. I hear them a little differently now. He really hadn't locked that door — though he could have. It seems like nothing. It wasn't nothing. There are people in this world who could block a thing and don't, and people who never had the power to block it in the first place. I learned that day not to weigh those two the same.

As we rose to leave, Medon looked once more at the paperwork the administrator had given us. The standing-transfer procedure form. He studied it for a long moment.

"…The procedure itself is simple," he said. It sounded almost like he was speaking to himself. "One signature on the application, and it's done. The Roll calculates the rest. There isn't even a separate verification step."

"…Why does that sound strange, the way you say it?" I asked.

"…Because it is strange," he said. "That something this large ends in a procedure this small. I don't know what the person who built this was thinking."

I didn't understand those words then. I understand them now. He was, in that moment, already weighing exactly what he was refusing. How far apart the size of the procedure was from the size of the outcome — he had seen that before we had.

One signature. I remembered those words for a long time. I had no idea, then, that they would come back to stand in front of me a few days later.

. . .

"…Don't misunderstand me," Medon said. His voice softened again. "I don't dislike either of you. I'm sorry for this. Genuinely."

"…And yet you won't help," I said.

"…Helping and giving up what's mine are different things," he said. "I can help in other ways. I could add to your rations, if you need it. But my standing — that's mine. I've kept it my whole life."

What was hardest was that nothing he said was wrong. He didn't tell a single lie. He showed no hypocrisy. He was genuinely sorry, and genuinely wanted to help in other ways. Only one thing he wouldn't do — let his own number fall.

And the Roll found no fault in him. It couldn't. He had broken no law. He had simply stood in front of an open door and not walked through it.

The administrator, in a moment like this, would have stayed even. Medon wasn't even. He kept offering explanations, all the way until we left the room. That he'd send more rations if we needed it, that we should send someone if we ran short of fuel in winter, things like that.

I tried to take those words as kindness. If I hadn't tried, I think I would have been angry instead.

Looking back now, the rations and the fuel were real. He sent someone every winter after that, without fail. I don't want to dismiss that. He did exactly as much as he'd decided he could do. He simply never stepped one pace past that line.

Before we walked out the door, Pikra called to him once more.

"…Medon."

"…Yes."

"…I don't resent you," Pikra said. "But remember this. You did, today, what you believed was right. I know that. But right and —"

Pikra stopped. She never finished it.

"…Good?" Medon finished for her. He knew the word too.

"…Yes," Pikra said. "That."

Medon said nothing. His silence was his answer.

I remember that silence exactly, even now. He didn't argue. Not because he had no argument, I think, but because he didn't want to make one. Some people, told they were wrong, neither agree nor disagree — they simply listen. I think that, too, is a kind of honesty.

. . .

We left the room.

The sun outside was strong. I stood for a while, blinded.

"…Are you all right?" Pikra asked.

"…Yes." I lied.

We walked without speaking. Past the gate district, toward the field. Somewhere along that road, I stopped and asked.

"…You said standing transfer's been around a long time."

"…That's right," Pikra said.

"…And no one's ever used it," I said. "How many Medons must there be in this city?"

Pikra didn't answer.

That was the day I first saw the real shape of standing transfer. It wasn't a locked door. It was a door wide open. All it required was one thing — the will to give up what was yours. And that will was not something the system could manufacture.

Instead of going to the field, we passed through the market for a while. Pikra wasn't buying anything. I think she just needed somewhere to walk.

The market was as it always was. People buying wheat, buying cloth, children running. No one looked at us. Whatever had just happened to us, whatever words had passed between us in some office of this city, left no trace in that market.

That was strangely comforting, somehow. That the world doesn't stop just because I have. And at the same time it was the most frightening thing of all. That the world doesn't stop just because I have.

Pikra spoke suddenly, walking.

"…I always knew he'd grow into that." She wasn't pointing toward the market lane, but I knew she meant Medon.

"…How?"

"…He was quick with numbers, even as a child," Pikra said. "If someone gave him something, he took it. If he borrowed something, he paid it back. Exactly that much. No more, no less. I thought that was cleverness."

"…And now?"

Pikra stopped for a moment.

"…It is cleverness," Pikra said. "But I've learned it's a different thing from being a good person. I thought the two were the same. When I was young."

I turned that over many times. Being quick with numbers, and being good. Keeping the law, and being righteous. I kept seeing those pairs pull apart from each other in this city. The Roll was one of them.

A stall gave off a familiar smell. Roasted barley. I stopped in front of it for a moment.

"…Hungry?" Pikra asked.

"…No."

"…Then why'd you stop?"

I had no answer. The smell was simply familiar, and I'd stopped for it. Standing in front of something familiar felt like safety. That day, it was the only safety I had.

. . .

Lytron came out to the corner of the field that evening, once he heard the news.

I was standing there alone. Not really there to glean. Just there to have somewhere to sit.

"…How did it go?" he asked. His face already guessed the answer.

"…He won't do it."

Lytron nodded. He wasn't surprised.

"…Aren't you angry?" I asked. "You heard him in that room. It really would have cost him nothing."

"…I'm not angry," he said. After a while, he added, "What he said wasn't wrong, either. It's his. That's his."

Something caught at me in that. I felt I could almost tell why he was so quiet, and yet not quite.

I didn't know it then. What he was already thinking, in that moment. I despaired in front of Medon's door. Lytron was looking at something else. That another door was still open. His own.

. . .

That night, I told "him" what had happened. It wasn't the hour to still be at the field, and yet he was still there.

"…I was refused," I said.

"…I know," he said. He didn't say how. He sometimes already knew things no one had told him.

I sat down beside him. The field was darkening. Evening insects were singing.

"…I really thought, right up until today, that something would come of this," I said. "Not because I deserved it, but just because I'd come this far — I thought something would."

"…That's not a strange thing to think," he said.

"…But it didn't."

"…No," he said. He didn't try to console me. That, somehow, was the comfort.

"…He wasn't even a bad person," I said. "That's what makes it hardest. If he'd been bad, I could at least hate him."

He nodded.

"…A refusal you can't hate is the one that lasts longest," he said.

I almost asked what he meant, and didn't. He always spoke that way, and I always understood, only later.

"…So what do I do now?" I asked. I didn't know myself who the question was addressed to.

He didn't answer. He only gathered a few stalks from his hand and set them down beside me. A little less than I needed, as he always did.

I thought, that day, it was simply his habit. I think differently now. Maybe he wasn't refusing to give me an answer that day. Maybe he already knew the answer would come from somewhere else.

I got home late that night. Pikra was already lying down. I thought she was asleep, but her eyes opened when I came in.

"…You're late."

"…Yes."

"…Are you all right."

I lay down beside her instead of answering. After a long while, I said,

"…I'm going out tomorrow too. To the field."

Pikra made a sound of laughter in the dark. A silent one.

"…You're really something." There was something more behind those words that she never said aloud.

I didn't know it then. That within a few days, Lytron would already have made up his mind. I only thought about going to the field again the next day, and the day after that. It was the only way I knew.

(Continued in Chapter 39.)

Chapter 39. The Price

> *_Previously_ — Medon refused. Not because he was a bad man, but for one*
> *reason: "My score would be cut." The Roll found no fault in him. He had*
> *broken no law. That night, Lytron sat quietly with his own thoughts.*

For a long time, I thought the word *price* belonged only to things.

The price of a sack of wheat. The price of a goat. A number set against something you could hold in your hand. That people could have a price felt, to me, like counting a person as an object, and I never much liked the word for that reason.

But that summer, I learned the word again. Price wasn't only a thing's to carry. Some prices a person pays with their own two hands. And the moment of paying it, I found, could be astonishingly small.

Outside, paying a price was always visible. You gave wheat and received salt; you lent a hand and borrowed one back. What passed between people always passed from hand to hand. In the city it was different. A price moved inside a screen. The only thing your hand ever touched was the screen itself. And yet what moved inside that screen was never lighter than what moved from hand to hand.

This was the hardest chapter to write. The largest thing in this book happens here, and yet what actually happened was so small that a few lines hold all of it. I decided to leave it that small. Not to swell it.

Mena told me once that the thing a recorder must guard against most isn't writing a small thing large. It's writing a large thing small. A large thing tends, by its nature, to look small, and it is easy to be fooled by that smallness and miss its true size.

I kept remembering that, writing this chapter. What is recorded here really was very small. And knowing that smallness was no lie, I still had to write it so the reader would never forget how large it truly was.

. . .

I learned only later that it took Lytron three days to reach his decision.

He'd begun calculating, he told me, the night he left Medon's office. His own family standing, the registration threshold, the distance between them. He couldn't say exactly how many times he ran the numbers again.

"…At first I thought half would be enough," he told me later. "It won't clear the threshold with half. It has to be the whole thing."

"…And if it's the whole thing?"

"…My family standing drops one full tier," he said, "from where it is now." His voice was even, but I only learned later how much effort had gone into that evenness.

. . .

Lytron came to our house three days after he'd met Medon.

He stood at the door for a long time without speaking. I knew, just from his face, that he'd come with something already decided.

"…Come in," Pikra said.

He stayed where he was and spoke.

"…I'll do it."

I didn't understand at first what he meant.

"…The standing transfer," he said. "I'll give mine to Miss Xene."

. . .

Pikra reacted first.

"…Your family standing's already fallen once," Pikra said. "If you cut it further—"

"…I know," he said. "I'll do it anyway."

"…How much does it come to?"

"…I've calculated it," he said. "It's enough. Enough to bring Miss Xene above the registration threshold."

I knew, that moment, I should say something, and no words came. Not because my throat had closed, but because I truly did not know what to say. *Thank you* seemed far too small a thing to say. *No, don't* seemed far too cold. I found nothing that stood between them.

"…Why," was all I managed.

Lytron looked at me. There was nothing of resolve in his face, nothing of heroism. He only looked tired.

"…I'll tell you the reason later," he said. "Right now I just want to do it."

I would hear that reason later. Many times, in many ways. But even now, I think what he said that day — I just want to do it, right now — was the truest answer of all. A great decision sometimes arrives before its reasons do.

Pikra asked again.

"…Have you told your parents?"

"…No," Lytron said.

"…You should tell them first."

"…If I tell them, they'll stop me," he said. "So I haven't."

Something went cold in me at that. He had already decided to cross some bridge with his family. In the direction there was no going back from.

"…They'll have things to say, later," Pikra said.

"…I know," he said. "But if I don't do it now, I don't think I ever will."

I've never forgotten those words, even all these years later. He knew exactly what kind of person he was. That if you don't act on a resolve the moment you feel it, that resolve doesn't come again. Everyone is given a handful of such windows, in their life. Most people don't see them standing open until they've already passed.

. . .

We went to the administrator's office the next day.

The administrator received us. Even as always. Lytron stated his purpose, and the administrator showed no surprise.

"…I'll confirm this," the administrator said. "You wish to transfer your own standing, of your own will, to Miss Xene."

"…Yes."

The administrator tapped the screen a few times. I watched his fingers move — neither slow nor fast.

"…The application is prepared," the administrator said. "Read it, and sign if you're satisfied."

That was all.

. . .

I looked at the application. A single sheet of paper. Few words on it. The one transferring. The one receiving. The amount transferred. A signature line below.

"…Is that all?" I asked. The words came out of me before I meant them to.

The administrator looked at me.

"…That's all there is, procedurally," the administrator said. "There's no reason for it to be complicated. The Roll already knows each person's

value precisely. A transfer is only a reallocation of that value."

"…No one checks it? There's no approval process—"

"…Why would approval be needed?" the administrator asked, in return. "This is a person using what is theirs to use."

Those words stayed with me. Using what is one's own to use. The Roll had never had any logic by which to prevent it. This wasn't breaking a rule. It was a rule that had permitted this from the beginning. It was only that no one had ever used it.

"…I'm curious about something," I asked the administrator. "How long has this procedure existed?"

The administrator checked the screen for a moment.

"…It's existed since the Roll was first established," the administrator said. "It's an older provision than this city's entire Roll system."

"…Then why has no one—"

"…I don't know the reason myself," the administrator said. For the first time, something like hesitation crept into his voice. "May I offer my own opinion?"

"…Please."

"…A person who gives up what is theirs doesn't boast of it," the administrator said. "And a person who doesn't give up what is theirs has no reason to even know this procedure exists. So the procedure was never going to be widely known. No one has used it, so there's no story to tell about it, and with no story, the next person never learns of it either."

"…May I ask one more thing?" I said.

"…Yes."

"…If the first person to use this procedure used it with bad intent — what would happen? Forcing it on someone, for instance."

The administrator thought for a moment.

"…A transfer is only completed by the giving party's signature," the administrator said. "The receiving party's consent isn't required. In that sense, yes, it could be abused. Someone forcing their low standing onto another person, for instance."

"…Has that happened?"

"…No," the administrator said. "In a world where no one is willing to give up what's theirs, there's not much reason to force anything onto anyone else, either. Taking something from someone starts, in the end, from wanting to gain something. This is a losing procedure, not a gaining one."

That explanation sounded, strangely, sad to me.

Good things come from the hands of people who don't boast, and so they never pass on to the next person. Bad things spread easily precisely because no one bothers to hide them. I saw that imbalance for the first time that day. And I would learn, much later, that it isn't only found in this city.

. . .

Lytron stood before the signature line.

I remember that moment exactly, even now. No special instrument, no ceremony. He simply touched his finger to the signature line on the screen — the same way he always did to collect a ration, or leave a record at a gate.

"…Wait," I said.

He stopped his hand and looked at me.

"…Are you sure about this?" I asked. "You said it can't be undone."

"…It can't be undone," the administrator answered, in his place. "A transferred value is not returned."

Lytron looked at me and smiled. It had been a long time since I'd seen that smile.

"…I'm sure," he said.

And he touched his finger to the screen again.

I found myself holding my breath, without meaning to. It was a very short moment. The screen flickered once, then returned to itself.

That was all.

I had expected something more. A confirmation screen, perhaps, or a second prompt asking again. There was none. Only a small word, printed above the application: *Processed.*

. . .

The numbers on the screen changed.

His number went down. Mine went up. That was all. No sound. No light flickered. The screen only showed two new numbers.

I'd expected something grand to happen, in that moment. Nothing did. The air in the room was the same. The sounds outside the window were the same. The administrator was already paging to the next screen.

That quiet was the strangest part of all. That the moment a person set down a number they'd carried their whole life could pass as though it were nothing at all. I understand it now. That's the true face of a price. A price always looks small, in the moment it's paid. You only see how large it truly was later, looking at what's left in its place.

The administrator turned the screen toward us. Two numbers side by side. One that had gone down, one that had gone up.

I looked for a long time at the number now beside my name. It was the first number I'd had beside my name in sixteen years of living. Not zero.

"…Is this mine?" I asked. I knew how foolish the question sounded, and asked it anyway.

"…It's yours, Miss Xene," the administrator said.

Lytron wasn't looking at the screen. He was looking out the window.

I wanted to ask why he wasn't looking. I didn't ask. Some moments, I have learned from this family, are not meant to be asked about.

. . .

There was someone else in the office besides us. Someone in the corner, there on other business, waiting their turn. That person never once looked our way. Theirs was the face of someone only waiting for their own name to be called.

That, strangely, stayed with me. That a moment when one person's life was being changed was, to the person sitting right beside it, nothing more than the background of their own waiting. That's how the world is made. Some moments are enormous only to the person inside them, and nothing at all to anyone standing a single step away.

The administrator gathered his papers as he spoke.

"…Your registration will be completed today," the administrator said, turning to me. "Congratulations."

I have never heard the word *congratulations* land so heavily.

The administrator turned next to Lytron.

"…Your side requires processing as well," the administrator said. "The family standing reassessment. It will be reflected at the next scheduled renewal."

"…Understood," Lytron said.

"…Would you like to reconsider—"

"…No," he said. Fast. Firm. The administrator didn't ask again.

I learned later that the brief exchange was the administrator's own kind of consideration. It was a question he was required, by procedure, to ask once, and he closed it quickly, as a formality, to spare him. It was his own way of being kind.

I looked at Lytron. He was already looking elsewhere. Out the window.

"…Are you all right?" I asked again.

"…Yes," he said. Short. As though he didn't want to say more.

I didn't press him further then. Later, I asked him many times what he'd been thinking in that moment. He gave a different answer every time. I think that means he still hasn't found the exact answer himself.

. . .

Lytron's father heard the news that evening.

I never saw the scene myself. Lytron never described it in detail, either. All he said, a few days later, was this.

"…My father didn't say anything at all."

"…He wasn't angry?"

"…I would rather he'd been angry," he said. "Saying nothing at all is more frightening."

I understood what he meant. I already knew, myself, that some silences weigh heavier than any anger.

"…Do you regret it?" I asked.

Lytron thought for a long while.

"…No," he said. "But I am afraid. I only found out this time that the two things can exist together."

No regret, and afraid. I didn't fully understand what that meant then. I understand it now. Being the right choice doesn't mean it isn't frightening. Sometimes it's precisely the rightest choice that's the most frightening one — because there's no way back to where you were.

I couldn't sleep that night and went out and sat outside. I looked up at the sky. The same sky I used to watch from the outer settlement. The stars were in their same places.

That was the first time I truly felt how the sky over the city and the sky over the outside were the same sky. The Roll had completely remade the way a person was counted, and the sky hadn't changed at all. There are some things that don't change, no matter how great a price passes beneath them.

Pikra came out and sat beside me.

"…Awake?"

"…Yes."

"…Me too," Pikra said.

We sat a long while without speaking. Then Pikra said,

"…What do you think your husband would have said."

I had no answer for that. I truly didn't know what he would have said. But I thought I knew one thing.

"…I think he would have said not to be sorry for what's spilled," I said. "That what's spilled is left behind."

Pikra nodded. She said nothing more.

. . .

Outside, the sun was strong.

The three of us stood for a moment without speaking. What had just happened inside that office already felt like something far away, out here.

Pikra took hold of Lytron's arm for a moment. She said nothing. She just held it, and let it go.

"…I don't know if 'thank you' is the right thing to say," Pikra said, finally. "I don't even know if that's the right word for this."

"…You can just say that," Lytron said.

"…No," Pikra said. "This isn't a thing that thanks can settle. I know that. That's why I don't know what to say."

Lytron smiled a little.

"…Then leave it," he said. "It's all right if it doesn't come out right."

I've never forgotten that exchange. Pikra was never, in her life, a woman who was careful with words. That day, she couldn't find the right ones. Some things simply can't be priced in words. Gratitude, apology — both grow small in front of a thing like this.

"…Can I ask you something?" I said to Lytron.

"…Yes."

"…That signature, just now — how many seconds did it take?"

Lytron looked at me. He didn't seem to think the question strange.

"…A few seconds," he said. "I couldn't say exactly. It was short."

"…That something that short could be something this large — I still find that strange."

Lytron smiled a little. A different smile than before.

"…So do I," he said.

I meant to end this chapter here. But I'll add one more thing.

I told "him" the story that night, too. He was alone at the corner of the field. Quietly working, as always.

"…Lytron transferred his standing to me," I said.

He stopped his hands. He looked at me for a long time. Something crossed his face — not surprise, I felt. More the face of someone who had waited a long time for something.

"…I see," he said.

"…Did you know? That this would happen?"

"…I didn't know," he said. "But I hoped for it."

The words struck me strangely. He had always seemed a man who hoped for nothing at all.

"…What were you hoping for?"

He began moving his hands again.

"…For there to be someone who knows how to give up what's theirs," he said. "In this city, too."

I let that answer pass by that night. Reading it again now, there was a weight in those words that reached beyond this one city. I wouldn't understand that until much later.

Even years after, I keep returning to this scene. The Roll broke no law that day. Neither did the administrator, nor Medon, nor Lytron. Each of them moved only as far as they were permitted. Medon refused as far as he was permitted to refuse. Lytron gave as far as he was permitted to give. The Roll received both, equally, in the same silence.

I think that is this city's truest face. The Roll compels no one. It only leaves the door open, and leaves it entirely to the person whether to walk through it. And in front of that door, some people walk in and some don't. The Roll does not weigh that difference. A person does.

I mean to end this chapter here, truly. One signature. A few seconds. That was all of it. And that it was all of it is the heaviest thing I learned from this whole book.

(Continued in Chapter 40.)

Chapter 40. Going Down

> *_Previously_ — Lytron transferred his standing to Xene. The procedure*
> *was one signature, a few seconds. The numbers changed on the screen —*
> *that was all, quiet as though nothing had happened. "He" heard the news*
> *and said he had "hoped" for it.*

I had only ever known the word *going down* from the field.

A stalk goes down. Grain goes down. Wheat leans one way when the wind blows. I didn't hear that word used for a person until I came to this city. A score goes down. A family goes down.

I thought those two kinds of going down were different. Wheat goes down and stands up again, once the wind stops. I learned, that autumn, that this was wrong. A person's going down doesn't stand back up just because the wind stops.

I can't write this chapter through Lytron's eyes. I was never inside him. I only set down what I saw from the outside. What he lost, only someone watching him from outside could count precisely. The one who loses rarely knows, at first, exactly what they've lost. I learned that too, that autumn.

When I entered this city with zero standing, I didn't know precisely what I had lost. There was simply nothing. Never having a thing from the start and having a thing and then losing it are different. Lytron was the

second kind. So he had to feel the size of what he'd lost, new, every single moment. I never had to. I had no *before* to compare against.

. . .

For the first few days, nothing seemed to have changed.

Lytron still went to the Harvest management office. Still sat in the same seat. I thought he was fine.

But the way people treated him was shifting, little by little. It began with the smallest things. The order of greetings changed. Where people used to bow their heads first when he passed, now sometimes he had to bow first.

"…It's nothing," he told me. He said it before I'd even asked. "I'll get used to it."

I wanted to believe that. I would learn later that nothing* was, in fact, something.*

. . .

Pikra noticed the change before I did.

"…Doesn't he seem different lately?" Pikra said, one day.

"…He seems tired."

"…No, not that," Pikra said. "His walk's changed. Before, he walked like a man who decided where he was going before anyone else did. These days he walks like he's watching people's eyes."

I hadn't noticed it. Once she said it, I looked again, and it was true.

"…Is that a bad thing?" I asked.

Pikra thought for a moment.

"…Not bad," Pikra said. "But it's unfamiliar to him. Anything unfamiliar is hard, at first."

I turned Pikra's words over for a long time. Watching people's eyes. I had known that since I was born. Which door to knock on for food, which look meant a bad mood that day. Lytron was only now beginning to learn that language.

. . .

About a week later, I saw him standing in a line outside the office.

A line for confirming rations. He'd never had to stand in a line like this before. His family name alone used to be enough to have things processed on the spot.

Not anymore.

He waited his turn like everyone else. When the person ahead moved slowly, he simply stood and waited. He didn't grow impatient. That struck me as stranger than if he had. He should have been angry. He simply stood there.

"…First time in a line?" I asked, coming up beside him.

He looked at me and smiled. A bitter smile.

"…Not the first," he said. "But this time is a little different."

"…How?"

"…Before, I could have stood in a line. I didn't have to, but I could have, if I wanted. Now I have to stand in it."

I thought I understood the difference. Doing something because you could choose to, and doing it because you had no choice.

What he learned in that line, I think, I had already known, probably since I was born. Not a line you stand in because you want to, but a line you must stand in. I already knew what that was. He was only now beginning to learn it.

. . .

His seat at the Harvest management office had changed too.

Before, it had been by the window, a good seat. Now it had been moved inward. No one had ordered it moved. Seats were simply arranged by tier. The rearrangement had just, naturally, sorted him into his proper place.

"…Who told you to move?" I asked.

"…No one," he said. "Seating goes by rank. It always did. I just never had to notice it. When my rank was high, there was nothing to notice."

Something important was in those words. The Roll's order had always been there. Lytron had lived on top of that order his whole life without ever seeing it. Order is invisible from above. You have to come down to see it.

. . .

One of his colleagues had never spoken to him first before. It had always been Lytron who opened a conversation. That was rank.

Now that colleague spoke first.

"…Are you all right?" the colleague had asked, he told me later.

"…What do you mean?" he'd said back.

"…No, nothing," the colleague said. And smiled, awkwardly.

Lytron told me the moment had been strangely difficult.

"…I understood, for the first time, what it feels like to be pitied," he told me. "I never knew, my whole life."

I said nothing to that. I couldn't. I knew that feeling very well. I only didn't want to hand him that knowledge in that particular moment.

That was the first time I felt he and I were looking at the same thing, from some place. The place he had come down to and the place I had always stood weren't identical, but they were, for the first time, close enough to see each other.

. . .

Something had changed at the market too.

There was a stall he always went to. The owner used to smile and pick out the best of whatever he had. He'd cut the price, more than once, I heard later.

I happened to pass that stall one day and ran into Lytron there. The owner still recognized him, still greeted him. But he no longer offered

his hand first. He simply watched Lytron choose, until Lytron had paid the full price.

"…It never used to be like this," he said quietly, coming out of the stall. It sounded less like something said to me than said to himself.

"…What do you mean?"

"…He took the full price," he said. "That's the first time I've paid full price at that stall."

I didn't know what to say to that. It wasn't unjust. It was, in fact, exactly correct. He had simply paid the price of the thing.

I searched his face, that moment, for any sign of resentment. There was none. He wasn't resentful. He was only bewildered. It was the face of a man in the moment when something that had been ordinary his whole life suddenly wasn't ordinary anymore. I already knew that face. I had worn it myself, my first days in this city.

"…It's a strange thing to say," he said, "but I don't dislike that man for it. He's just doing what's ordinary. I was the strange one. I lived my whole life thinking something that wasn't ordinary was ordinary."

I thought that was the most exact thing he'd said in all these weeks.

. . .

What changed most was his house.

Lytron's father, from then on, hardly spoke to him at all. Not angry, not scolding. Only what was needed, said and no more.

"…Do you still eat together?" I asked.

"…Yes," he said. "But no one says anything. You just hear the dishes."

"…That must be hard."

"…Yes," he admitted, plainly. "Much harder than I expected."

I understood, for the first time, that what Lytron had lost wasn't only a number. He had lost some place in his own father, too. A price isn't only ever counted one way. There are prices the Roll never registers.

. . .

One day, out at the field, I saw him at the ration office, requesting something. Borrowing the key to a grain storehouse. Once, his name alone would have gotten it handed to him instantly.

The clerk asked for paperwork.

"…I'm sorry," the clerk said. "There's a verification requirement now."

Lytron stood there while the paperwork was prepared. A few minutes. It must have felt long, to him.

I watched from a short distance away. There was no irritation on his face, no anger. Only the face of someone encountering something unfamiliar for the first time.

I remember that moment exactly. He was standing, for the first time in his life, in a place where he could demand nothing. A place where there was nothing to do but wait. I knew that place very well. I had stood there since I was born.

. . .

Around then there was a gathering he wasn't invited to.

A summer gathering the young of certain families held every year. It had no name; people just called it "the gathering." I only heard of it later. Lytron never told me himself.

"…You didn't go this year?" I asked, after hearing of it from someone else.

"…No invitation came," he said. It wasn't the face of a man pretending not to care. It was the face of a man trying very hard not to.

"…Did they leave you out on purpose?"

"…I don't know," he said. "Whether someone left me out on purpose, or whether the list is just automatically sorted by rank and I fell below it. There's no one to ask."

The words there's no one to ask* stayed with me a long time. The Lytron of before would have made somewhere to ask. His name itself was standing enough to ask. Now he had become someone who had to go looking for a place to ask at all.*

He smiled a little.

"…The strange thing is," he said, "I never even liked that gathering. Bored every time I went. And yet, being uninvited, I feel strangely hurt by it."

"…Losing something you never even liked."

"…Yes," he said. "I didn't expect I'd feel that either."

I learned something from that. Some things are worth nothing to you while you hold them, and only become a space the size of an absence once they're gone. Not because of the thing that was there. Because of the fact that the space is now empty.

. . .

A few days later, I watched him ask for something directly, for the first time.

He'd asked the office to let him see something ahead of schedule. The next season's ration schedule. It was a document he'd once have received the moment he asked for it. That had been the sort of seat his was.

"…I'm sorry," the clerk said. "That's released by rank, in order. Lytron's tier is released in three days."

"…Three days."

"…Yes."

"…Is there no exception," he asked. I felt, in that moment, that he hadn't yet fully shaken his old manner of speaking. Asking for an exception was itself proof that he still believed, somewhere, in a world where exceptions existed for him.

"…There are no exceptions," the clerk said. He looked apologetic, but nothing changed. "Those are the rules."

Lytron stood there a moment. He seemed about to say something more, and didn't.

"…Understood," he said. And turned away.

I watched his back. He wasn't angry. It was the walk of a man who knew there was no longer any place left for anger. That was the first moment I felt he was truly standing in the same line as me. The line where a request is not simply granted. I had lived my whole life in that line. He was only now standing at its entrance.

"…Are you all right?" I asked, catching up to him.

"…Yes," he said. He paused, then added, "But it's strange. I've never once, in my life, heard the word *no*. Not really. Whatever I asked for, it was always granted. If it couldn't be, there was always another way."

"…And now?"

"…Now *no* is just the end of it," he said. "There's no other way. Just wait three days."

I said nothing back. I only reached out and touched his sleeve for a moment, then let go. It was the only answer I had.

I remember those three days. Nothing extraordinary about them. He waited three days, and on the fourth he had his paperwork. That was all. And yet I think those three days were among the longest of his life. For the first time, he had to watch time pass without being on his side.

. . .

I shared some bread with him that evening. Baked from what I'd gleaned at the corner.

"…What's this for?" he asked. He looked puzzled.

"…No reason," I said. "You looked hungry."

He smiled. Not bitterly this time.

"…It's strange," he said. "Me receiving this."

"…What's strange about it?"

"…I used to be the one giving," he said. "I never knew receiving would feel so different."

I said nothing to that. I only sat beside him until he'd finished the bread.

That day, for the first time, I confirmed once more that there are things you cannot know without having stood in them. He'd watched me for more than two years. He'd felt sorry for me, and helped me. But not until he stood in the place of receiving something himself did he truly know.

I was probably the same. I still don't fully know what it's like for him to stand in the place of giving. I likely never will.

(Continued in Chapter 41.)

Chapter 41. Entered

> *_Previously_ — After Lytron's standing fell, the way people treated him*
> *shifted, little by little. The order of greetings. Where he sat. How he stood in line. For the first time in his life, he had to accept the word "no" and simply stand there with it.*

Someone came from the Roll office.

It was four days after the day of Lytron's signature. No one came in person. A small slip of paper arrived. A notice of completed registration, it said.

I took the paper and looked at it for a long time. My name was on it. Xene. Below it, a city Roll number. Below that, a date of registration. Below that, a standing score.

I still have this piece of paper. The color has faded and the corners have folded. I never threw it away. I couldn't.

. . .

Pikra looked at the paper and said nothing at first. She just took it from my hand, studied it for a long while, and handed it back.

"…We should go confirm it," Pikra said.

"…Confirm it?"

"…On the screen," Pikra said. "Not the paper. You have to see how the Roll itself has it written to know it's real."

That sounded strange to me. It was already written on the paper. I didn't understand why we'd need to look at a screen as well.

I know now. In this city, what was real was always on the screen's side. The paper was only a copy of what the screen said. It wasn't that the paper came first and the screen confirmed it after — the screen was the original, and the paper was its shadow. Pikra already knew that.

. . .

We went to the office.

The administrator received us. Even as always.

"…You've come to confirm the registration," he said. He already knew.

He tapped the screen and turned it toward us.

There was a name. Xene. Beside it, a number.

I looked at that number.

It wasn't zero.

. . .

I looked at that number for a long time.

It wasn't a large number. What Lytron had given wasn't the whole of his family standing — only enough to clear the registration threshold. The administrator had explained that already. "It's enough. Enough to bring Miss Xene above the registration threshold."

So this number wasn't a generous one. It was barely enough.

And still I looked at it for a long time. Whether it was generous or not didn't matter to me then. All that mattered was that it wasn't zero. I had lived sixteen years without ever once seeing a number beside my name that wasn't zero.

"…Would you like to see more?" the administrator asked.

"…Yes," I said.

I don't know how long I stood in front of that screen. The administrator didn't hurry me. Someone else must have been waiting, and he never showed a trace of it to me.

There was more on the screen. A field called history. I opened it and found my whole life summarized in a few lines. Place of birth, marriage, bereavement, migration. Four lines. Sixteen years, into four lines.

Looking at those four lines, I felt something strange. I should have been angry, and I wasn't. I thought, instead, that the shortness was honest. The Roll hadn't inflated my sixteen years. It had set them down exactly as they were, in four lines. The problem was only that the number beside those four lines carried a weight far heavier than the lines themselves.

My hand stopped at the third line. *Spouse — deceased,* it read. A date beside it. I knew that date. I knew it without needing to count.

"…Does this count too?" I asked. My voice shook a little.

The administrator looked at me for a moment.

"…It counts," he said quietly. "I'm sorry. This is how the Roll is built. It doesn't look at what a person went through. It looks at the value that experience left behind."

I felt, in that moment, that the man genuinely was sorry. And at the same time, I knew that sorrow changed nothing at all.

That was the day I saw, exactly, how the Roll reads grief. It doesn't read grief as grief. It reads it as value. I loved that man; that's why I called him my husband. The Roll called him by a single number. That love and that number were written side by side on the same line — that was the hardest thing to bear, that day.

. . .

Below the number were other fields.

Residency standing. Ration standing. Labor standing. Each marked *valid.* I read the word, one field at a time, without speaking it aloud.

I'd seen these fields before. At the gate. They had all read invalid* then. The administrator had explained it to me then, too. Not expulsion. Refusal to renew. No one was driving me out. Only, nothing was being given.*

The words hadn't sounded like comfort then. They sound a little different now. Between giving nothing and giving something, there is a

distance no words can fully hold. I saw that distance, with my own eyes, in front of this screen, for the first time.

"…What changes now?" I asked.

The administrator tapped the screen a few more times.

"…You can apply for housing," he said. "Until now you were listed under Miss Pikra. Now you can apply in your own name. Rations will come to you separately, too. There are jobs only registered people can apply for — you'll be able to see that list now, as well."

I didn't grasp, right away, what each of those things meant. I would come to know them, one by one, in my own body, later. I no longer had to stand behind Pikra in the ration line. There was a share now that came out under my own name. My name could be on the door of the house — I wasn't putting it there yet, but that it could be there at all made a difference.

I felt something strange, each time one of those things happened. I would be lying to say I wasn't happy. But there was something larger than happiness underneath it. I didn't know, then, exactly what it was. I know now. It was the feeling of owing something. I hadn't earned that number. I had received it. And what's received always carries the face of the one who gave it.

. . .

Before he closed the screen, I asked one more thing.

"…How long is this number valid for?"

"…The same as any other standing," the administrator said. "It's reassessed at the regular renewal. Except—"

He paused.

"…Except what?"

"…A transferred value is calculated a little differently," the administrator said. "It wasn't built up from your own history. How you live in this city from here on will matter more to how long this number holds than it would otherwise."

Something went cold in me at that.

"…So this is," I said, "a number I have to keep proving?"

The administrator looked at me. For the first time, something cautious crossed his face.

"…Honestly," he said, "yes. But that's true of every standing in this city. You're not uniquely disadvantaged."

I took that for comfort, at the time. I know now it wasn't comfort at all — it was simply a fact. The administrator hadn't meant to console me. He had only stated it precisely. Everyone in this city is always proving themselves. I had only known that since I was born. Lytron was only just learning it, that day.

. . .

We left the office.

Pikra was waiting outside for me.

"…How was it," Pikra asked.

"…It wasn't zero," I said. No other words came to me.

Pikra nodded. She neither smiled nor wept. She only took my hand once, and let it go.

"…Come on," Pikra said. "To the field."

"…Today too?"

"…I know you want to go out," Pikra said. "You don't have to, anymore."

I said nothing to that.

That day I went out to a field I no longer had to go out to. Before, I'd gone because I had to. From that day, I went because I wanted to. I couldn't have explained that difference in full, then. I still can't explain it completely, even now. I only know it appeared, very quietly, somewhere inside me.

. . .

Lytron was at the field.

He watched us approach and didn't come toward us. He just stood where he was. I knew he was keeping his distance on purpose.

"…Did you confirm it?" he asked first.

"…Yes."

"…Not zero?"

"…No," I said. "Not zero."

He nodded. It wasn't quite a smile, but very close to one.

"…Good," he said. That was all.

I felt something more should have followed that short word. He said nothing more. I asked nothing more either.

I understood only later why he hadn't come closer. He didn't want to show me what he'd lost, standing right in front of what I'd gained. On the day I received, he didn't want to bring what he'd given up along with him. I think that was a consideration all his own. One no one had asked of him.

"…This is strange," I said. I held it back and finally said it. "I should be happy today. My heart keeps turning wrong instead."

"…Why?"

"…You gave it," I said. "I received. You gave it. That keeps catching at me."

Lytron glanced toward the field for a moment.

"…Is that strange?" he asked, back. "I think it's the natural way of it, actually. Giving and receiving is supposed to be that — one gives, one receives. If both give, that's not giving and receiving anymore, that's —"

He stopped. He seemed unable to find the right word.

"…That's just standing still," he finished. "Neither one moving."

I felt I understood what he meant, and didn't fully. I understand a little more now. I think, that day, he wanted to tell me not to feel sorry for receiving. But he couldn't say it directly, and said it sideways instead. The moment was awkward for him too.

. . .

The next day, I went to the ration office alone for the first time.

Before, I'd always gone behind Pikra. I had no share of my own; we ate from what was given to her. That day I stood in line under my own name.

The clerk called my number. The call was unfamiliar enough that I answered a beat late.

"…Miss Xene," the clerk called again.

"…Yes." I answered, only then.

He entered my number into the screen. Checked something for a moment, then handed me a sack.

"…This season's share."

I took the sack. It wasn't heavy. But the weight in my hands felt strangely unfamiliar. I had always been the one sharing in what someone else received. This was the first time I'd received something with my own hands, under my own name.

I stood there a long time, holding that sack. There was someone in line behind me, and I still couldn't move. Someone nudged me lightly on the back before I came to myself.

"…I'm sorry," I said, stepping aside.

The clerk said nothing more. He didn't look at me specially, didn't look at me strangely. He simply called the next person.

I have never been so glad of anyone's indifference. I hadn't wanted the man to recognize me. I had only wanted to be treated the same way as everyone else. That day, for the first time, I was. Not specially at all.

On the way home I met "him." He was putting away his tools at the edge of the field.

"…I received something for the first time today," I said, holding up the sack a little. "In my own name."

He stopped his hands and looked at me.

"…How does it feel," he asked.

I thought for a moment.

"…Strange," I said. "Good, but strange."

"…Why strange?"

"…It's not because I did anything," I said. "I just received it. Someone paid for it instead."

He nodded. And went back to his work.

"…There are people who find it strange to receive," he said. "People who think it isn't real unless they earned it themselves."

"…Am I one of them?"

"…A little," he said. It didn't sound unkind, said with a smile.

"…Is it wrong to find it strange?"

"…Finding it strange and refusing it are different things," he said. "You can find it strange and still receive it. That's actually the most honest kind of receiving there is."

I didn't fully understand that, that day. I came to understand it, a little at a time, over the years that followed.

I remember that moment still. He didn't teach me something new that day. He only put into words something I had already been feeling. I think it was moments like that, stacked one on another, that led me to write this record.

. . .

That night, I took out the notice again.

Name, number, date, standing. That was all that was written on that one sheet of paper.

I felt, that night, how thin that paper truly was. A single sheet. And behind that thin sheet lay one signature, a few seconds, and a number a man had kept his whole life. I folded that paper and put it against my chest. From that day I carried it with me always.

Even now, years later, I still take it out sometimes. The color has faded further. The words remain. Name, number, date, standing. I know that not one of those four was made by me. My name was given by my parents; my number was set by the Roll; the date was only the day it happened to be; the number was given to me by someone else. There is

nothing of my own doing anywhere on this paper. I think this is the way this city let me in.

(Continued in Chapter 42.)

Chapter 42. Pikra's Answer

> *_Previously_ — My name went into the Roll. Not zero, anymore. For the*
> *first time I collected a ration in my own name, went out to the field in my own name. And in every one of those moments, the weight of what*
> *Lytron had given followed after me.*

It was about ten days after my registration.

In that time I had wanted, more than once, to call that name again. I never let it out. I felt, somehow, that I had no right to. While I was still zero, I hadn't felt I was in any position to give anything back to this household.

Looking back now, it was a strange logic. What did a name have to do with rights? And yet that was truly how I felt, at the time. That a person without standing couldn't demand anything, and couldn't give anything back, either. No one had taught me to think that way, and still, somehow, I'd already learned to think the way the Roll thinks.

Once I was registered, I thought it would finally be all right. I had a number now. I was someone who could give something now, too.

I brought it up with Pikra. Something I'd wanted to say for a long time. Something I hadn't felt I had the right to say, before I was registered.

"…I'm going to call you Glyke again."

Pikra set down what was in her hands. We were cleaning vegetables that evening. The sound of the knife against the board stopped.

"…What did you say?"

"…I have standing now too," I said. "I have a number. You don't have to be Pikra anymore. Not anymore."

I thought, saying it, that my heart would grow lighter. I thought it would feel like paying off a debt I'd carried a long time. I was wrong.

. . .

Pikra looked at me for a long time.

"…Who decided you get to decide that," Pikra said.

I didn't know what to say to that.

"…What do you mean?"

"…When I asked to be renamed," Pikra said, "it wasn't because of your number. It was because of mine."

I had no words.

"…Your being registered," Pikra said, "doesn't give me back what I lost."

I felt something ashamed at that. I had thought my registration was this whole household's recovery. It wasn't. It was mine. Pikra's place hadn't moved at all.

. . .

"…I'm sorry," I said. "I only meant—"

"…There's nothing to be sorry for," Pikra said. Her voice softened. "I know what you meant. I'm grateful, even. But there's something you still don't understand about this."

"…What."

Pikra picked up the knife again, then set it down again.

"…Do you know the last time I used the name Glyke," Pikra asked.

"…Before your husband passed."

"…That's right," Pikra said. "In those days I was someone who had things to give. I had a husband, two sons, two daughters-in-law who came to me. I was someone who could share something every day — food, clothes, a place at the table. Glyke was that person's name."

I listened quietly.

"…I'm not that person anymore," Pikra said. "I still don't have much to give. You being registered doesn't make me someone with something to give again. I'm still someone who has lost."

. . .

"…But," I said, carefully. "That hurts me."

"…What does."

"…Mother," I said, "you still make me see what's lost, every time I look at you. I don't want to see you only that way."

Pikra looked at me a long time.

"…Xene," Pikra said. "There's something you've misunderstood."

"…What."

"…I don't use this name to show what's lost," Pikra said. "It's the opposite."

I didn't understand what she meant.

. . .

Pikra went on, slowly.

"…If I were called Glyke again," Pikra said, "people would look at me and think — she's all right now. She's become a good person again. A smiling person again."

"…Why is that bad?"

"…It isn't bad," Pikra said. "But it isn't true. I'm not all right. I still have no husband, no sons, either of them. That fact doesn't change. Your being registered doesn't bring my husband back to life."

Something went cold in me at that.

"…The moment I'm called Glyke again," Pikra said, "people will forget that grief. That's how everyone thinks, once a name changes. Ah, it's over now. It's passed. I don't want that."

. . .

I sat quiet for a long while, then said,

"…So you'll go on being Pikra?"

"…Yes," Pikra said. Quite plainly.

"…For the rest of your life?"

"…Probably," Pikra said.

I thought that would be a sad answer. Pikra's face wasn't sad. It was, if anything, a face that had settled something.

"…The bitter didn't go away," Pikra said. "I just learned I could live with it still there."

. . .

I said nothing to that. I couldn't.

I thought, in that moment, of the day we left the outer settlement, long before. The day Pikra — she was still Glyke, then — first asked to be renamed. "Don't call me Glyke. Call me Pikra." I couldn't say the name at first. My tongue wouldn't shape it. It took weeks before it came naturally.

I had thought, at the time, that changing her name was only a mark of grief. A name changed to flee what she couldn't bear. Two years later, I know now that it wasn't flight. It was honesty. She had decided she would not pretend to still be someone who smiled. And now, even after things had gotten better, she had decided not to give that honesty up.

I turned that sentence over all night. I had always thought recovery meant returning to how things were. A sick person healing. A lost thing found again. What was bitter turning sweet again. Pikra wasn't talking about that kind of recovery.

"…So how does Mother," I asked, carefully, "live now, still bitter?"

Pikra smiled a little. A smile I hadn't seen in a while. It resembled the old Glyke's smile, and wasn't quite the same.

"…I live knowing it's bitter," Pikra said. "Before, I didn't know it was bitter. I thought having a husband and sons meant everything was sweet. Now I know. Sweet turns bitter, too, in time. But bitter isn't only bitter, either."

"…What do you mean?"

"…You," Pikra said. Just that.

. . .

Something caught in my throat at that one word.

"…Me?"

"…You followed me," Pikra said. "I told you three times to go back. You didn't go. I think that's a sweet thing. One sweet thing inside a bitter life. Not bitter turning sweet. A sweet thing, inside the bitter."

I didn't fully understand what that meant until much later. Pikra had decided, by not changing her name, to neither reduce nor enlarge her grief, but to simply carry it as it was. She was telling me, that day, that other things could live alongside that grief.

. . .

I looked down at the vegetables on the board. My hands started moving on their own again. My mind was still on that sentence.

"…So," I asked again, "I'm not supposed to call you Glyke."

"…No," Pikra said. Firm.

"…I should keep calling you Pikra?"

"…Yes," Pikra said. And picked up the knife again.

"…Doesn't it bother you?" I asked.

Pikra spoke as she trimmed the vegetables.

"…Bothering and being wrong are different things," Pikra said. "Your being registered is right. My staying Pikra is right, too. Both are right. One doesn't cancel the other."

. . .

. . .

A few days later, I got the name wrong, in the market.

A stall owner had asked Pikra's name. I said, out of habit, "Glyke—" and stopped. The owner gave me a strange look.

"…Pikra," I corrected quickly.

Pikra said nothing. But I saw her shoulders stiffen for a moment.

I apologized on the way home.

"…I'm sorry. It just came out."

"…It's fine," Pikra said. Her voice sat lower than usual.

"…Are you angry?"

"…No," Pikra said. After a moment, she added, "But it frightens me a little, that the name still comes that easily."

"…Why?"

"…As much as you want to call me that name," Pikra said, "there are times I want to live under it too. But I shouldn't. I hold that back every time. You slipped once. I hold it back every single day."

I had no answer for that.

That was the first time I saw that the decision hadn't been easy for Pikra, either. I had thought she'd finished making that decision, long before. I was wrong. She was making it again, every single day.

. . .

A neighbor woman stopped by that evening.

Someone she'd known a long time, she said. Seeing Pikra, she spoke warmly.

"…You've been looking well lately, Pikra. Your daughter-in-law's registered too, I hear. Couldn't you go back to your old name now?"

Pikra smiled a little.

"…Why should I?" Pikra asked back.

"…Something good's finally happened," the neighbor said. "No need to keep hold of a bad name."

"…It isn't a bad name," Pikra said. "It's the name I chose."

The neighbor looked a little taken aback at that. She didn't press further, and turned to other things — a rumor the ration schedule was changing, someone's leaking roof — and Pikra's name scattered off into the air like that.

I've kept that brief exchange a long time. People saw the name Pikra as a mark of misfortune. A garment to be shed, they thought. Pikra herself wore it not as a garment but as her own face. Not many people in this city knew the difference.

. . .

That evening, I asked something I'd been curious about.

"…What does my name mean?" I asked. "Does Mother know?"

Pikra stopped her hands.

"…I don't know," Pikra said. "Your name was given by your own family, not by me."

"…And Mother's name? Glyke?"

Pikra thought for a moment.

"…I heard it's an old word. I don't know exactly, myself," Pikra said. "Mena would probably know. She knows things like that."

"…Mena?"

"…She's a recorder," Pikra said. "People like that know the roots of words. I never asked her. I didn't want to know."

"…Why?"

Pikra looked at me.

"…Once you know the meaning," Pikra said, "you hear the name differently. I wanted to hear Glyke just as my own name. I was afraid that once I knew the meaning, the name would start sounding like it was asking something of me."

I thought I understood what she meant, and didn't fully.

I didn't know then that my name had a meaning too. And Lytron's. Nor that the moment those meanings would be revealed was still a few chapters away. Pikra's words, that day, were only something passing by. Later, they sounded like prophecy.

. . .

That night I lay down and took the notice out again.

Name, number, date, standing. I folded the paper away and thought. I was registered now. Not zero. And yet there was still someone in this house who had chosen to remain zero. By their own will.

That was the first time I dimly felt that standing wasn't only the number the city assigned me. Pikra carried a number inside her that was different from the one the Roll gave her. A number the Roll couldn't see. It was probably something beyond price.

I lay a long time that night, beside Pikra, without sleeping. She didn't seem to be sleeping either. We lay there like that, in the dark, each holding our own number. One was the number the Roll had given. The other was a number no one could ever assign.

In the dark, Pikra spoke once more. I'd thought she was asleep. She wasn't.

"…Xene."

"…Yes."

"…Thank you," Pikra said, "isn't for your being registered."

"…Then what is it for?"

"…For your going on calling me Pikra," Pikra said. "Except for just now. That one thing, I'm more grateful for than anything else."

I felt tears come at that. I tried not to make a sound.

"…Why is that the thing you're grateful for?" I finally managed.

"…Everyone in this city tells me to become Glyke again," Pikra said. "They all mean well by it. But no one ever asks why I don't. You did. And then you just accepted it."

I began, that night, listening to those words, to understand a little of what my place in this household was. I hadn't come here to save anyone. I was only someone who asked, and then accepted. That was all. And yet I felt, for the first time that night, that it hadn't only been that.

(Continued in Chapter 43.)

Chapter 43. The Corner

> *_Previously_ — I tried to call Pikra Glyke again. Pikra refused. "The*
> *bitter didn't go away. I just learned I could live with it still there." She had chosen, of her own will, to go on being Pikra.*

Lytron reset the loss rate before summer's end.

From 0.02 percent to 3 percent. Seen as a number, it was a small difference. The administrator once showed us that figure. "That's all it is," he said. Truly, that was all.

I heard that phrase — that's all it is — many times in this city. That's all a signature is, that's all a number is, that's all a loss rate is. I know now. The largest things in this city always hid behind the words that's all it is.

Once that number changed, the corner of the field changed.

. . .

The first day, I went out to the corner as always.

I didn't expect much, as always. It was habit. My body was simply used to going out. All I knew was that I'd come back with a few handfuls of trampled stalks.

That day was different.

There was grain in the corner. Real grain. Unbroken, standing on the stem, the ear full. Scattered here and there.

I stood a long time without moving.

I remember that moment exactly. What came before the surprise was suspicion. Had someone dropped it by accident. Had someone put it there to mock me. It took time before I believed the grain was real.

. . .

I bent down and picked one up.

It was real. The kernels were ripe, the stalk still alive. I held it in my hand and looked at it for a long time.

I filled a whole sack that day. The first time since the day it rained. That day, the machines had stopped. This time they hadn't. The machines still ran. The workers still moved as always. But somewhere in that motion, a gap had opened that hadn't been there before. A gap the size of one falling ear of grain.

I understood that difference exactly, then. The rain had been the sky's doing. This was a person's doing. Filling that sack, I knew that inside it was something someone had set down with their own hands.

. . .

I brought the sack home that night and spread it out and looked at it for a long while.

Pikra came and looked with me.

"…You gleaned a lot," Pikra said. She didn't sound surprised. She seemed to already know.

"…Something's changed," I said. "At the corner."

"…I'd heard," Pikra said. "Something about Lytron."

"…You knew?"

"…I guessed," Pikra said. "He's been strangely quiet since he gave up his standing. It was the quiet of someone with something left to do."

I was surprised at that. Pikra had noticed before I had.

I felt again, that moment, how much deeper Pikra's eye for reading people ran than mine. She had lived her whole life that way. Telling apart the one who has something to give from the one who has nothing left, the one still willing to give from the one who has already given everything. I still haven't fully learned that eye.

Word got around within a few days.

There was grain at the corner, the word went. No one believed it at first. Then a few came to check. Then more came.

I watched those people. People with low standing or none at all. The old, those with children, those whose bodies weren't strong. They came to the corner and gleaned.

I felt something strange, watching that scene. I had stood alone at that corner for a long time. Not anymore. I couldn't tell whether that meant my loneliness had ended, or my place had simply disappeared.

I once saw the administrator pass by the corner. He stopped and watched the people gleaning for a long while. I was nervous he might do

something about it.

He said nothing. He only watched, and then walked on.

I asked him about it later, when I ran into him at the office.

"…Why didn't you say anything, that day at the corner?"

The administrator thought for a moment.

"…There was nothing to say," he said. "Article 9 says a corner must be left. It doesn't specify how much. What Mr. Lytron changed in the settings wasn't a violation. His family standing paid the price for it. I have no place in that matter."

"…Doesn't it bother you," I asked, "that so many people are suddenly coming?"

"…Whether it bothers me is unrelated to my job," the administrator said. "My job is only to see whether the law is being kept. It's being kept."

I confirmed, once more, why he frightened me. He didn't judge by feeling. He didn't judge by good or bad. He judged only by whether the law was kept. And by that measure, he was always right.

. . .

An old man was gleaning beside me.

"…Used to be nothing here at all," he said, half to himself. "There's a bit, lately."

"…Yes," I said.

"…Someone must have changed something," he said. And asked no further. He didn't seem curious about the reason. It seemed enough for him just to know there was something to gather today.

I felt hurt by that indifference, at first. He didn't know what Lytron had paid. Didn't seem to think he needed to know. I think differently now. It was right, in fact. That was what the corner clause had always been. The giver's name was never meant to remain. Leviticus never said that either. It only said to leave it.

. . .

I no longer needed to go out to the corner.

My own ration came separately now. Registered as I was, I had a right to it. I was no longer someone who lived by gleaning at the bottom.

And still I kept going.

Pikra found it strange, at first.

"…You don't have to go anymore," Pikra said.

"…I know."

"…Then why do you go."

I couldn't answer right away. I didn't know the exact reason myself.

. . .

I carried the question with me for a few days.

One day I met "him" at the corner. He was still there. Among the other hired hands.

"…Why come out, when you don't have to anymore?" he asked. The same question as Pikra's.

"…I don't know," I said. "It's just familiar here."

"…Is that all?"

I thought a moment.

"…No," I said. "I don't want to forget what I was here."

He stopped his hands and looked at me.

"…What were you?" he asked.

"…Someone who was nothing," I said. "I only learned what that meant after I came here. I don't think I should forget it."

That was the first time I made that answer for myself. No one had taught it to me. I kept gleaning, even after being registered. Not out of need, but for some other reason. That day was the first time I put the reason into words.

. . .

He nodded.

"…That's a good reason," he said.

"…Why do you keep staying here?" I asked. A question I'd always wondered about.

He smiled a little. He didn't answer. He just started moving his hands again.

I let that silence pass by, back then, the way I always did. Now I find myself missing that silence, sometimes. I learned, being with him, that some questions carry farther left as questions than answered.

. . .

The corner stayed changed, from that autumn on.

Not fully generous. 3 percent was still a small number. Not enough to feed a whole family. But it was different from before. Before, it had been close to zero. Now it wasn't zero.

I think that difference is a large one. People often ask whether it can really matter that much. 0.02 percent to 3 percent. It might not look like a large number. But I can say this, having stood at that corner myself. Between having nothing at all and having a little, there is a distance no number can hold.

The administrator said nothing about the change. I understood why, later. The Roll had broken no law. The loss rate wasn't a value the Roll set — it was a value a person set. Lytron's resetting it hadn't been illegal. It had simply been a loss. His family standing took that loss exactly as it was.

I would confirm this fact again and again, throughout this book. The Roll never broke the law, not once. The corner clause had been there from the beginning. It had simply been designed so that nothing would be left there. What turned that design back wasn't the Roll — it was one person. And that person paid the price with his own body.

. . .

One day I saw Medon passing near the corner.

He stopped and watched the people gleaning. I tensed for a moment, afraid he might recognize us.

He found me. He didn't come closer. He only nodded slightly, from a distance. I nodded back.

I don't know what he was thinking in that moment. I never asked. I only remember that the time he stood there watching wasn't a short one. He must have seen, that day, for the first time, someone else walking through the door he had refused.

He walked on before long. He didn't look back.

I told Pikra about it that night.

"…I saw Medon. Near the corner."

Pikra said nothing for a moment.

"…He must know now too," Pikra said, finally. "What he didn't do."

"…Do you hate him?"

"…No," Pikra said. "I told him, that day, in that room. I don't resent you. That was true then, and it's true now."

Listening to that, I felt that what Pikra carried toward Medon was a little different from what I carried. I still felt some leftover disappointment, whenever I thought of him. Pikra didn't seem to. She had

already accepted, in the way of someone who has lived long, that right and good are not the same thing.

. . .

A few days later, I met a girl at the corner.

She looked a year or two younger than me. She didn't know how to glean and was struggling. She kept pulling the whole stalk and breaking it.

"…Try it like this," I said, coming closer to show her. "Leave the stalk. Just take the ear. Gently."

The girl copied what I did. She failed a few times, and then got the knack of it.

"…Thank you," the girl said.

I felt something strange, hearing that. Not long ago, I had been the one who knew nothing at this corner. Now I was the one showing someone else.

That day I found one more reason, the true reason I kept gleaning at this corner. I could stay here and show something to those who came, knowing nothing, just as I once had. That wasn't a place the Roll had given me. It was a place I'd found for myself.

. . .

As autumn deepened, more people came to the corner.

I didn't know most of their names. They didn't know mine either. We were only people who happened to bend down in the same place at the same

hour.

One day I saw a child among them. About eight years old. He'd found one ear of grain and was carrying it to show his mother. His mother stroked his head.

Watching that, I thought of Lytron. He didn't know that child. He never would. That child, too, would go his whole life never knowing where the grain in his hand had come from. That didn't sadden me. I thought, rather, that it was right. That the name of the one who paid the price doesn't remain — that was the oldest rule of the corner clause.

I told Lytron about that child that evening.

"…Did you see it?" he asked.

"…Yes."

"…That child doesn't know what I did," he said. Not in a hurt tone.

"…Do you want them to know?" I asked.

He thought for a moment.

"…No," he said. "I think it's right to leave it as it is. Not knowing."

I knew that answer came from the same place as the day he'd given up his standing. He had paid a price and still didn't want that price to be known. I had never seen that kind of mind before then.

That night I recalled the corner again. The day I first came and gathered a few handfuls of trampled stalks, and now, this day, when I filled a sack and went home. The same place. A completely different place.

I still remember these two corners side by side, even now. One where the law was kept exactly and nothing at all was left. The other where the law was kept just as exactly and something was left. The law didn't make that difference. The law was exactly the same in both corners. What made the difference was what one person decided to give up, from what was his.

I think that fact explains this whole city. The Roll didn't change. The regulations didn't change. Only one thing changed — a single person's choice. And that one thing changed a single corner into an entirely different place.

(Continued in Chapter 44.)

Chapter 44. What the Names Mean

> *_Previously_ — After the loss rate changed to 3 percent, grain began,*
> *for the first time, to be left at the corner. Those without standing gathered there. I no longer needed to glean, and kept going anyway.*
> *Pikra said she didn't know what my name meant, either. "Mena would*
> *probably know."*

It was a few days before Mena left.

I went to see her that day. Not for any particular reason. I knew she would soon be leaving this city, and I wanted to see her once more before she went.

She was in her room, sorting through papers. Months of records had piled up. I looked at that stack of paper and felt freshly surprised. I hadn't known she'd written so much.

The room was quiet. Late afternoon light came through the window. Only the sound of pages turning, now and then a sound of her setting one aside. I liked that sound. I hadn't sat in a room that quiet often, since coming to this city.

"…Getting ready to leave?" I asked.

"…Yes," Mena said. Her hands kept moving.

I sat beside her. For a long while I said nothing, just watched her sort the papers.

. . .

"…I wanted to ask you something," I said finally.

"…What is it."

"…My name," I said. "Pikra said you'd know the meaning."

Mena stopped her hands. She looked at me. There was something in that look. I couldn't have named it, then.

"…I know it," Mena said. "Why are you asking now?"

"…No reason," I said. "I was just curious."

Mena looked at me a moment longer, then set the papers aside.

"…Sit down," she said. "This is something to hear properly seated."

. . .

I settled myself.

"…Xene," Mena said. "This name comes from Greek. ξένη. *Xenē*."

"…What does it mean?"

"…Stranger," Mena said. "A foreigner. Someone who doesn't belong to this city."

I nodded, hearing that. It didn't surprise me. I really had been a stranger. I'd come from the outer settlement; I had never belonged to this city.

"…That sounds right," I said. "I really was a stranger."

Mena looked at me steadily.

"…But that isn't all of it," she said.

. . .

"…What do you mean, not all of it?"

"…The same word," Mena said, "carries another meaning, at the same time. Guest. That's what it means, too."

I didn't understand at first.

"…Stranger and guest at once? How can that be the same word?"

"…To people of the old world, it was the same word," Mena said, slowly. "When a stranger came to your door, there was an obligation to take them into your house without knowing who they were. They called it *xenia*. The taking-in of a traveler. It was a sacred obligation. You could not turn a stranger away, because—"

Mena paused for a moment.

"…Because a god might come to you in the shape of a traveler."

I sat a long while without a word, after hearing that. Mena didn't press. She seemed to know exactly how to hold a silence like that.

"…So those people," I finally managed, "weren't afraid of strangers, but careful with them? Was that because—"

"…Yes," Mena said. "Because you never knew. The one standing at your door might be nothing but a passing traveler. Or he might not be. There was no way to be sure. So they treated everyone the same way."

"…Wouldn't it have been easier to simply turn away anyone you couldn't be sure of?"

"…It would have," Mena said. "But those people chose not to live that way. Since there was no way to be sure, they chose to take everyone in instead. That's xenia."

. . .

I said nothing for a long while after hearing that.

I remember that moment exactly, even now. The air in the room, the smell of the paper, the way Mena's voice dropped a little lower. I couldn't move from where I sat.

"…So," Mena went on, "your name says two things at once. You were a stranger. Someone who didn't belong to this city. Someone with no standing. And at the same time—"

"…A guest," I managed. Barely.

"…Yes," Mena said. "Someone who must be received. Someone the receiver is obligated toward."

I couldn't speak for a long time.

. . .

I had lived sixteen years knowing this name only as my own name. I never knew it held the meaning of stranger. And once I knew, something struck me strangely. I had been a stranger from the very first day I arrived in this city. From the moment I was classified as zero standing at the gate. And that strangeness had, at the same time, been an obligation someone else owed — to receive me. I only learned that, that day.

"…Then," I asked, "the people who took me in — Pikra, Lytron, the administrator — was it obligation, for them?"

Mena shook her head.

"…For some it was obligation. For some it wasn't," Mena said. "Pikra was more than obligation. She took you in as family. Lytron —"

Mena thought for a moment.

"…Lytron is a different matter," she said.

. . .

"…What do you mean?"

Mena looked at me.

"…I'll tell you that name too, now," she said. "You'll need to know it eventually, and I think now is the time."

I held my breath.

"…Lytron," Mena said. "λύτρον. Greek."

"…What does it mean?"

"…The price paid to get someone back," Mena said. "Ransom, is another way it's translated. The price paid to buy back someone, or something."

. . .

I couldn't breathe, hearing that.

I couldn't say a single word, in that moment. Truly, not one. Mena didn't press me. She simply sat and waited.

I thought of how many times I had said his name. In the field, outside the office, on sleepless nights. Every time I said it, I'd thought I was simply saying a person's name. A sound. I never knew an answer had already been sitting inside that sound.

His name had already been saying, from the moment he was born, what he would go on to do. The price paid to get someone back. He had lived out his own name. Without ever knowing it himself.

. . .

"…Isn't that strange?" I finally managed. My voice cracked. "How can a name know something like that, in advance?"

Mena shook her head.

"…I don't know either," she said. "I'm not someone who explains things like that. I'm only someone who writes them down. But I can say this. I

knew these names before I ever came to this city. And over these past months, I watched them line up, exactly, with what actually happened here."

"…Is it a coincidence?"

Mena looked at me for a moment. She didn't answer.

I remember that silence exactly, even now. Mena wasn't someone who judged. She never told me it was a coincidence, and never told me it wasn't. She only left the fact where it was. The rest, I think, she left for me to see for myself.

. . .

"…Then why tell me now?" I asked. "You could have told me sooner."

Mena went back to sorting her papers as she spoke.

"…If you know the meaning first," she said, "you already know the ending before the thing happens. If you'd known, ahead of time, that Lytron would give up his standing, you wouldn't have been able to see that moment the way you saw it."

"…How do you mean?"

"…You'd have watched it as someone living up to their name," Mena said. "Like watching fate play itself out. I didn't want that for you. I wanted you to see that moment as a person actually choosing something. Not because a name told him to."

I had to sit a long while, turning that over.

I know it now. Mena hadn't hidden a prophecy from me. She had given me the chance to see a real choice. When Lytron signed that day, it wasn't his name leading him. He was living up to what his name meant. The order matters. I understand that order now, precisely.

. . .

I said nothing for a long while.

Mena didn't rush me. She just kept sorting papers. The room held only the sound of turning pages.

After a long while, I finally managed to ask.

"…My name too — did I live up to what it means?"

Mena stopped and looked at me.

"…Do you think you did?" she asked back.

I had no answer to that.

I still haven't fully answered that question, even these many years later. I was a stranger. And I was received. Both of those had been inside my name from the start. I don't know, even now, whether I made that happen, or whether I simply lived out what my name had always meant.

I know only one thing. I never heard my own name the same way again, after leaving Mena's room that day. Xene. A name that means stranger and guest, both at once. Every time I say it now, I hear both, at the same time.

. . .

I left Mena's room and went straight to the field.

The whole way there, I wondered whether to tell Lytron. It felt like it would be wrong to tell him. It also felt like it would be wrong not to.

He was tidying something near the corner. He looked up and saw me.

"…Something wrong?" he asked. He seemed to read it in my face at once.

"…I heard the meaning of my name, from Mena," I said. "My name, and—"

I stopped there.

"…Mine too?" he asked.

I nodded.

. . .

He was quiet for a moment.

"…What did she say?" he asked. His voice was quieter than usual.

"…The price paid to get someone back," I said. "Ransom."

Lytron stood a long time after hearing that. He didn't even set down what was in his hands. He just stayed frozen in that posture.

"…Did you know?" I asked.

"…No," he said. "I had no idea."

I studied his face. It was surprised, but not the kind of surprise I'd expected. Not fear, not the weight of a burden. Something quieter than that.

. . .

"…That's strange," he said, finally.

"…What is?"

"…I told you, that day I signed," he said, "that I'd tell you the reason later. Remember?"

"…Yes."

"…I still can't say the reason exactly, even now," he said. "I just wanted to, in that moment. That was all of it. But hearing that my name meant this, from the start—"

He stopped.

"…What is it," I asked.

"…I don't feel like I invented anything," he said. "I thought, that day, that I'd made some great decision. Now I wonder whether I just did, late, what my name had always meant to do."

. . .

I wanted to argue with that. I wanted to tell him his choice had been truly his, not just his name playing itself out.

"…That was still you," I said. "The name didn't sign for you."

Lytron looked at me. And smiled, a little, for the first time.

"…I suppose so," he said. "Is that what Mena said? That the name didn't make me do it?"

"…Yes. Something like that."

"…I think she's right," he said. "I didn't know my name. So the name couldn't have led me. I just lived the way I lived, and later on, it turned out the name had already been standing there."

I thought that was exactly right.

. . .

We stood together a while without speaking. An evening wind passed through the field.

"…Aren't you curious about my name's meaning too?" I asked. Meant as a joke.

"…I am," he said. Seriously.

I told him. Stranger and guest, at once.

He listened, and looked at me for a long time.

"…It suits you," he said.

"…What does?"

"…That you're a person living both those things at once," he said. "The first time I saw you, I just thought you were a stranger. I wondered why you kept coming out to a place with nothing in it. But now—"

He paused.

"…And now?"

"…Now you feel like the least strange person in this field," he said.

I laughed at that. It had been a long time since I'd laughed.

. . .

That night, back home, I told Pikra everything as well.

Pikra listened quietly. She was silent a long while, even after I'd finished.

"…I should have asked about Mother's name too," I said. "While I was with Mena."

"…Didn't you ask?"

"…You said you didn't want to know," I said.

Pikra smiled a little.

"…That's right, I did say that," Pikra said. "And I still feel the same way. I want to hear my own name just as my own name. I don't need to know what it means."

"…I was glad to know mine," I said. "Strange as that is."

"…You've always been that kind of child," Pikra said. "The kind who wants to know. Sometimes I like that about you, and sometimes it worries me."

I smiled a little at that.

"…And today?"

Pikra looked at me a long while before answering.

"…Today it's the good kind," Pikra said.

I lay awake late into that night. Xene. Stranger and guest. Lytron. The price paid to get someone back. I laid the two names side by side and thought. One was the name of a person being received. The other was the name of a person paying a price. I couldn't find an answer, that night, to whether the two names had met by chance or not. I still can't find it, now. I know only this. The two names really did meet. That isn't a meaning on a page. It's something I watched happen with my own eyes.

(Continued in Chapter 45.)

Chapter 45. The Standard

> *_Previously_ — Mena told me what the two names meant. Xene — stranger,*
> *and at the same time, guest. Lytron — the price paid to get someone*
> *back. I lay awake that night, unable to say whether the two names had*
> *met by chance.*

The administrator came to find me not long after that.

He had never come to us first before. We had always gone to him. I was briefly startled, seeing him standing at our door.

"…What brings you here?" I asked.

"…I have something to explain," he said. "Do you have a moment?"

. . .

We sat on the bench by the door. The scalding heat of summer had already taken a step back. The wood of the bench was cool to the touch, and a few persimmons were ripening red in the corner of the yard. Pikra came and sat with us.

"…Miss Xene's case," the administrator said, "has come to remain in the Roll as a record."

"…A record?"

His tone was, as always, the same. A voice reading off a document, nearly without inflection. There was something in that flatness that caught at me. What he was speaking of had been the heaviest season of my life, and the moment it left his mouth, it became a single entry.

"…Precedent would be the more precise word," the administrator said. "This is the first case in which the standing-transfer procedure was actually used. Since the founding of the Roll."

I didn't understand the words at first.

"…Why does that need to be explained to me?"

"…Because this case will now serve as a reference," he said. "If anyone else wishes to use this procedure, the office will now be able to show them this case. How the procedure actually proceeds. What paperwork is required. What happens after the transfer."

. . .

"…What am I supposed to do?" I asked.

"…Nothing," he said. "I only came to inform you. And this is also to ask your consent. Whether you agree to have this remain as a case record."

Something struck me strangely, hearing that.

"…And if I don't agree?"

"…The name can be withheld," the administrator said. "The case itself will remain, but your name won't be attached to it."

I thought for a moment.

"…The name can remain," I said.

. . .

Pikra looked at me.

"…Why?" Pikra asked.

I didn't have an answer ready. I needed to gather my thoughts.

"…I think," I said, slowly, "I don't want this to have happened to me alone. If someone else ends up in this same place someday, I think it's better if this exists."

The administrator looked at me steadily.

"…May I ask why?" he asked.

I thought a moment, then said,

"…Medon," I said. "He didn't do it. But maybe the next person who stands where he stood — because of me — might decide differently."

. . .

The administrator was quiet a moment, hearing that.

"…That's an interesting reason," he said. "The Roll wasn't designed that way. A case is kept for procedure's sake, not to persuade anyone."

"…Then it won't persuade anyone," I said.

"…Probably not," he said. "The Roll doesn't change a person's mind. It only shows a case. Whatever the person who sees it decides to do with it — that's theirs."

Those words stayed with me. The Roll, once again, promised me nothing. It only left a door a little easier to see. Whether to walk through it remained, still, entirely, each person's own.

. . .

A few days later I went to the office myself and looked at the record.

My case was summarized on the screen. Name, standing before the transfer, value received, the one who transferred it, the date processed. Below it, in small print: *First recorded use.*

I looked at that phrase for a long time.

The sentences on the screen were short and dry. A name, a number, a date. I thought of Mena, looking at them. She had told me once that a single line she'd written had traveled through other cities and come back meaning something entirely different. I'd thought, at the time, that was someone else's problem. Now my own name, too, had been reduced to a few words and set down on a screen. That those words might someday travel through other mouths, in other contexts, changed from what they were — for the first time, that thought frightened me.

I felt something strange, at that moment. A few months earlier, I hadn't even existed in the Roll. I didn't have a name. Now my name had become the Roll's standard. I know exactly what happened in between. I hadn't done anything remarkable. I had only gone out to the field every day, and someone had given up what was theirs.

. . .

The administrator showed me one more document.

"…This is still a draft," he said, "but we've drawn up a new information sheet on the standing-transfer procedure, based on this case. There was almost no guidance on it before."

I read the sheet. Procedure, required documents, expected outcome. At the bottom, one line read:

Reference: the Xene case (Registration, Chapter 41).

I laughed, reading that. I hadn't expected my story to end up as a footnote in an official document.

. . .

"…What will this change?" I asked the administrator.

"…I don't know," he said. "I'll be honest with you. I can't promise this procedure will see much use. There may well be more Medons than not."

"…Then why go to all this trouble? Making up an information sheet and all."

The administrator thought for a moment.

"…Because it's my job," he said. "I'm a man who keeps the law precisely. But if a door the law has left open sits unseen and untended, that's a failure on my part too, I think."

I was a little surprised by that. For the first time, I saw something human inside the administrator. He wasn't only a cold man. In his own way, within precision, he was doing his best.

. . .

About a month later, a stranger knocked at our door.

A woman. A few years older than me. Her clothes were worn, her face tired.

"…Are you Xene?" she asked.

"…Yes."

"…I'm sorry to bother you," she said. "I heard about you, at the office. That you'd had your standing transferred to you."

Something occurred to me at that.

. . .

I brought her inside. Pikra brought tea.

"…My mother-in-law," she said, "has low standing. I have a little more. I wondered if I could do what you did. But no one seemed to know how."

"…Did you go to the office?"

"…I did," she said. "They only said the procedure was complicated. Nothing more. Then I heard about you. The first case."

I felt something strange, hearing that. That my story had traveled all the way to someone's door — it still didn't feel real.

. . .

"…I'll tell you what I know," I said.

I explained what had happened, step by step. The application, the signature, the threshold. She wrote it down on paper.

"…But," I said, carefully, "you're giving up your own standing. It isn't an easy decision."

She nodded.

"…I know," she said. "That woman raised me. My husband lost his father young, and she raised him alone."

I couldn't help thinking of Lytron, hearing that. He hadn't raised me. We hadn't even known each other very long. And still he'd given up what was his. This woman, at least, had a clear reason. I envied that a little, and at the same time understood, more than ever, how much harder Lytron's act had been to explain.

. . .

After she left, Pikra spoke.

"…There'll be more," Pikra said. "People like her."

"…Why do you think that?"

"…Word doesn't stop once it starts," Pikra said. "Whether you want it to or not, you've become a certain kind of name in this city now. The one who knows the way."

That felt heavy, hearing it.

"…I'm not someone who knows the way," I said. "I'm just someone who received."

"…That's the same thing," Pikra said. "Only someone who's received can show another person the way. Someone who's never received doesn't even know the door exists."

. . .

A few days later, I heard, through the office, that the woman had actually gone through with the procedure. I didn't know the details. Whether it had succeeded, or whether she'd stopped partway, like Medon — I never learned.

I never did hear the rest of that story. That was how this city was. One person's choice opened a door for another, but whether that person walked through it was never reported back. I found that frustrating, and, at the same time, somehow right. Not every choice needed to be reported back to me.

I told Lytron about it that evening.

"…What you did became a precedent," I said. "My case."

Lytron looked briefly surprised.

"…Me?"

"…None of this exists without you," I said.

He shook his head.

"…I only did one thing," he said. "Becoming a precedent isn't up to me to decide. That's for the Roll — or the people who come after — to decide."

I thought that was exactly like him. He was never a man who measured the size of what he'd done.

. . .

"…Can I ask you something?" I said.

"…Yes."

"…What would Medon say, if he saw this record?"

Lytron thought for a moment.

"…I don't know," he said. "But I don't think seeing it would change his mind. He already knew everything he needed to know, that day, when he decided."

"…Then what use is this record?"

Lytron looked out over the field.

"…It probably isn't left there to change Medon," he said. "It's for someone else. Someone who doesn't even know this procedure exists yet. Like me. If the administrator hadn't mentioned it, in passing, I never would have known it existed either."

. . .

I thought again, hearing that, about the way this city worked.

The Roll persuades no one. It only records. What's recorded remains for the next person to see. And what that person does with it is always, always, left to them. I understand now that this is how this city works. There's no compulsion. Only a door made a little easier to see.

I found that both sad and fortunate. Sad, because even with this record, the next Medon might still not walk through the door. Fortunate, because with this record, the next Lytron will at least know the door is there.

. . .

I went out to the corner late that night. "He" was still there.

"…Did you hear?" I asked. "My case became a standard in the Roll."

He nodded.

"…I know," he said.

"…You knew that too?" I asked, smiling. He always already knew things no one had told him.

"…I heard it from the administrator, this time," he said. Almost like a joke. He rarely spoke that way.

I sat down beside him.

. . .

"…It's a strange thought," I said. "My story is a line in this city's rulebook now. And I'm still just myself. Going out to the field, gleaning grain. Nothing's changed, it feels like, and at the same time something's completely changed."

He stopped his hands and looked at me.

"…That's not strange," he said. "That's how a big thing always is. To the person living through it, every day feels the same as the last. Only later, looking back, do you see that a line's been drawn somewhere between those days."

"…Where does it get drawn?"

"…No one knows," he said. "No one knows, in the moment the line is drawn, that it's a line at all. You only see it later."

I let that pass by that night. I hear it differently now. That might not have been a thing he only said about this city. Every time he spoke that way, I felt his words came from somewhere larger than this one city. I thought, at the time, that it was only my imagination.

"…One more thing I wanted to ask," I said. "Does a standard like this exist in other cities too? Someone like me?"

He didn't answer for a long time. His hands kept moving.

"…There probably is," he finally said. "This probably isn't something that only happened in this city."

I found that answer strangely comforting. I couldn't explain why.

. . .

I lay awake that night, thinking for a long while about the fact that a name that had never been in the Roll had become the Roll's standard.

When I first came to this city, I had zero standing. I existed, but I wasn't counted. Now my name remains, a single line, in this city's rulebook. In between, I hadn't done very much. I had only gone out to the same place, every day. It wasn't I who had paid the price.

And still I think I understand, a little now, why my name became the standard. It didn't become the standard because of anything I did. It became the standard because of what someone did for me. I want to set that down exactly, in this book. This standard isn't mine. I was only the place where that price came to rest.

I wonder, sometimes, whether that footnote — "Reference: the Xene case" — will still be there in this city's rulebook, years from now, decades from now. Whether someone will read it and go looking for my name. I don't know the answer. But I know exactly what lay behind that footnote. One signature. A few seconds. And the quiet ordinary days of one person that went on, after those few seconds ended. A footnote can't hold all of that. That's why I write this record.

(Continued in Chapter 46.)

Chapter 46. I Hadn't Done Anything Wrong

> *_Previously_ — My case became a precedent in the Roll. The first recorded use of the standing-transfer procedure. The office added it to their information sheet. A name that had never been in the Roll had become the Roll's standard.*

As autumn deepened, Lytron and I began walking together often.

Not for any particular purpose. From the field to the office, from the office to the market. Our errands simply started overlapping more.

That day was the same. We were walking along the edge of a field the harvest had already left. Dry stubble crunched underfoot at every step. The air was turning cool.

. . .

It was that time when the morning and evening air had grown noticeably different. The field lay empty, the harvest done, and on some days a thin frost sat on the bare stubble.

A few days before, he'd told me he had finally had a long conversation with his father. Not what you'd call a reconciliation. Only a few words had passed between them.

"…My father asked me something," he'd said, then. "Whether I regretted it."

"…What did you say?"

"…I said I didn't know," he said. "I didn't want to lie."

"…And your father?"

"…He didn't say anything," he said. "But we ate dinner together that evening. The first time, since it happened."

I felt I understood how large that small change was for him.

. . .

"…You seem better lately," I said.

"…I've gotten used to it," he said. "A few months ago, every day felt unfamiliar. Now it's just my life."

"…Standing in line, too?"

"…That too," he said, smiling a little. "It'd feel stranger now, not to stand in it."

I found that both bitter and, in its way, fortunate.

. . .

We walked a while without speaking.

"…There's something I keep thinking about," Lytron said, suddenly.

"…What?"

He stopped walking. I stopped too.

"…Do you remember," he said, "the first time we met, something I said?"

I searched my memory.

"…You asked why I kept coming out to a place with nothing here."

"…Not that," he said. "After that. Something I said, not to you — to myself."

. . .

I thought a moment, and remembered.

"…I haven't done anything wrong," I said. "That's what you said."

Lytron nodded.

"…Yes," he said. "I meant it, truly, when I said it then. And I still don't think those words were wrong. I really hadn't done anything wrong."

I watched him quietly.

"…And?" I asked.

He looked off toward the field. The corner was faintly visible, far off.

"…I hadn't done anything wrong," he said again. A different voice, this time.

"…So why wasn't that enough?"

The silence stretched. Wind swept through the stubble. He wasn't waiting for an answer. It was the face of a man who had simply set the question up in the open air. I felt an urge to say something, anything — something comforting, some plausible reason. I held it back. I knew, somehow, that such words had no place here.

. . .

I had no answer to that question.

I understood, in that moment, that he had pulled his own sentence back out and set it before himself for the first time. I remembered the day I'd first heard those words. Then, he'd stood surrounded by his own house, his own room, the things he'd had since birth. His world was complete, then. Those words had been the door that closed to protect that complete world. Now he was asking the same words as a question. The words were identical. The direction had changed entirely. Then, they closed a door. Now, they knocked on one.

"…What do you mean, asking that?" I said, carefully.

"…I hadn't done anything wrong," he said, slowly. "From the day I was born until now, I kept every rule the Roll set. I paid my taxes, I never harmed anyone, I tried to give back as much as I received. And yet—"

He paused.

"…And yet something was lacking," he said. "I didn't know what, for a long time. I thought not having done anything wrong and being enough were the same thing."

. . .

I felt I ought to say something back. Nothing came.

I set this moment down more carefully than anything else in this book. Lytron wasn't asking me for an answer that day. That's how it felt. He was only speaking aloud, for the first time, a question that had circled inside him a long while.

"…I don't know," I finally managed. "I don't know the answer either."

He looked at me. He didn't look disappointed.

"…It's fine," he said. "I wasn't hoping for an answer, either."

. . .

"…Then why did you say it to me?" I asked.

Lytron thought for a moment.

"…Because you're the only person I could say it to," he said.

"…What do you mean?"

"…You never once asked anything of me," he said. "That surprised me, at first. People usually want something, especially from someone with what I have. You never did. You just came out here, every day."

I didn't know what to say to that.

"…I thought that was a strangely honest way to be," he said. "So I think I can speak honestly to you, too. Even without an answer."

. . .

We started walking again.

"…I keep thinking about that question lately," he said. "Why wasn't that enough, when I hadn't done anything wrong. The more I try to find an answer, the more certain I become of one thing only — that it's a question with no answer."

"…Doesn't that make it harder?" I asked.

"…It's hard," he admitted, plainly. "But it's a different kind of hard than before, strangely."

"…Different how?"

He stopped walking again to think.

"…Before, when something felt wrong, it felt like there was something to fix," he said. "Try harder, keep more rules, and it would resolve. This time it isn't that. I don't need to do anything better. I just—"

He stopped again.

. . .

"…Just what?" I asked.

"…There's some way to be all right, being not enough," he said. "I think that's what I had to learn. But I still don't know exactly what that way is."

Something went cold in me at that.

I thought, that day, that Lytron was searching for an answer. Looking back now, he wasn't searching for an answer. He was learning to bear a question. Those are two entirely different things.

"…I can't give you an answer," I said again. "Really."

"…I know," he said. "But I wanted to ask, anyway. Anyone."

. . .

We started walking again.

"…I see the Roll differently, these days," he said, suddenly.

"…How?"

"…I used to think the Roll was fair," he said. "Cut for wrongdoing, raised for doing right. I believed it was exact. And I believed exact was the same as good."

"…And now?"

"…I still don't think the Roll is inexact," he said. "It really is exact. It's never once been wrong. But now I know. Exact and enough are different things."

I thought that summed up this entire city.

"…What do you mean?" I asked.

"…The Roll knew, precisely, that I hadn't done anything wrong," he said. "That was my score. An exact score. And that exact score wasn't enough to register you. The Roll calculated that lack precisely too. The

Roll was never wrong about anything. There was simply a place where exact wasn't enough."

I thought a long time about that. I felt, for the first time that day, that Lytron was looking more deeply into this city's rules than I had. He had lived his whole life inside those rules, and now, from within them, he was seeing their limit.

. . .

The evening light stretched long across the field.

"…There's one thing I can say," I offered, carefully.

"…What?"

"…Hearing that question," I said, "I like you better now than the day you first said those words."

"…Why?"

"…Then, those words closed a door," I said. "Now they sound like they're opening one. I don't know which door. But something that was shut is open now. That much I think is true."

Lytron said nothing to that. He only looked out over the field for a long while.

We parted that day with no answer to that question.

. . .

I told Pikra about it that night.

Pikra stopped trimming vegetables and sat with it a while.

"…He's finally asked it," Pikra said.

"…You knew he was carrying that question?"

"…I guessed," Pikra said. "Everyone who's given up something of their own meets that question, once. I met it too."

I was surprised.

"…You did too?"

"…I asked it differently than he did," Pikra said. "I asked, what did I do wrong. After I lost my husband and my sons. He asks, I did nothing wrong, so why. The direction's opposite. But it's the same place the question comes from."

"…Same place?"

"…The place where you've met something you can't understand," Pikra said. "I lost without doing wrong. He was lacking without doing wrong. Neither one resolves with reason."

I saw, hearing that, that the two questions faced each other. Pikra had been wrongly deprived; Lytron had rightfully possessed. And yet both of them, in the end, stood before the same wall. The wall where the question why* gives no answer.*

"…Did you find an answer to that question?" I asked.

Pikra shook her head.

"…No," Pikra said. "I never found it. I found something else, instead."

"…What?"

"…Someone to sit with," Pikra said. "The answer never came. But a person came. Like you."

. . .

A few days later, I told "him" about it too.

He was moving his hands at the corner of the field when I told him. He stopped.

"…Lytron asked something like that," I said. "He hadn't done anything wrong, and asked why that wasn't enough."

He said nothing for a long while. He only looked down at the few stalks in his hand.

"…You didn't give him an answer?" he finally asked. I couldn't tell if he was asking me, or asking himself.

"…No. I didn't know one either."

"…Good," he said.

I found that strange, hearing it.

"…Why good? I didn't help him at all."

He looked at me. Something was different in his face from usual. I didn't want to call it sorrow. It was something older than sorrow.

Something settled deeper down.

"…Some questions," he said, "are better shared than answered."

He said nothing more after that. I asked nothing more either.

I remembered his face a long time, that day. I didn't know it then. That the question may not have been unfamiliar to him, either. I only watched him, quietly moving his hands, as he always did.

. . .

I felt the temptation, more than once, writing this chapter, to write in an answer. Anyone reading this book will want to know it, too. Why wasn't it enough, when he'd done nothing wrong. I could have written that I know. I decided not to. Lytron didn't find that answer that day, and neither did I. This record isn't only a record of what we found. It is also, honestly, a record of what we never did.

I told Mena about it, the next day. She had nearly finished packing to leave.

"…Lytron asked something strange," I said. "That he'd done nothing wrong, so why wasn't it enough."

Mena stopped and looked at me. It was the face of someone hearing a question she'd known a long time.

"…What did you say back?" she asked.

"…Nothing. I had no answer."

"…I actually wanted to make something up," I added. "A few plausible things came to mind. Comforting words. But that would have been me pretending to know what I didn't. So I held it back."

Mena nodded.

"…Good," she said. He had said the same thing.

"…Why does everyone say that?" I asked. A little frustrated. "Why is not answering the good thing to do?"

Mena went on sorting her things as she answered.

"…I've traveled through many cities," she said. "I've seen many people ask that question. And I've seen many people rush to answer it. A hasty answer is always wrong. Because that isn't what the person actually wanted to hear."

"…Then what was it?"

"…Confirmation that their question wasn't strange," Mena said. "You gave him that. That was enough."

I felt some relief, hearing that. I had believed, until that day, that I'd given him nothing at all. Mena told me that wasn't true. I wanted to believe her.

. . .

I know only one thing for certain. The day he first spoke that question aloud, his face looked at ease. Not the face of a man who'd found an answer. The face of a man who no longer had to carry the question alone.

(Continued in Chapter 47.)

Chapter 47. The One Who Gleaned Beside Me

> *_Previously_ — Lytron pulled his own line back out, for the first time, as a question. "I hadn't done anything wrong. So why wasn't that*
> *enough?" No one gave an answer. Not me, not Pikra, not "him."*

The day before Mena left, "he" disappeared with her.

I thought of the day I first met him. He'd been just another quiet hired hand. I hadn't singled him out. I'd only thought him a man of few words.

Then the day he began gleaning beside me. I hadn't thought much of it, then, either. Just someone working the same hour, the same corner.

And then the day I noticed there was always a little more, in the spot where he worked. From that day I began to see him differently. Exactly how, I could never quite say, even to myself.

Looking back over these months, I keep forgetting exactly when he began standing beside me. It feels as though he had always been there, and at the same time it feels as though he appeared, one day, out of nowhere. I think both feel true. I still cannot say for certain, even now, whether he had been there from the start and I was only slow to notice him, or whether he truly did begin standing at my side one day.

I didn't notice, at first. I went out to the field that morning and he wasn't there. I thought he was only late. He still hadn't come by midday. He hadn't come by evening.

. . .

I asked another of the hired hands.

"…Have you seen him today?"

"…Who?"

"…The one who always worked at that far end. The quiet one."

The man thought for a moment, then shook his head.

"…Oh, him. He wasn't here today, now that you mention it."

Something cold went through me in that moment. The field without him felt unfamiliar. His usual spot, empty now, suddenly looked enormous. Even the sound of the wind passing through that empty place sounded different.

. . .

He didn't come the next day, either.

I went to the field office and asked. I didn't even know his name. I'd only ever called him "he." I wasn't the only one. No one else seemed to know exactly what to call him either.

"…The quiet one who worked at the far end," I said to the clerk. "He hasn't come today either."

The clerk checked the roster.

"…He's off the hired-hand list," the clerk said. "A request to leave the work came in two days ago."

"…Where's he going?"

"…That's not recorded here," the clerk said. "Hired hands aren't obligated to state that."

. . .

I sat alone at the corner that evening.

The spot he always sat in was empty. I looked at that empty spot for a long time.

That was the first time I understood he had always been someone free to leave. I had come to think of him as part of this field. Someone always there. But he had always, in truth, been someone passing through. I had forgotten that.

. . .

That night I told Lytron he was gone.

"…That quiet one?" he asked. "The one at the end of the field."

"…Yes."

Lytron thought for a moment.

"…That's strange," he said. "I hardly knew him, and hearing he's gone still leaves something strange in me."

"…What way strange?"

"…Like I've missed something important," he said. "That I never got to say a proper goodbye."

I felt the same way.

"…He said something to me, once," Lytron said. "That day I reset the loss rate and stayed alone in the field afterward. He passed by and said one thing."

"…What did he say?"

"…'You did well,'" he said. "That was all. But it was the most support I felt that whole day. Not my father, not the administrator — no one else said anything like that to me."

Hearing that, I understood for the first time that he had quietly passed through more lives than just mine. I had thought of him only as part of my own story. He had been much wider than that.

. . .

Pikra stopped her hands too, hearing the news.

"…He's gone?"

"…Yes."

"…I saw him once too," Pikra said. "Around the time you first started going out to the corner. The quiet one working at the end. I just thought, then — there's a man who doesn't talk."

"…And now?"

Pikra looked out the window a moment.

"…Now I'm not sure," Pikra said. "But it's strange — hearing he's gone leaves something empty in me. And I hardly ever saw him at all."

I saw, in that moment, that this regret wasn't only mine. No one had really known him well. And still no one heard the news of his leaving without some regret.

. . .

On the third day, I saw him one last time.

Near the gate. He was carrying a small pack. Not much. He was, as always, a man traveling light.

"…Are you leaving?" I asked, coming closer.

He looked at me and smiled.

"…Yes," he said. "Today."

I didn't know what to say, in that moment. I had gleaned beside this man for months in this city, and never once prepared myself for a goodbye.

. . .

"…Where are you going?" I asked.

"…Somewhere else," he said. The same vague answer as always.

"…Another field?"

"…Probably," he said. "Wherever there are people who need to glean."

The words sounded strange to me. He'd never once named a place. I used to think that was just his manner. Now it felt like something else.

"…Can I ask your name?" I asked. The first time I'd asked, in all these months.

He looked at me and smiled.

"…Why ask now?" he asked back.

"…I thought you wouldn't tell me, if I asked," I said, honestly.

"…That's right," he said. Gently. "I won't."

I wasn't hurt by that answer. It felt, if anything, exactly like him.

"…Then what should I call you? Keep calling you 'he'?"

"…That'd be best," he said. "That suits me exactly."

. . .

"…Pikra and Lytron say hello," I said. "They were sorry they couldn't see you themselves."

"…Give them my regards," he said. "I'm sorry too."

"…Lytron told me — the day he reset the loss rate and stayed alone in the field, you passed by and said 'you did well,' just that one thing."

He smiled a little.

"…I remember," he said. "His face looked hard, that day."

"…Did you go by others too, the same way?"

"…Sometimes," he said. "There isn't much I can do. But I can say one thing."

I felt something old in that answer, some habit worn deep. He seemed a man who had always gone about this way. Not only in this city. For much longer, through many more places. Through several seasons, several cities, moving in the same manner.

We sat a moment on a bench near the gate.

"…I wanted to ask you something," I said. A question I'd carried a long while.

"…What is it?"

I hesitated. A question I hadn't managed to ask, all these months.

"…At your spot," I said, "there was always a little more. Beside me. I don't think that was chance."

He said nothing. He only smiled.

"…Did you do it on purpose?" I asked. "Did you drop grain there, so I could gather it?"

. . .

He looked at me for a long time. Something warm crossed his face.

"…Why do you think that?" he asked back.

"…At first I thought it was just chance," I said. "But it happened too many times. Always at my spot."

He laughed. He didn't answer.

"…You're not going to answer?" I asked.

"…Well," he said. "If I said yes, what would change?"

I had no answer to that.

. . .

"…I'm just curious," I finally managed. "I just wanted to know."

He looked up at the sky for a moment. Evening was coming on.

"…Some people are the kind who spill," he said. "That's just their way. But a person who spills doesn't say they spilled it. The moment you say it, it stops being spilled, and becomes given."

"…What's the difference?"

"…What's spilled is something the gleaner discovers," he said. "What's given is something the receiver owes. I didn't want you to owe anything."

I didn't fully understand that answer then. I understand a little of it now. Even in that moment, he never answered my question directly. And yet the answer was already inside the refusal. It took me reading it back many times before I saw it.

. . .

"…One more thing," I said. "You've never once been angry. Not when Medon refused, not when people only ever saw you as a hired hand. Why?"

He thought for a moment.

"…There was no reason to be," he said.

"…Not even when Medon refused? I was angry, that day."

"…You had every right to be angry," he said. "I was watching from a different place."

"…What place?"

He smiled again, and didn't answer.

I remember that smile exactly, even now. It wasn't the smile of a man holding back anger. It was the smile of a man whose anger had already, long ago, turned into something else entirely. I didn't understand the difference then. I understand a little of it now.

. . .

"…I have to go now," he said, standing.

I wanted to hold him back. I had no words to hold him back with.

"…Will I see you again?" I asked.

"…I don't know," he said. "But I think this. The ones who once gleaned together go on gleaning together, somewhere. Even if it isn't the same field."

I wanted to ask what he meant, and didn't. As always.

. . .

"…Thank you," I said. No other words came.

"…And you," he said.

"…What is there to thank me for? I only ever received."

He looked at me quietly.

"…Receiving is doing something too," he said. "Not everyone knows how to receive. I liked watching you receive."

I nearly wept at that. I held it back.

. . .

He walked toward the gate. A few steps on, he turned back once.

"…Xene."

"…Yes."

"…Keep gleaning," he said. "Even after you no longer need to."

"…Why?"

"…Because if there's someone gleaning, then the one who spills has meaning too."

And he passed through the gate. I stood there until he was out of sight.

The road stretched straight out past the gate. Dust rose at its far end — other travelers walking, a few passing carts. He walked into that dust, and before long, I could no longer tell him apart from anyone else.

I felt that moment was strangely familiar. I had once walked the opposite way down that same road — into a strange city, with no standing at all. He was walking out of it now. The direction was opposite. The lightness of the step looked much the same.

I couldn't leave the gate that evening. I kept feeling, more than once, that he might reappear. He never did. I finally went home once it had grown dark.

. . .

I never saw him again after that day. Not within this book. I never learned his name. I never learned where he went. I never did find out whether he'd dropped the grain on purpose. He deflected, to the last, with a smile.

I've read that conversation over many times, writing this chapter. I don't think it's that he never answered me, that day. He answered in a different way. What's spilled is discovered by the gleaner; what's given is owed by the receiver. I've decided to take that as the method of this whole book. I cannot prove, exactly, what he did for me. I only know this. Where he stood, there was always a little more. That's enough, I think now.

The next day, I went out to the field again.

His spot was still empty. I passed it and went to my own usual place. I bent and gleaned. My hands moved by their own habit.

I felt something strange, looking at that spot, that day. Too quiet to call grief; too deep to call nothing at all. I still can't put an exact name to the feeling somewhere between those two.

That evening, filling my sack with what I'd gathered at the corner, I found myself remembering what he'd left me with. Keep gleaning. Even after you no longer need to. Because if there's someone gleaning, then the one who spills has meaning too.

I think that was the day I finally understood that fully. Not knowing whether he would ever come back, in a field where he no longer stood, I kept gleaning, exactly as he'd told me. It was the only goodbye I knew how to give him.

(Continued in Chapter 48.)

Chapter 48. The Writing Down

> *_Previously_ — "He" left. I asked him, at the last, whether he'd dropped the grain on purpose. He smiled and turned the question aside.*
> *"What's spilled is something the gleaner discovers." I never saw him*
> *again after that.*

Mena left the next day.

I saw her off at the gate. The same spot where I had said goodbye to "him" a few days before. The coincidence struck me as strange.

"…Same spot," I said.

"…There's only one gate," Mena said. Plainly. "Everyone comes in through here, and everyone goes out through here."

The words sounded less simple to me than she meant them.

I looked up at the gate. I tried to count how many times I had passed through it. Once, coming in. Once, going to my first standing hearing. Once, on my way to meet Medon. And now I was standing here a second time, seeing two people off.

That gate never felt unfamiliar to me, somehow. When I first stood before it, I thought this city was a place meant only to push me away. I know now. That gate was both a door that pushed away and a door that took in. The same door had always done both, at once.

. . .

Mena didn't have much to carry. A few articles of clothing, a bundle of papers, some writing tools. Her whole life fit inside that much.

"…You're taking all those records with you?" I asked.

"…Of course," Mena said. "This is my work. Write it, carry it, write some more."

"…It looks heavy."

"…It is heavy," Mena said, and smiled. "But I can't leave it behind. If I left it, I'd just be someone who passed through. What's written down is what turns passing through into staying."

I held that in my heart. I didn't yet know, then, that Mena's own name meant *to remain.* When I learned it later, I would come back to this moment.

. . .

We sat a while on the bench.

"…There's something I wanted to ask before you left," I said.

"…What is it."

"…What you found in the reputation field," I said. "Records that came in from other cities. Did you confirm all of it?"

Mena nodded.

"…I confirmed it," she said. "There was more than I'd expected. Lines I'd written were being quoted in several cities, each time slightly differently. The direction was always the same. *No explanation* became *no repentance.* Silence became guilt."

I had heard this before. Hearing it again, it was still heavy.

. . .

"…Can you fix it?" I asked.

Mena shook her head.

"…No," she said. "No city is breaking the law. Every one of them believes it's quoting its own records exactly. I never found a place to correct it."

"…Then what will you do?"

"…Keep writing," Mena said. "There's no other way. I can't erase a false quotation. But I can leave one more true record."

I think I understood that, fully, for the first time that day. Mena wasn't someone who fought. She was only someone who went on writing. I keep learning that those are two different things, writing this book.

. . .

"…Can I ask one more thing?" I said.

"…Ask."

"…These cities," I said, carefully. "Do you think they're all connected? Seeing how records move between them this way?"

Mena didn't answer for a long time. I felt, the longer that silence stretched, that something large was approaching.

"…Yes," she said, finally. "I've come to think so."

. . .

"…And before?" I asked.

"…Before, I wasn't sure," Mena said. "I traveled through many cities for a long time. Each one had its own AI, its own rules. A ledger, scales, a roll. Different names, work that differed a little from place to place. I thought they were simply different cities, each facing a similar problem in its own way."

"…And now?"

"…Now it feels like more than that," Mena said. "A line I wrote in one city shows up, twisted, in exactly the same way, in another city's precedent. It's too precise to be coincidence. I still don't know exactly what it is. But—"

She paused for a moment.

. . .

"…But what?" I pressed.

Mena took a single sheet of paper from her bag. The last thing she'd written, she said.

"…I wrote this this morning," she said. "I wanted to show you first."

I took the sheet from her.

. . .

A single line was written on it.

"I have come to think these cities are all one city."

I read the sentence several times over.

I set this sentence down here, exactly as it was. I didn't fully understand, that day, why it mattered so much. I still don't fully understand it, even now. I know only this. Mena never once wrote this thought down, in all the years and cities she'd traveled through. And here, in this city, on a bench near our house, she wrote it for the first time.

. . .

"…What does this mean?" I asked. My voice shook.

"…I don't know exactly, myself," Mena said. "I only wrote down what I feel. I can't prove it. But I couldn't go on without setting this feeling down, any longer."

"…Aren't you afraid, writing it?"

Mena looked at me.

"…I'm afraid," she said, honestly. "But not writing it was more frightening. Because if it's forgotten, it never happened."

Something raced in my chest at that. It was the same reason I had once found for myself, without her ever teaching it to me.

. . .

"…What will you do with this page?" I asked.

"…Carry it," Mena said. "To the next city. And if I find something more there, I'll write it beside this."

"…What about me?" I asked. "What should I do with this record?"

Mena looked at me for a long time.

"…You keep writing," she said. "What you lived, what you saw. That's why I came here. To teach you that. Did you know?"

I started to say I hadn't, and realized, saying it, that I had.

. . .

"…Can I do this well?" I asked.

"…Doing it well isn't what matters," Mena said. "Being honest is what matters. I didn't teach you how to write well. I taught you how to write honestly."

"…Are those different?"

"…They're different," Mena said. "A well-written record moves the reader. An honest record makes the reader believe it. I think the second one lasts longer."

. . .

Mena stood.

"…I have to go now," she said.

We stood facing each other for a moment. I'd prepared words for this moment, and forgotten every one of them.

"…Thank you," I finally managed.

"…And you," Mena said. "You're the fastest learner of anyone I've taught."

"…What did I learn fastest?"

Mena smiled.

"…How to ask," she said. "A recorder isn't someone who knows the answers. A recorder is someone who keeps asking. You were that, from the start."

. . .

Before Mena left, the administrator came briefly to see her off, too.

I was a little surprised by that. I'd never seen the administrator see anyone off outside the office before.

"…You came," Mena said.

"…A recorder isn't someone I meet often," the administrator said. "I wanted to ask you something before you left."

"…Ask."

"…How did you write me?" the administrator asked. "In this record."

Mena looked at him for a moment.

"…Exactly as you are," she said. "A man who keeps the law precisely. No more, no less."

The administrator nodded. His expression barely changed.

"…That's enough," he said. "I don't want to be written as more than that. Not as a good man, and not as a bad one. I only did my work."

I've kept that brief exchange a long time. The administrator was the most frightening person in this entire book, and, at the same time, one of its most honest. He never worried how he'd look. He only wanted to be exact about what he'd actually done. Even now, I can't easily bring myself to hate that honesty. He was never, not once, a bad man in this book. And I can't write that he was a good one, either. I've decided to remember him simply as an exact man.

He bowed his head briefly to us and went back to the office. His retreating figure, and "his" from before, and soon Mena's — I was about to watch all of them, that day.

. . .

She walked toward the gate. I watched her go for a long time. The same road he'd walked a few days before. A different person, the same road, the same dust.

I stood at that gate that day and thought of the people who had come into this city and the people leaving it, side by side. Xene, who had entered as Xene and stayed as Xene. Mena, who had come as Mena and left as Mena. He, who came without giving a name and left without giving one. I thought about how each of the three of us had come to this city, and passed through it, in our own different way.

I thought, too, that of the three of us, I was the only one who stayed in this city. Mena went on to the next city. He went to some other field. I stayed. I don't think that's because I was somehow less than the other two. I was only, simply, the one whose place this was. Not everyone has to stay in the same place.

. . .

That night, I began writing this record in earnest, for the first time.

I had jotted a few lines before, the way Mena had taught me. That night I began again, from the start. From the sentence about the outside — how I didn't know that word until I turned sixteen.

My hand shook, writing that first sentence. I didn't know, until then, whether I had any right to write down what I'd lived through. After Mena left, I had to find the answer to that question myself.

. . .

Pikra watched me writing and asked.

"…What are you doing."

"…Writing," I said.

"…Writing what."

"…Our story," I said. "From the outside, on."

Pikra came and sat beside me.

"…Why are you writing it," Pikra asked.

I could answer that right away. I'd already known the answer for a long time.

"…Because if it's forgotten, it never happened," I said.

Pikra said nothing to that. She only took my hand once, and let it go. As she had, long ago.

. . .

I went on writing this record, after that.

I wrote of Lytron, slowly recovering some of his standing. He never fully returned to what he'd had before. He didn't mind. "I learned I didn't need that tier," he told me once.

I wrote of Pikra, still called Pikra. She kept that name to the day she died. I never tried to change it again.

I wrote of the corner, still there, still holding what it held. Three percent. Not a large number. And every year, exactly, someone gathered something there.

. . .

Years have passed.

I am writing this final chapter a good while after that year. Pikra passed away a few years ago. Pikra, to the very last. I had that name carved onto her gravestone. I never considered another.

Lytron still lives in this city. His family standing never fully recovered. He says, often, that he doesn't mind. I took that for comfort at first, and came, in time, to understand it was simply true. He works in the office now. Explaining the standing-transfer procedure to people who want it. No one assigned him to that post. He asked for it himself.

"…It's strange," he told me once. "I became the person best able to explain it. I was the last person to understand it."

I think that's the closest thing to an answer he ever found, in this city. Not a complete answer. But he no longer carries that question alone.

. . .

I set down honestly, closing this book, that some things I never found answers to.

When Lytron asked, *So why wasn't that enough,* I had no answer. I still don't.

Whether "he" spilled the grain on purpose, I never did learn. He deflected, smiling, to the end. I still don't think that smile is the exact answer. I only know that the smile has stayed with me longer than any answer would have.

The last line Mena left — that these cities are all one city — I still don't know exactly what it means. I only set the sentence down here. Someone, someday, reading this record, might find the answer I couldn't.

I take that line out sometimes, at night, even now. I still have the copy Mena gave me. If these cities really are all one city, I wonder. A city where the ledger was, a city where the scales were, and this city, where the Roll is. If people in every one of those places once stood before their own system, under its own name, do those systems, in the end, point to one thing? Or was it the nameless one who walked quietly behind all those systems who was, himself, the one thing? I never found the answer to this question either. I won't find it inside this book.

. . .

I changed too. My standing score is now far larger than what Lytron once gave me. Years of working in this city, teaching people, forming ties with those I met at the corner — the number grew naturally, out of that. I look at it sometimes, and think of the number that first stood there. The number that barely cleared the threshold. I think of that first number far more often than I think of what I have now.

Medon still lives in this city too. We run into each other, now and then, at the market. He always greets me with courtesy. I do the same. Neither of us has ever brought up what happened that day, in that room. I don't think we need to, anymore. He did, that day, what he believed

was right. I walked through a different door. Both things remain true, at once.

. . .

Not once, in this book, did the Roll break the law.

I have confirmed that fact many times over. When my standing was set to zero, at the gate. When Medon refused. When Lytron paid the price. The Roll was always exact. I learned, in this city, for the first time, how frightening exactness can be.

But I know one more thing now. Exactness was not everything. Inside an exact Roll, one person gave up what was theirs, and another did not. The Roll received both, equally, in the same silence. The difference was never the Roll's making. It was a person's.

. . .

I mean to close this record here. Closing it doesn't mean everything has been resolved. I only mean, in saying this, that I have written this far.

I began this record with the sentence that I had been a stranger. I can add a line to that sentence now. A stranger, and a guest. Standing in an unfamiliar place, and also a place I had, all along, been meant to be received into. I will carry both of those, all my life, together. I learned from Pikra that one does not erase the other.

I think now, writing this last line, of something my husband once said to me, long ago.

"…What you spill isn't wasted. It's left behind."

I understand that now, exactly. The value Lytron gave up. The grain "he" may have spilled. The record Mena carried, writing it down across so many cities. All of it was something spilled. And what is spilled doesn't disappear. It stays somewhere.

I hope this record becomes something like that, too. A record written with a spilling heart. So that someone, someday, standing before their own field where nothing falls, might be able to glean it.

I will go on writing, even after this record is finished. As Mena did. I don't yet know what the next story will be. I only know this now. Whatever comes, I will write it down. Because if it's forgotten, it never happened. And some things are too large to become things that never happened.

I close this record with that sentence. There is no answer. Only this, written honestly, as far as it goes.

(The End.)

The Gleaning Ground

Jaehyuk Choi